

**Fool's Stage | BURNED MEMORIES**

**AND MADE-UP APOLOGIES**

A Story: by Alias Lupus

## A Letter From Alias

Hello again.

If you are reading this, then somehow you survived the first book. Congratulations.

I am still trying to figure out how we managed it.

A lot has happened since I first found that impossible wagon.

I have walked roads that should not exist.

I have visited Structures older than maps.

I have followed clues left by people who seemed determined to make everything more confusing than necessary.

Some mysteries became answers. Most answers became bigger mysteries.

More importantly, I met people.

Rowan still talks too much.

Maris still writes everything down.

Corvin still pretends not to care.

Eldric still answers important questions with 'a little.'

There are still questions left unanswered.

Who built the wagon?

Who was M?

Why do the Structures exist?

Who were my parents?

I do not know. Not yet.

But I intend to find out.

Thank you for joining us again.

The road ahead is uncertain.

But then, the best roads usually are.

— Alias

## **FOOL'S STAGE | Burned Memories And Made-Up Apologies**

Copyright © 2026 Portal Master Of Games All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, transmitted, stored in a retrieval system, or translated into any language in any form or by any means without prior written permission from the author, except for brief quotations used in reviews or educational discussion.

Recommended Reading Age: 16+ This story contains themes of identity, memory, friendship, regret, personal growth, and philosophical questions that may be best appreciated by older teen and adult readers. First Edition Beta Reader Version 1.0 Author: Portal Master Of Games Genre: Philosophical Fantasy Adventure Fantasy Mystery Fantasy For everyone who has ever followed a road without knowing where it would lead. And for those who discovered that the journey mattered more than the destination.

## Contents

|                                                            |     |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| Fool's Stage   BURNED MEMORIES .....                       | 1   |
| AND MADE-UP APOLOGIES.....                                 | 1   |
| A Letter From Alias .....                                  | 2   |
| FOOL'S STAGE   Burned Memories And Made-Up Apologies ..... | 3   |
| What Came Before.....                                      | 7   |
| Characters.....                                            | 8   |
| Places .....                                               | 8   |
| Known Structures .....                                     | 8   |
| The Pathstriders.....                                      | 9   |
| Opening Quote .....                                        | 10  |
| PART I - THE MAN WHO LEFT .....                            | 11  |
| Chapter 1 .....                                            | 11  |
| A Dream of Tomorrow .....                                  | 11  |
| Chapter 2 .....                                            | 19  |
| The Stranger at Camp.....                                  | 19  |
| Chapter 3 .....                                            | 27  |
| The Impossible Coin .....                                  | 27  |
| Chapter 4 .....                                            | 33  |
| The Shared Journal.....                                    | 33  |
| Chapter 5 .....                                            | 46  |
| Twenty Years Missing .....                                 | 46  |
| Chapter 6 .....                                            | 57  |
| Anger .....                                                | 57  |
| Chapter 7 .....                                            | 71  |
| The Road Not Taken .....                                   | 71  |
| Chapter 8 .....                                            | 84  |
| The Road Backward .....                                    | 84  |
| PART II - WALKING THE WRONG ROAD .....                     | 96  |
| Chapter 9 .....                                            | 96  |
| The Hall Once More .....                                   | 96  |
| Chapter 10 .....                                           | 111 |
| Burned Memory I - The Road Alone.....                      | 111 |

|                                             |     |
|---------------------------------------------|-----|
| Chapter 11 .....                            | 126 |
| Echoes Revisited.....                       | 126 |
| Chapter 12 .....                            | 139 |
| The Silent Observatory .....                | 139 |
| Chapter 13 .....                            | 152 |
| A Journal Left Behind .....                 | 152 |
| Chapter 14 .....                            | 165 |
| Hollow Creek.....                           | 165 |
| Chapter 15 .....                            | 185 |
| Burned Memory II - The Things I Missed..... | 185 |
| Chapter 16 .....                            | 196 |
| The Archive Again.....                      | 196 |
| Chapter 17 .....                            | 212 |
| Questions Unread.....                       | 212 |
| Chapter 18 .....                            | 225 |
| The Man Called Varux .....                  | 225 |
| PART III - THE TOWER ABOVE.....             | 236 |
| Chapter 19 .....                            | 236 |
| East of Home .....                          | 236 |
| Chapter 20 .....                            | 246 |
| Burned Memory III - Following M.....        | 246 |
| Chapter 21 .....                            | 264 |
| The Climb .....                             | 264 |
| Chapter 22 .....                            | 277 |
| The Room of Farewells .....                 | 277 |
| Chapter 23 .....                            | 288 |
| What I Left Behind.....                     | 288 |
| Chapter 24 .....                            | 299 |
| One Floor Higher .....                      | 299 |
| Chapter 25 .....                            | 313 |
| The Hidden Room .....                       | 313 |
| Chapter 26 .....                            | 326 |
| M's Final Lesson.....                       | 326 |

|                               |     |
|-------------------------------|-----|
| Chapter 27 .....              | 339 |
| Where My Choice Began.....    | 339 |
| PART IV - HOME .....          | 351 |
| Chapter 28 .....              | 351 |
| Returning.....                | 351 |
| Chapter 29 .....              | 364 |
| Familiar Walls.....           | 364 |
| Chapter 30 .....              | 377 |
| The Birthday .....            | 377 |
| Chapter 31 .....              | 387 |
| Moonlit Secrets .....         | 387 |
| Chapter 32 .....              | 400 |
| Shared Fires.....             | 400 |
| Chapter 33 .....              | 411 |
| Things Worth Keeping.....     | 411 |
| Chapter 34 .....              | 422 |
| The Last Evening.....         | 422 |
| Chapter 35 .....              | 433 |
| The Road Home.....            | 433 |
| PART V - WHAT REMAINED.....   | 448 |
| Chapter 36 .....              | 448 |
| The Journal I Never Read..... | 448 |
| Chapter 37 .....              | 458 |
| The Gifts Left Waiting.....   | 458 |
| Chapter 38 .....              | 472 |
| Adventure Awaits .....        | 472 |

## What Came Before

Alias, a young wolffolk archivist from the town of Maanhaven, discovered a mysterious wagon carrying journals, records, and clues connected to forgotten roads hidden from modern maps.

Joined by Rowan, Maris, Corvin, and the mage Eldric, he followed a trail left behind by an unknown traveler known only as M.

Their journey led them through ancient Structures, impossible archives, forgotten histories, and places that seemed to exist for reasons long lost to time.

One name continued to appear:

Varux Hyborea.

A stranger tied to the coin Alias carried.

A stranger connected to roads older than memory.

A stranger who seemed to know far more than he should.

The greatest mysteries were not always hidden inside ancient ruins.

Sometimes they were hidden inside people.

And some roads lead not toward discovery—but toward consequences.

## Characters

Alias — A young wolffolk archivist driven by curiosity, questions, and a desire to understand the world.

Rowan — Energetic, humorous, and often the loudest person in the room.

Maris — A meticulous record keeper who writes down nearly everything.

Corvin — Practical, observant, and far more caring than he admits.

Eldric — An experienced mage whose answer to most difficult questions is 'a little.'

Gerhardt — Owner of the tavern in Maanhaven and a familiar face throughout the journey.

## Places

Maanhaven — Alias's home town and the place many roads eventually return to.

The Ancient Roads — Forgotten paths hidden from most maps.

The Eastern Sea — A distant coast tied to mysteries yet unresolved.

Cliff Academy — A school founded by Eldric, dedicated to learning, discovery, and passing knowledge forward.

## Known Structures

The Structures are ancient locations scattered across the world.

Their builders remain unknown.

Each Structure appears to serve a purpose beyond simple architecture and often teaches a lesson as much as it reveals an answer.

Many mysteries surrounding them remain unsolved.



## **The Pathstriders**

The name eventually adopted by Alias and his companions.

Not heroes.

Not conquerors.

Not legends.

Simply travelers who continued walking the road together.

According to Rowan, several significantly worse names were suggested first.

## Opening Quote

"I thought there would always be time to come home later."

## PART I - THE MAN WHO LEFT

### Chapter 1

#### A Dream of Tomorrow *Shared Journal Entry 417*

*"If you find yourself walking alone, stop. Look behind you. Sometimes the answer is not ahead.  
Sometimes it has been trying to catch up all along."*

The road beyond Gray Hollow was quiet. Not suspiciously quiet. Not mysteriously quiet. Just the kind of quiet that appeared after a long day of walking. The sun had already disappeared behind the distant hills, leaving streaks of orange and purple across the sky, and the air smelled of damp earth, cooling grass, and the smoke from a campfire Rowan had built too large on purpose.

Corvin had corrected the fire with the expression of a man repairing civilization itself. Rowan had called this censorship. Maris had written both opinions down. Eldric, naturally, had made tea and refused to choose a side, which everyone agreed was the same as choosing the most annoying side possible.

Alias sat near the fire with his notebook open across his knee. He had meant to record the route from Gray Hollow, the condition of the roads, and the symbols carved into the stone marker they had passed before sunset. Instead, he had drawn Rowan arguing with a pile of firewood. It was not an accurate drawing, exactly, but it captured the emotional truth of the moment.

"I still think we should have taken the left road," Rowan said.

Corvin did not look up from the map spread across his lap. "We passed that crossroads six hours ago."

"And?"

"And the decision has already been made."

Rowan pointed dramatically into the darkness. "There could have been treasure."

"There could have been a swamp," Corvin replied.

"There could have been treasure in the swamp."

"There could have been two swamps."

Maris lifted her pencil. "I have recorded both possibilities."

Rowan blinked. "You wrote that down?"

"I write everything down."

"You need a hobby."

"This is my hobby."

Alias smiled despite himself. Some things never changed, even when the world around them kept trying to become impossible. Rowan was still incapable of letting an argument die. Maris still carried enough notebooks to make a traveling library jealous. Corvin still pretended not to care while checking everyone's boot straps, map marks, and water flasks. Eldric still answered questions with the calm cruelty of someone who had spent a lifetime learning how to be unhelpful on purpose.

Across the fire, the old mage sat on a folding stool with a cup of tea balanced between both hands. He watched the flames as though they were explaining something everyone else was too young to understand.

"A little," Eldric said.

Alias looked up. "No one asked anything."

"I know."

Rowan dropped his head back with a groan. "He is getting worse."

"Or we are becoming more aware of it," Maris said.

"That sounds worse."

Corvin folded the map. "Both can be true."

The camp settled into laughter, the ordinary kind, the kind that did not need to be written into history to matter. It slipped between them with the warmth of the fire, softer than the mysteries they carried and more comforting than any answer they had found so far. Alias found himself listening to it longer than he meant to.

He had not expected companionship to become something he noticed like weather. At the beginning, he had thought of the journey as a question. The wagon, the coin, the impossible language, M, Varux Hyborea. A chain of clues. A road of answers. But somewhere between the first Structure and the many wrong turns after it, the journey had become something else.

It had become Rowan stealing the last piece of bread and then pretending he had saved everyone from a suspicious crust. It had become Maris whispering to old texts as if they were stubborn animals. It had become Corvin saying he did not care and then caring with terrifying precision. It had become Eldric making tea in places where tea had no right to exist.

It had become them.

Alias lowered his gaze to the coin hanging beneath his shirt. He had begun wearing it on a cord after nearly losing it in a river crossing two weeks earlier. Corvin had called the decision sensible.

Rowan had called it dramatic. Maris had asked whether the coin's proximity to his heart altered any measurable reaction. Eldric had said, 'A little,' and refused to explain whether he was joking.

The coin was cold now, but not warning-cold. Just metal-cold. Ordinary-cold. Alias had learned to identify several kinds of impossible object behavior, which was not a skill he had expected to need when he was younger.

"You are doing the face again," Rowan said.

Alias blinked. "What face?"

"The thinking face."

"I have more than one."

"No, you have one face with several levels of problem inside it."

Maris nodded without looking up. "That is accurate."

"Traitor," Alias said.

"Archivist," Maris corrected.

Corvin began packing the map away. 'If the thinking face produces a decision to leave the road before sunrise, I object in advance.'

'No decisions,' Alias said. 'Just questions.'

'That is usually how your decisions begin.'

Alias had no defense against that because it was true.

The fire burned lower. The sky darkened completely, and the first real stars appeared between gaps in the branches. The group slowly surrendered to the end of the day. Rowan rolled into his blanket while loudly declaring he was not tired, then fell asleep before anyone could disagree.

Maris wrote for another twenty minutes, though her pencil slowed near the end until the final lines became more determination than scholarship. Corvin checked the perimeter twice. Then, because he was Corvin, he checked the knots on the packs before finally lying down.

Only Eldric remained awake.

Alias watched him over the fire. "Aren't you sleeping?"

"Eventually."

"That is not an answer."

"It is."

"No, it is not."

"A little."

Alias groaned and pulled his blanket around his shoulders. Eldric smiled faintly into his tea, which was more suspicious than any ancient inscription they had found that week.

For a while Alias stared upward. The stars looked sharp above the trees. He thought of roads hidden from maps, of the wagon that had started everything, of M's scattered trail, of the name Varux Hyborea appearing again and again like a shadow walking a few steps ahead of him. He thought of his parents too, though he tried not to. Thinking of them at night always made the questions feel closer.

Who were they? Why did memory blur whenever he reached for them? Why did some missing things feel like empty rooms while others felt like doors someone had locked from the other side?

The fire cracked softly. Somewhere beyond the camp, an owl called once and then thought better of continuing.

Alias closed his eyes.

Sleep arrived quietly.

\* \* \*

At first the road looked familiar. That should have been comforting. Instead it made Alias uneasy.

The sky above him was grey. Not cloudy, not stormy, not even properly dark. Just grey. The color seemed drained from everything around him. The road stretched endlessly ahead, disappearing into a distant haze. Alias looked behind him and found only more road. No camp. No trees. No hills. No stars. No fire. No Rowan snoring like an accusation against nature.

Just silence.

His footsteps echoed as he began walking. The sound was too clear, as though the road itself had been waiting to hear him move. The further he went, the more wrong everything felt. The road was familiar in the way a forgotten word was familiar. Not remembered, exactly. Recognized.

Then he saw someone far ahead, standing perfectly still.

Alias stopped.

The figure did not move. A grey cloak hung from narrow shoulders. The hood was raised. The road was grey. The sky was grey. The world was grey. Only one thing stood out: a silver coin hanging from a chain at the figure's chest.

His coin.

Alias's hand immediately moved to his own neck. The coin was there, cold against his skin.

The figure began walking toward him.

Not quickly. Not threateningly. Just steadily, step by step, as though this meeting had been planned long before Alias arrived. The closer the figure came, the more Alias wanted to run. He did not know why. Fear usually explained itself eventually. This fear did not. It simply stood inside him and waited.

The figure stopped only a few steps away.

Its hood hid most of its face, but not enough.

A scar crossed one cheek. Grey fur touched the jaw. Golden eyes looked out from beneath the shadow of the hood. Older eyes. Tired eyes. Eyes that had seen far too much and slept far too little afterward.

Alias felt his stomach drop.

The face looking back at him was his own.

Older. Sharper. Worn by years he had not lived.

For several seconds neither of them spoke.

Then the stranger sighed. It was not dramatic. It was not threatening. It was only tired, and somehow that was worse.

"You still have time," the older Alias said.

Alias stared. "What?"

"You still have time."

"Time for what?"

The older version of him looked toward the empty horizon. A faint smile touched his face. It was not happy. It looked like a memory trying to survive being remembered.

"To do better than I did."

The road seemed to grow quieter.

Alias took one step back. 'Who are you?'

The older Alias looked at him then, truly looked, and for the first time the tiredness cracked. Beneath it was regret. Beneath that, sadness. Beneath that, something painfully close to hope.

He opened his mouth as if he meant to answer.

Instead he said, 'I'm sorry.'

The world shattered.

The road vanished beneath Alias's feet. The grey sky cracked like glass. The sound of breaking filled everything, and for one impossible heartbeat Alias saw flashes inside the fragments: a tower, a chair, folded clothes, a journal left unread, a tavern table, a cake too sweet to understand, graves beneath a pale morning sky.

Then all of it collapsed into darkness.

Alias woke with a sharp breath.

The campfire had burned down to red coals. The trees were still trees. The sky was still full of stars. Rowan was still snoring. Maris slept with one hand near her notebook. Corvin's pack sat exactly where he could reach it. The world had returned to ordinary shapes.

His heart had not returned with it.

Alias sat up slowly and pressed one hand to his chest. The coin beneath his shirt was cold. Not ordinary-cold. Not metal-cold. This cold moved through his fingers like a warning whispered too close to the skin.

Across the fire, Eldric was awake.

Of course he was.

The old mage held his cup of tea in both hands. Steam rose from it, which was impossible because the fire had nearly gone out and no one had reheated anything. Alias decided not to ask. There were only so many mysteries a person could survive before breakfast.



Eldric watched him carefully.

Alias swallowed. "I had a dream."

"Yes."

"You say that like you already knew."

"A little."

Alias closed his eyes. 'I am going to throw that cup into the woods one day.'

'You would miss it.'

'I would not.'

'A little.'

Despite himself, Alias almost laughed. Almost. The dream still clung to him too tightly.

Eldric's expression softened. 'What did you see?'

Alias looked toward the darkness beyond camp. For a moment he considered lying. He could say it was nothing. A strange road. A bad feeling. Too much travel, too little sleep. The kind of answer people gave when they wanted concern to leave them alone.

But the older face remained behind his eyes.

His face.

Not a reflection. Not exactly.

A warning wearing his skin.

"I saw myself," Alias said quietly.

Eldric did not move.

That was how Alias knew the answer mattered.

"Older," Alias continued. "Much older. He had my coin. He said I still had time."

The old mage looked into his tea as though an answer might be hiding there. If one was, it had the sense not to reveal itself.

"And then?" Eldric asked.

"Then he said he was sorry."

The night seemed to lean closer.

Eldric was silent for a long time.

Alias hated that silence more than any riddle.

"It was just a dream," Alias said, mostly because he wanted Eldric to disagree.

Eldric lifted his gaze. 'Some dreams are only dreams.'

"And this one?"

The old mage's face became unreadable in the firelight.

"This one," Eldric said, "may be trying to arrive before the person it belongs to."

Alias stared at him.

Before he could ask what that meant, the coin pulsed once against his chest.

Cold. Sharp. Certain.

Far beyond the trees, somewhere down the road they had not yet walked, something silver flashed and vanished.

Eldric looked toward it.

So did Alias.

Neither of them spoke again until morning.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 2

### The Stranger at Camp

#### *Shared Journal Entry 418*

*"A road does not become safe because it is familiar. It only becomes familiar because someone has survived walking it before."*

Morning arrived with the deliberate cheerfulness of something that had not spent the night dreaming of itself.

Alias woke before the sun. For several seconds he lay still beneath his blanket, staring at the pale shapes of branches above him and trying to decide whether the dream had truly ended. The camp was quiet except for Rowan's snoring, which suggested that no supernatural warning had been powerful enough to disturb him.

Then Alias touched the coin beneath his shirt.

It was cold.

Not ordinary cold. Not the harmless chill of metal left outside overnight. This was the same sharp, inward cold it had carried in the dream, as if the road of grey dust had reached through sleep and left one finger against his skin.

He sat up.

Eldric was already awake beside the ashes of the fire. A small blue flame hovered above his palms, warming a kettle without smoke or sound. The old mage looked tired in the soft dawn light, though whether that meant he had slept badly or simply looked like someone who had read too many difficult books was impossible to tell.

"You are awake," Alias said.

"Eventually," Eldric replied.

"That is not how being awake works."

Eldric poured tea into two cups. "It has worked for me so far."

Alias accepted the cup, because refusing tea from Eldric felt like the sort of mistake that became an important lesson later. The steam smelled of mint, something bitter, and a third ingredient he could not identify. He decided not to identify it.

"Did you sleep?" Eldric asked.

"No."

"A little?"

"Not funny."

"I was not attempting humor."

"That somehow makes it worse."

The rest of the camp woke slowly. Corvin emerged first, fully dressed and already irritated by the fact that the sun had risen without consulting the map. Maris woke with a pencil trapped in her hair. Rowan woke last, rolled out of his blanket, and landed directly on one of his own boots.

"Ambush," Rowan announced into the grass.

"By footwear?" Corvin asked.

"You have not seen what these can do when properly motivated."

"I have seen what they do when improperly tied."

Rowan looked down at the boot. "That was a separate incident."

Breakfast was bread, dried apple, and tea strong enough to improve several unrelated problems.

Rowan complained about the bread. Corvin complained about Rowan complaining about the bread. Maris wrote down the route they intended to take, crossed out one direction, and wrote it again more neatly.

Alias tried to eat. He managed half a piece of bread before Rowan noticed that he had not said anything for nearly three minutes.

"You look terrible," Rowan said.

"Good morning to you too."

"I mean it. You look like you fought a ghost and lost on points."

Maris glanced up. "That is oddly specific."

"It is a useful life skill."

"No," Corvin said. "It is not."

Alias looked toward Eldric. The old mage was studying his tea with an attention that felt suspiciously deliberate.

"I had a dream," Alias said.

Rowan stopped chewing. "Was I in it?"

"That is your first question?" Maris asked.

"I need to know whether dream-me was impressive."

"You were asleep in the dream."

"Then dream-me had excellent judgment."

The joke landed softly. Alias tried to smile, but the grey road was still too clear behind his eyes.

"It was not a normal dream," he said.

That changed the room around the fire. Not visibly. Not enough for anyone else to name. But Corvin set down his cup. Maris closed her notebook instead of opening it. Rowan's grin faded at the edges.

"Tell us," Corvin said.

Alias did.

He described the empty road first: the colourless sky, the silence, the way every step had sounded too loud. Then the figure. He did not try to make it less strange. He described the grey cloak, the scar, the coin on the chain, and the eyes that had looked like his own after years had been added to them.

When he reached the apology, nobody interrupted.

"He said I still had time," Alias finished. "Then he said he was sorry."

Rowan looked toward the road beyond the camp. "That is not a dream I would like to have."

"Thank you," Alias said. "I had not considered that."

"I am here to help."

Maris's expression had gone thoughtful in the way that usually meant she had found seven questions and was deciding which one could be asked without frightening everyone. "Did the coin react before you slept?"

"No."

"After you woke?"

"Yes. It was cold."

"How cold?"

"Maris."

"Details matter."

"It felt like it knew something."

That was the answer she wrote down.

Corvin rubbed one thumb along the edge of his cup. "We have encountered reflections, records, voices, and Structures that respond to memory. A dream does not necessarily mean a prophecy."

"You believe it was a prophecy?" Rowan asked.

"I believe it was a dream until we have evidence otherwise."

"And if evidence is standing beside the road later today?"

"Then I will revise the assessment."

"That is disappointingly reasonable."

Corvin gave him a flat look. "I work very hard at it."

Eldric remained quiet.

Alias waited. Finally he said, "You have something to say."

"A little."

"You have been saying that since I woke up."

"That is because I have had a little to say since you woke up."

Rowan made a sound of personal betrayal. Maris pinched the bridge of her nose. Corvin looked ready to throw the kettle into the nearest tree.

Eldric set his cup down. When he spoke again, the lightness had left his voice.

"Some dreams are only dreams," he said. "Some are memories wearing masks. Some are warnings that arrive early because waiting would make them useless."

"Which one was mine?" Alias asked.

"I do not know."

The honesty landed harder than another riddle would have.

"But?" Alias asked.

"But a road shown in a dream is not a road you are required to walk."

Alias looked down at his hands. "What if it is already my road?"

Eldric's gaze softened. "Then you will still choose every step."

No one spoke for a while after that.

They packed soon afterward. Corvin checked the route twice, then a third time because the sky looked like it might rain later. Maris wrapped her notebooks in oilcloth. Rowan claimed that the rain would avoid him out of respect. The sky gave no sign of agreeing.

By midmorning, the road had taken them through open fields where last season's crops stood in rough gold lines beneath the wind. Small villages appeared and disappeared behind low hills. A woman waved from a fence while two children tried to count the group's packs and disagreed loudly about the answer.

The ordinary world helped. Alias wanted it to.

He watched Corvin pause at every marker stone. He watched Maris stop once to sketch a flower growing from a crack in an old wall. He watched Rowan attempt to befriend a goat that had no interest in friendship and a great interest in his sleeve.

"It likes you," Maris said.

"It is trying to eat me."

"Those are not always different things," Eldric said.

"You know, sometimes I think you enjoy watching us struggle."

"A little."

Alias laughed before he could stop himself. The sound surprised him. It did not remove the dream, but it made room around it.

Near noon, when the others stopped beside a stream to refill their water flasks, Alias found Eldric standing a short distance away beneath a willow tree. The mage had one hand resting against the bark. For a moment Alias thought he was listening to the tree. With Eldric, that possibility could not be dismissed.

"Have you had dreams like that?" Alias asked.

Eldric did not turn. "Dreams of myself?"

"Dreams that felt like they belonged to someone else. Or to someone you had not become yet."

The old mage was quiet long enough that the stream seemed to grow louder.

"A little," he said at last.

"That does not answer anything."

"It answers more than I intended."

Alias folded his arms. "Then answer the question you did intend."

Eldric looked at him. The expression in his eyes was not pity. Alias was grateful for that. Pity made questions feel smaller. This was something else. Recognition, perhaps. Or caution.

"I have known people who saw possible roads before they reached them," Eldric said. "Some spent their lives trying to avoid them. Some ran toward them. Neither choice made the road disappear."

"So what am I supposed to do?"

"Pay attention."

"That is all?"

"No. But it is the beginning."

Alias wanted something clearer. A warning. A rule. A piece of old magic written in a language that could be translated if Maris had enough paper and patience. Instead he got Eldric's calm face and a stream carrying leaves away one at a time.

"If I see him again," Alias said, "I am going to ask him who he is."

"That seems reasonable."

"You are not going to tell me not to?"

"No."

"Why not?"

Eldric looked toward the road. "Because curiosity is not the danger. Forgetting why you are curious is."

Before Alias could decide what that meant, Corvin called from the stream.

"Alias. If you are finished interrogating the trees, we are leaving."

"I was not interrogating a tree."

Rowan looked over. "That is exactly what someone interrogating a tree would say."

They returned to the road.

The afternoon passed without prophecy. That was almost disappointing.

The fields narrowed into woodland. The road rose and fell beneath old branches. Sunlight broke through the leaves in shifting pieces, turning the mud gold and green. Alias kept watching ahead, then behind, then at every stranger they passed. A merchant with three mules. Two sisters



carrying baskets. A tired guard with a broken buckle. None of them wore a grey cloak. None of them had his eyes.

By the time Corvin began looking for a place to camp, Alias had almost convinced himself that the dream had been nothing more than fear trying to give itself a face.

Then the coin turned cold.

He stopped walking.

Corvin noticed first. He always did. "What is it?"

"The coin."

Rowan immediately looked toward the trees. "Is it doing the warning thing or the mystery thing?"

"Those are not separate categories," Maris said.

"They should be."

The cold deepened against Alias's chest. He looked ahead.

The road curved around a low hill and opened into a small clearing. Old stones marked the edge of it, perhaps the remains of a ruined travelers' shelter. It was an ordinary enough place to camp.

Flat ground. Water nearby. Enough trees to cut the wind.

Someone was already there.

He stood beside the largest stone with one hand resting on its weathered surface. A grey cloak hung from his shoulders. His hood was down now. His fur and hair were darker than Alias's, touched at the edges by years the younger version had not lived. A thin scar crossed one cheek.

Around his neck hung a silver coin on a chain.

Alias forgot how to breathe.

Rowan took one slow step backward. "That is not a goat."

"Thank you, Rowan," Corvin said quietly. "Your observations remain essential."

Maris did not reach for her notebook. That frightened Alias more than the stranger.

Eldric stood very still.

The stranger looked from one face to another. When his gaze reached Alias, something in it changed. Not surprise. Not relief. Something older and sadder than both.

"Hello, Alias," he said.

The voice was not exactly Alias's.

It was what Alias's voice might become after too many winters, too many roads, and too many apologies.

The stranger smiled.

It was a tired smile.

"I was hoping you would take this road."

\* \* \*

## Chapter 3

### The Impossible Coin *Shared Journal Entry 419*

*"The impossible thing is not that a road can bring you back. It is that, after all that distance, someone might still be waiting."*

Nobody moved.

The stranger's smile disappeared first. It did not fall away dramatically. It simply became too tired to hold.

Corvin placed one hand near the handle of the knife at his belt. He did not draw it. That made the movement worse somehow. Rowan had stopped making jokes. Maris was watching the man with the fixed, careful attention she normally saved for old inscriptions that might explode if translated incorrectly.

Eldric stood beside Alias without seeming to move there.

"What do you want?" Corvin asked.

The stranger looked at him. "A conversation."

"People who want conversations usually begin with their names."

"Fair."

For a moment, he seemed to search through several answers and dislike all of them. Then he said,

"Varux."

Rowan frowned. "That sounds made up."

"It is," Varux said. "In a way."

"That did not make it sound less made up."

"Rowan," Corvin said.

"What? I am helping."

Alias barely heard them. He could not stop looking at the coin around the stranger's neck. It was not only similar to his. Similar would have been easier. It had the same uneven rim, the same small crescent mark pressed into the silver, the same thin line running through the center like a road seen from high above.

Except this one was older.

The metal had darkened in places. A scratch crossed the crescent. The chain looked worn from years beneath a collar or shirt.

His own coin went cold against his chest.

Varux noticed.

"I know," he said quietly.

Alias's head snapped up. "You know what?"

"The feeling."

"No. You do not get to say things like that."

Varux swallowed. It was a small movement, but it made him look less like a threat and more like someone waiting for a blow.

"Then let me show you," he said.

Corvin stepped forward. "You will not touch him."

"I am not asking to."

Varux raised both hands, palms open. "Alias, take yours out. Please."

The word please sounded wrong in his voice. It sounded practiced. Like he had said it before in an empty room and been answered only by silence.

Alias did not move.

"Why?" Maris asked.

"Because he deserves proof before he deserves an explanation," Varux said.

Eldric looked at Alias. He did not nod. He did not tell him what to do. He simply waited, which was somehow more difficult than advice.

Alias pulled the coin from beneath his shirt.

The moment it touched the air, the clearing changed.

The coin in his hand flashed silver-white. Not brightly enough to blind anyone, but enough to throw hard lines across Corvin's face and turn the wet grass around their boots pale. Varux's coin answered a heartbeat later.

It did not shine.

It woke.

A dull light moved beneath its surface, like a coal remembering fire. The two coins pulled toward one another on their chains, not physically at first, but with an invisible pressure Alias felt in his wrist.

The clearing went silent.

Even the wind seemed to have stopped.

Maris whispered, "That is impossible."

"I have been told," Varux said, "that I collect impossible things."

Rowan stared at the coins. "All right. I hate this one."

"Only this one?" Corvin asked.

"I hate several things currently. I am prioritizing."

Alias stepped forward before anyone could stop him. The coins trembled harder. He could see details now. The scratch on Varux's coin had begun at the crescent and cut toward the center. It was not random.

It followed the same path as a shallow mark on his own coin.

Not yet a scratch. Not yet deep enough to notice unless he knew where to look.

Alias held his breath.

"What are you?" he asked.

Varux's eyes closed.

It lasted only a second. When they opened, they were still Alias's eyes. They were just older than any eyes had a right to be.

"I am you," Varux said.

Rowan laughed once.

It was not because he thought it was funny.

"No," Rowan said. "No. That is not an answer. That is a bad riddle."

"It is not a riddle."

Corvin's hand finally moved away from his knife. Not because he trusted Varux. Alias could tell that much. It moved because Corvin was thinking, and thinking had become more urgent than fighting.

"You are claiming to be a future version of Alias," Corvin said carefully.

"Yes."

"How far?"

Varux looked at Alias instead of answering Corvin.

"Far enough," he said, "to know that you should not ask me that first."

Alias felt the anger arrive before he recognized it. It came hot and clean, cutting through the fear.

"Do not talk around me," he said. "You walk into our camp, you say my name, you wear my coin, and then you tell everyone that you are me. You do not get to decide what I ask."

Varux flinched.

Not much. But he did.

"You're right," he said. "You should ask."

"Then answer."

Varux looked down at the two coins between them. "Seventeen years."

The number did not make sense at first.

Alias stared at him.

Maris spoke before he could. "Seventeen years from now?"

Varux nodded.

Rowan put both hands over his face. "I was happier before breakfast."

Eldric had not looked away from Varux since the coins began to react. "You said you are him," he said. "That is not the same as saying you are from his future."

"It is the closest thing I have to the truth."

"The closest thing?" Corvin asked. "That sounds like there is a less convenient part."

"There are many inconvenient parts."

"Good. I was worried this would be simple."

Varux almost smiled at that. Almost. "It was never simple."

Alias's coin burned cold in his palm.

"How did you get here?" he asked.

Varux's gaze shifted toward the road behind him. The road that had led into the clearing. The road that had led back through the woods, into fields, past the stream, past the dream, toward a future Alias had not reached yet.

"By making the same mistake twice," he said.

"No," Alias said. "That is not an answer either."

"I know."

"Then give me one."

Varux was quiet long enough that Rowan finally lowered his hands.

"I found a way back," Varux said. "Not perfectly. Not safely. The Structures do not like being used as doors, and time does not like being treated as a place on a map. But I found a way. I arrived before you began this road."

"Before Gray Hollow?" Maris asked.

"Before all of it."

"How long before?" Corvin asked.

"Five years."

The number made the clearing feel smaller.

"You have been here for five years?" Alias asked.

Varux nodded.

"And you just waited beside roads until I showed up?"

"No."

"Then what did you do?"

Varux looked like the answer hurt.

"I prepared."

"For what?"

"For you."

Alias laughed then. It came out sharp and wrong. "I do not need preparation."

"I know you think that."

"I know what I need better than you do."

Varux's face tightened. "I used to think that too."

The words landed hard because they were not cruel. If anything, they were tired.

Maris stepped closer, though not close enough to be within reach. "You said the Structures do not like being used as doors. Which Structure?"

Varux's attention snapped to her. For the first time, fear crossed his face.

"Not now," he said.

Maris's eyes narrowed. "Why not?"

"Because once you know where it is, you will look for it."

"That is generally how knowledge works."

"I know."

"Then why bring it up at all?"

"Because I am bad at explaining things in the right order."

Rowan pointed at him. "At least that part sounds like Alias."

Nobody smiled.

Varux looked toward Rowan, and something in his expression broke open for a moment. He looked away too fast.

Alias noticed.

"Do you know them?" he asked.

Varux went still.

"Do you know Rowan? Corvin? Maris? Eldric?"

"I know all of you."

"From where?"

"From the years after this."

The answer should have been obvious. It was still unbearable.

Eldric spoke quietly. "And did we stay together?"

Varux looked at him.

The old mage's voice had not changed. It was even. Gentle. But Alias heard the question underneath it.

Did we make it?

Varux's hand closed around his older coin.

"Yes," he said. "For a long time."

The silence that followed was different from the others. Nobody knew what to do with it. Rowan looked down at the grass. Corvin's jaw tightened. Maris's fingers closed around the strap of her notebook bag.

Alias hated Varux for answering that way.

He hated himself for understanding why.

"Stop," he said.

Varux looked back at him.

"You keep saying things that sound like half of a warning. You keep looking at them like you have already lost them. Stop doing that."

Varux's face went blank.

It was not a guarded expression. It was worse than that. It was the look of someone who had trained himself not to react because reaction was too expensive.

"I am trying," he said.

"Try harder."

Eldric's hand settled lightly on Alias's shoulder. It did not stop him. It only reminded him that he was not alone in the clearing.

Varux looked at the hand.

His eyes lowered.

"That is why I came," he said.

Alias stared at him. "What?"

"Not to frighten you. Not to control where you go. Not to make you into someone else."

"Then why?"

Varux looked at the group, one by one. His gaze lingered on each face as if he was memorizing something that had once been taken from him.

"Because I left," he said.

The words were quiet.

"I left when I was your age. I thought I needed to find an answer before I could come home. I thought there would always be time later. Time to write. Time to visit. Time to explain. Time to say sorry."

The coin in Alias's hand had stopped glowing, but it was still warm now. Warm enough that he could feel the pulse in his palm.

"I came back because I thought I could stop you from becoming me," Varux continued. "Then I spent five years making plans, hiding from people who might recognize me, trying to understand the one thing I still could not fix."

"And what is that?" Alias asked.

Varux met his eyes.

"The part where I believed I had to do it alone."

The words went through Alias like the cold from the dream.

For an instant he saw the grey road again.

The older version of himself standing at its center.

I am sorry.

"I do not believe that," Alias said.

Varux gave a small, sad laugh. "Not yet."

"I have them."

"I know."

"Then I will not leave them."

Varux's expression did not change, but something in his shoulders did. They folded inward by a fraction.

"I said that too."

Corvin stepped between them just enough to interrupt the moment. "We are not accepting any of this without evidence."

"Good," Varux said.

"Do not sound pleased."

"I am pleased because you are still you."

"That is not reassuring."

"It is not meant to be."

Maris had finally opened her notebook. "What evidence can you provide without revealing one of your forbidden destinations?"

Varux thought about it.

"The shared journal," he said.

Alias blinked. "What shared journal?"

Rowan looked at Maris. "We have a shared journal?"

"No," Maris said. "We have several notebooks and an ongoing disagreement about whether Rowan should be allowed near ink."

"I have been allowed near ink. It has not forgiven me yet."

Varux looked almost confused. Then realization crossed his face.

"It begins later," he said. "After something happens at the Hall."

"The Hall?" Maris repeated.

"Not now."

"That phrase is becoming a problem."

"I know."

"Stop saying that."

Varux looked briefly embarrassed. It made him look younger. It made him look too much like Alias.

"The journal will be proof," he said. "You will recognize your own handwriting. All of you. It has entries I could not have written without knowing you."

"Where is it?" Corvin asked.

"With me."

"Of course it is," Rowan muttered.

Varux reached beneath his cloak, slowly, so no one mistook the movement for a weapon. He pulled out a weathered book bound in dark blue leather. It was thicker than Alias's notebook and held together with a thin cord wrapped around it several times.

He did not offer it.

Not yet.

"This is not yours yet," Varux said. "It belongs to all of you. I kept it because I did not know how to let it go."

That sentence frightened Alias more than the impossible coin had.  
Varux looked at him again.  
"Tomorrow," he said. "You can read it tomorrow. Tonight, I think you should decide whether you want me near your fire."  
The clearing grew darker around them. Clouds had covered the last of the evening light. Somewhere beyond the trees, thunder muttered once.  
Rowan looked at the stranger. "You are not sleeping in my blanket."  
"Reasonable."  
"You also do not get first choice of breakfast."  
"Also reasonable."  
"Rowan," Corvin said.  
"I am establishing boundaries."  
Maris closed her notebook. "We should decide together."  
Corvin nodded once. "We will."  
Eldric said nothing.  
Alias still held his coin.  
Across from him, Varux held the older one.  
Two coins. Two versions of one person. One road behind them, another waiting ahead.  
It was impossible.  
And somehow, that was no longer the part Alias feared most.

\* \* \*



## Chapter 4

### The Shared Journal

#### *Shared Journal Entry 420*

*"A shared page is a promise: I was here, you were here, and neither of us has to carry the road alone."*

The storm arrived before anyone had decided what to do with the stranger.

A first drop of rain struck the dust between them. Then another. The wind shifted through the clearing, carrying the smell of wet leaves and distant thunder.

Corvin looked up at the sky, then at Varux, then back at the sky.

"Convenient," he said.

"I did not arrange it," Varux replied.

"That is exactly what someone who arranged it would say."

Rowan lifted one hand. "For once, I agree with Corvin."

"Mark the date," Corvin said.

Maris was still studying the two coins. Alias had put his back under his shirt, but the warmth remained against his chest. Varux's coin had disappeared beneath the grey cloak. The clearing looked normal again, which was somehow the most suspicious thing about it.

"We need a fire," Eldric said.

That simple sentence broke the stillness.

Corvin moved first. "Rowan, wood. Maris, water. Alias, with me."

Nobody asked Varux to do anything.

Varux did not ask if he should.

He stepped away from the old stone and stood at the far edge of the clearing, hands visible at his sides, while the group made camp around him. The rain was light at first, enough to darken the ground and make the grass shine. Rowan returned with a bundle of branches over one shoulder and stared at Varux as if the man might transform into a wolf the moment nobody was looking.

"You can help," Rowan said eventually.

Varux blinked. "I can?"

"You have hands."

"That is not always considered sufficient evidence."

"It is for wood."

Corvin gave Rowan a look.

"What?" Rowan said. "If he is evil, he can carry the evil wood."

Varux's mouth twitched.

He crossed the clearing and took half the branches from Rowan without touching him. His movements were careful. Too careful. He stacked the wood beneath the sheltering remains of an old stone wall, placing the driest pieces at the centre.

Corvin watched him do it.

"You build fires often?" he asked.

"Often enough."

"You put the ash pit on the wrong side of the wind."

Varux paused. Then he looked up at the low broken wall, the slope beyond it, and the trees leaning west.

"You're right," he said.

Rowan grinned. "First victory of the evening."

Varux moved the wood without argument.

Alias could not decide whether that made the stranger less frightening or more. If someone had claimed to be Alias from seventeen years in the future, Alias thought, they should at least argue with Corvin about fire placement.

Then again, maybe seventeen years was enough time to learn not to.

Eldric started the fire with a small spark from his palm. The blue flame caught quickly, then turned gold and ordinary. Everyone gathered around it by instinct, though there was still a wide space between Varux and the rest of them.

Corvin opened his pack and removed a folded groundcloth. He spread it beside the fire, then looked directly at Varux.

"Put everything you are carrying on that."

Varux nodded.

No complaint. No clever remark. He unclasped his cloak first and placed it carefully on the cloth.

Underneath, he wore dark travel clothes patched at the elbows and shoulders, clothes that had clearly been repaired many times by someone who cared more about function than appearance.

Then he added a knife with a plain handle, a small pouch of coins, a roll of bandages, a waterskin, a flint, a compact map case, two pencils, and a narrow leather notebook.

Last came a larger book.

It was bound in faded blue leather. A dark cord wrapped around it three times. The cover had been worn smooth where hands had carried it for years.

Maris leaned forward.

"The journal?" she asked.

Varux's fingers stayed on the cover.

"Yes."

Corvin crouched beside the groundcloth without touching anything. "Anything else?"

Varux hesitated.

Then he pulled a second book from an inner pocket. This one was smaller, black, and far more weathered. Its corners had been softened by rain, dust, and use.

"My own journal," he said. "You do not get that one."

Corvin raised an eyebrow. "Why not?"

"Because it is mine."

"For someone claiming to be Alias, you are unusually good at boundaries."

Varux looked toward Alias. "I learned late."

The answer made the air around the fire tighten.

Eldric lifted a hand. "The blue book."

Varux looked down at it.

"That one is not only yours," Eldric said.

"No," Varux agreed. "It is not."

He sat on the wet grass across from the group. He did not move closer to the fire.

Rowan pointed to the empty space beside the flames. "You will get colder over there."

"I have been colder."

"That was not an invitation to say something sad."

"I know."

"Stop saying that too."

For the first time, Varux gave a real laugh. It was quiet and surprised, as though the sound had escaped before he could stop it. Rowan stared at him. Then his expression changed, just slightly.

Alias noticed. He noticed everything now.

Maris reached for the blue journal, but stopped when Varux's hand tightened against the cover.

"You said we could read it," she said.

"I said tomorrow."

"It is raining now. That makes it practically tomorrow."

"No, it does not," Corvin said.

"It is emotionally tomorrow."

"It is not emotionally anything."

Eldric's eyes moved to Varux. "Why wait?"

Varux looked at the fire.

"Because I wanted one evening where you did not know every bad thing I know," he said.

Nobody spoke.

The rain began to fall harder. Rowan shifted beneath the shelter of the broken wall. Maris pulled her cloak tighter around her shoulders. Corvin looked as if he had prepared an argument and then misplaced it.

Alias felt anger stirring again, but it was different this time. It was not the bright anger from the road. It was heavier.

"You keep deciding things for us," he said.

Varux looked up.

"You say you came here because you did not want to decide my road. But then you tell us what we can know and when we can know it."

"I am trying not to hurt you."

"You do not know what hurts me."

Varux stared at him for a long moment.

"No," he said quietly. "Not anymore."

The answer should have made Alias feel better. Instead, it made him feel as if he had stepped too close to the edge of something deep.

Eldric spoke before anyone else could.

"Let him choose what he shares tonight," the mage said. "But let that choice have consequences."

Varux's eyes moved to him.

"What consequences?" he asked.

"If you ask for trust while hiding behind every answer, they may refuse you a place by their fire."

Varux nodded once.

"Fair."

Alias watched him. "Then what will you share?"

Varux rested both hands on the blue journal.

"The first pages," he said. "The pages that belong to all of you before they belong to me."

Maris drew a slow breath. "What does that mean?"

"It means this journal begins after a place called the Hall. You have not been there yet. You will."

"That sounds like another warning," Rowan said.

"It is not meant to be."

"That has not made me feel better once tonight."

Varux loosened the cord around the journal. His fingers moved with familiarity, but not comfort. When the cover opened, the pages inside smelled faintly of old paper and smoke.

He turned past several blank sheets, then stopped near the beginning.

"This is the first entry," he said.

The page was filled with different handwriting.

Alias leaned forward.

At the top, someone had written:

Shared Journal. Do not lose it.

The line underneath was in Maris's neat, precise hand.

This is a record of what we find. It is also a record of what we survive.

Below it, in Corvin's compact writing:

And where we found it. Do not make me guess later.

Then Rowan's handwriting, uneven and much larger:

Rowan has decided this is an excellent idea and would like everyone to remember that.

Maris had added beneath it:

Rowan did not decide anything.

The final line was written in a hand Alias recognized immediately.

It was his own.

We were all here.

Alias stopped breathing for a second time that day.

The words were not extraordinary. That was what made them worse. They were exactly the sort of sentence he might write when nobody was watching. Small. Private. Honest in a way he would deny if Rowan pointed it out.

"It could be copied," Corvin said.

Maris did not look away from the page. "Not easily."

"People can copy handwriting."

"Not this many hands. Not with this many changes in pressure, age, and habit."

Varux watched them without speaking.

Maris reached closer. "May I?"

He nodded.

She took the book carefully. For several moments, she did nothing but study the ink. Alias saw her thumb hover near the edge of a page without touching it.

"This ink has aged," she said.

Corvin frowned. "Ink ages."

"Yes. But not like a page written yesterday and left in rain. It has been kept dry for years. Some of it was written with different ink at different times. The page has been opened and closed thousands of times."

Rowan looked between the book and Varux. "Thousands?"

"That was a figure of speech."

"It was not," Varux said.

Rowan's face fell.

Eldric held out his hand. Maris passed the journal to him.

The old mage read the first page, then turned to the next.

His expression changed.

"What?" Alias asked.

Eldric did not answer at once. He read a line twice. Then he closed his eyes briefly.

"This is my handwriting," he said.

Nobody laughed.

"Can you tell?" Corvin asked.

"I can tell."

"How?"

Eldric touched one of the letters on the page. "I make this mark only when I am tired."

Rowan looked at it. "It looks like a normal mark."

"It is not."

"How can you know?"

"Because I am tired often enough to recognize it."

Varux looked down at the fire.

Eldric turned the book slightly so the others could see. The entry was short.

Eldric: Begin with what you saw. Do not begin with what you fear you saw.

Alias read the line twice.

It sounded like Eldric. More than that, it sounded like something Eldric might tell him after a difficult day.

"Did you write that?" Alias asked.

"Not yet," Varux said.

The rain drummed against the old wall.

Corvin's eyes narrowed. "You said the journal began after the Hall. If the first pages are in our future, why are you willing to show them?"

Varux's hand moved toward the book, then stopped.

"Because I remember writing some of them," he said. "I remember these first days. I remember the parts before I left."

The last words were almost lost beneath the rain.

"And the rest?" Maris asked.

Varux looked at the cord still lying beside the journal.

"The rest is tied shut for a reason."

Alias felt the question before he asked it. "What reason?"

Varux's gaze did not meet his.

"Because there are pages in it that were written after I was gone."

No one said anything.

A small pop came from the fire.

Rowan looked down at his hands.

Corvin's face became very still.

Maris shut the journal carefully and placed it between them.

"Who wrote them?" she asked.

Varux's mouth tightened.

"All of you," he said.

The answer did not explain enough. It explained too much.



Alias looked toward the dark trees beyond the clearing. The road was somewhere out there, hidden by rain. Seventeen years. Five years of waiting. A future version of himself who carried a journal he was afraid to read.

He did not want to imagine what could be written after someone was gone.

"Did they know you were alive?" he asked.

Varux looked at him then.

Not away. Not through him. At him.

"I do not know," he said.

It was the first answer that sounded afraid.

Rowan broke the silence before it could become unbearable.

"All right," he said, too loudly. "New rule."

Corvin glanced at him. "We have not agreed to the first rule."

"We need several."

"Fine. State the rule."

Rowan pointed at Varux. "No disappearing."

Varux blinked.

"No walking away in the night. No deciding that you have to face mysterious old buildings alone. No vanishing into grey roads. No secret dramatic exits."

For a moment, Varux did not speak.

Then he said, "That is a reasonable rule."

"Good. Also, if you become a wolf, you have to tell us first."

"Rowan," Maris said.

"What? We have already met the future version of Alias. I am widening the possible dangers."

Varux's eyes flicked toward Alias and away again.

Alias noticed.

That was not an answer.

Eldric noticed too. His expression did not change, but he leaned back slightly, as if placing the thought somewhere safe for later.

Corvin folded his arms. "My rules are simpler. You do not lead us anywhere without explaining why. You do not take our supplies. You do not touch anyone's things without asking. You tell us if there is immediate danger."

Varux nodded after each one.

"Agreed."

Maris added, "And you answer questions honestly."

Varux hesitated.

Rowan made a noise. "Oh, that is bad."

"I will not lie," Varux said.

"That is not the same thing," Maris replied.

"No. It is not."

"Then say what you mean."

Varux looked at the blue journal between them.

"I will answer honestly when I can," he said. "And when I cannot, I will tell you that I cannot instead of pretending the question does not exist."

Maris considered this. She did not like it. Alias could see that. But after a moment, she nodded.

"That is at least a rule."

Eldric looked at Alias. "And yours?"

Everyone turned toward him.

Alias had not expected that.

The rain softened. It was still falling, but less violently now. The fire reflected in the wet grass. Across from him, Varux waited without moving.

He looked tired. Not weak. Not harmless. Tired in the way a road looked tired after too many carts had passed over it.

"You do not get to make choices for me," Alias said.

Varux's face tightened.

"You can warn me. You can tell me what happened to you. You can be afraid for me. But you do not get to decide which road I take because you do not like where yours went."

For the first time, Varux looked as if he might argue.

Then he did not.

"I agree," he said.

Alias studied him. "You mean that?"

"No," Varux said. "I mean I will try to live by it."

It was not the same answer.

But it was more honest.

Alias nodded once.

Corvin stood and picked up the knife Varux had placed on the groundcloth. He held it out, handle first.

"Keep this," he said.

Varux did not take it.

"Why?"

"Because I do not want you unarmed in the woods."

"You do not trust me."

"No. But I do not trust the woods either."

Varux looked at the knife for a long time before accepting it.

"Thank you," he said.

Corvin grunted, which was as close to forgiveness as he seemed willing to offer.

They made space near the fire after that. Not much. Varux still sat at the edge of it, but he was no longer outside the circle.

Rowan handed him a cup of tea.

Varux accepted it carefully.

"You drink tea?" Rowan asked.

"Sometimes."

"Do you like it?"

"Not really."

"Then why drink it?"

Varux looked at Eldric.

The old mage lifted his cup.

"Ah," Rowan said. "That makes sense."

For a few minutes, nothing important happened.

They ate the rest of their bread. Maris dried the blue journal with a cloth and wrapped it again. Corvin checked the maps. Rowan complained that all serious conversations should include at least one sweet pastry. Eldric said nothing, but the corner of his mouth lifted when Rowan was not looking.

Alias watched Varux over the rim of his cup.

The older version of himself stared into the fire.

At some point, he looked up.

Their eyes met.

"What?" Alias asked.

Varux shook his head.

Then, after a moment, he said, "You are still here."

Alias frowned. "Obviously."

"No," Varux said. "Not obviously."

He looked back at the fire.

Alias did not know what to say to that.

Later, when the rain had faded into a soft tapping from the trees, the others began preparing to sleep. Corvin chose the order of watch before anyone could argue. Rowan protested anyway. Maris put the blue journal inside her pack, with Varux's permission, and tied the flap closed twice.

Alias lay down beneath his blanket but did not sleep.

Across the fire, Varux sat awake with the first watch. His grey cloak was wrapped around his shoulders. The scar on his cheek looked pale in the dying light.

For a long time, neither of them spoke.

Then Alias said, "Did you know I would see you in the dream?"

Varux's shoulders went still.

"I hoped you would not," he said.

"That is not an answer."

"No."

Alias waited.

Varux looked toward the road beyond the clearing.

"I did not know whether the coin would reach you," he said. "I did not know whether I would. I only knew that I had to try."

"Why?"

Varux's fingers closed around the coin under his shirt.

"Because I remembered being nineteen," he said. "And I remembered thinking there would always be another day to come back."

Alias stared at the dark shape of him.

"I am not you," he said.

Varux nodded.

"I know."

But this time, he did not say it like a habit.

He said it like a prayer.

Alias closed his eyes.

The fire cracked softly between them.

For the first time since the dream, the road in his mind did not look empty.

It looked crowded with questions.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 5

### Twenty Years Missing *Shared Journal Entry 421*

*"The years do not disappear. They wait in the places where you should have been."*

Alias woke with the feeling that someone was watching him.

For one terrible second, the grey road returned.

Then the dawn came through the leaves.

The storm had passed in the night. Water clung to every branch above the clearing, and the ground smelled dark and clean. The fire had sunk into a bed of red coals. On the far side of it, Varux sat awake beneath his grey cloak.

He was not looking at Alias.

He was looking at the blue journal.

It rested in Maris's pack, which she had placed between herself and Corvin before falling asleep. The flap was closed. The straps were tied. The book was out of reach.

Varux watched it anyway.

Alias sat up. The movement made Varux glance over.

"Morning," Varux said.

Alias hated that the older voice made the word sound familiar.

"Did you sleep?"

"A little."

Alias sighed. "You are going to keep saying that, aren't you?"

"Probably."

"Good. At least something about you is annoying in a normal way."

The corner of Varux's mouth moved. It was not quite a smile.

Around them, the camp began to wake. Corvin checked the clouds before checking on anyone else. Maris reached for her pack before she fully opened her eyes. Rowan woke, looked at Varux, and sat upright so quickly that his blanket wrapped around one leg.

"Right," Rowan said. "Still there."

"Still here," Varux replied.

"That was not a welcome."

"I know."

Rowan pointed at him. "There it is again."

Breakfast happened because people needed food even when an impossible version of their friend had appeared from the future. Corvin made sure everyone ate. Maris made sure the journal stayed where she could see it. Eldric made tea. Rowan burned one piece of bread and insisted it had been "strategically toasted."

Alias sat beside the fire with his coin in his hand.

It had been quiet since last night. The silver looked ordinary again. Too ordinary. Like it had never glowed. Like it had not answered another coin worn by a man with his face.

Varux noticed him staring at it.

"You can ask," he said.

"Then answer properly."

"That is less of a question."

Alias closed his fingers around the coin. "How old are you?"

Varux did not answer immediately.

The others grew quiet.

"Thirty-seven," he said at last.

Alias did the number in his head before he could stop himself. He was nineteen. Almost twenty. The answer created a space between them that was too large to cross.

"Seventeen years," Maris said quietly.

"Nearly eighteen," Varux replied.

Rowan looked down at his breakfast. "That is a very long time."

"It felt longer," Varux said.

Corvin leaned forward, elbows on his knees. "You said you have been here for five years. Here meaning before we began this journey."

"Yes."

"So you arrived at thirty-two."

"Yes."

"From the future."

"Yes."

"And waited for five years."

Varux nodded.

Corvin looked as though he was arranging the information into boxes and discovering that the boxes had started fighting.

"Why?" he asked.

Varux's hands settled around his cup. "Because I could not arrive any closer."

"Could not?" Maris asked. "Or would not?"

Varux looked at her. "Both."

Maris accepted that answer without liking it.

Alias did not.

"You had five years," he said. "Five years before we started. You knew something bad would happen to you. You knew you would leave. You knew all of this." He held up the coin. "Why did you not stop it?"

Varux's eyes lowered.

"I thought about it."

"That is not what I asked."

"I know."

"Then answer me."

The fire gave a small crack between them.



Varux looked up again. "Because stopping you from walking would not have saved you."

Alias stared at him.

"It would have made you someone else," Varux continued. "Maybe safer. Maybe smaller. I did not come back to build you a cage out of my fear."

"You are still trying to tell me where to go."

"I am trying not to."

"That is not the same thing."

"No." Varux's voice dropped. "It is not."

Eldric placed another piece of wood on the coals. "Let him finish."

Alias wanted to argue with that too. Instead, he looked away.

Varux took a breath.

"I arrived five years before this road began," he said. "I found somewhere quiet. I learned what I could. I made sure I would be able to find you when the time came. That was all."

"That was all?" Rowan asked. "You hid for five years with a magic time coin and a journal from the future, and that was all?"

"I also ate badly, slept badly, and made several maps that Corvin would hate."

Corvin looked up. "Show me."

Varux almost laughed. "That was not the part you were supposed to focus on."

"It is the part I trust."

For the first time that morning, the older Alias looked genuinely uncertain what to do. Then he reached into his pack and removed a folded sheet of paper. He handed it across the fire.

Corvin took it.

It was a map. Not a magical one. Just ink on paper, marked with roads, hills, small villages, and lines that showed where the rivers crossed the land. But the notes in the margins were dense. Too dense. Alias could see changes in the handwriting from one corner to another. Some notes had been written in a steady hand. Others leaned sharply downward, as if the writer had been tired or cold.

Corvin scanned it in silence.

"This section is wrong," he said.

Varux leaned forward. "Which section?"

"The ridge west of Lorn is not shaped like that."

"It was after the flood."

"What flood?"

Varux stopped.

The whole group watched him.

"Not now," he said.

Rowan dropped his head into his hands. "I need a new phrase. That one is getting old."

Maris reached for the map. "You saw a flood?"

"Yes."

"When?"

"Later."

"How much later?"

"Maris."

"Details matter."

"Still true," Varux said.

She took the map from Corvin before he could object. "You have changed things."

Varux's expression closed.

"I do not know."

"You said you did not come back to control events."

"I did not."

"Then how can the map show a flood that has not happened?"

"It may still happen."

"That is not what I asked."

Varux looked exhausted.

Alias saw it. The tiredness was not just about sleep. It was in the way the older version held himself, like every answer had to be carried before it could be spoken.

"I do not know what changes," Varux said. "That is the truth. I know what happened to me. I do not know what must happen to you."

The sentence settled heavily over the camp.

Eldric nodded once, almost to himself.

"Then the future is not fixed," Maris said.

"I hope not," Varux replied.

"That is not reassuring either," Rowan muttered.

Corvin folded the map and returned it. "You cannot tell us every future danger."

"No."

"You cannot tell us every future place."

"No."

"You cannot guarantee that anything stays the same."

"No."

"Then why are you here?"

The question did not sound angry. That made it sharper.

Varux looked at the journal in Maris's pack.

"I came back because I thought I could prevent one thing."

Alias waited.

Varux's voice became quieter.

"Me leaving."

Nobody moved.

The morning had grown bright around them, but Alias felt cold again.

"You left us?" Rowan asked.

Varux shut his eyes.

"I left all of you."

"Why?" Alias asked.

The word came out small. He hated that.

Varux opened his eyes. "Because I thought there was an answer waiting at the end of the road."

"What answer?"

"I do not know."

Alias frowned. "You do not know?"

"I knew what I was looking for. I thought I did. The Structures. The First Keepers. M. My parents. The things nobody else could explain." He looked down at his hands. "I thought if I kept walking, I would become the kind of person who could understand all of it."

"And did you?" Maris asked.

Varux gave a tired smile that did not reach his eyes. "No."

The answer was so simple that Alias almost missed it.

"No?"

"No."

"After seventeen years?"

"After nearly eighteen years."

"After all of that?" Rowan asked.

Varux nodded.

"What did you find?" Corvin asked.

"Some answers."

"Which ones?"

"Not enough."

The fire popped again.

Alias looked at the blue journal. "And the others?"

Varux went still.

"The others what?"

"What happened to them after you left?"

Varux did not answer.

The silence grew.

"That is not fair," Alias said.

"I know."

"Stop saying that."

Varux flinched.

This time, he did not hide it.

"I am sorry," he said.

The apology made Alias angrier.

"Do not say that either."

Varux stared at him.

"You come here and tell us you are me. You tell us you left them. You tell us you spent almost twenty years looking for answers, and now you are sorry?" Alias stood so quickly that his cup tipped over. Tea soaked into the earth beside his boot. "Sorry does not explain anything."

"I know it does not."

"Then why keep saying it?"

Varux looked like he had been asked a question with no safe answer.

"Because I practiced it for years," he said.

That stopped everyone.

His voice was almost empty.

"I practiced what I would say when I came home. On roads. In rooms. When no one was there. I made apologies until I hated every version of them. Then I arrived here, and none of them sounded right."

Alias did not know what to do with that.

Varux looked down at the ashes.

"I thought there would always be time to come home later," he said. "That was the mistake."

The clearing was silent except for the birds waking in the trees.

Maris's hand rested on top of the journal pack.

"Is that why you did not read it?" she asked.

Varux looked at her.

"The journal," she said. "You said pages were written after you were gone. You said you did not know if they knew you were alive. Did you not read the pages?"

Varux did not answer.

Maris's expression changed.

"You did not."

"I read some."

"Not all of them."

"No."

"Why?"

Varux's fingers tightened around his cup until Alias thought it might crack.

"Because every time I opened it," he said, "I saw proof that the road had kept going without me."

The words landed harder than any prophecy.

Rowan looked away.

Corvin's face had gone stiff.

Eldric's gaze remained on Varux, steady and unreadable.

Alias felt his anger twist. It was still there. But now it had something else mixed into it. Something he did not want to name.

"You kept the journal," he said.

"Yes."

"But you did not read it."

"Yes."

"You could have known what they wrote. You could have known if they were all right."

"Yes."

"And you did not."

Varux's voice barely carried. "No."

Alias turned away.

For a moment he could not look at him.

The road beyond the clearing was bright now. Rainwater shone in the ruts. There were no grey ashes. No empty sky. Just trees, mud, and birdsong.

He wished it made him feel better.

"Nearly twenty years," Varux said behind him.

Alias did not turn.

"That is how long I was missing from them. Not exactly on a clock. But in every way that mattered. I kept thinking I was only gone for one more day."

He paused.

"Then one more road. One more question. One more place."

Alias closed his eyes.

"One more tomorrow," Varux finished.

The words stayed with him.

After a while, Corvin spoke.

"Where are we going now?"

Everyone looked at him.

Corvin shrugged slightly. "We cannot sit here forever. We have a route. We have a stranger who may be useful or dangerous. We have questions that will not answer themselves. So where are we going?"

Alias expected Varux to answer.

The older version of him did not.

He looked at Alias instead.

It took Alias a second to understand.

The choice was his. He hated that too.

He looked at Corvin's map. At Maris's pack. At Rowan, who was pretending not to be worried. At Eldric, who gave nothing away except patience.

Then he looked at Varux.

"You said you will not choose my road," Alias said.

"I will not."

"Then you walk with us."

Varux's expression did not change at first.

Then his shoulders lowered. Not in relief exactly. More like someone setting down a weight he had not expected anyone else to notice.

"If you want me to," he said.

"I do not," Alias replied.

Rowan made a choking sound that might have been laughter.

Alias looked at the road.

"But I want answers."

Varux nodded.

"Then walk," Alias said.

They packed in silence.

The blue journal went back into Maris's pack. Corvin kept Varux's map for longer than he said he would. Rowan handed the older Alias a piece of unburned bread without looking at him. Varux accepted it with a quiet thank you.

By the time they left the clearing, the sun had broken through the clouds.

Varux walked at the back.

Alias walked near the front.

Between them, the road stretched forward in a line of wet earth and morning light.

It did not look like a future.

It looked like a choice.

\* \* \*



## Chapter 6

### Anger

#### *Shared Journal Entry 422*

*"Anger is not proof that you do not care. Sometimes it is proof that you cared enough to expect someone to stay."*

The first hour of walking was quiet.

Not peaceful quiet.

Corvin led. Maris stayed close enough to him to check the map whenever the road bent around another hill. Rowan moved between them and the back of the group, talking too much whenever silence became too heavy and then stopping abruptly when no one answered.

Varux walked behind everyone.

Alias knew that without looking.

He could feel him there in the way he felt the coin beneath his shirt: a pressure he had not asked for, too close to ignore and too far away to understand.

The road from the clearing was narrow after the rain. Water still filled the deepest ruts. Their boots sank into the mud, and every now and then Rowan made a dramatic noise about being claimed by the earth.

"Do not pull me out," Rowan said after one particularly loud squelch. "If I die here, I want people to remember I fought bravely."

"You stepped in a puddle," Corvin said.

"It was a strategic puddle."

"It was directly in front of you."

"Exactly. It knew my route."

Maris stared at the road. "That is not how puddles work."

"That is what they want you to think."

Normally, Alias would have laughed.

Instead, he kept walking.

The anger had not gone away after the clearing. It had settled somewhere behind his ribs and stayed there, warm and sharp. Every time he remembered Varux sitting beside the fire with the blue journal in his hands, it pressed harder.

Nearly twenty years.

One more road.

One more tomorrow.

Alias hated those words because they sounded like excuses, even when Varux had not meant them that way.

At midday, Corvin called a stop beside a low stone bridge. The stream beneath it ran clear and fast from the hills, carrying leaves and broken twigs between its rocks. Everyone began unpacking food.

Varux did not.

He stood at the far end of the bridge, staring down at the water.

Alias watched him for a moment before crossing to him.

Varux heard him coming but did not turn.

"You know this place," Alias said.

It was not a question.

Varux rested both hands on the wet stone railing. "Yes."

"From before?"

"From later."

"Same answer."

"Not always."

Alias stopped beside him.

The stream was loud enough that the others could not hear them clearly. They were close enough to see, though. Corvin glanced over once. Eldric glanced over twice.

"What happened here?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at the water.

"Nothing important."

Alias laughed without humor. "That is not how you say nothing important."

"In my road, we crossed here three times."

"And?"

"The first time, Rowan fell in."

From behind them, Rowan looked up from his bread. "Excuse me?"

Varux continued as if he had not heard him. "The second time, Corvin argued with a bridge keeper for forty minutes because the keeper had drawn the map of the river wrong."

Corvin's expression changed. "He drew it wrong?"

"Very wrong."

"How wrong?"

"Enough that you were still talking about it four years later."

Corvin went silent.

"The third time?" Alias asked.

Varux's fingers tightened against the stone.

"The third time, I came back alone."

The stream seemed to fill the entire world.

Alias looked at him.

Varux had not said it dramatically. He had said it as if he had repeated the sentence so many times inside his head that the words had worn smooth.

"Why?" Alias asked.

Varux did not answer.

"Why were you alone?"

"I told you. I left."

"That does not mean they all disappeared."

"No."

"Then where were they?"

Varux finally turned to face him.

There was no anger in his eyes. That made Alias angrier.

"You want a list?" Varux asked quietly. "A date? A reason I was alone on that bridge?"

"I want you to stop talking like every question is a trap."

"It is not a trap."

"Then answer it."

Varux looked away.

Alias stepped closer.

"You came back here. You found me. You made me see you in a dream. You made your coin react to mine. You stood beside our fire and told us you had been missing for nearly twenty years." His voice rose before he could stop it. "And now you act like I am asking too much when I want to know what happened after you left."

Across the bridge, Rowan had gone quiet.

Varux's face tightened.

"You are not asking too much," he said.

"Then why will you not tell me?"

"Because some answers do not belong to me alone."

Alias stared at him.

"What does that even mean?"

"It means their stories are theirs."

"They are our stories."

"Yes."

"Then tell me."

Varux closed his eyes for a moment. When he spoke, his voice was lower.

"I am afraid that if I tell you every bad thing I remember, you will start seeing the road as a list of disasters waiting for you. I did that. I looked at every place and thought only about what it could take from me. I do not want that for you."

"You do not get to decide that."

"I know."

Alias pushed both hands through his hair. "Stop saying that."

Varux opened his eyes.

This time, Alias saw something flash through them. Not fear. Not exactly. A kind of pain that had become so familiar it no longer knew how to leave.

"All right," Varux said.

The answer was so quiet that it made Alias pause.

"I will stop saying it," he continued. "But I cannot stop knowing that I hurt people by deciding things for them."

The words should have softened something.

They did not.

"You left," Alias said.

"Yes."

"You chose to leave."

"Yes."

"Then you came back and hid for five years."

"Yes."

"And you still think you know what is best for me."

Varux did not answer.

The silence was answer enough.

Alias turned away.

"Come on," Corvin called from the other side. "We need to make up time."

They crossed the bridge without speaking.

The road climbed after that, leaving the stream behind. Trees crowded closer together. Their branches held the last drops of rain, which fell now and then onto shoulders and packs. The air had turned cool.

By late afternoon, they reached a fork where an old milestone leaned sideways in the grass.

The left road continued north through the woods. It was narrow but clear.

The right road sloped east toward a low ridge. It was rougher, almost hidden beneath old leaves.

Corvin unfolded the map.

"The north road is faster," he said. "The east road is longer but avoids the ridge."

"Is the ridge bad?" Rowan asked.

"It is steep."

"That is not a no."

"It is a ridge. Ridges are generally steep."

Maris crouched beside the milestone and wiped away mud. Faded markings appeared beneath her hand.

"East road used to be a trade route," she said. "It may have a shelter farther on."

Rowan brightened. "A roof?"

"Possibly."

"Excellent. I vote roof."

Corvin studied the map. "The northern road reaches the village before dark if we keep pace. The eastern road probably does not."

"Village means beds," Rowan said.

"Village also means people," Maris replied.

"People often have beds."

Varux had stopped behind them.

Alias noticed because Varux had gone too still.

"What?" he asked.

Everyone looked at him.

Varux stared at the northern road.

"We should take the east road," he said.

Corvin's eyes narrowed. "Why?"

Varux did not answer immediately.

Alias felt the anger returning before he knew what he was going to say.

"Let me guess," he said. "Something happens on the north road."

Varux's face changed.

"Not necessarily."

"That is not what I asked."

"In my road, yes."

Rowan looked between them. "What happened?"

Varux said nothing.

Corvin folded the map. "If there is danger, tell us."

"It is not certain," Varux replied.

"That is not an answer either."

"There were two men on the road."

The group went quiet.

"Bandits?" Maris asked.

"Maybe. They were waiting near the bend after the birches."

"Did they hurt anyone?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at him.

"No," he said quickly. "Not us."

"Not us?"

"They did not hurt anyone."

"Then why should we take the longer road?"

Varux hesitated.

"Because I remember them," he said.

Alias stared at him.

That was the whole reason.

Not danger. Not certainty. Not even a warning. Memory.

"You remember them," Alias repeated.

"Yes."

"And that is enough for you to change our route."

"I am only suggesting—"

"No." Alias stepped closer. "You are doing it again."

"Alias," Eldric said quietly.

But Alias could not stop.

"Every time you see something that scares you, you want to move us somewhere else. A different road. A different choice. You say you do not want to make a cage out of fear, but you are already building one."

Varux's face went pale.

The others did not interrupt.

"Take the east road if you want," Varux said.

"What?"

"I said you can take it."

"You know I am not saying that."

"I know."

"Stop—"

"I mean it." Varux looked at the ground. "Take the road you choose. I will not force you."

The anger had nowhere to go after that.

Alias looked toward the north road. It was a simple path between trees. Nothing about it looked dangerous. The thought of taking the east road because Varux remembered something bad made his skin crawl.

"North," he said.

Corvin did not move.

"Alias," Maris said carefully, "we should decide this because it is the better road, not because you are angry."

"I know."

"That is not usually something you say."

"Well, I do."

Corvin looked at the map one more time. Then he nodded.

"North road," he said. "We stay alert."

Varux took a step back.

"All right."



He did not argue.

That made Alias feel worse.

They followed the northern path.

For the first half hour, nothing happened.

Rowan began talking again, cautiously at first. He pointed out a bird with bright red wings. Maris tried to identify it. Corvin said it did not matter what it was called as long as it did not attack them. Eldric said that was not a useful method of classification.

Alias walked ahead.

Varux stayed behind.

The path curved through a stand of white-barked birches just as Varux had said.

Corvin raised one hand.

Everyone stopped.

The road looked empty.

Then Alias saw the rope.

It was thin and dark, stretched low between two trees at ankle height. Almost invisible against the shadowed ground.

Rowan inhaled sharply.

Varux moved first.

Not toward the rope. Toward Alias.

He caught Alias by the shoulder and pulled him backward at the same time Corvin drew his knife.

The rope snapped upward.

A net fell from the branches.

It missed Alias by the width of a hand.

Two men emerged from the trees.

They were not soldiers. Their clothes were mismatched and damp, their faces half-covered with cloth. One held a short bow. The other carried a club.

"Leave the packs," the man with the bow said.

Nobody moved.

"Leave the packs," he repeated, "and nobody gets hurt."

Rowan looked at Corvin. "This seems like the part where someone gets hurt."

"Quiet."

Varux had stepped in front of Alias.

The movement was so familiar that Alias hated it immediately.

"Move," he whispered.

Varux did not.

"Move."

The bowman aimed at Varux's chest.

"Not one more word," he said.

Eldric lifted one hand slowly.

The clubman pointed at him. "No magic."

Eldric's hand stopped.

The rain had left the forest smelling clean. The moment did not.

Alias could hear his own breathing. He could hear Rowan breathing beside him. He could hear the tiny creak of the bowstring as the man held it taut.

Varux's shoulders were tense.

"You do not want this," he said.

The bowman laughed. "You know what I want?"

"Yes."

That word changed the air.

The bowman frowned. "What?"

"I know what happens if you take the packs. I know which way you run. I know where you try to sell the compass. I know that the man you sell it to cheats you. I know you argue with him until your friend breaks his hand."

The clubman stared at Varux.

The bowman lowered the bow by a fraction.

"Who are you?" he asked.

Varux did not answer.

He only looked at the man with an expression Alias had never seen before. Not anger. Not fear.

Recognition.

"You can walk away," Varux said. "Take the road west. There is a farm before nightfall. Ask for work. The woman who owns it will not trust you, but she will give you bread if you repair the fence."

The bowman looked at the clubman.

"He's mad," the clubman whispered.

"Maybe," Varux said. "But you still have a choice."

For a second, Alias thought it might work.

Then the bowman fired.

The arrow never reached Varux.

Eldric's hand closed.

The air between them folded like clear water struck by a stone. The arrow stopped inches from Varux's chest and fell straight down.

Everything happened at once after that.

Corvin lunged for the bowman. Rowan grabbed the clubman's arm before the club could rise. Maris threw a small vial of red powder directly into the bowman's face. He swore and stumbled backward, rubbing at his eyes.

Alias did not think.

He moved.

The net lay tangled at his feet. He kicked it toward the clubman's legs. Rowan shoved at the same time. The man went down hard.

Corvin knocked the bow from the other man's hand. Eldric did not cast anything else, but the blue light around his fingers made both attackers freeze.

"Leave," Eldric said.

The word was quiet.

The men ran.

They did not take the west road.

They ran south through the trees, crashing through wet branches until the sound disappeared.

For several seconds, nobody spoke.

Then Rowan sat down in the middle of the road.

"I would like to return to breakfast," he said.

Maris was breathing hard. Red powder streaked her fingers.

Corvin picked up the fallen bow, inspected it, and snapped it in half.

"Not bad," he said to Maris.

She looked surprised. "Thank you."

"Do not get used to it."

Alias turned toward Varux.

The older version of him was still standing where the arrow had fallen. His face was pale. One hand pressed against the coin beneath his shirt.

"You knew them," Alias said.

Varux nodded.

"You knew exactly what they would do."

"Almost."

"And you still let us take this road."

Varux looked at him.

"You chose this road."

"Because you were trying to control me."

"I was trying to protect you."

"You could have told us everything."

"I could have."

"Why did you not?"

Varux looked at the broken bow in Corvin's hand. At Rowan sitting in the mud. At Maris, who was wiping red powder from her palms. At Eldric, whose hand still glowed faintly.

"Because I did not want you to believe I was always right," Varux said.

Alias stared.

"And were you?"

"No."

The answer came fast this time.

"No," Varux repeated. "I remembered two men. I remembered a net. I remembered the arrow. I did not remember Maris having red powder. I did not remember Corvin breaking the bow. I did not remember you moving first."

Maris looked at Alias.

Varux's voice shook once, then steadied.

"I remembered being afraid," he said. "That is not the same as knowing what will happen."

The anger in Alias did not disappear.

But it changed shape.

Corvin looked at Varux for a long moment. "Next time, tell us the threat."

Varux nodded.

"Next time, I will."

"Not the whole future. Just the threat."

"Just the threat."

Rowan stood and brushed mud from his trousers. "And next time, maybe we do take the road with the roof."

"That is not the lesson," Maris said.

"It can be more than one lesson."

Eldric stepped closer to Varux.

"You protected him," he said.

Varux looked down at the arrow in the mud.

"I tried."

Eldric's gaze moved to Alias. "And he protected himself."

Alias felt something tighten in his chest.

Varux looked at him.

For a moment neither spoke.

Then Alias said, "You can warn us."

Varux nodded slowly.

"But you do not get to stand in front of me every time."

The older version of him swallowed.

"All right."

"You promise?"

"I promise to try."

Alias frowned.

Varux gave him the smallest, tired smile.

"I am learning that promises are easier to make than to keep."

That was not a comforting answer.

It was honest enough.

They left the birches behind as the sun began to lower through the trees. Nobody suggested turning back. Nobody suggested the east road.

The road ahead was still muddy. Still narrow. Still full of places where something might be waiting beyond the next bend.

But the group walked closer together now.

Not because they trusted Varux.

Not yet.

Because anger had made one thing clear.

Whatever happened next, Alias was not walking it alone.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 7

### The Road Not Taken

#### *Shared Journal Entry 423*

*"A road can lead anywhere. The question is who you leave standing at the crossroads when you choose it."*

They reached the crossroads an hour before sunset.

It was not much to look at. Two roads met beside an old stone marker, and a third had once existed but had been swallowed by grass and roots. The marker leaned toward the ditch as if it had become tired of giving directions years ago.

Corvin stopped in front of it.

"Well," he said. "That is inconvenient."

Rowan looked at the stone. "It appears to be a rock."

"It is a milestone."

"It is a rock with ambitions."

Maris stepped closer and brushed moss from the carved face. The markings underneath were worn but readable.

"Maanhaven, west," she said. "Old River Road, north. East road is..." She leaned in. "The writing is damaged."

Varux had gone still behind them.

Alias did not need the coin to know why.

The older version of himself stood a few paces from the marker with his cloak pulled close around him. He was looking at the eastern road, where the trees grew thick and the path narrowed until it vanished into evening shadow.

"East road used to lead to Veyr's Crossing," Varux said.

Corvin glanced at him. "Used to?"

"The crossing is still there. The road is not maintained."

"How do you know?"

Varux did not answer right away.

Rowan groaned softly. "We are doing that again."

"I walked it," Varux said.

"When?" Maris asked.

"Before I left."

That sentence reached Alias before the rest of it did.

Before I left.

The east road looked harmless. It did not have a warning sign. It did not glow. It did not carry smoke or broken arrows or any proof that someone had once made the wrong choice there.

It was only a road.

"What happened?" Alias asked.

Varux shook his head.

"Nothing happened there."

"That is not what I asked."

Varux looked toward the dark path. "That is the problem."

Corvin moved to the map case at his belt. "Our route is north. Old River Road reaches Hollow Creek in two days if the weather holds. The east road adds time and takes us away from the river."

"We take north," Maris said.

"Obviously," Corvin replied.

"Obviously to you. Not everyone has a map in their soul."

"That is not how maps work."

Rowan pointed north. "Does that road have a roof at the end?"

"Eventually."

"Then north."

The decision should have been easy.

Alias watched Varux instead.

"Why did you take east?" he asked.

The others fell quiet again.

Varux looked like he had heard the question years ago. Maybe he had. Maybe he had asked it of himself so often that it no longer surprised him.



"There was a message," he said.

"From M?" Maris asked.

Varux's gaze snapped to her.

"How do you know that name?"

"Because you said it yesterday."

"I said too much yesterday."

"You say that like it is new information."

Rowan smiled faintly. "That one was almost funny."

Varux ignored him.

"The message was not from M exactly," he said. "It was a copy of a page someone said M had written. It mentioned a place east of Veyr's Crossing. A hidden archive. A name I thought might explain something."

"What?" Alias asked.

"My parents."

The word cut through the clearing.

Varux looked down at the road.

"I thought it would be one night away. I thought I could go, find the archive, and return before anyone worried."

"Did you?" Alias asked.

"No."

The answer came too quickly.

Corvin closed the map case. "How long were you gone?"

"At first?"

"At first?"

"Three weeks."

Rowan stared at him. "You thought you would be gone one night."

"Yes."

"And you were gone three weeks."

"Yes."

"What were you doing?"

"Walking. Looking. Failing to find the place. Finding other things. Telling myself I was already too far away to turn back."

Alias felt the anger from the bridge rise again.

"You could have come back."

"I could have."

"You wanted to."

"Every day."

"Then why did you not?"

Varux looked at him.

"Because returning without an answer felt worse than continuing without one."

The words landed in Alias's chest like a stone.

Maris frowned. "That makes no sense."

"I know."

"Stop saying that."

Varux nodded once.

"Sorry," he said.

Rowan made a small, helpless sound. "That one might be worse."

Eldric had been quiet since they reached the marker. Now he walked to the stone and placed two fingers against the carved word for Maanhaven.

"People often mistake movement for progress," he said.

Varux's eyes flicked toward him.

"Going somewhere can feel like doing something," Eldric continued. "Especially when the alternative is facing the people who may ask why you failed."

The old mage did not sound accusing.

That made the sentence harder to hear.

Varux looked away.

"I did not fail," he said.

Eldric nodded. "No. You did not."

Varux seemed surprised by that.

"You made a choice," Eldric said. "Then you made the next choice. Then the next. A road does not become impossible to leave in one step. It becomes impossible because you keep finding reasons not to turn around."

The wind moved through the leaves. Somewhere beyond the trees, a crow called once and then fell silent.

Alias looked at the east road.

"So you did come back eventually," he said.

Varux did not answer.

Alias turned toward him. "Did you?"

The older version of him swallowed.

"Yes," he said.

"After three weeks?"

"No."

"How long?"

Varux's hand drifted toward the coin beneath his shirt.

"Not until later."

"How much later?"

"Alias."

"No. You do not get to say my name like that and hope I stop asking."

Varux flinched.

The others watched without speaking.

"How much later?" Alias asked again.

"Years."

The word was almost too quiet to hear.

Nobody moved.

"Years?" Rowan said.

Varux nodded.

"How many?"

"I do not remember the exact number."

"That is not possible," Maris said.

"It is when you are trying not to count."

Maris looked as if she wanted to argue, but she could not find a way through the answer.

Alias stared at Varux.

"You did not come back for years?"

"No."

"And they were still there?"

"Some of them."

The word some changed everything.

Varux saw it happen. Alias knew he did. The older version looked like he wanted to take the sentence back.

He did not.

"You said you would not tell us every bad thing," Alias said.

"I will not."

"But you keep dropping pieces of them on the ground and making us stand in them."

Varux closed his eyes.

"That is fair."

Alias laughed once, sharp and tired. "That is the first thing you have said today that I believe."

Corvin stepped between them before the argument could become something worse.

"North road," he said firmly. "We have lost enough daylight standing here."

Nobody argued.

Not even Varux.

They took the northern path.

For a while, Alias walked beside Corvin. Neither spoke. The road descended through low hills where the trees opened enough to show bands of gold sky between them. The air smelled of wet earth and pine.

After several minutes, Corvin said, "You do not have to forgive him because he is you."

Alias looked at him.

"I did not say I was going to."

"You do not have to hate him because he is you either."

"I did not say that."

"No. But you are thinking very loudly."

Alias scowled. "You cannot hear thoughts."

"I can hear boots. Yours are angry."

Alias looked down at his feet. His boots were muddy. They did not look angry.

"That is not a real thing," he said.

"It is enough of a thing."

Corvin's voice was calm. Not gentle exactly. Corvin rarely used gentle when practical would work.

"His choices are not yours," he said. "And your choices are not automatically better because you are angry at him."

Alias did not like that either.

"Everyone is suddenly wise today."

"That is because everyone except Rowan has tried thinking before talking."

From farther down the road, Rowan shouted, "I heard that!"

"Good," Corvin called back.

The group walked until the trees thinned and the road crossed a small meadow. A wagon stood crooked near the far fence.

At first, Alias thought it had been abandoned. Then he saw a woman crouched beside one wheel and a boy no older than ten holding a lantern that had not yet been lit. A mule stood in the harness, unhappily chewing at nothing.

The wheel had come loose from its axle.

Corvin noticed the problem at the same moment the woman looked up.

"We can help," he called.

The woman stood quickly, one hand moving to the small knife at her belt.

"We are not asking for money," Corvin added.

"That is usually what people say before asking for money," Rowan muttered.

Corvin ignored him.

The woman looked at the group one by one. She paused at Varux.

Alias saw it. The grey cloak. The scar. The strange quietness around him.

Then she looked at the sky.

"If you can get this moving before dark," she said, "you can have whatever food I have left."

"We have food," Corvin said. "We will take shelter in return if the rain comes back."

"Fair."

The work began immediately.

Corvin examined the axle. Maris found a solid branch at the edge of the meadow and helped strip it down. Rowan spoke to the mule in a soothing voice that became less soothing when the mule stepped on his foot. Eldric used no magic at first, only held the lantern while the woman worked.

Alias knelt beside Corvin and handed him tools.

Varux stayed back.

He did not seem to know where to stand.

The woman noticed.

"You have hands too, grey cloak," she said.

Varux blinked. "I do."

"Then use them."

Rowan grinned. "That is what I said yesterday."

Varux took off his cloak and set it on the grass. Without it, he looked less like a stranger and more like Alias's shadow made older.

He knelt beside the axle.

Corvin glanced at him. "Do you know wagons?"

"A little."

"That means no."

"It means I have fixed this one before."

Corvin stopped moving.

"What?"

Varux looked at the wheel.

"Not this wagon," he said quickly. "A wagon like it."

The woman snorted. "There are many wagons like it."

"Yes," Varux said. "There are."

He began working.

His hands knew what to do. He braced the axle, adjusted the split pin, and told Alias to hold the wheel steady while Corvin tightened the wood support. There was no magic in it. No prophecy. No impossible coin.

Only work.

The boy holding the lantern watched Varux carefully.

"Are you a ranger?" he asked.

Varux looked up.

"No."

"Then why do you look like one?"

Rowan made a noise that sounded suspiciously like he was trying not to laugh.

Varux considered the question.

"I have walked a long way," he said.

The boy nodded as if that explained everything.

"My mum says people who walk too far forget where home is."

The meadow went quiet.

The woman looked embarrassed. "Kellan."

"What? She does."

Varux's hands stopped on the axle.

Alias saw his face turn away before anyone else could notice it.

"Sometimes," Varux said softly, "they do."

The boy held up the lantern. "Then you should write it down."

Varux looked at him.

"Write what down?"

"Home."

Kellan said it as if it were obvious.

"Then when you forget, you can read it."

Nobody spoke.

The axle creaked as Corvin tested it.

Then he stood.

"That should hold until the next town," he said.

The woman climbed onto the wagon and took the reins. The mule gave a doubtful shake of its head but began moving when she clicked her tongue.

Kellan leaned over the side.

"Goodbye, grey cloak," he called.

Varux lifted one hand.

"Goodbye."

The wagon rolled down the road toward the west, its wheels bumping unevenly but holding.

Varux watched until it disappeared.

Alias stood beside him.

"You could have taken the east road," he said.

Varux did not look at him.



"Yes."

"You could have taken it just now."

"Yes."

"But you did not."

"No."

"Why?"

Varux was quiet.

"Because you were all here," he said.

It was not an apology.

It was not an answer either.

But for the first time, Alias understood a little of what the older version meant when he said he had come back to stop himself from leaving.

The road did not pull people away with ropes or magic.

Sometimes it only asked whether they wanted to keep walking.

They camped in the meadow that night.

The woman had pointed them toward a small abandoned shelter beyond the fence, a stone building with one missing shutter and a roof that was mostly intact. Rowan declared it the best roof in the world. Corvin declared it structurally questionable. Maris declared both statements unhelpful.

Eldric lit the fire.

Varux sat farther from it than everyone else again, but not as far as before.

Alias watched him for a while.

Then he got up and crossed the room.

Varux looked up.

"What is it?" he asked.

"I want to know what happens next."

Varux's face tightened.

"Next?"

"Not all of it. Not the bad parts you think will break us. I want to know what you expect us to do now that you are here."

The fire crackled between them.

Varux looked toward the blue journal in Maris's pack.

"I want to go backward," he said.

Alias frowned. "Backward where?"

"Through the road I took."

"To the east road?"

"Eventually."

"Why?"

Varux's voice was low.

"Because I cannot explain who I became from the end. You would only see the ruins. If you want answers, you need to see the choices in the order they happened."

Alias thought of the eastern road. The old milestone. The place where someone had chosen one night and lost years.

"You want us to retrace your life?"

"No." Varux looked at him. "I want you to retrace the places where I stopped coming home."

The words settled into the space between them.

"And then?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at the fire.

"Then maybe you can decide what you would do differently."

Alias wanted to say that he already knew.

He did not.

Outside, wind moved through the meadow grass. Somewhere far away, a wagon wheel turned toward home.

Alias looked down at the coin in his hand.

Then he closed his fingers around it.

"Tomorrow," he said, "you tell everyone."

Varux nodded.

"Tomorrow," he agreed.

For once, the word did not sound like an excuse.

It sounded like a place they might actually reach.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 8

### The Road Backward

#### *Shared Journal Entry 424*

*"Sometimes the only way to understand where you went wrong is to walk back until you find the moment you stopped asking for help."*

Varux was gone when Alias woke.

For one hard, stupid second, panic came before thought.

The old shelter was full of grey morning light. Corvin was asleep nearest the door, one hand still close to his knife. Maris had her cloak pulled over her head. Rowan was facedown beneath half a blanket, somehow taking up more space than anyone else. Eldric sat by the remains of the fire with both hands around a cup of tea.

But Varux's place was empty.

Alias was on his feet before he knew he had moved.

Eldric looked up.

"He is outside," the mage said.

Alias stopped.

"Outside where?"

"Outside the shelter."

"That is not helpful."

"It is accurate."

Alias pushed past the broken shutter and found Varux sitting beneath the low stone wall, a few steps from the door. His grey cloak was spread beside him. The blue journal lay open on his knees, but he was not reading it.

He was drawing.

A map covered the ground in front of him. Not one sheet of paper. Several. Lines joined other lines. Roads crossed rivers, passed villages, climbed ridges, stopped at circles marked in faded ink. Some names were crossed out. Others had been written so many times that the paper had nearly torn beneath them.

At the centre of the map, Varux had drawn a route in dark pencil.

It did not go forward.

It turned back on itself.

Alias stood there for a moment, waiting for Varux to notice him.

The older version of himself did not.

"What are you doing?" Alias asked.

Varux looked up quickly.

"Making a route."

"You already have maps."

"These are different."

"How?"

Varux looked down at the papers again. "These are mine."

That answer made Alias careful.

He stepped closer.

The route began at the shelter's general area and bent north-west through a part of the map Alias did not recognize. It passed a small symbol shaped like an open door, then wound south toward a larger circle drawn around a name written in blue ink.

THE HALL.

From there, the route continued in stages, each line darker than the one before it. One part had been circled twice. Another had a single letter beside it.

M.

"Is this where we are going?" Alias asked.

"Yes."

"All of it?"

"Eventually."

"Why does it go backward?"

Varux's pencil stopped.

For a second, he looked older than he had yesterday. Not older in years. Older in the way old roads looked after rain, when every wheel-mark showed at once.

"Because I have spent too long only looking ahead," he said.

Alias waited.

Varux put the pencil down.

"I told you I found answers in pieces," he continued. "I found them in the wrong order. I reached the end of things without understanding how I had begun. I went to places because I thought they mattered, but I did not stop to ask what I was leaving behind."

He tapped the map once.

"So we start with the last place where I was still close to all of you. Then we follow the path backward. Not to repeat it. To understand it."

"The Hall," Alias said.

"The Hall."

Eldric appeared in the doorway behind him. Alias had not heard him move.

"The Hall is north-west," the mage said. "Three days, if the road remains clear."

Varux nodded.

"Four if it rains," Corvin said from inside.

Alias turned. Corvin was awake now, standing in the shelter doorway with his arms folded. Maris leaned over his shoulder, her hair still untidy. Rowan had somehow woken too, though he looked offended about it.

"You have been listening?" Alias asked.

"Obviously," Corvin said.

"People discussing routes before breakfast should be required to speak louder," Rowan added. "It is rude to make me wake up curious."

Maris stepped outside and crouched beside the papers.

"This route is not only backward," she said. "It is layered."

Varux looked at her.

She pointed to the lines. "You have marked the places you reached later first. The Hall. Then the old observatory. Then the archive. Then..." Her finger paused above the circle marked M.

"Whatever this is."

"You should not know that name yet," Varux said.

Maris looked up. "Then you should stop writing it on maps."

Rowan made a quiet sound of approval.

Varux rubbed one hand across his face. "Fair."

"Who is M?" Alias asked.

The letters sat small and dark on the paper.

Varux's expression changed. It was not fear exactly. It was recognition, and something like grief.

"Someone who left me a warning," he said.

"Are they alive?" Maris asked.

"I do not know."

"Are they dangerous?"

"I do not know."

"Do they know you?"

Varux hesitated.

"Not exactly."

Rowan looked at Alias. "I am beginning to understand why you were angry."

Alias looked back at the map.

"Why not just go to M first?" he asked.

"Because I did that once."

"Was it wrong?"

Varux gave a tired half-smile. "It was not simple."

"That is not an answer."

"No."

"Then answer me."

Varux was quiet.

"Going straight to M is what I would have done," he said at last. "It is what I did. I thought one person, one page, one hidden room would explain everything. But the things I needed to understand were already behind me."

He looked toward the road beyond the meadow.

"I skipped the people who could have helped because I thought the answer was somewhere else."

Alias did not know what to say to that.

He thought of the woman with the wagon. The boy holding the lantern. Write down home.

"Then why do we go to the Hall first?" Corvin asked.

"Because it is the first place you will understand after the end of Book One," Varux said.

Everyone stared at him.

Varux blinked.

"That came out wrong."

"Book one?" Rowan asked.

"I mean..." Varux stopped. "After the beginning of this journey."

"That did not help," Maris said.

"I know."

Rowan pointed at him. "You said it again."

Varux sighed.

Eldric watched him with mild amusement, but when he spoke his voice was serious.

"You want them to walk backward through your choices."

"Yes."

"You want them to see the places that changed you."

"Yes."

"And you want them to reach the point where you left."

Varux did not answer.

He did not need to.

The silence became a shape on the map.



Alias looked at the eastern road in his mind, the old milestone, the place where a one-night trip had become years. He still did not understand how someone could keep walking that long.

But perhaps he was beginning to understand how one step could become another.

"So the Hall first," Alias said.

Varux nodded.

"The Hall first."

"Then what?"

"Then the observatory."

"Then?"

"The archive."

"Then?"

Varux looked at the line that led east.

"Then the road I took when I stopped coming home."

The morning had fully arrived now. Sunlight moved across the meadow, pale and bright. It caught on the damp grass and made every drop shine.

Rowan stepped outside, stretching his arms above his head.

"All right," he said. "I have a question."

Everyone looked at him.

"If we are walking backward through future-Alias's terrible choices, are we allowed to make fun of him while we do it?"

"No," Maris said.

"Somewhat," Corvin said at the same time.

Eldric sipped his tea. "Only if it is funny."

Rowan looked pleased. "A wise ruling."

Varux looked at Alias.

"Are you all right with this?" he asked.

Alias almost laughed.

There were too many things he was not all right with. An impossible coin. A second version of himself. A future made of missing years. A journal full of pages he did not know how to read.

But Varux had asked.

That mattered.

"I am not saying yes because you want me to," Alias said.

"I know."

"Stop."

Varux closed his mouth.

Alias looked at the map again.

"I am saying yes because I want answers."

The older version of him nodded slowly.

"Good," he said.

Maris gathered the loose pages with more care than Varux had used. "Then we should leave before Corvin invents a schedule with no breaks."

"I already have one," Corvin said.

"Of course you do."

Rowan peered over his shoulder. "Does it include lunch?"

"It includes survival."

"That is not the same thing."

"It usually is."

They packed.

The shared journal went into Maris's bag again. This time, before she closed the flap, Varux watched it for a long moment.

"You can hold it," she said.

Varux looked at her.

"I mean it," Maris continued. "It is yours too."

His expression tightened.

"No," he said. "Not yet."

Maris nodded once and closed the pack.

Alias did not miss the way Varux looked away afterward.

They left the meadow before the sun rose high.

The road north-west climbed slowly through hills dotted with black stone. For the first hour, nobody spoke much. It was not awkward. It was the kind of quiet that came after a decision had finally been made.

Corvin walked at the front with the map. Maris kept close beside him, adding notes where the road had changed from the old markings. Rowan moved ahead whenever he saw something interesting and then returned immediately if it turned out to be a bird, a rock, or a fence.

Varux walked beside Eldric.

Alias noticed that too.

At first, they spoke too quietly for him to hear. Then the path narrowed and Alias found himself close enough to catch pieces.

"You are certain?" Eldric asked.

"No," Varux said.

"Good."

Varux glanced at him. "Good?"

"Certainty can be useful. It can also become a prison."

Varux looked ahead.

"I know."

Eldric gave him a look.

Varux sighed. "I am sorry."

"That is not an improvement."

For the first time, Eldric smiled openly.

Alias almost smiled too.

They walked until the hills opened into a long view of the valley below. A river cut through the land in a shining curve. Beyond it, distant mountains rose blue against the sky.

Varux stopped.

The others did not at first. Then Rowan noticed he was not moving and turned back.

"What is it?" he asked.

Varux did not answer.

He was staring at the mountains.

Alias stepped beside him.

"Do you know this place?"

"Yes."

"From before?"

Varux nodded.

"My first real map ended there," he said.

He pointed toward the far mountains.

"I thought the world stopped after the ridge. I was wrong."

Rowan followed his finger. "Does it stop after the next ridge?"

"No."

"That seems unfair."

"Worlds are often larger than maps," Eldric said.

"Then maps need to become larger."

Corvin looked offended. "That is what maps do."

Varux's face softened as he watched them argue. It lasted only a moment, but Alias saw it.

Something warm.

Something remembered.

Then the older version looked toward the road again.

"We should keep moving," he said.

Corvin nodded. "Agreed."

They went on.

By afternoon, the sky had turned silver with cloud. The first drops of rain began just as they reached a roadside shrine made from three standing stones and a cracked bronze bowl.

Rowan ducked beneath the nearest stone.

"Roof," he announced.

"It is not a roof," Maris said.

"It is spiritually a roof."

Alias stopped beside the bowl. Someone had left a bundle of dried flowers there, tied with blue thread. The flowers had long since lost their colour.

Varux stood a few steps away.

"Did you leave those?" Alias asked.

Varux looked surprised.

"No."

"Then why are you looking at them like that?"

The older version stared at the flowers.

"Someone left flowers here once," he said. "A long time ago."

"Who?"

"I do not remember."

Alias looked at him.

Varux noticed.

"Not everything important stays clear," he said quietly. "That is another thing I learned too late."

The rain grew harder.

Eldric lifted one hand and a thin blue dome shimmered above them, just large enough to keep the worst of the rain from reaching the group.

Rowan looked up at it.

"You could have done that yesterday."

"I could have."

"Why did you not?"

Eldric considered this.

"Because I wanted you to appreciate roofs."

Rowan looked at the three standing stones.

"Fair."

They waited beneath the small shield of magic while the rain passed over the road.

Maris sat against one of the stones and took out the shared journal.

Varux noticed immediately.

"You are writing?" he asked.

"Yes."

"What?"

Maris looked at the page.

"That we chose the Hall."

Varux went quiet.

Maris continued writing.

"That we found an old shrine. That it rained. That Rowan called a standing stone a roof. That Corvin disagreed."

"I did disagree," Corvin said.

"You always do," Rowan replied.

Maris did not look up.

"That we are all here," she finished.

The phrase caught in the air.

Alias saw Varux close his eyes.

Not for long.

But long enough.

When he opened them, he did not ask to read the page.

He only said, "Write that part clearly."

Maris nodded.

"I will."

The rain slowed.

The blue shield faded.

Corvin stood and rolled the map shut.

"Hall first," he said.

"Hall first," Alias echoed.

Varux looked down the road that led north-west.

For once, he did not look afraid of where it went.

He looked afraid of what it might remember.

Then he began walking.

This time, the others followed not because he had chosen for them, but because they had chosen together.

The road curved away beneath the wet trees.

Behind them, the east road remained somewhere far away, waiting for a version of Alias who had once believed every answer lived at the end of it.

Ahead, the Hall waited.

And for the first time, they were walking toward the past on purpose.

\* \* \*

## PART II - WALKING THE WRONG ROAD

### Chapter 9

#### The Hall Once More *Shared Journal Entry 425*

*"Some places do not change when you leave them. That is why it hurts to return and find that you have."*

The Hall did not look smaller the second time.

Alias had expected it to.

He had expected familiarity to take some of the weight from it: to make the broken towers less tall, the old stone doorway less dark, the carved figures on the outer walls less watchful. They had already been here once. They had walked through its silent rooms, opened its doors, read the words it seemed to have been waiting centuries to show someone.

But when the road bent around the ridge and the Hall rose from the valley below, it looked larger than memory.

The building had no single shape. It spread across the hillside in long wings of pale stone, joined by narrow bridges and cracked towers. Windows stood empty in rows above the entrance. Vines climbed the walls as if the forest had been patiently trying to reclaim it one green hand at a time.

Above the main doors, the same inscription waited.

WELCOME, TRAVELERS.  
WHAT YOU SEEK MAY NOT BE WHAT YOU NEED.

Rowan read it aloud.

Then he looked at the building.

"I still do not like places that greet us before we have introduced ourselves."

"They are not greeting you," Maris said. "They are greeting travelers."

"I am a traveler."

"Unfortunately."

Corvin studied the route down into the valley. "We camp before entering. The sun is too low for an old building with unknown floors and a tendency to hide rooms."



"It only hid one room," Rowan said.

"That we found."

"Exactly. A successful number."

Eldric said nothing.

Varux had stopped at the edge of the ridge. The grey cloak tugged in the wind behind him. His hands were loose at his sides, but Alias could see the tension in them.

The Hall was not a place Varux had remembered from far away.

It was a place he had carried.

"Do you want to go down?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at him.

For once, the older version did not answer with a careful half-truth.

"No," he said.

The honesty surprised everyone.

"But we should," he added.

"Why?" Rowan asked.

"Because this is where I began making the wrong kind of sense."

Maris tilted her head. "What does that mean?"

Varux looked back toward the Hall.

"It means I found information and thought it was the same thing as understanding."

Eldric nodded slowly.

Alias noticed it. "You agree?"

"I have made that mistake," Eldric said.

Rowan stared at him. "You?"

"Once or twice."

"That is alarming."

"It should be."

They made camp on the ridge where the ground was dry and the valley could be watched from above. Corvin wanted an early start. Maris wanted to compare the notes she had taken during their first visit with the map Varux had made years later. Rowan wanted to know whether the Hall had a kitchen, because any building that large must have had one and therefore possibly still contained something edible.

"It has no kitchen," Maris said.

"You do not know that."

"I searched the western wing."

"You did not search for food."

"I was searching for knowledge."

"Then you were searching wrong."

Even Varux smiled at that. It was quick, almost hidden, but Alias saw it.

They ate near the fire while the Hall darkened below them. Shadows collected in its empty windows. The building did not glow or move. It did not need to. It had the patience of something that knew people would come inside eventually.

After dinner, Maris spread her notes on a flat stone.

"I wrote that the central doors opened only when Alias touched the lower symbol," she said. "I also wrote that the inscriptions changed after we entered."

"They changed because the coin reacted," Alias said.

"Yes. But why?"

"Because old magic enjoys being difficult," Rowan offered.

Eldric looked at the papers. "The Hall was built for Readers."

Varux's gaze lifted.

Maris noticed. "You knew that?"

"Not the first time," Varux said. "Later."

"How much later?"

He hesitated.

"Years."

Rowan sighed theatrically. "I should start collecting every time someone says years. I could buy a house."

"With what?" Corvin asked.

"Emotional damage."

"You cannot pay for a house with emotional damage."

"Then landlords are missing an opportunity."

Maris tapped one of the copied symbols. "Readers of what?"

"The world," Eldric said. "Or perhaps its history. The people who made this place believed knowledge could be carried between generations without being lost."

Varux looked at the Hall.

"They were wrong," he said.

The words were quiet. Too quiet.

Eldric did not disagree. "They were incomplete."

Varux glanced at him.

"Knowledge can be preserved," Eldric continued. "Understanding cannot. That must be made again by the people who inherit it."

Maris looked as if she wanted to write that down, but did not. Instead she folded the notes and placed them back in her pack.

The fire burned lower.

Alias found Varux standing away from the others at the edge of the ridge. The older version held his coin outside his shirt. Its scarred surface caught the firelight in dull flashes.

"You keep looking at it," Alias said.

Varux did not turn. "So do you."

"Mine does not look like it has been dropped off a mountain."

"It has."

Alias paused. "What?"

"Not yours. Mine."

"Why?"

Varux looked down at the coin.

"I was angry."

The answer was so unexpected that Alias almost laughed.

"At who?"

"Everyone."

"That seems practical."

"It was not."

"What happened?"

Varux tucked the coin back beneath his shirt. "Later."

Alias frowned.

Varux looked at him and raised both hands slightly.

"That was an honest later. Not a hiding later."

"I do not know the difference yet."

"I know."

Alias gave him a look.

Varux exhaled through his nose. "I am trying."

The wind moved across the ridge.

Below them, the Hall waited in darkness.

"Do you remember the first time we came here?" Alias asked.

Varux's face changed.

"Yes."

"Everything?"

"No."

"What do you remember?"

Varux looked down the hillside.

"Rowan complained about the stairs."

"That is believable."

"Maris found a book before anyone else."

"Also believable."

"Corvin spent half an hour deciding whether a bridge could be trusted."

"Very believable."

Alias waited.

"And me?" he asked.

Varux was silent.

"You stood at the doors," he said. "You were afraid, but you did not want anyone to notice. You touched the symbol with your whole hand."

Alias looked at his palm.

"I still have the mark," he said.

"I know."

"Did it hurt?"

"Not then."

That answer made Alias look up.

Varux did not explain.

The next morning, they entered the Hall.

The central doors opened the same way they had before. Alias placed his hand against the lower carved symbol, a circle crossed by three thin lines. The coin beneath his shirt warmed. Stone groaned somewhere deep inside the building.

Then the doors pulled inward.

Cold air rolled over them.

Rowan took one step through the entrance and stopped.

"It still smells like dust and bad decisions."

"That is not a smell," Maris said.

"It is here."

The entrance hall had changed very little. Broken mosaics covered the floor. Tall columns lifted into darkness. Along the walls, carved shelves stood empty except for a few blackened shapes that might once have been books or boxes.

Sunlight entered through gaps in the high ceiling and fell in pale bars across the dust.

Alias remembered standing here before. He remembered the feeling of being watched by a building that had no eyes.

Varux walked in last.

As he crossed the threshold, every candle bracket along the walls flickered blue.

The group froze.

The flames lasted only a second.

Then they vanished.

"That did not happen last time," Rowan said.

"No," Maris replied. "It did not."

Varux had gone pale.

Eldric looked at him. "Did it happen for you?"

"Not exactly."

"That phrase again," Corvin said.

Varux pressed one hand against the wall. "The Hall remembers Readers. It knows there are two of us."

Alias touched the coin under his shirt.

"Is that bad?"

"I do not know."

"That is becoming a problem too."

"I know."

Rowan raised a hand. "I would like to formally request that nobody say they know anything until they are prepared to explain it."

"Seconded," Corvin said.

Maris shook her head. "You cannot vote on language."

"We can vote on most things."

"You voted to call a standing stone a roof."

"It was spiritually a roof."

Eldric began walking toward the western corridor. "The records room is this way."

Varux stopped him.

"No."

Everyone turned.

The older Alias looked startled by his own voice.

"The records room is this way," he repeated, gesturing toward the eastern corridor.

Eldric studied him.

"We found it to the west."

"You found a records room to the west."

The difference hung in the air.

Maris stared at Varux. "There is another one."

"Yes."

"How do you know?"

"Because I found it later."

"How much later?"

Varux closed his eyes briefly.

"Years."

Rowan whispered, "House."

Corvin looked at the east corridor. "We agreed you would warn us about threats."

"I am."

"Is there a threat?"

"No."

"Then why did you stop Eldric?"

"Because the west room will give you pages you already know how to read." Varux looked at Maris. "The east room will give you pages you do not."

Maris's eyes narrowed with interest.

Eldric did not move.

"Are you certain?" he asked.

Varux looked toward the passage.

"No."

Eldric nodded.

"Good."

They went east.

The corridor was narrower than the western one. The walls bore faded murals: figures carrying lamps through a black forest; a child offering a book to an older woman; a circle of people gathered around a table covered in maps. Most of the faces had been worn smooth by time.

Maris slowed to study them.

"These are not Keepers," she said.

"What are they?" Alias asked.

"Travelers, maybe. Teachers. Families."

Varux looked at the mural of the table.

"They are Readers," he said.

"Not the special kind?" Rowan asked.

Varux shook his head. "The ordinary kind."

Rowan frowned. "There is an ordinary kind?"

"People who write things down so someone else does not have to begin from nothing."

That quieted him.

At the end of the corridor, they found a circular door cut into the stone. No handle. No symbol. Only a line of old text above it.

Maris stepped close enough to read.

"It says..." She frowned. "The words are damaged."



Eldric joined her. "Try the third word as carry, not keep."

Maris did.

Her expression changed.

"Those who carry nothing alone," she read slowly, "may enter."

No one moved.

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version was staring at the words as if they had struck him.

"What do we do?" Rowan asked.

"Maybe it wants us to hold hands," he added after a second.

Corvin looked horrified. "No."

"It is a possibility."

"It is not."

Maris placed one hand against the door.

Nothing happened.

Eldric tried next.

Nothing.

Alias stepped forward, but Varux caught his wrist.

Not hard.

Still, Alias pulled back.

"I said you do not get to decide things for me."

"I know." Varux released him immediately. "Sorry."

"Then why stop me?"

Varux looked at the door.

"Because I tried alone."

The words were barely more than breath.

Alias stared at him.

"What happened?"

Varux swallowed.

"The door opened."

"And?"

"I went inside."

"That is what doors are for."

"Not always."

The corridor seemed colder.

Varux looked at the others.

"I went inside alone. I thought I could read faster without stopping to explain things. I thought I would come back in an hour."

The old road, the old excuse.

One more hour.

"Did you?" Alias asked.

Varux shook his head.

"What happened inside?" Maris asked.

Varux did not answer.

Then Eldric stepped forward.

"We enter together," he said.

Corvin looked at the door. "How?"

Eldric turned to the group.

"By carrying something that belongs to someone else."

Rowan blinked. "Like a pack?"

"Perhaps."

Maris looked toward the blue journal in her bag.

Varux saw it too.

"No," he said immediately.

Maris frowned. "Why not?"

"Not that."

"Why?"

"Because I carried it in once."

The answer made everyone still.

"You carried the shared journal?" Alias asked.

"Not then. My journal. The first one."

"And it opened?" Maris asked.

"Yes."

"What happened?"

Varux looked at the floor.

"I stopped writing in it after."

That was not an answer, but it was enough to make Maris remove her hand from the bag.

Eldric took a small folded square of paper from his robe. It was old, almost soft at the edges.

"My first map," he said.

Rowan stared. "You keep your first map?"

"It is embarrassing."

"Now I need to see it."

"You will not."

Eldric held the paper out to Corvin.

"Take it," he said.

Corvin did.

Then Corvin placed one hand on Maris's shoulder. Maris gave Alias the blue journal. Alias handed it to Rowan. Rowan looked offended by the responsibility but accepted it with both hands.

Varux remained outside the circle.

Alias looked at him.

"Come here," he said.

Varux did not move.

"You said we enter together," Alias continued.

The older version looked at the door, then at the group.

"I do not think I should."

"Why?"

"Because last time I went in, I made it about me."

Alias stepped closer.

"Then do not do that this time."

Varux's face tightened.

It was not a victory. Alias could see that. It was a request Varux did not believe he deserved.

But after a moment, he stepped into the circle.

Alias took his wrist.

Not because the door demanded it.

Because he wanted to.

"Nobody goes alone," Alias said.

The others nodded.

Eldric spoke the words above the door in the old language. Maris repeated them. The stone beneath their feet trembled.

Then the circular door opened inward.

Beyond it lay a room full of shelves.

Not empty shelves.

Books filled them from floor to ceiling.

The sight stole the breath from all of them.

Some books were covered in dust. Some had cracked bindings. Some were wrapped in metal threads or sealed inside glass cases. But they were there. Hundreds. Thousands, perhaps. A whole hidden library waiting in the dark.

At the centre stood a round table.

On it rested one open book.

The pages were blank.

Rowan whispered, "That seems rude."

Maris walked toward it slowly.

Varux did not.

He stood at the doorway, staring at the blank book as if it were more dangerous than an arrow.

Alias looked at him.

"This is where you went alone," he said.

Varux nodded.

"What did it show you?"

The older version did not answer.

The blank pages began to darken.

Words appeared in thin blue ink.

Not for everyone.

Only for Alias.

WELCOME BACK, READER.

Alias felt the coin burn against his chest.

Then a second line wrote itself beneath the first.

YOU CANNOT WALK BACKWARD WITHOUT REMEMBERING WHY YOU RAN.

Varux made a sound behind him.

Not a word.

Not quite a breath.

Alias turned.

The older version had gone white.

The room did not look different. The books were still books. The table was still stone. The door remained open behind them.

But Varux was no longer seeing the room.

Alias knew that look now.

He had seen it at the east road.

At the bridge.

In the places where the future pressed too close.

"Varux?" he said.

The older Alias did not answer.

His hand went to the scar on his cheek.

The blue ink spread across the page.

The next words appeared slowly.

BURNED MEMORY I — THE ROAD ALONE.

Varux closed his eyes.

And the Hall disappeared.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 10

### Burned Memory I - The Road Alone

#### *Burned Memory I*

*"Memory did not return like a story. It returned like smoke: first the smell, then the sting, then the fire, later turned into ash."*

The Hall vanished.

Not all at once.

The shelves became shadows. The blue words on the blank page spread into the shape of a road. The smell of dust changed into wet earth, then cold smoke, then the sharp iron smell of rain on stone.

Alias tried to move.

His body did not listen.

He was standing somewhere else.

The sky was grey.

No. Not grey like clouds before a storm. Grey like colour had been washed from it and never returned. The road beneath his boots was narrow and broken, running east between black trees. Every branch leaned away from the wind.

He looked down at his hands.

They were older.

The scar across one knuckle was not there yet. The coin around his neck was brighter than Varux's, but it already carried the first thin mark across its crescent.

Alias knew, with the terrible certainty dreams sometimes gave, that he was not himself.

He was inside someone else's memory.

Or inside the part of himself that had become someone else.

Ahead, a small campfire burned beneath an overhang of stone.

Four bedrolls lay around it.

Rowan's was closest to the fire, half-unrolled and covered in crumbs. Maris's was placed neatly beside a stack of books, her pencil tucked into the fold of her blanket. Corvin's pack rested against a tree with the map case strapped closed twice. Eldric sat awake on a flat rock, one hand around a cup of tea.

At the centre of the camp stood a younger Alias.

Not the Alias watching.

The Alias who had not yet left.

He was nineteen. His fur was untidy from rain. His shirt sleeve had a tear at the wrist. A small travel bag rested at his feet, packed too carefully to be accidental.

The sight hurt.

Not because the younger Alias looked unhappy.

Because he looked certain.

Eldric looked up from his tea.

"You are awake early," he said.

The younger Alias froze.

For a moment, nobody else stirred.

"I could not sleep," he said.

"That is often true before a person does something foolish."

The younger Alias tried to smile. "You say that about everything."

"No. I say it about the things I recognize."

The fire snapped.

Alias - the one inside the memory - wanted to shout. He wanted to step between them. He wanted to grab his younger self by the shoulders and shake him until the road disappeared.

Do not go.

The words did not leave his mouth.

The younger Alias looked down at the bag.

"I found something in the pages from the Hall," he said.

Eldric did not ask where the pages were. He already knew.

"The copied page," he said.

"Yes."

"The one you said you would show Maris in the morning."



"I was going to."

Eldric took another sip of tea.

"Was?"

The younger Alias pulled a folded sheet from inside his shirt. Even from where he stood, the older Alias recognized the paper. The writing on it was cramped, faded, and copied from another hand.

A direction.

A place name.

A promise that something waited east of Veyr's Crossing.

Under the name, someone had written a single letter.

M.

"I think it mentions my mother," the younger Alias said.

The fire seemed to shrink.

Eldric looked at the page for a long time.

"Think?" he asked.

"It says a wolffolk woman crossed there with a human scholar. It says they were looking for the First Keepers."

"It says maybe."

"It says enough."

"Enough for what?"

The younger Alias's hand tightened around the page.

"To go."

Eldric did not move.

"You have a route already," he said.

"I can be gone one night."

"One night."

"Maybe two."

"On a road you have never walked."

"I have the map."

"Corvin's map does not show what you hope it will show."

"It shows the crossing."

"It shows a road."

The younger Alias looked toward the trees. The eastern road waited beyond them, invisible in the dark.

"I need to know," he said.

Eldric's expression softened.

That was worse than anger.

"I know," he said.

The younger Alias looked at him quickly, as if he had expected an argument and did not know what to do with understanding.

"I will come back," he said.

Eldric glanced at the packed bag.

"When?"

"Tomorrow."

The older Alias felt the word like a blade.

Tomorrow.

The younger version said it without fear. Without irony. With the clean certainty of someone who had never spent years learning how quickly tomorrow could become a place no one reached.

Eldric did not tell him no.

The older Alias remembered hating that later.

He remembered wanting Eldric to have stopped him. To have raised his voice. To have woken the others. To have taken the page and burned it in the fire.

But Eldric only said, "Leave a note."

The younger Alias nodded.

He pulled a small scrap of paper from his bag and wrote quickly by the firelight.

Gone east. Back tomorrow. Do not worry.

He hesitated, then added:

- Alias

Rowan shifted in his sleep.

The younger Alias looked at him.

For one second, he almost sat down.

The older Alias saw it. He saw the pause. He saw the choice still open, tiny and human and completely possible.

Then the younger Alias placed the note beneath Maris's notebook.

He took his bag.

And he walked away.

The memory moved with him.

The first morning alone felt easy.

That was what made it dangerous.

The road east of Veyr's Crossing was wet from rain, but it was clear enough to follow. The page gave directions in pieces: a fallen watchtower, a river bend, a black-stone marker shaped like a hand. The younger Alias found all three before noon.

He told himself Eldric had worried for nothing.

He told himself Rowan would make jokes about it when he returned with an answer.

He told himself Maris would be angry that he had gone without her, but only for a little while.

He told himself Corvin would complain about the route and then ask for every detail.

He told himself home was still behind him.

At midday, he found the first fork.

The left road led back west.

The right road continued east through a narrow cut between hills.

The copied page said east.

The younger Alias chose east.

The first night alone felt less easy.

He built a poor fire beneath a rock shelf and ate dry bread without tasting it. The forest was louder without Rowan. Every sound carried too far. Every branch moving in the dark sounded like someone approaching.

The paper lay beside him.

At first, it was only a small folded square like any other page.

Then, after midnight, ink began to move across it.

RETURN.

The younger Alias stared at the word.

The paper had never written to him like that before.

He picked it up.

"What?"

The word remained.

RETURN.

"I am coming back tomorrow."

The ink faded.

For a moment, the page was blank.

Then a new word appeared.

LATER.

The younger Alias folded the paper shut and pushed it into his pack.

The older Alias wanted to cry out.

He remembered this.

Not the details. Not the shape of the rock shelf or the exact sound of rain on leaves. Those had worn away with time. But he remembered the feeling: irritation. The strange anger at a page for telling him something he did not want to hear.

He had thought the Paper was being dramatic.

He had thought he had more time.

On the second day, the road vanished.

Not completely. There were still traces of it: old wheel ruts filled with moss, broken stones half-buried beneath roots, a rusted marker post leaning toward the ditch. But the path no longer knew where it was going.

The younger Alias kept walking.

He found a small village near sunset.

It had seven houses, a closed smithy, and a woman who looked at his coin too long before offering him a bed in the loft above her stable.

"Traveling alone?" she asked.

"Only for a night."

She looked at the mud on his boots.

"That is what people say when they do not want to explain why they are gone."

The younger Alias did not answer.

The woman did not ask again.

He lay awake in the loft listening to rain tap against the roof.

Tomorrow, he told himself.

Tomorrow he would reach Veyr's Crossing.

Tomorrow he would find the archive.

Tomorrow he would turn around.

On the third day, he reached the crossing.

It was not what he expected.

Veyr's Crossing was not a city or an old scholar's refuge. It was a muddy trading post built around a narrow bridge. Three wagons stood in the square. A dog slept beneath a cart. A man sold apples from a barrel and watched everyone with bored suspicion.

The younger Alias asked about the archive.

Nobody knew what he meant.

He asked about the First Keepers.

One man laughed.

He asked whether a wolffolk woman and a human scholar had passed through years ago.

The apple seller studied him.

"Lots of people pass through," he said. "That is what crossings are for."

The younger Alias showed the copied page.

The seller read it, frowned, then handed it back.

"Old writing," he said.

"Can you read it?"

"Not enough to help you."

"Do you know who M is?"

The seller shrugged.

"Everyone is someone else's initial."

The answer should have been nothing.

Instead, it felt like a door closing.

The younger Alias spent the rest of the day asking anyway.

He asked the innkeeper, the bridge keeper, the woman selling cloth, an old fisherman repairing nets by the river. He asked until the sun went down and the same answers began repeating in different voices.

No.

Maybe.

Never heard of it.

Try farther east.

The last answer was the one that trapped him.

Try farther east.

It sounded like progress.

It sounded like a reason not to return yet.

The older Alias watched the younger version leave the crossing the next morning with less food, less money, and more certainty than before.

He did not go west.

He went east.

Days broke apart.

The memory did not show each one. It showed the pieces that had burned deepest.

A ruined shrine where he found another copied symbol carved into the stone and convinced himself he was close.

A rainstorm that soaked his pack and blurred the ink on his map.

A traveler who offered him a ride west. The younger Alias refused because the wagon would take him away from the archive.

A letter.

Not a real letter. Not yet.

A page of the Paper, unfolded by itself beside his fire.

MARIS IS ANGRY.

The younger Alias stared at it.

"How do you know that?"

The Paper wrote:

I KNOW MANY THINGS.

"Then tell her I am fine."

The page stayed blank.

"Tell her I will come back tomorrow."

Again, nothing.

Then:

WRITE IT YOURSELF.

The younger Alias crumpled the page in his hand.

The Paper tore.

He froze.

For a second, he tried to smooth it flat again.

The tear remained.

The older Alias felt the shame of it even now.

Not because he had damaged magic paper.

Because that had been the first time he had been given a way home and treated it like an inconvenience.

He did not write.

On the seventh day, he reached the place marked on the copied page.

There was no archive.

Only a hill covered in black stones and a collapsed watchtower whose roof had fallen long ago. He searched until his hands bled. He moved loose rocks. He climbed through the tower's broken lower rooms. He found old bird nests, a rusted buckle, a strip of red cloth caught beneath a stone.

No hidden door.

No records.

No answer.

At sunset, he sat on the tower steps and watched the road west turn gold in the distance.

He could still go back.

The thought came clearly.

He knew it was true.

He could walk west. He could return to the camp. He could say he had been wrong. He could give Maris the page. He could let Corvin study the route. He could let Rowan complain. He could sit across from Eldric and admit that he had gone alone because he had been afraid someone would tell him no.

He could go home.

The younger Alias pressed his hands over his face.

Then he opened the copied page again.

There, at the bottom, beneath the directions he had followed, was a phrase he had ignored before.

Not the first door. The door after.

He looked toward the eastern hills.



He stood.

The older Alias felt something inside himself break.

No, he tried to say.

No. Do not do it again.

But the memory had already chosen.

The younger Alias went east.

The road became colder after that.

The memory blurred through weeks.

A village with snow still on the roofs.

A different map bought from a merchant who lied about the scale.

A message from the Paper:

ROWAN ASKED IF YOU ARE DEAD.

The younger Alias read it by a fire that barely warmed his hands.

"Tell him no."

The Paper wrote:

TELL HIM.

The younger Alias put the page away.

A month passed.

Then another.

The people in the memories became thinner. Not literally. The younger Alias simply stopped seeing them properly. He passed strangers without asking names. He slept in empty barns and ruined shelters. He learned to keep his coin hidden. He learned which berries made him sick. He learned to hear footsteps before they reached his fire.

He learned to be alone.

And because he was learning it, he told himself he had to continue.

That was the lie.

The road did not demand that he keep walking.

It only became easier to walk than to return.

The memory shifted again.

Winter.

The younger Alias stood outside a tavern in a town he did not know. Snow had gathered in his fur. His hands were wrapped in torn cloth. A warm orange glow shone through the window.

Inside, people were laughing.

For a moment, he saw Rowan's face in every movement. Corvin's hand holding a mug. Maris bent over a book. Eldric sitting in a corner with tea.

Then the vision disappeared.

They were strangers.

The younger Alias stayed outside.

He did not go in.

The older Alias remembered why.

He had no answer.

He had nothing to say.

He had been gone too long to walk back in and pretend it was only one night.

The Paper appeared in his pocket after dark.

The torn edge had been repaired somehow. Not perfectly. A thin white line remained through the page.

It wrote one sentence.

THEY WOULD HAVE LET YOU IN.

The younger Alias stared at it until the ink blurred.

Then he folded it shut.

He did not burn it.

He wanted to.

The thought had come often by then. Burn the Paper. Burn the notes. Burn the maps. Burn every reminder that he had failed to return.

But he could not.

Not because he was brave.

Because some part of him still wanted to be found.

The memory began to fade.

The snow became dust.

The tavern window became blue light.

The lonely road became the blank page in the hidden library.

Alias stumbled backward into himself.

He was back in the Hall.

The books stood around him. The stone table was cold beneath his hand. Maris had one arm around his shoulders. Rowan was saying something, but it took a moment for the words to become clear.

"Alias? Hey. You are here."

He was breathing too fast.

Across the room, Varux stood by the doorway with both hands pressed against the stone.

He looked worse than Alias felt.

The older version of him had not watched the memory.

He had lived it again.

The blank book lay open on the table.

The blue words had vanished.

Only one sentence remained.

YOU CANNOT WALK BACKWARD WITHOUT REMEMBERING WHY YOU RAN.

Nobody spoke.

Then Varux said, "I had meant to be gone one night."

His voice cracked on the last word.

It was the first time Alias had heard him sound young.

Not thirty-seven.

Not mysterious.

Not like a warning wearing his face.

Just young.

And alone.

Eldric stepped closer to him.

"You came back," the mage said.

Varux gave a small, bitter laugh.

"Eventually."

Eldric did not look away.

"Eventually is still a direction."

Varux stared at the floor.

Alias looked at the shelves of books around them. At the open page. At the old Paper tucked into his own pack, waiting silently.

He thought of the younger Alias sitting outside the tavern in the snow.

They would have let you in.

His anger was still there.

But it had changed.

It was no longer only anger at Varux for leaving.

It was anger at the road for making loneliness sound like a punishment people deserved.

Alias stepped toward the older version of himself.

"Next time," he said, "you tell us before you run."

Varux looked up.

"Next time?" he asked.

Alias held his gaze.

"You said we are walking this road backward."

Varux's face went still.

"We are," he said.

"Then you do not walk the next part alone."

For a second, Varux looked like he might refuse.

Then he nodded.

"All right," he said.

This time, when he said it, Alias believed him a little.

The Hall did not feel warmer.

But the door behind them was still open.

And nobody left through it alone.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 11

### Echoes Revisited

#### *Shared Journal Entry 426*

*"An echo is not a second chance. It is proof that something was real enough to remain."*

For a while, no one moved.

The hidden library had returned to itself. The blue words were gone from the open book. The shelves stood in their patient rows around the room, untouched by the memory they had just forced into the air.

Alias could still smell snow.

It made no sense. The Hall was dry and cold, not winter-cold. Yet he could almost hear the wind against the tavern wall from the memory. He could still see the younger version of himself standing outside the orange window while strangers laughed inside.

They would have let you in.

The sentence would not leave him alone.

Varux was the first to move.

He stepped away from the doorway and sank down against the wall. Not dramatically. Not like someone collapsing. More like someone who had been holding himself upright for too long and had finally run out of reasons.

Eldric crouched beside him.

"You are here," the mage said.

Varux looked at the floor. "I know."

Eldric did not correct him.

Alias watched the older version of himself press one palm against his eyes. The scar across his cheek looked sharper now. He looked exhausted in a way Alias had not understood before.

Not tired from the road.

Tired from remembering it.

Maris approached the table. The blank book still lay open in the center, its pages pale and empty. She did not touch it at first.

"It called that a Burned Memory," she said.

Rowan, who had been unusually quiet since the memory ended, looked at her. "That sounds bad."

"It sounds deliberate," Corvin said.

"Those can be the same thing."

Maris nodded slowly. "It did not show us everything. It showed a chain of choices."

Varux lowered his hand.

"A chain is still a prison if you keep adding links," he said.

The words were not addressed to anyone in particular.

Alias stepped closer to the table. His coin had stopped burning, but warmth still pulsed under his shirt. He looked down at the blank page.

"Why did it show us that?" he asked.

Eldric stood.

"Because the Hall keeps records," he said. "Perhaps it believed this was one you needed."

"Needed?" Alias repeated. "It showed him failing for years."

"It showed him leaving," Eldric said. "There is a difference."

Varux laughed once, without humor. "Not to the people I left."

The room fell quiet again.

Then Rowan walked over and sat beside Varux on the floor.

No one had asked him to.

He simply did it.

Varux looked sideways. "What are you doing?"

"Sitting."

"I can see that."

"Good. Then you have no reason to ask."

Varux stared at him.

Rowan folded his arms. "You looked like you were about to start saying sorry again. I am preventing that."

For a second, Alias thought Varux might tell him to leave.

Instead, the older version lowered his head.

"That is not a real method," he said.

"It is now."

Corvin looked toward the shelves. "We should make use of the room while we are here. The memory may have been the point of entering, but it cannot be the only thing hidden in a library this large."

Maris brightened slightly. There were still shadows under her eyes, but a room full of unknown books was stronger than most worries.

"Agreed," she said. "We document the shelves, look for dates, maps, repeated names, anything connected to the Hall or the observatory."

"The observatory?" Alias asked.

Varux looked up.

"I marked it on the route," he said. "It was the next place I went after the Hall. Not immediately. But it is connected."

"Connected how?"

"I do not know."

Rowan stared at him.

Varux held up a hand. "I know how that sounds."

"That is not the problem," Rowan said. "The problem is that you keep being mysterious in rooms that are already mysterious. It feels greedy."

A small smile pulled at Maris's mouth before she could stop it.

Corvin opened his map case. "Library first. Observatory later."

They divided the room.



Maris took the shelves closest to the open book. Corvin moved toward a row of bound maps stacked in narrow compartments. Eldric began reading the oldest volumes, testing their pages with a careful touch before opening them. Rowan volunteered to look for food, received three disapproving stares, then agreed to check the lower shelves for anything that looked useful.

Alias stood in the middle.

Varux was still against the wall.

"You should help," Alias said.

Varux looked at the books. "I do not know where to begin."

"That is new."

"Not really."

Alias hesitated. Then he picked up a thin volume from the nearest shelf and held it out.

"Here."

Varux looked at it.

The cover was dark green, cracked across the spine. No title appeared on the front. A small symbol had been stamped into the lower corner: a circle crossed by three lines.

The Reader mark.

"I read that one," Varux said.

"Then read it again."

He did not take the book.

"Why?"

"Because I am asking you to."

The older Alias looked at him for a long moment.

Then he accepted it.

Their fingers touched for half a second.

Varux pulled his hand back first.

He opened the book.

The first page contained only one sentence.

A Reader does not own what they learn.

Varux went still.

Alias read over his shoulder.

The next line appeared as they watched.

A Reader carries it until it can be shared.

Neither of them spoke.

Then the ink faded, leaving an ordinary page covered in faded handwriting from someone who had lived centuries before them.

"That was not there before," Alias said.

"It was," Varux replied. "I think."

"You think?"

"I read this book alone. I read it like a lock. I was looking for the key. I did not look at the door."

Alias frowned. "That does not mean anything."

"I know."

Varux stopped himself.

This time, he smiled. It was tired, but real.

"Sorry," he said. "It means I only looked for what would help me leave."

Alias looked again at the page.

A Reader does not own what they learn.

He thought of the blue journal. Of Varux carrying it through years he would not read. Of the younger version leaving without telling anyone what he had found.

"Then maybe the Hall is showing us different things because we are here together," he said.

Varux looked at him.

"Maybe," he said.

Across the room, Maris made a sound that was halfway between a gasp and a triumphant shout.

Everyone looked over.

"I found a catalogue," she said.

Rowan lifted a book from the shelf beside him. "Is it edible?"

"No."

"Then I found nothing."

Maris ignored him. She carried a heavy volume to the central table and opened it carefully. Its pages were thick, each one divided into columns of ink. Most entries had faded, but some had been preserved by the strange dry air of the room.

"These are records of rooms," she said. "Not books. Rooms. Places visited by Readers."

Corvin stepped beside her.

"Can you read the headings?"

"Some."

She traced the first column.

"Hall of Carrying. Archive of Unasked Questions. Silent Observatory." Her finger paused. "And here."

The entry beside it had been crossed out by an old black line.

"Road of Returning," Maris read.

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version had gone still again.

"Is that a place?" Alias asked.

"No," Varux said.

"It is in the catalogue."

"It is not a place in the way you mean."

"That is not an answer."

Varux pressed two fingers to the page.

"The Road of Returning is a path between structures," he said. "Or it was. I never found it."

Maris looked at the crossed-out line.

"Then why is it here?"

"Because someone expected it to exist."

Eldric studied the page over her shoulder.

"Or someone wanted it to."

The distinction sat heavily in the room.

Rowan stopped pretending to search for food.

"Can we use it to get him home?" he asked.

The question came out more quietly than anyone expected.

Varux looked at him.

"I do not know."

Rowan nodded once, like he had expected the answer and did not like it.

Maris turned a page.

"This entry has a reference number. The Silent Observatory is marked with the same symbol as the Hall."

Corvin leaned closer. "Route?"

"Not exactly. But there is a note in the margin."

She read it silently first.

Then again.

"What?" Alias asked.

Maris's face had gone pale.

"It says: When the sky has no answer, look for the room that listens."

Rowan looked upward at the ceiling.

"That is not enough information to find anything."

"It might be," Eldric said.

"The observatory," Varux murmured.

Maris looked at him. "You knew that note?"

"No."

"Then how did you know the observatory came next?"

Varux opened his green book again. He turned through several pages, then stopped at one near the middle.

"There was a map," he said. "Not a full map. A drawing of a hill with a building on top. I thought it was a clue to M."

"Was it?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at the old ink.

"I never found out."

The answer did not feel like a secret. It felt like a missing piece.

Corvin took the catalogue and read the entries from the beginning. "If the observatory is next, we need to know how far."

Varux looked reluctant.

Then he reached into his pack and pulled out the folded map from that morning. He placed it beside Corvin's.

"Two days from here," he said. "Maybe three if the northern pass is closed."

"You have been there?" Corvin asked.

"Yes."

"What did you find?"

Varux hesitated.

"A lot of empty rooms."

Rowan stared.

"That is it?"

"No."

"Then what?"

Varux looked at the doorway.

"The sky."

No one knew what to do with that.

Maris did. She began taking notes.

The next few hours passed differently from the first.

The Hall did not become safe. The hidden library did not stop feeling strange. But the room grew less silent. Corvin and Maris argued over whether the catalogue had been sorted by place or by purpose. Rowan found a sealed tin containing dried fruit and announced that he had always believed libraries were secretly designed for his needs. Eldric found a book of old star charts and sat down with it beneath a shelf.

Alias and Varux read together.

Not every book changed.

Most were ordinary records: notes on ruined roads, observations about animals, copied pages of laws no one still followed. One contained thirty pages describing the correct way to preserve ink. Rowan called it "the most dangerous book in the room," and Maris told him he was not allowed to touch it.

But every so often, a page reacted.

When Alias touched a book of travel records, blue lines appeared beside a paragraph about a flooded bridge. Varux looked over and said, "That happened after I came back."

"When?" Alias asked.

"Later."

Alias gave him a look.

Varux sighed. "After the flood. That is all I know."

It was not much, but he had answered.

When Varux touched a thin book of letters, one page opened by itself. The handwriting on it was not theirs. It belonged to someone called Liora, who had written:

I kept the lamp on. You did not come home, but I kept it on anyway.

Varux closed the book immediately.

Alias did not ask why.

He did not need to.

Near sunset, Eldric found the echo.

It was hidden in a narrow mirror at the far end of the room. At first Alias thought it was only a sheet of dark glass set into the wall. Then Eldric brushed dust from the frame and the surface moved.

Not like water.

Like memory.

Shapes appeared inside it.

The main hall.

Their first visit.

Alias saw himself - the past version of himself, only days ago - standing in front of the entrance doors with his hand on the lower symbol. Rowan was pacing in a circle. Corvin was studying a crack in the floor. Maris had her notebook open. Eldric stood near the wall with his hands folded behind his back.

They were all there.

The echo had no sound at first.

Then it did.

"Do you think it bites?" past Rowan asked.

"It is a door," past Corvin replied.

"That has not answered the question."

"It is not supposed to."

Past Alias looked nervous. He rubbed his thumb against the coin under his shirt.

Maris noticed.

"You do not have to touch it alone," she said.

"I know," past Alias replied.

"That is not what I said."

Then Corvin stepped beside him. Rowan stood on his other side. Eldric placed one hand gently between Alias's shoulders.

The past version of Alias put his hand on the symbol.

The doors opened.

The echo paused there.

Varux had come to stand beside the mirror.

He did not speak.

His face had gone completely still.

Alias looked at him.

"You remembered that?" he asked.

Varux shook his head.

"Not like this."

The echo moved again.

Past Rowan rushed through the entrance first and immediately tripped over a broken tile. Maris laughed. Corvin tried to help him up while insisting he had told him to watch the floor. Eldric looked toward past Alias and smiled.

The echo faded.

The mirror became dark glass again.

Nobody spoke for a long time.

Then Varux said, "I was happy."

The words were almost too quiet to hear.

Alias looked at him.

Varux still watched the empty mirror.

"I forgot that part," he said.

Something in Alias's chest hurt.

Not because the older version had forgotten.

Because he had needed a room full of old books to remind him.

Maris stepped closer to the mirror.

"It kept that moment," she said.

"Why?" Rowan asked.

"Because it mattered," Eldric said.

Varux shook his head slightly. "It was small."

Eldric looked at him.

"Small things are often what survive."

The room had grown dark around them.



Corvin packed the maps. Maris returned the catalogue to its shelf but left a narrow ribbon of cloth marking the observatory page. Rowan divided the dried fruit into equal portions and gave Varux one without making a joke about it.

Alias waited until the others were near the door.

Then he turned to Varux.

"You said you forgot being happy," he said.

Varux nodded.

"Do not do that again."

The older version looked surprised.

Alias did not know why he had said it. Maybe because the echo had made something clear. Maybe because he was angry at a future that could take people, years, colours, and even the memories that had made the road worth walking.

Varux's eyes softened.

"I will try," he said.

Alias frowned.

Varux smiled faintly.

"That was not a promise," he added. "It was an answer."

Alias considered it.

"Better," he said.

They left the library together.

The circular door closed behind them with a soft scrape of stone. The Hall's corridors were darker now, but the route back to camp was familiar. For the first time since returning, Alias did not feel as if the building was watching them leave.

It felt as if it had shown them what it was holding and was waiting to see what they would do with it.

Outside, night had fallen over the valley.

The first stars appeared between the clouds.

Varux stopped beneath the entrance inscription and looked toward the north.

"The observatory is that way," he said.

Alias joined him.

"Then that is where we go next."

Varux nodded.

The road ahead was still unknown.

But somewhere beyond the dark hills, a room was waiting to listen.

And this time, no one would arrive alone.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 12

### The Silent Observatory *Shared Journal Entry 427*

*"The sky does not answer every question. Sometimes it only shows you how small your answer has been."*

The observatory appeared on the second evening.

At first Alias thought it was another peak.

The mountains had been rising around them all day, layer after layer of dark stone and wet pine. Clouds dragged low across the slopes. The northern pass had narrowed into a path that zigzagged above a gorge, where meltwater thundered somewhere below without ever showing itself.

Then the mist lifted.

A round black dome stood on the ridge ahead.

It had no windows. No banners. No obvious doorway from this distance. It looked less like a building than a stone dropped from the sky and forgotten by the mountain.

Rowan stopped walking.

"That," he said, "is not a comforting place."

"Most observatories are not designed for comfort," Maris said.

"Then observatories need better designers."

Corvin studied the slope. "We can reach it before dark if we keep moving."

"That is always your answer," Rowan said.

"It has kept us alive so far."

"That is because we have not found a place that serves dinner."

Varux had not said anything since the dome came into view.

Alias glanced back at him.

The older version stood in the middle of the path with his hood down, rain darkening the fur around his ears. He was looking at the observatory as though it had just called his name.

"You remember it," Alias said.

Varux nodded once.

"I remember the road," he said.

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

"Do you remember what is inside?"

Varux's gaze stayed fixed on the dome.

"Mostly empty rooms."

"Mostly?"

"I found one room that was not empty."

Rowan groaned. "You know, in a normal group, that would be useful information."

"It is useful information."

"It is haunted information."

Maris looked at Varux. "What was in the room?"

The older Alias hesitated.

"A telescope."

Rowan blinked. "That is it?"

"No."

"Then why did you stop there?"

Varux rubbed one hand against the side of his neck. "Because it was pointed at nothing."

Nobody spoke for a moment.

Eldric watched the dome.

"Nothing is not always empty," he said.

Rowan looked toward the dark sky. "That sounds like the beginning of an explanation I will regret asking for."

Corvin adjusted the strap of his pack. "We can discuss philosophy under a roof. Move."

They reached the observatory just before the rain began.

The path ended at a wide platform cut into the ridge. Half of it had collapsed into the gorge, leaving a sharp broken edge where the mountain fell away. The dome stood at the far side, built from black stone fitted so closely that even centuries of rain had not opened a crack between the blocks.

A single door faced the platform.

It was tall, circular at the top, and plain except for three carved marks in the stone above it: a star, an open eye, and the Reader symbol.

Alias felt his coin warm.

Varux's coin did not answer.

That worried him more than if it had.

The door opened when Alias placed his palm on the Reader symbol.

No one was surprised anymore.

That was probably not good.

Inside, the observatory smelled of cold metal and old rain. A spiral stair led upward through the center of the building. Narrow passages branched from it at every level, disappearing into rooms whose doors had either fallen away or sealed themselves long ago.

The first floor was empty except for broken tables and copper instruments whose uses had been lost with the people who made them.

The second contained shelves of cracked lenses, some no larger than a coin, others wide enough to cover Alias's chest.

The third had no floor.

Instead, a narrow walkway curved around the outer wall, leaving an open shaft in the center where wind rose from somewhere below. The sound it made was low and steady.

Like breathing.

Rowan stopped at the edge of the walkway.

"No," he said.

Corvin did not look at him. "It is safe."

"You said that about a bridge two days ago."

"The bridge was safe."

"The bridge was emotionally unsafe."

Maris peered over the railing. "The shaft goes all the way down."

"Wonderful," Rowan said. "A building with a hole in it."

Varux stood at the wall, looking at the staircase leading upward.

"The telescope is at the top," he said.

"Then that is where we go," Alias replied.

The older version looked at him.

"You do not have to."

"I know."

Varux waited.

Alias sighed. "Sorry. I mean I want to."

That was different. Varux seemed to understand it.

They climbed.

The stairs were narrow and wet in places where rain had found its way through the dome. Their footsteps echoed around the circular walls. The higher they went, the stronger the wind became.

At the top waited another door.

This one was not plain.

Words had been carved around its rim in several rings, one inside the next. Maris wiped away centuries of dust with the edge of her sleeve and began to read.

"Outer ring is a warning," she said. "Something about... silence."

"That seems fitting," Rowan muttered.

"The middle ring is harder." Maris leaned closer. "It says: The sky hears no voice that is spoken only to itself."

Corvin frowned. "What does that mean?"

Eldric looked at the door.

"It means a person can stare upward forever and still refuse to listen."

Rowan lifted one hand. "I would like to vote against the door speaking in riddles."

"It is not speaking," Maris said.

"Then the wall is speaking in riddles."

"That is not better."

Varux had gone quiet again.

Alias stepped closer to him.

"You went in alone," he said.

The older Alias nodded.

"Did the door open for you?"

"Yes."

"How?"

Varux looked at the words.

"I told it what I wanted."

"What did you want?"

The answer took too long.

"An answer."

Alias waited.

Varux gave a small, bitter smile. "It did not appreciate the lack of detail."

"So it opened anyway?"

"Eventually."

"Because?"

"I said I would not leave until it did."

Rowan stared at him. "That is your solution to doors?"

"It used to be."

Corvin crossed his arms. "And now?"

Varux looked at the group.

"Now I ask better questions."

Eldric stepped toward the door. "Then ask one."

The older Alias looked startled.

"What?"

"You know what you want from this place. Say it."

Varux's eyes shifted toward Alias, then away.

The wind pressed against the dome above them.

"I want to know why I came here," he said.

Nothing happened.

Maris traced the middle ring again.

"The sky hears no voice that is spoken only to itself," she repeated.

Alias looked at Varux.

"Maybe it does not want what you want," he said.

Varux blinked. "What?"

"Maybe it wants you to say who you want it for."

The words left Alias before he had time to think about them.

Everyone looked at him.

Varux's face changed.

He looked at the door for a long time.

Then he said, "I want to know how to stop leaving people behind."

The observatory shook.

Not violently. Not enough to throw them from their feet. But the stone under their boots gave a low, deep sound, as if something inside the mountain had turned over in sleep.

The carved words filled with blue light.

A line appeared beneath them.

NOT BY LOOKING AWAY FROM THEM.

The circular door opened.

Beyond it was the telescope room.

It was larger than Alias expected. The dome overhead was split by a thin opening that ran from one side to the other. Through it, the sky showed as a narrow dark line.

At the center of the room stood a telescope made of black metal and pale glass. It was taller than Corvin, mounted on a complicated ring of gears. The lens faced upward.

Or it should have.

Instead, it pointed directly at the floor.



Rowan stared at it.

"That seems wrong."

"It is not broken," Maris said. She moved closer, careful not to touch the machinery. "The gears are locked deliberately."

"Why would an observatory point its telescope at the ground?" Alias asked.

Varux walked toward it slowly.

"Because it is not looking at the sky," he said.

"What is it looking at?"

Varux did not answer.

Eldric placed his hand on one of the outer rings. "The room that listens," he said.

The words from the catalogue returned to Alias's mind.

When the sky has no answer, look for the room that listens.

Maris stood beside the telescope and read the markings engraved around its base.

"They are not star names," she said. "They are dates."

"Dates from when?" Corvin asked.

"I do not know yet."

Rowan looked through the side of the telescope, though the lens pointed down. "Can anyone see anything?"

"Do not touch it," Maris snapped.

"I am not touching it."

"You are leaning on it."

"I am emotionally leaning on it."

Varux almost laughed.

Then the telescope moved.

The gears clicked once.

Rowan jumped backward.

The lens turned slowly, grinding through a small arc until it faced a dark brass plate set into the floor. At the center of the plate was a circle the size of a coin.

Alias's coin burned hot.

Varux took a step away from the machine.

"No," he said.

The word was not loud.

It was enough to stop everyone.

"What?" Alias asked.

"Do not put the coin there."

"Why?"

Varux's jaw tightened.

"Because I did."

The wind outside the dome rose, filling the room with a low, hollow sound.

"What happened?" Maris asked.

Varux looked at the brass plate.

"It showed me the sky."

"That is what telescopes do," Rowan said.

"No." Varux's voice cracked. "It showed me every place I had been when I should have been somewhere else."

The room went quiet.

Alias looked at the circle in the floor.

"What did you see?"

Varux swallowed.

"Campfires. Roads. Empty rooms. The roof of a tavern in the snow. A bridge. The Hall." He looked down. "Then it showed me Maanhaven."

Alias felt the name settle heavily into the room.

"Maanhaven?" Corvin asked.

"Home," Varux said.

Nobody spoke.

The telescope clicked again.

Blue light spread beneath the brass plate.

A single sentence appeared in the air above it.

WHAT DID YOU MISS?

Alias stared at the words.

Rowan spoke first, quietly.

"That seems personal."

Varux took another step backward.

"I cannot do this again."

Eldric turned toward him. "You do not have to do it alone."

"I did not say I wanted to do it."

"No," Eldric said. "You said you were afraid."

Varux looked at him.

The older Alias's hands had started shaking.

Alias saw it. So did everyone else.

For a second, the future version of him looked as though he might run.

The door stood open behind him. The spiral stairs waited. The road beyond the observatory was still there, even if they could not see it.

Alias stepped between Varux and the door.

Not close enough to trap him.

Close enough that he had to see him.

"What did you miss?" Alias asked.

Varux laughed once. It was a terrible sound.

"Everything."

"No."

The answer surprised them both.

Alias looked at the brass plate, then back at Varux.

"You did not miss everything. You are here."

Varux's face tightened.

"I missed enough."

"Then say one thing."

"Alias."

"One thing."

The telescope hummed.

The blue words waited.

Varux looked at the floor.

Then he said, "Dinner."

Rowan blinked.

"What?"

Varux's eyes closed.

"Dinner at Gerhardt's tavern," he said. "Rowan complaining about soup. Corvin trying to read maps while Maris corrected him. Eldric drinking tea because he said the tavern coffee was an insult to plants." His voice broke. "I missed sitting down when I did not have to leave again in the morning."

The room became very still.

The words in the air changed.

WHAT YOU MISSED STILL MATTERS.

The telescope moved.

This time, it pointed upward.

The dome opened.

Stone panels slid away without sound, revealing the full night sky.

Stars spilled over the room.

For a moment, nobody could speak.

The clouds had gone while they climbed. The sky above the mountain was enormous and sharp with light. The telescope's lens caught it all, drawing thin blue lines between stars that had seemed scattered a moment before.

Maris stepped forward first.

"They are moving," she whispered.

They were.

The lines shifted. Not randomly. They connected stars into roads, circles, doors, rivers. A map formed above them, made of light.

At the center was a familiar mark.

The Hall.

Then a line ran north to the observatory.

Another ran south-east.

Hollow Creek.

Corvin stepped beside Maris. "That is our route."

"No," Maris said. "It is a record of routes."

The blue map tightened.

A point of light appeared at Hollow Creek, blinking slowly.

Then another word appeared above the telescope.

LISTEN THERE.

Rowan looked at the stars.

"To what?"

No answer came.

The map faded.

The dome remained open.

For several seconds, everyone stood beneath the stars without speaking.

Varux had not moved.

Alias turned to him.

"You saw Maanhaven last time," he said.

Varux nodded.

"And now?"

The older version looked up at the sky.

"Now I saw the road back to it."

Alias followed his gaze.

It was not an answer. Not a promise. The sky did not tell them that anyone would be waiting, or that the lost years could be repaired.

But it had drawn a path.

Maybe that was enough for one night.

Eldric walked to the brass plate and picked up something that had slid from a narrow compartment near the telescope.

It was a small black key.

No longer than his finger. Its handle was shaped like an open eye.

Maris leaned closer. "What does it open?"

Eldric turned it over.

A faint engraving ran down its side.

HOLLOW CREEK.

Varux stared at it.

"I never found that," he said.

"You were alone," Alias replied.

The older version looked at him.

Then he nodded.

"Yes," he said. "I was."

They left the observatory after midnight.

The mountain path down was dark, but the stars gave enough light to follow. Rowan complained that he could no longer complain about the observatory, because it had shown him a sky full of roads and that was "unfairly impressive."

Corvin carried the black key.

Maris carried three pages of copied star charts.

Eldric walked beside Varux.

Alias walked ahead.

The road to Hollow Creek waited below them.

It had waited for years.

This time, they were coming together.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 13

### A Journal Left Behind

#### *Shared Journal Entry 428*

*"Some journals are left behind because they are too heavy to carry. That does not mean they stop carrying you."*

The descent from the observatory took most of the next day.

By noon, the mountain had fallen behind them in layers of wet stone and dark fir trees. The path was steep enough that Rowan complained about his knees, his boots, the weather, and gravity in general.

"Gravity is not personal," Maris said.

"It is always personal."

"How?"

"It waits until I am carrying something."

Corvin did not look back from the front of the group. "Then carry less."

"I am carrying the same amount as everyone else."

"You are complaining more."

"That is because I am contributing morale."

Varux walked near the back with Eldric. The black key from the observatory hung from a leather cord around Corvin's neck, tucked inside his coat where it would not catch the light. Every so often Corvin touched it through the fabric, as if confirming it was still there.

Alias understood the feeling.

His own coin had been quiet since they left the observatory. Too quiet. The silence did not make it harmless. It only made him wonder what it was waiting for.

Near evening, the trees changed.

The tall mountain pines thinned into lower woods marked by pale bark and wet moss. The air warmed. A stream appeared beside the road, then disappeared beneath roots, then appeared again farther downhill. Its water was clear enough that Alias could see stones turning beneath the current.



"Hollow Creek is close," Varux said.

Everyone looked at him.

He had spoken without being asked.

Rowan tilted his head. "That was useful."

"I am trying."

"Do not make it emotional."

Varux gave him a tired look. "You make everything emotional."

"That is because everything has feelings."

"Rocks do not have feelings."

Rowan pointed at a boulder beside the road. "That one looks disappointed."

Corvin walked past it. "It is a rock."

"Exactly. Imagine how hard its life has been."

The stream bent around a low hill, and the road opened into a narrow clearing. An old waystation stood there: one room of stone and timber, roof half-collapsed on the eastern side, shutters hanging crooked from their hinges. A weather-beaten sign stood beside the door, though the writing had long since worn away.

Varux stopped so suddenly that Eldric nearly walked past him.

"What is it?" Alias asked.

The older version stared at the waystation.

"I know this place."

"From your road?" Maris asked.

"Yes."

"Was it important?"

Varux did not answer at once.

Then he said, "Not at the time."

That was never a good sign.

Corvin studied the roof. "It will keep off most of the rain. We can stop here."

"Do we have to?" Rowan asked.

"It is getting dark."

"That is not a reason to sleep in a haunted house."

"It is not haunted," Varux said.

Rowan looked at him. "You do not know that."

"I have slept here."

"That is also not proof."

They entered carefully.

The front room was empty except for a broken table, a stone hearth, and a bench that had collapsed under the weight of years. Rain had come through the damaged roof and left dark stains across the floor. A narrow doorway at the back led to a storage room filled with old crates and a carpet of dry leaves.

Maris ran her fingers along the wall near the hearth.

"There used to be a guest ledger," she said. "Look. The shelf marks are still here."

"Do not tell me it is another journal," Rowan said.

Varux had gone pale.

Alias looked at him.

"Is it?"

The older version stepped into the back room.

For a moment, he only stood there.

Then he crouched beside a loose floorboard near the far wall.

"No," he said quietly. "Not a guest ledger."

Eldric moved closer but did not touch him. "What is it?"

Varux placed one hand on the floorboard.

"A mistake."

Corvin folded his arms. "We have had several of those. Be specific."

Varux looked up.

"I left something here."

The room went silent.

Alias felt the old anger stir again, but it was weaker now. Less like a blade. More like a bruise he kept pressing to see whether it still hurt.

"What?" he asked.

Varux slid the floorboard aside.

Underneath it was a narrow hollow in the stone foundation. Dust covered everything inside. There was a rusted tin cup, a small bundle of cloth, and a leather journal wrapped in oilskin.

Varux did not reach for it.

The journal was black.

Not like the private one he carried now. This was larger, with a torn strap and a faded crescent stamped into the cover. The leather had warped around the edges, but it was still intact.

Maris inhaled sharply.

"How long has that been there?"

Varux looked at it.

"Years."

"How many?"

"Too many."

Corvin stepped closer. "You remembered exactly where it was."

"I remembered trying not to."

That answer quieted him.

Alias crouched beside the hollow, but he did not touch the journal.

"Why did you leave it?"

Varux's hand hovered over the cover.

"Because I was afraid someone would find it."

"Then why hide it instead of burning it?"

The older version's expression tightened.

"Because I was more afraid no one would."

No one spoke.

Rain began tapping softly against the damaged roof.

Varux finally lifted the journal from the hollow. Dust rose from the cover. He wiped it away with his sleeve, but the crescent remained dull and scratched beneath his hand.

"This was my first field journal," he said. "Not the one I carry now. This was before I learned how to write like I expected anyone else to read it."

"Do you?" Maris asked.

"Write like that now?"

"Expect anyone else to read it."

Varux looked at her.

"No."

The answer was too honest to argue with.

He sat on the floor beside the broken board. The journal rested on his knees. For a long moment, he did not open it.

Rowan leaned against the wall. "You know we are all looking at it, right?"

"I know."

"Good. I did not want you to think we were pretending not to."

Varux almost smiled.

Then he unfastened the torn strap.

The first page had stuck to the cover. He lifted it carefully. The handwriting beneath was his, but younger. Alias could see it immediately. The letters were sharper, pressed too hard into the page.

The same handwriting that had written the note beneath Maris's notebook: Gone east. Back tomorrow. Do not worry.

At the top of the page was a date.

Day 19.

Alias looked at Varux.

"Nineteen days after you left?"

Varux nodded.

"I thought the date would make me turn around," he said. "It did not."

He read the first entry silently.

Then he turned the book slightly so they could see.

Day 19. The road is still east. I have found no archive, no proof, and no one who knows the name from the page. I should turn back. I will turn back when I have enough to explain why I left.

Below it, written later in different ink, was one added line.

I do not know what enough is.

Maris read it twice.

Corvin looked away.

Rowan said nothing.

Alias felt something pull tight inside him.

"It sounds like you knew," he said.

Varux kept looking at the page.

"I did know."

"Then why did you keep going?"

"Because knowing a mistake is not always the same as being ready to stop making it."

The fire in the main room had not been lit yet. The only light came from the doorway and the blue-grey evening beyond it. Varux's face looked older in that light.

He turned another page.

Day 43. I passed a cart travelling west. The driver said I could ride with him as far as Maanhaven for two silver pieces. I said no. I told him I had somewhere important to be.

A line had been scratched through at the bottom.

I did. I just did not know where.

Alias looked at the journal.

"You wrote that?"

"Apparently."

"You do not remember?"

"Not everything." Varux's thumb brushed the edge of the page. "I remember the cart. I remember him laughing when I said I was looking for a hidden archive. I remember watching the road west until I could not see it anymore."

"Then you could have followed it."

"Yes."

The word made Alias angry again.

Not because Varux was refusing to explain.

Because he was not.

He was telling the truth.

Maris pointed to a mark in the margin. "What is this?"

It was a small line of blue ink beside the entry. Different from Varux's handwriting. The letters were narrow and precise.

HOME IS A DIRECTION TOO.

Varux's fingers stopped.

"The Paper," Alias said.

"Yes."

"It wrote that?"

"Yes."

"And you ignored it?"

Varux nodded.

Rowan stared at him. "Your paper is rude."

"It gets worse."

From inside Alias's pack came a faint rustle.

Everyone looked toward it.

Alias slowly pulled out the folded Paper. It was creased from travel and tucked between his journal and a small pouch of dried fruit. The surface was blank at first.

Then blue letters appeared.

I WAS CORRECT.

Rowan laughed.

It startled everyone.

Even Varux.

"You wrote that?" Rowan asked the Paper.

The blue letters changed.

YES.

"That is absolutely rude."

STILL CORRECT.

Corvin covered his mouth with one hand. It did not entirely hide the smile.

Maris leaned closer, fascinated. "It recognizes the older connection."

Varux looked at the Paper.

"It remembers," he said.

The words did not sound happy.

Alias watched him.

"What did it mean when it said it gets worse?"

Varux looked down at the field journal.

He turned farther into the book.

The entries grew shorter.

Day 91. I followed the old river north. The page says there is another mark. I have stopped asking whether it is worth it.

Day 126. Dreamed of the tavern again. Rowan was arguing with Gerhardt about soup. I woke up before I heard the end.

Day 174. The Paper says Maris wrote in the shared journal. I told it I did not want to know what she wrote.

Day 175. It told me anyway. She wrote: "If you are alive, come back angry. Just come back."

The rain sounded louder on the roof.

Alias stared at the words.

Maris did too.

"I wrote that?" she asked.

Varux nodded.

"You do not remember?"

"I remember reading it."

"Did you answer?"

Varux's throat moved.

"No."

Maris did not look at him.

She looked at the page.

"I do not know if I would write that," she said quietly.

"You did," Varux said.

"Maybe I will not now."

"That is allowed."

Maris lifted her eyes.

The older version of Alias looked tired, but he did not look away.

"That is the part I keep forgetting," he said. "You are not here to become the people I remember. You are here to become yourselves."

The room stayed quiet.



Then Corvin stepped closer to the journal.

"What does it say about Hollow Creek?" he asked.

The question gave everyone something practical to hold.

Varux turned pages slowly. Near the end, the entries became harder to read. Rain had blurred the ink, and several pages had been torn out completely.

"Here," he said.

A rough map filled the page. A creek curved across it. Beside a small black mark, someone had drawn the open-eye symbol from the key.

HOLLOW CREEK. OLD MILL. BELOW THE WATERLINE.

Underneath, written in the younger Varux's hand:

The key opens the door. The door does not open for one person.

Below that, the Paper had added a single line in blue ink.

DO NOT GO ALONE.

Rowan pointed at the page. "Your Paper really likes that sentence."

"It had reasons."

"Did you listen this time?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at the map.

"No."

The answer landed heavily.

"What happened?" Corvin asked.

Varux closed the journal.

"Not here."

Alias looked at him.

"That is a hiding later."

"Yes."

"Then why say it?"

"Because I will tell you when we reach the mill."

For a moment, Alias wanted to argue.

Then he looked at the old entry again.

The key opens the door. The door does not open for one person.

The next part of the road was already waiting.

"Fine," he said.

Varux's eyes lifted.

"But no more deciding after we get there. No more doing it alone."

The older version nodded.

"No more alone."

It sounded like a promise.

Alias hoped it was.

They lit the hearth before night fully arrived. Corvin found enough dry wood in the storage room to start a fire. Rowan repaired part of the broken shutter with a loose plank and declared himself a carpenter. Maris sat near the flames with the field journal open beside her, reading only the pages Varux had given permission to read.

The older Alias kept the rest close.

He did not hide it. He simply held it on his lap, fingers resting against the torn strap.

Eldric joined him near the fire.

"You left it behind on purpose," the mage said.

Varux nodded.

"You thought you did not deserve to carry it?"

"Something like that."

Eldric looked at the journal.

"Things we leave behind do not always remain where we put them."

Varux gave a faint smile. "That is a very Eldric way of saying it."

"It is an old person way of saying it."

"You are not that old."

Eldric looked at him.

Varux blinked.

For one awkward second, he looked exactly nineteen.

"I mean," he said, "you are old. Just not..." He stopped. "Sorry."

Eldric's expression softened.

"You have seen more years than he has," the mage said. "That does not make you older in every way."

Varux looked down.

Alias pretended not to hear, but the words stayed with him.

Later, when the fire had burned low, the Paper rustled in Alias's pack again.

He took it out.

Blue ink appeared.

YOU FOUND IT.

Alias looked at the journal in Varux's hands.

"Did you know it was there?"

NO.

"Then why did it bring us here?"

The Paper stayed blank for a long time.

Finally, it wrote:

BECAUSE SOME THINGS MUST BE FOUND BEFORE THEY CAN BE FORGIVEN.

Alias read the words twice.

Across the fire, Varux was asleep at last.

Not fully relaxed. One hand still rested on the field journal. But asleep.

The old waystation creaked around them. Rain whispered through the damaged roof. Outside, the creek ran unseen through the dark.

Tomorrow they would reach Hollow Creek.

Tomorrow they would find the old mill.

Tomorrow, Alias thought.

Then he looked at the Paper.

The blue ink was already fading.

He added quietly, "And we will go together."

The Paper wrote one final word.

GOOD.

Alias folded it shut.

For the first time, tomorrow did not feel like a promise that could disappear if he looked away.

It felt like a place with room for all of them.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 14

### Hollow Creek

#### *Shared Journal Entry 429*

*"A creek can look shallow until you try to cross it carrying everything you refused to put down."*

Hollow Creek was louder than Alias expected.

The name had made him imagine a small ribbon of water slipping through a quiet valley. Instead, the creek tore through the woods in a broad, fast-moving channel, swollen by rain and mountain melt. Grey water struck black stones hard enough to throw white spray into the air. The banks were steep and slick with moss.

On the far side stood the old mill.

It leaned toward the creek as if listening to it.

The wheel had fallen years ago. One half of it lay broken in the water, caught between rocks. The millhouse itself had sagged at one corner, but the roof still held. A narrow bridge of old planks crossed from the near bank to the door.

Or it had once.

Three planks were missing from the middle.

Rowan stopped beside Alias and stared at the bridge.

"I do not like this place," he said.

"You have said that about every place we have visited," Maris replied.

"That is because every place keeps giving me reasons."

Corvin crouched beside the first plank and pressed his hand against the wood. "The supports may hold one person at a time."

"May?" Rowan asked.

"Nothing old likes certainty."

"You are all learning to speak in riddles. I blame the buildings."

Varux had not looked at the bridge.

He was staring at the millhouse door.

The black key hung at Corvin's chest, hidden beneath his coat. Even from several steps away, Alias could feel his own coin growing warm.

"That is it?" Alias asked.

Varux nodded.

"The old mill."

"Where the door is below the waterline," Maris said.

"Yes."

Rowan looked at the creek. "I would like to point out that the water is currently above the waterline."

"That is how water works," Corvin said.

"I know how water works. I just do not approve of it."

Eldric walked to the bank and studied the current. His staff sank an inch into the soft ground.

"The creek has risen recently," he said. "The lower channel may be inaccessible until it falls."

Varux finally looked away from the millhouse.

"It was higher in my road too."

Corvin turned toward him. "And what did you do?"

The older Alias did not answer.

Alias already knew.

"You went in alone," he said.

Varux's face tightened.

"Yes."

"How?"

"I found a way down from the far bank."

"Where?"

Varux pointed upstream, toward a line of stones half-hidden beneath the trees.

"There used to be a maintenance path. It follows the creek under the mill. The door is in the old foundation."

Corvin looked at the bank, then the broken bridge, then the line of dark trees.

"Used to be," he repeated.

"Yes."

"Do you remember whether it is still there?"

"No."

"Helpful."

"I know."

Rowan looked at Varux. "That is the first time I have believed you saying that."

Maris opened her notebook. "The key opens the door. The door does not open for one person."

"That is what the journal said," Alias replied.

"Yes. I am reading it because it matters."

"It does."

She looked at the creek. "Maybe the first part is literal. The key opens the door. The second part could mean it requires more than one person to reach it, or more than one coin, or more than one Reader."

"Or it could mean the door is too heavy," Rowan said.

Corvin gave him a look.

"What? Old doors are often heavy."

Eldric stepped closer to the water. He held one hand above the current. A faint blue line spread from his fingers, not into the creek but across its surface, tracing a path beneath the foam.

"There is a channel under the bank," he said. "A hollow beneath the mill."

"Hollow Creek," Maris murmured.

"Possibly," Eldric said.

Varux moved before anyone could stop him.

He was halfway toward the trees when Alias caught his arm.

The older Alias froze.

"You said no more alone," Alias said.

Varux did not look at him.

"I was only checking the path."

"With no one else?"

"I can be back in a minute."

The words were too familiar.

Alias tightened his grip.

"That is what you said before."

Varux closed his eyes.

For a moment, he looked ashamed. Then something else crossed his face: fear, perhaps, or the old reflex to pull away before anyone saw it.

"You are right," he said.

He did not move.

Alias let go.

Corvin watched the exchange without comment. Then he picked up his pack.

"We check the path together," he said. "Eldric, you watch the water. Maris, bring the key notes. Rowan, stay where you can see the bridge."

Rowan frowned. "That sounds like you are giving me the job because you do not trust me."

"It is because you shout loudest."

"That is fair."

The maintenance path had almost disappeared.

It began upstream from the mill, where a narrow ledge cut through the bank beneath a tangle of roots. In some places, the earth had collapsed into the creek. In others, old stones still formed steps. The group moved slowly, one at a time, with Corvin testing each foothold before anyone else used it.

Varux walked between Alias and Eldric.

Alias did not think that was an accident.

The farther they went, the colder the air became. The creek's roar softened as the path dipped beneath an overhang of stone. Moss covered the walls. Water ran in thin silver lines over the rock.



Then they found the door.

It stood beneath the mill's foundation, half-submerged in the side of the creek.

A dark rectangle of stone framed it. The water reached almost to the bottom hinge, washing over the threshold in quick, hard pulses. Above the lock was the same open-eye symbol carved into the black key.

Maris drew a breath.

"There."

Corvin stepped closer, balancing one hand against the wall. "The key fits?"

Varux looked at the lock.

"It did."

"Did?"

"It may still."

"That is not reassuring."

"It is honest."

The creek surged against the door.

Eldric raised one hand. Blue light gathered along his fingers. The water at the threshold slowed, not stopping completely, but thinning as if held back by an invisible wall.

"I cannot hold it long," he said.

Corvin reached beneath his coat and pulled out the key.

The black metal looked almost blue in the magic light.

Varux watched it with a strange expression.

"What?" Alias asked.

The older version did not answer immediately.

"When I found it," he said, "I thought it would solve everything."

Rowan looked at the key. "That is a lot to put on a key."

"It was not really about the key."

"What was it about?"

Varux looked at the door.

"Believing there was one thing that could make all the wrong choices disappear."

The current pushed against Eldric's spell.

The blue light flickered.

"Corvin," Eldric said.

Corvin knelt beside the lock. He slid the key into the narrow opening.

It fit.

Everyone held their breath.

Corvin turned it.

Nothing happened.

"That would have been too easy," Rowan said.

Maris crouched beside him. "There are marks around the frame."

Thin lines had appeared in the stone, almost invisible beneath the water. They ran from the keyhole outward in six directions, each ending in a shallow handprint pressed into the wall.

One for every person standing there.

Alias looked at Varux.

"The door does not open for one person," he said.

Varux nodded slowly.

"Six handprints," Maris said. "Six people."

"That is convenient," Rowan said.

"Or planned," Eldric replied.

They placed their hands against the marks.

Alias's palm fit the lowest print. Varux stood beside him, his hand against the one nearest the keyhole. Maris and Corvin reached the upper marks. Rowan placed his hand against the stone and immediately frowned.

"It is cold."

"Everything is cold," Corvin said.

"No. This is personal cold."

Eldric's hand touched the final print.

The black key turned on its own.

The door opened inward.

A rush of air came out of the darkness beyond, carrying the smell of wet stone, rust, and something old enough that Alias could not name it.

The creek surged.

Eldric's spell broke.

Water crashed over the threshold, but the open door held it back. Not with magic from Eldric. With something inside the room. The water curved around the doorway, running along invisible edges before spilling into a lower channel beneath the foundation.

Rowan stared.

"I hate that I think that is impressive."

"You can be impressed and afraid," Maris said.

"I am very talented at both."

They entered.

The door led into a circular chamber beneath the mill. A low ceiling of black stone arched over them. Water dripped from the walls into a shallow trench that ran around the edge of the room. Old gears, broken pipes, and wooden channels filled the shadows, as though the mill had once been built around something much older than itself.

At the center stood a table.

Not a wooden table. A stone pedestal shaped like an open book.

On it lay six narrow slots.

And in the middle rested a small metal box.

Varux stopped breathing.

Alias heard it.

"What is that?" Maris asked.

Varux stared at the box.

"I do not know."

"That is not true," Alias said.

The older version looked at him.

"I know what I thought it was."

"What?"

"An answer."

The box was no bigger than two hands placed side by side. It had no lock. No handle. Only a strip of blue metal across the front, engraved with a sentence in old letters.

Maris stepped forward and read it slowly.

WHAT YOU TAKE ALONE WILL RETURN AS WEIGHT.

The room became quiet except for the water.

Rowan looked at the box. "That is a terrible warning."

"It is a clear warning," Corvin said.

"Clear warnings are still terrible."

Eldric circled the pedestal without touching it. "The slots may require something from each of us."

Maris looked at the six openings. "What kind of something?"

Varux's hand had moved to his chest.

His coin.

Alias saw it.

"No," he said.

Varux looked at him.

"It is probably asking for the coins," the older Alias said.

"Maybe."

"It asked for six people at the door."

"That does not mean it asks for six coins here."

Varux looked at the pedestal. "It did last time."

The sentence dropped into the room.

Corvin turned sharply. "You opened this before."

Varux did not answer.

"Did you?" Corvin asked again.

"Yes."

"Alone?"

"Yes."

"How?"

Varux's face tightened.

"The door was not underwater then."

"That does not answer the question."

"I had the key. I had my coin. I had..." He stopped.

"The Paper?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at the floor.

"Yes."

"And the box opened?"

"Yes."

"What was inside?"

The older version stared at the metal box as if it might answer for him.

"A map fragment," he said. "A name. A direction east."

"M?" Maris asked.

Varux nodded.

"What did it say?"

He closed his eyes.

"Follow the one who already walked away."

Nobody spoke.

Rowan looked between Varux and Alias. "That is not helpful."

"No," Varux said. "It was not."

Corvin crossed his arms. "And then you left."

Varux's eyes opened.

"Yes."

"Because of a box."

"Because I thought the box proved I was right."

"Did it?"

"No."

The answer came quickly.

"No," Varux said again. "It proved I was desperate."

The room felt smaller.

Alias looked at the six slots.

"What did you put in them?" he asked.

Varux hesitated.

"Nothing."

"What?"

"I had only one coin. I only used the middle slot."

"And it opened?"

"Partly."

Maris stepped closer to the pedestal. "Then maybe you did not open the whole thing."

Varux looked at her.

She pointed to the box. "Six slots. Six people. A warning about taking something alone. You opened it enough to get a direction, but not enough to understand it."

The idea moved through the room.

Corvin leaned forward. "That fits the pattern."

Rowan frowned. "What pattern?"

"Varux finds something, takes the part that seems useful, and leaves before seeing the rest."

The older Alias lowered his head.

"Yes," he said.

It was not defensive.

That made it worse.

Alias looked at the box.

"Then we do not do that."

Varux lifted his eyes.

"You said we are going backward to understand the choices," Alias continued. "So we understand this one. We do not take one part because it looks like the answer."

Maris nodded. "We solve the whole mechanism."

Eldric looked at the six slots. "The coins may not be the only things it accepts."

"What else?" Rowan asked.

The older mage looked at them one by one.

"Something carried."

Alias thought of the words above the library door.

Those who carry nothing alone may enter.

He reached into his pack and took out the folded Paper.

The moment it touched the air, the slots glowed blue.

Varux's eyes widened.

"The Paper," he whispered.

Blue words appeared across the page.

NOT ENOUGH.

Rowan leaned over Alias's shoulder. "Rude."

The Paper wrote:

ACCURATE.

Maris took the shared journal from her bag.

The moment she placed it near one of the slots, another line of blue light appeared.

Corvin removed his map case.

Eldric set his old folded map beside the pedestal.

Rowan looked down at himself.

"I have a piece of bread."

"That is not what it means," Maris said.

"I have other things."

"Like what?"

Rowan searched through his pockets. He found a length of string, a smooth green stone, a button, two dried berries, and a small carved wooden whistle.

Varux stared at the whistle.

Rowan noticed.

"What?"

The older Alias looked away.

"Nothing."

"That was not nothing."

Rowan held up the whistle. "I found it in Maanhaven. Gerhard said it was useless."

Varux's expression changed again. It was quick, but Alias understood now. The older version remembered the small things too. That was what made them hurt.

"Keep it," Varux said quietly.

Rowan looked confused.

"Why?"

"Because you like it."

Rowan frowned. "I do not like it."

"You carry it everywhere."

Rowan opened his mouth.

Then closed it.

After a moment, he placed the whistle beside the final slot.

The stone pedestal hummed.

Six lines of blue light connected the objects: Alias's Paper, Maris's shared journal, Corvin's maps, Eldric's first map, Rowan's whistle, and Varux's coin.



Only five slots were filled.

Everyone looked at Alias.

His coin burned warm against his chest.

"You do not have to," Varux said immediately.

Alias looked at him.

"Why not?"

"Because last time the coin showed you things."

"You mean it showed you things you did not want to see."

Varux did not answer.

Alias reached beneath his shirt and pulled out the silver coin.

It looked small in his palm.

Too small for all the roads it had touched.

He placed it in the last slot.

The pedestal shook.

The chamber filled with blue light.

Water rose in the trench around them, spiraling in slow circles. The metal box opened without a sound.

Inside lay not a map fragment, but six folded pages.

Each page bore a different name.

MARIS.

CORVIN.

ROWAN.

ELDRIC.

ALIAS.

VARUX.

Nobody moved.

Rowan whispered, "That is worse than a map."

Maris stepped close enough to read the smallest text beneath the names.

"Choose one," she said.

"What happens if we choose wrong?" Corvin asked.

The Paper wrote in blue.

YOU HAVE ASKED THIS QUESTION MANY TIMES.

"That is not an answer," Corvin said.

The Paper remained blank.

Eldric looked at the six pages.

"Not wrong," he said. "Incomplete."

Varux's face had gone pale.

"Do not open mine," he said.

Alias looked at him.

"Why?"

"Because it is mine."

"Your journal is yours," Alias said. "This is not the same."

"You do not know that."

"No. But neither do you."

Varux took a step toward the pedestal.

Corvin moved between him and it.

"We agreed," Corvin said. "No taking things alone."

The older Alias stopped.

For a second, anger flashed across his face.

Not at Corvin. At himself.

He stepped back.

"Fine," he said.

Maris looked at the pages again. "The mechanism may want each person to choose their own."

"That would be reasonable," Eldric said.

Rowan picked up the page with his name before anyone could stop him.

The blue light around the chamber flickered.

"Rowan," Maris said.

"What? It has my name."

"That does not mean you should open it."

"It literally means I should open it."

"No, it literally means it has your name."

Rowan held the page carefully. The seal had no wax, only a thin blue line pressed across the fold.

He looked at Varux.

"Did you open these last time?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"I did not see them."

The answer settled over the room.

He had opened the box alone. He had taken the map. He had missed the pages completely.

Alias felt something shift inside him.

Not forgiveness. Not yet.

But proof.

The old choice had been incomplete because he had been alone.

"Open it," Alias said.

Rowan looked at him.

"Are you sure?"

"No," Alias said. "But we are here."

Rowan nodded.

He broke the seal.

The page unfolded.

At first, nothing was written on it.

Then blue ink appeared.

ROWAN WILL MAKE YOU LAUGH ON THE DAY YOU BELIEVE LAUGHTER IS A  
BETRAYAL.

Rowan stared at the sentence.

The chamber went silent.

"What does that mean?" he asked.

No one answered.

Even Varux looked shaken.

The line faded.

Below it, a second sentence appeared.

DO NOT LET HIM THINK HIS JOY WAS SMALL.

Rowan looked at Varux.

The older Alias had turned away.

Alias felt the shape of the future in that moment, not as a clear event but as a bruise beneath the words. Something would happen. Something Rowan would face. Something Varux remembered so painfully that he could not look at him.

Rowan folded the page slowly.

"I do not like that," he said.

"No," Varux whispered. "You should not."

"But it is not happening now."

"No."

"Then I get to keep making jokes."

Varux looked at him.

"Yes," he said.

"Good."

Rowan put the page back on the pedestal.

Maris picked up hers.

The blue light rose again.

She opened it.

MARIS WILL KEEP WHAT OTHERS ARE TOO AFRAID TO REMEMBER.

Her face went still.

A second line appeared.

WHEN SHE ASKS YOU TO READ, DO NOT MAKE HER READ ALONE.

Maris folded the page without speaking.

Corvin's jaw tightened.

Eldric watched the words fade.

One by one, they understood the rule.

The pages were not maps.

They were warnings made of people.

Corvin took his page next.

CORVIN WILL FIND THE WAY HOME AFTER HE STOPS BELIEVING HE MUST DRAW  
IT ALONE.

He stared at it for a long time.

Then he placed it down.

Eldric opened his.

THE TEACHER CANNOT WALK EVERY ROAD FOR THEM.

The old mage read the second line silently.

Alias saw his expression change, but Eldric folded the page before anyone else could.

"My turn," Alias said.

Varux looked up sharply.

"You do not have to."

"I know."

Alias took the page with his name.

It was warm.

He broke the seal.

The blue words appeared slowly.

ALIAS WILL LEAVE WHEN HE BELIEVES THE ANSWER IS FARTHER THAN HOME.

The air left his lungs.

The next line appeared.

REMIND HIM: HOME CAN ALSO BE A ROAD.

Alias could not look at anyone.

He folded the page.

The final page remained.

VARUX.

No one reached for it.

Varux stood very still.

"I said do not open it," he whispered.

Alias looked at him.

"Why?"

"Because I already know what it says."

"Do you?"

Varux's eyes flicked toward the blue journal in Maris's bag.

Then toward the field journal in his own pack.

Then toward the door.

"I know enough."

"No," Alias said.

Varux stared at him.

"You know what you are afraid it says."

The chamber hummed around them.

Corvin stepped closer to the pedestal, but he did not touch the page.

"It has his name," he said. "He should choose."

Varux looked at the page.

His hand shook as he reached for it.

For a moment, he could not break the seal.

Then Rowan placed one hand on his shoulder.

Not a joke. Not a speech.

Just a hand.

Varux looked at him.

Rowan shrugged. "You said nobody goes alone."

The older Alias swallowed.

Then he opened the page.

The blue words appeared.

VARUX WILL COME HOME WHEN HE STOPS BELIEVING HE MUST EARN  
FORGIVENESS BEFORE ASKING FOR IT.

No one moved.

The second line came more slowly.

THE DOOR WAS NEVER LOCKED.

Varux made a sound like he had been struck.

Alias watched the words blur in the older version's eyes.

For seventeen years, he thought, Varux had walked toward answers because he believed he had to  
return with something worth bringing.

He had thought the people waiting at home would need a reason to let him back in.

The page said otherwise.

The door was never locked.

Varux folded over slightly, one hand pressed against his chest.

Eldric stepped to his side.

"Read it again," the old mage said.

Varux shook his head.

"Read it."

"I cannot."

"Then I will."

Eldric took the page gently from his hand.

His voice was steady when he read the words aloud.

"Varux will come home when he stops believing he must earn forgiveness before asking for it.

The door was never locked."

The blue light in the room softened.

The metal box closed.

The pedestal went still.

For a long moment, no one spoke.

Then Varux sat down on the wet stone floor.

Alias sat beside him.

He did not know what to say.

So he did not say anything.

After a while, Varux spoke first.

"I left before I knew whether they would forgive me."

Alias looked at him.

"That is usually how asking works," he said.

Varux gave a breathless laugh.

It was not much.

But it was there.

Outside, the creek struck the mill foundations, loud and alive.

The door behind them remained open.

And for the first time, Varux looked at it without seeing an escape.

He saw a way back.

\* \* \*



## Chapter 15

### Burned Memory II - The Things I Missed

#### *Burned Memory II*

*"The worst things were not the tragedies. They were the ordinary evenings he kept promising himself he would return for."*

The creek was quieter after midnight.

It still ran beneath the mill, grinding itself against the stones, but the noise had become part of the dark. The campfire outside the hidden chamber had burned down to coals. Corvin kept first watch near the millhouse door. Maris slept with the blue journal tucked beneath one arm. Rowan had somehow wrapped his blanket around both feet and one hand. Eldric sat awake beside the fire with a cup of tea he had reheated three times.

Alias could not sleep.

Across the room, Varux sat with his back against the wall.

The older version of him had not opened either journal since they left the chamber. The field journal rested beside his pack. His private black journal lay inside it. The shared journal remained with Maris.

Between all three books, Alias thought, there were probably enough words to fill a life.

And none of them seemed to make Varux feel less alone.

The Paper rustled inside Alias's pack.

He sat up.

Blue ink appeared across its folded surface.

HE IS NOT ASLEEP.

Alias looked at Varux.

"I can see that."

SO CAN HE.

Alias frowned.

The Paper wrote again.

YOU ASKED WHAT HE MISSED.

"I did."

HE DID NOT ANSWER.

Before Alias could respond, Varux spoke from across the room.

"Do not ask it to do this."

Alias froze.

Varux was looking at the Paper.

"It is going to show another memory," he said.

The words carried no anger. Only exhaustion.

"How do you know?" Alias asked.

"Because it did before."

The Paper remained still in Alias's hands.

Eldric looked up from his tea.  
"Does it have to?" he asked.  
Varux laughed once without humor. "Nothing has to. That was always the problem."  
Blue letters appeared.  
YOU MAY CLOSE THE PAGE.  
Varux stared at the words.  
Alias looked from the Paper to the older version of himself.  
"Can we?"  
"Yes," Varux said.  
"Then why did you not?"  
Varux's gaze lowered.  
The Paper wrote one more line.  
HE DID NOT WANT TO KNOW WHAT HE HAD LOST.  
The fire popped.  
For a long moment, nobody moved.  
Then Varux reached across the floor and held out his hand.  
"Give it to me," he said.  
Alias did not.  
"Why?"  
"Because I am tired of it deciding when I remember."  
The Paper wrote:  
INCORRECT.  
Rowan, without opening his eyes, said, "Did the paper just call you wrong?"  
"Go back to sleep," Varux said.  
"I am trying. Your emotional problems are loud."  
Maris made a small sound that might have been laughter. She did not wake fully.  
Varux looked at Alias again.  
"Please."  
The word was quiet.  
Alias gave him the Paper.  
Varux held it between both hands. For a second, nothing happened. Then the blue ink spread  
across the page, not in words this time but in a thin line that widened into smoke.  
The millhouse disappeared.  
The warmth of the coals vanished.  
The room became cold.  
Very cold.  
Alias stood in a narrow rented room above a market street.

Snow pressed against the window in hard white sheets. A small stove sat cold in the corner. A bedroll lay rolled against the wall, untouched. Maps covered the floor. Pages of copied symbols were pinned above the desk, their corners curling from damp.

At the desk sat Varux.

Younger than he was now. Older than Alias. His fur was longer and uneven, his clothes worn at the cuffs. The scar on his cheek was newer, red against the grey of his face.

He was writing in the black journal.

No. He was trying to.

The page had only one sentence on it.

The archive was empty.

He stared at the words for a long time.

Then he crossed them out.

The line beneath read:

The archive was not empty. I was looking for the wrong thing.

He crossed that out too.

The next line was blank.

A knock came from the door below.

Varux did not move.

Another knock.

Then the sound of someone climbing the stair outside.

His hand went to the knife at his belt.

"Varux?" called a familiar voice.

He froze.

It was not Alias's voice.

It was Maris's.

The name sounded wrong in the cold room. Too alive. Too close.

Varux stood slowly.

For one second, the older Alias watching the memory moved toward the door.

Then the memory pulled him back.

The footsteps stopped outside.

"Varux?" Maris called again. "I know you are in there."

Varux did not answer.

The door opened.

Maris stepped inside.

She was older than the Maris sleeping by the mill fire, but not by much. Her hair was tied back with a blue thread. A leather satchel hung at her side, bulging with papers. Her eyes found Varux immediately.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Then Maris said, "You are alive."

Varux's mouth opened.

Nothing came out.

Maris looked around the room. The maps. The notebooks. The cold stove.

"You look terrible," she said.

The words were so ordinary that Alias felt them hurt.

Varux gave a weak smile. "You too."

"I have been traveling."

"So have I."

"No." Maris stepped closer. "You have been hiding."

Varux looked away.

The older Alias watching from inside the memory felt shame rise through him like smoke.

Maris set her satchel on the desk.

"I found one of your marks in a records room near the south road," she said. "Then another in Veyr's Crossing. You are not as difficult to track as you think."

"I was not trying to be tracked."

"I know."

Varux flinched.

Maris saw it.

Her face softened for one painful second.

Then she reached into her satchel and pulled out the blue shared journal.

It was thinner then. The cover was cleaner. The cord around it had only been wrapped once.

"I brought this," she said.

Varux stared at it.

"Why?"

"Because it belongs to you too."

"It does not."

"Yes, it does."

"I left."

"I know."

"Then why are you here?"

Maris's hands tightened around the journal.

"Because you did not die," she said. "And I am tired of hearing people say they do not know where you are as if that is the same thing."

Varux looked at the floor.

Outside, wind pushed snow against the window.

Maris placed the journal on the desk.

"There are entries," she said. "Some are mine. Some are Corvin's. Rowan wrote one about a door that bit him. Eldric wrote three lines and somehow made all of them annoying."

Varux did not touch it.

"What do you want me to do?" he asked.

"Read it."

"I cannot."

"Why?"

"Because I do not know what it says."

Maris stared at him.

"That is why people read," she said.

Varux's voice broke. "What if it says you hate me?"

The room became silent.

Maris did not look away.

"Then you will know," she said.

He stared at the blue journal.

"You want me to come back," he whispered.

"Yes."

"I do not have answers."

"I did not ask for answers."

"I do not know where my parents are."

"I did not ask for that either."

"I failed."

Maris took one step forward.

"You left," she said. "That is not the same thing."

Varux closed his eyes.

The older Alias watching the memory could feel the moment splitting open inside him. The door was there. The shared journal was there. Maris was there.

Everything he later told himself he wanted was standing in a cold room, asking him to come home.

"Stay tonight," Maris said. "We can leave in the morning."

Varux did not answer.

"Please," she added.

He looked at the maps on the wall.

At the copied symbols.

At the black journal on the desk.

Then at the blue shared journal.

"I cannot," he said.

Maris's face did not change at first.

That was the worst part.

Then she nodded.

"All right."

She picked up her satchel.

Varux took one step toward her.

"Maris."  
She stopped at the door.  
"I will come back," he said.  
She turned.  
"When?"  
The word was not angry.  
It was tired.  
Varux could not answer.  
Maris waited.  
Finally he said, "Soon."  
Something inside her expression went still.  
"Write it down," she said.  
Then she left.  
The door closed.  
The shared journal stayed on the desk.  
For a long time, Varux stood in the cold room without touching it.  
Then he sat down.  
The memory blurred.  
The snow at the window became rain.  
The rain became summer light.  
The rented room changed. New maps replaced old ones. A different coat hung by the door. The  
scar on Varux's face had faded from red to pale silver.  
The shared journal was still on the desk.  
Dust had gathered on it.  
The Paper lay half-tucked between its pages.  
Blue writing moved across the visible corner.  
ROWAN HAS A STORY FOR YOU.  
Varux looked at it.  
He was older now. His hands were steadier. His eyes were not.  
"What story?" he asked.  
The Paper wrote:  
HE FELL THROUGH A FLOOR AND BLAMES THE FLOOR.  
Varux stared at the sentence.  
Despite himself, a laugh escaped him.  
It lasted one second.  
Then he looked at the shared journal.  
"Is he all right?"  
YES.  
"Did he ask about me?"

The Paper did not answer immediately.

Then:

YES.

Varux closed his eyes.

"Tell him I am fine."

WRITE IT.

He did not.

The memory moved again.

Autumn.

Varux sat beside a fire outside a ruined watchtower. The Paper was open on his knee. The blue shared journal lay beside it, now worn at the corners.

A new entry glowed faintly on the page.

Corvin finished the river maps today. He says they are his best work. He says he does not care what anyone thinks. He made us all look at them for an hour.

Below that, in Rowan's handwriting:

They are very good. Do not tell him I said that.

A later line appeared in Maris's hand.

Eldric is teaching at the academy twice a week now. He says it is temporary. The students have started calling him Master Eldric when he cannot hear them.

Varux read every word.

The older Alias watching the memory felt the warmth of it return for one short breath. Corvin being proud. Rowan making a joke that was almost a compliment. Eldric teaching somewhere near home.

He could picture it.

He could almost hear them.

Then the Paper wrote:

WRITE BACK.

Varux put the journal away.

The warmth disappeared.

The memory skipped forward.

A town square in spring.

Varux stood across the street from a familiar tavern.

Not Gerhardt's tavern. Not Maanhaven. But close enough that the sight had stopped him. People sat at tables beneath striped awnings. A young woman dropped a stack of plates and began laughing before anyone could scold her. An old man held the door open for a family carrying too many bags. Someone played a fiddle badly from an upstairs window.

Varux stood in the rain.

The shared journal rested inside his coat.

The Paper had written a message that morning.

MARIS IS IN MAANHAVEN THIS WEEK.

He had read it three times.  
Then he had walked east.  
The older Alias inside the memory felt the old anger at himself rising again.  
Why?  
Why had he kept doing it?  
The answer came from the younger Varux before anyone asked.  
"Not yet," he whispered.  
The rain slid down his face.  
"Not until I have something worth bringing back."  
The Paper wrote from inside his coat.  
THEY DID NOT ASK FOR PROOF.  
Varux did not answer.  
The memory shifted once more.  
A room without windows.  
Older Varux sat at a long table covered in maps and open books. The grey cloak lay over the back  
of a chair. The Paper was nowhere in sight.  
On the table rested the shared journal.  
He stared at it.  
Then he shoved the Paper inside the cover, closed the journal, and tied the cord around it twice.  
"Stop," he said.  
No answer came.  
He stood and carried the journal to a stone shelf near the door.  
"Stop asking me to write."  
The room remained silent.  
He placed the journal on the shelf.  
"I will come back for it later."  
The older Alias watching the memory knew the lie before the younger one said it.  
The memory darkened.  
Varux walked away.  
For a while, there was only the sound of his footsteps.  
Then a voice spoke inside his mind.  
WRITE.  
Varux stopped.  
The voice was not loud. It was not human. It had no breath in it. It was a sentence formed from  
ink and paper and every note he had ignored.  
Varux turned around.  
The shelf was far behind him.  
The shared journal was still there.  
The Paper was still inside it.



WRITE, the voice said again.  
Varux pressed both hands to his head.  
"No."  
YOU CANNOT LEAVE IT BEHIND.  
"I just did."  
NO.  
The word did not shout.  
It did not need to.  
The memory broke apart.  
Alias fell backward into the present.  
The millhouse returned around him.  
Rain whispered through the broken roof. The creek rushed beneath the floor. The Paper lay  
between Varux's hands, blue ink fading across its surface.  
Varux was breathing too quickly.  
Eldric had moved closer without Alias noticing. One hand rested lightly on the older Alias's  
shoulder.  
"Here," Eldric said. "You are here."  
Varux nodded once.  
But he did not look convinced.  
Maris was awake now, sitting up beside the fire with the shared journal in her lap. Rowan had  
woken too. Corvin stood in the doorway, watching the dark outside with his arms folded.  
Nobody spoke for a while.  
Then Maris said, "I came to find you."  
Varux looked at her.  
The present Maris was younger than the one in the memory. She did not have the blue thread in  
her hair yet. Her face had not learned the tiredness Alias had seen in that other version.  
"I mean," she said carefully, "I would come to find you."  
Varux's eyes filled, but he looked away before the tears could fall.  
"That is worse," he said.  
"Why?"  
"Because you still mean it."  
Maris held the blue journal closer.  
"Then do not make me write it twice."  
The Paper rustled.  
Blue words appeared.  
ACCURATE.  
Rowan stared at it.  
"Your Paper has no sense of timing."  
IT HAS EXCELLENT TIMING.

"I hate that it can answer."

The Paper did not reply.

Alias looked at Varux.

"You did not just miss big things," he said.

Varux was quiet.

"No," he said.

"You missed dinners. Jokes. Maps. Letters."

"Yes."

"You missed people trying to bring you home."

"Yes."

Alias did not know what to say next.

Anger still lived inside him. It probably would for a long time. But now it had a shape. It was not just about a future Alias leaving. It was about how many times he had been given a door and decided he was not allowed to use it.

Eldric looked at the field journal near Varux's pack.

"Why did you keep the Paper?" he asked.

Varux gave a small, tired laugh.

"Because it would not leave."

"That is not what I asked."

The older Alias looked at the folded page.

Then he said, "Because it kept reminding me that someone might still be waiting."

The fire crackled.

Maris opened the shared journal.

"You should write something now," she said.

Varux looked at it like it was a weapon.

"I do not know what to say."

Rowan leaned back against his blanket. "Try your name. That is usually a good start."

Corvin nodded. "Then the date."

"Then a complete sentence," Maris said.

Eldric raised his tea. "A modest goal."

Varux looked around the room.

At all of them.

At the people he had once known in another form and the people who were still here, still younger, still unfinished.

Slowly, he took the shared journal from Maris.

He opened it to a blank page.

His hand shook as he picked up the pencil.

For a long time, he did not write.

Then he pressed the pencil to the page.

Alias could not see the words from where he sat.

He did not need to.

The pencil moved.

Once.

Then again.

Varux wrote his name.

Outside, the creek kept running toward a road none of them could see.

The Paper turned blue beneath Alias's hand.

One final line appeared.

NEXT: THE ARCHIVE OF UNASKED QUESTIONS.

Alias read it.

Then he looked at Varux, who was still writing.

Tomorrow, the road would lead them to another place.

Tonight, someone had finally stopped leaving a page blank.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 16

### The Archive Again

#### *Shared Journal Entry 430*

*"An archive is not a place where answers sleep. It is where questions wait for someone brave enough to read them."*

Varux wrote three lines before breakfast.

Alias knew because Maris saw him do it.

She had woken before anyone else, as usual. By the time the others stirred, she was sitting beside the ashes of the fire with the shared journal open in her lap, reading a page that was still damp with fresh pencil.

Varux sat a short distance away with his hands around a cup of tea.

"What did he write?" Rowan asked.

Maris looked up.

"That is not yours to read without asking."

Rowan looked offended. "It is the shared journal."

"Shared does not mean stolen."

"It means shared."

"It means we share what we choose to share."

Rowan turned toward Varux. "Can I read it?"

The older Alias looked at the book as if the answer were hiding inside it.

Then he nodded.

Maris held the page where everyone could see.

The handwriting was uneven. It slanted down at the end of each line, as if the writer had tried to stop halfway through and then forced himself to continue.

Day 1.

I found the road again.

I am not walking it alone.

For several seconds, nobody spoke.

Then Rowan said, "That is a good start."

Varux lowered his eyes.

"It is only three lines."

"Three lines is more than none," Maris said.

Corvin tied the black key around his neck again. "We should move. The archive is south-east from here, correct?"

Varux nodded.

"One day if the lower road is passable."

"And if it is not?"

"Two."

Corvin looked at him.

"That was almost useful."

"I am improving."

"Do not rush it."

They left Hollow Creek after sunrise.

The route south-east followed the creek for several miles before the water curved away into a low valley. The woods grew thinner. By noon, the trees opened onto wet fields scattered with old stone walls. A pale road ran through the grass, half-covered by moss and fallen leaves.

Varux walked beside Alias.

Not close enough to crowd him. Close enough that neither had to raise his voice.

"Do you remember this road?" Alias asked.

"Not well."

"You keep saying that."

"It is true."

"What do you remember?"

Varux looked ahead.

"I remember being hungry."

Alias frowned.

"That is all?"

"I remember a town somewhere near the archive. I remember buying bread and pretending I was only passing through." He rubbed his thumb against the edge of his sleeve. "I remember wanting to ask somebody if they knew my name."

"Why did you not?"

Varux smiled without humor.

"Because I was using another one."

Alias looked at him.

"Varux?"

The older version went quiet.

"Yes," he said.

"Why did you choose it?"

Varux did not answer immediately.

"The first time someone asked who I was after I had been gone a while, I did not know what to say. Alias felt like a name that belonged to people who expected me to come home." He looked toward the road. "Varux was a name no one had missed yet."

The words were simple.

They hurt anyway.

Alias did not know how to answer. He wanted to say that a name was just a name. He also knew that was not true.

Ahead, Corvin stopped beside a broken marker stone.

"The map says the archive should be beyond this field," he called.

Maris moved up beside him. "There is no building."

"Maybe it is hidden," Rowan said.

"Maybe the map is wrong," Corvin replied.

Varux stood very still.

"It was hidden," he said.

The group turned.

"How?" Maris asked.

The older Alias pointed toward the far side of the field. A line of low hills rose there, covered in grass and black thorn bushes. At first they looked ordinary.

Then Alias saw the door.

It was set into the hill itself, a rectangle of pale stone nearly covered by roots. No sign marked it. No road led directly to it. Only an old dry streambed curved down from the hills and ended at the doorway.

Rowan stared.

"We walked past that."

"Yes," Varux said.

"How did you see it?"

"I did not," Varux replied. "The Paper told me to stop."

The Paper rustled inside Alias's pack.

Blue ink appeared.

I DID.

Rowan looked toward Alias's bag. "It really enjoys being right."

CORRECT.

"I was not talking to you."

Alias pulled the Paper out and folded it smaller.

Varux watched him.

"Do not be angry at it," he said.

"I am not angry."

"It is annoying."

"It is very annoying."

The blue ink wrote:

STILL USEFUL.

Maris smiled despite herself.

The archive door opened when Alias pressed his coin against the Reader mark hidden beneath the roots.

Inside, the air was dry and warm.

It did not feel like the Hall. The Hall had felt ancient in a grand way, all towers and mosaics and rooms that had forgotten their purpose. The archive felt smaller, closer, almost domestic. Narrow shelves lined the walls. Lamps hung from chains in the ceiling, their blue flames lighting rows of papers, journals, maps, and sealed boxes.

The first room held a desk.

Behind it sat a chair.

Empty.

Rowan looked around. "This is less haunted than I expected."

"Give it time," Corvin said.

Maris walked toward the nearest shelf. Labels had been carved into the wood in a language she had begun to recognize from the Hall.

"These are categories," she said.

"Of what?" Alias asked.

Maris read the first three slowly.

"Maps Returned. Records Unfinished. Questions Unread."

Everyone stopped.

Varux had not moved from the doorway.

Alias looked at him.

"You have been here."

"Yes."

"Did you read the questions?"

Varux shook his head.



"Why not?"

"Because I thought I already knew mine."

Maris turned toward the shelf.

"Questions Unread," she repeated.

There were dozens of narrow boxes beneath the label. Each had a small slot for a card. Some were empty. Others held folded papers, their edges yellowed by age.

Corvin stepped closer. "They are sorted by name."

"Whose names?" Rowan asked.

Maris ran one finger along the card labels.

"Travelers. Researchers. Readers." Her hand stopped.

"Here."

The card read:

VARUX HYBOREA.

The room went silent.

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version did not look back.

"Varux Hyborea?" Maris asked.

Varux nodded.

"That is your full name?" Rowan said.

"No."

"Then why is it on the box?"

Varux's jaw tightened.

"Because that is the name I gave the archive."

"Why?"

The question came from Alias.

Varux closed his eyes for one second.

"Because I did not want it to know who I was."

"The archive?" Corvin asked.

"Yes."

"That is not how records work."

"I know."

"Stop."

Varux opened his eyes.

"Because I did not want a place that remembered names to remember mine," he said. "Not Alias. Not the name my parents gave me. Not the name the others knew."

Maris looked at the card again.

"Hyborea?"

"It was the name of a mountain range on an old map," Varux said. "I saw it and used it."

Rowan stared at him.

"You chose a fake name from a map?"

"Yes."

"That is the most Corvin thing I have ever heard from you."

Corvin looked offended. "I choose useful names."

"Mountains are useful."

"They are not names."

"They are if you need one."

The argument did not soften the room.

Alias stepped toward the box.

"What questions did you leave?"

Varux looked at him.

"I do not remember."

"That is not possible."

"It is when you are trying not to remember."

Maris opened the box.

Varux moved forward.

"No."

The word struck harder than he intended. Everyone stopped.

Varux looked at the open box, then at Maris.

"Please."

Maris held still.

"Why?" she asked.

The older Alias did not answer.

Alias felt the old anger return. Not bright. Not explosive. He was tired of doors that opened only after Varux had decided what everyone else was allowed to see.

"You told me the archive had questions," Alias said.

"I told you it existed."

"You brought us here."

"I know."

"Then you do not get to stop us at the first thing that has your name on it."

Varux looked at him.

For a moment, the room seemed to shrink around them.

Then Varux nodded.

"Open it," he said.

Maris removed the first folded page.

The paper inside was blank except for one line written in the archive's blue ink.

WHAT WOULD YOU CALL YOURSELF IF NO ONE WAS WAITING?

Rowan frowned. "That is not a question. That is a problem."

Varux stared at the page.

"I remember that one," he said.

"Did you answer it?" Maris asked.

"Varux."

The second page opened itself.

WHAT WOULD YOU CALL HOME IF YOU WERE AFRAID TO RETURN?

Varux did not answer.

The blue letters beneath it appeared slowly.

A PLACE I WILL VISIT LATER.

Alias felt something tighten inside him.

The archive had written his answers down.

Not just the words he had wanted to remember. The words he had used to avoid the truth.

Maris opened another page.

WHAT DO YOU WANT TO KNOW?

The answer had been written in Varux's own hand.

WHY DID THEY LEAVE ME?

The room went quiet.

Alias stared at the line.

Varux's face had gone pale.

"Your parents," Maris said softly.

Varux nodded once.

The next page unfolded.

WHAT WILL YOU DO IF THE ANSWER HURTS?

The answer below it was written in dark, hurried ink.

KEEP WALKING.

No one spoke.

The Paper rustled in Alias's hand.

Blue letters appeared.

THAT WAS NOT THE ONLY OPTION.

Varux laughed once, but there was no humor in it.

"No," he said. "It was just the one I chose."

Corvin looked at the box.

"Are there more?"

"Yes," Maris said.

"Do we read them?"

Varux looked like he wanted to say no.

Then he looked at the blue shared journal in Maris's bag.

"Not all," he said. "Not today."

Alias studied him.

"Why not?"

"Because I am allowed to be afraid of some things."

The answer surprised him.

It was not a refusal. It was not a trick. It was simply true.

Maris folded the pages and placed them back in the box.

"Then we read the questions that belong to us," she said.

"What questions are those?" Rowan asked.

She looked at the shelf labels.

"Questions that are not about the future. Questions that were left here before Varux ever came."

They searched together.

The archive held more than questions. In the next room, Corvin found returned maps that had been left by travelers who never came back to collect them. Maris discovered letters written but never sent, kept in sealed cases. Rowan found a stack of recipes copied from taverns across the continent and declared the archive officially useful.

Eldric walked slowly between the shelves, reading titles without touching them.

Alias stayed near the Questions Unread boxes.

He could not stop thinking about the one that had asked Varux what he would call home.

A place I will visit later.

It sounded harmless when written down.

It was not.

Near the back wall, he found a small box with no name card.

Only the Reader symbol.

He looked toward Eldric.

"Can I open this?"

The old mage studied it.

"You can ask why it is there first."

Alias frowned. "Why is it there?"

Nothing happened.

Rowan leaned over his shoulder. "Maybe it is waiting for a better question."

Alias looked at the box.

"Who left it?"

The lock clicked.

The lid lifted.

Inside rested a single strip of paper.

It was not old. The ink was not faded. The edges were clean.

Maris took it first.

"There is writing on both sides," she said.

On one side, in blue archive ink, was a sentence:

TO THE READER WHO BELIEVES EVERY ANSWER LIVES AHEAD:

Below it, in another hand, someone had written:

You are not wrong to seek. You are wrong to seek alone.

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version looked as startled as anyone.

"I did not write that," he said.

Maris turned the page over.

The back carried a rough drawing of a road dividing in two. One branch led east into a line of mountains. The other curled west toward a small circle marked with a simple word.

HOME.

At the bottom was an initial.

M.

The room went still.

Rowan stared at the page. "That is M?"

"Probably," Maris said.

"Probably?"

"An initial is not a person."

"Neither is a mountain, apparently, but we use those as names now."

Varux stepped closer to the paper.

For the first time, he looked afraid of it.

"I never found that," he said.

"But it was here," Alias replied.

"Not in my road."

Maris looked at him. "Then something has changed."

The words hung in the archive like a new doorway.

Corvin took the strip of paper and studied the drawing.

"The road east is not labeled," he said. "But the west road is."

"Home," Rowan said.

"Yes."

"That seems obvious."

"Nothing in old archives is obvious."

Eldric looked at the page for a long time.

"Maybe M did not leave an answer," he said. "Maybe M left a warning."

"About what?" Alias asked.

Eldric looked at Varux.

"About mistaking the road for the reason to walk it."

Varux did not argue.

At the front desk, one of the blue lamps flickered.

Then a drawer beneath it opened by itself.

A small bell rang somewhere inside the walls.

Everyone turned.

"What was that?" Rowan asked.

Maris moved to the desk. Inside the drawer lay a narrow card, blank except for one blue sentence.

RETURN WHAT YOU CARRY.

Corvin frowned. "What does that mean?"

Eldric looked at the room.

"Perhaps this archive does not keep things for us."

The shelves around them seemed suddenly heavier.

Returned maps. Unsent letters. Questions unread.

All the things people had carried until they could no longer hold them.

Varux looked down at the private black journal inside his pack.

Alias saw it.

"So return something," he said.

The older version looked at him sharply.

"What?"

"You said the archive remembers names. It holds questions. It keeps things people could not carry." Alias pointed to the desk. "Return something."

Varux's hand closed around the strap of his pack.



"No."

"Why?"

"Because this is mine."

"Your journal?"

"Yes."

"You do not have to give it away."

"I know."

"Then what is the problem?"

Varux looked at the shelves.

"If I leave it here, I might not come back for it."

The room went quiet.

The answer was so small.

It made Alias understand more than a speech would have.

He was not afraid of losing the journal.

He was afraid of proving that he could leave again.

"You do not have to leave the journal," Alias said.

Varux looked at him.

"Leave a page."

The older Alias did not move.

Maris opened the shared journal and handed him a loose sheet of paper.

"Write something for the archive," she said. "A question. A record. Something you are willing to leave behind."

Varux held the paper.

For a long time, he did not write.

Then he sat at the desk.

The others gave him space.

The pencil moved slowly across the page.

When he finished, he folded it once and placed it in the open drawer.

The blue lamp brightened.

The drawer closed.

The archive was silent again.

"What did you write?" Rowan asked.

Varux looked at the desk.

"A question."

"What question?"

The older Alias considered him.

Then he said, "How do I come home without making them carry my guilt?"

Nobody laughed.

The Paper wrote in blue letters:

BY WALKING WITH THEM.

Varux stared at the words.

Alias looked at the shelves of old questions.

Then at the road drawing from M.

Home was marked as a destination.

Not a reward.

Not something to earn.

A direction.

The archive door opened behind them.

Outside, late afternoon light poured over the hills.

They had found no answer about Alias's parents.

No clear truth about M.

No way to repair seventeen years.

But they had found a warning someone had left for a Reader who thought answers lived only ahead.

And they had found proof that the future did not hold every page already written.

As they stepped out into the light, Varux paused beside Alias.

"The town is close," he said.

"What town?"

"Ravencross."

"Is that important?"

Varux looked down the road.

"It is where I first used the name Varux."

Alias stared at him.

The older version did not look away.

"Maybe," he said, "it is time to tell you why."

The road south waited beneath the fading sun.

Behind them, the archive kept its unanswered questions.

Ahead, the man called Varux had finally begun to offer an answer.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 17

### Questions Unread

#### *Shared Journal Entry 431*

*"A question can be unanswered without being unimportant. Sometimes it is only waiting for the person who has finally learned how to hear it."*

Ravencross announced itself with ravens.

They gathered on the old gate before the group reached the town, black wings crowded along its curved ironwork. There were dozens of them. Some watched from chimneys. Others paced the wet roofs or lifted into the air at the sound of the group's boots, only to settle again a few streets farther on.

Rowan stopped beneath the gate and looked up.

"I like towns that have a reasonable number of birds," he said.

Maris counted the nearest group with her eyes. "There are thirty-one on that roof alone."

"Exactly. Unreasonable."

The town itself was small, built where three old roads met beneath a low ridge. Its houses climbed the slope in crooked rows of stone and dark timber. A market square sat at the center, mostly empty in the late afternoon except for a woman sweeping rainwater from the front of a shop and a boy carrying baskets that were clearly too large for him.

It looked ordinary.

That was the first thing Alias noticed.

After the Hall, the observatory, the archive, and the mill beneath Hollow Creek, he had begun expecting every important place to announce itself with a door that opened only for Readers or a sentence carved into stone. Ravencross had none of that. It had a baker, a smithy, three narrow streets, and a crooked bell tower with one missing pane of glass.

Varux had stopped just inside the gate.

He was not looking at the ravens.

He was staring at a two-story inn across the square. Its sign showed a black feather crossing a silver road.

The Crossed Feather.

"Is that where you stayed?" Alias asked.

Varux nodded.

“The first time,” he said.

“First time using the name?” Maris asked.

“Yes.”

The answer left the group quiet.

Corvin looked toward the sky. “We need rooms before the rain returns.”

Rowan turned to Varux. “Does this inn have food?”

“Yes.”

“Good food?”

Varux paused.

“Better than the road.”

“That sounds like an endorsement from someone who has eaten bark.”

“I have not eaten bark.”

“Yet.”

They crossed the square.

The inn door opened before they reached it. A woman stepped outside carrying a bucket of grey water. She was perhaps in her fifties, broad-shouldered, with silver hair braided down her back.

She stopped when she saw Varux.

The bucket nearly slipped from her hand.

“Varux?” she said.

The name sounded different in someone else’s voice.

Not like a warning.

Like recognition.

Varux went still.

The woman stared at him for several seconds, then shook her head as though trying to clear a thought that had no right to be there.

“No,” she said. “You cannot be.”

Rowan looked at Alias. “This is bad, right?”

“I do not know.”

The woman set the bucket down slowly. “You left five years ago.”

Varux swallowed. “I know.”

“You paid for a room for a month and stayed for almost four. Then you vanished without collecting your things.”

Varux looked toward the inn door.

“I did not leave anything important.”

The woman gave a short laugh.

“You left three books, a coat, a cracked cup, and a note telling me not to worry.”

No one moved.

Alias felt the words land in exactly the wrong place.

Not to worry.

The woman’s eyes flicked from Varux to the rest of them. She studied Alias for a second too long.

Then her expression changed.

“Oh,” she said.

Varux stepped forward. “Lessa—”

“You brought them.”

His face closed.

“I did not mean to bring anyone into this.”

Lessa looked at the group again. “You look tired. Come inside before the birds decide you are part of their evening meeting.”

Rowan looked upward. “Do they have meetings?”

“They have opinions,” Lessa said. “That is worse.”

Inside, the Crossed Feather smelled of bread, damp wool, and something sweet simmering in a pot. A fire burned in the center hearth. The room held six tables, most empty. Old maps covered the walls, their edges curled from years of smoke and heat.

Alias followed Varux toward the back, where a narrow stair climbed to the upper floor.

Lessa stopped him with one hand.

“Your room is still there,” she said.

Varux blinked. “You kept it?”

“I rented it to travelers. I did not keep it as a shrine.”

“That is not what I meant.”

“I know.” Her face softened slightly. “But I did keep the things you left.”

Varux looked as if he did not know whether to be relieved or afraid.

Lessa glanced at the group. “You can have the table by the fire. I will bring food. Then you can decide whether you want to go upstairs.”

Varux nodded.

The table by the fire had enough room for all of them, though Rowan immediately took up more than his share of the bench. Maris sat with the shared journal in front of her but did not open it.

Corvin spread a map beside the salt dish. Eldric accepted tea from Lessa with the solemn gratitude of someone receiving medicine.

Varux sat across from Alias.

For a while, nobody spoke.

Then Rowan said, “So. Questions unread.”

Maris looked at him.

“What?” he said. “That is the chapter’s title, isn’t it?”

Corvin rubbed his temples. “What chapter?”

“The chapter we are currently in.”

“We are not in a chapter.”

“We are always in a chapter. Life has structure.”

Maris stared at Rowan for a long second. “I hate that you may be right for the wrong reasons.”

Varux looked between them.

The corner of his mouth lifted.

Alias watched it disappear again when Lessa returned with a tray of bowls.

Stew. Fresh bread. Apples cooked with cinnamon. Not a celebration, but close enough that the table fell quiet for a different reason.

Rowan took one bite and closed his eyes.

“This town is forgiven for the ravens,” he said.

Lessa placed a cup of tea beside Varux. “You still take it with too much honey?”

Varux stared at the cup.

“I did?”

“You did. You claimed it made the bitter herbs more honest.”

Rowan pointed at him. “That sounds like you.”

“It does not,” Varux said.

“It really does,” Alias said.

For a moment, Varux looked at him.

Then he picked up the cup.

He added honey.

After Lessa walked away, Maris opened the shared journal.

“I am writing the questions,” she said.

Varux tensed immediately.

“Not the answers,” Maris continued. “Only the questions. We have found too many things we are supposed to understand later. I want them written somewhere before they become another road we walk past.”

Varux relaxed by a fraction.

“That seems reasonable,” he said.

“Good. First question: why did you call yourself Varux?”

The room quieted.

Varux held his tea in both hands.

“When I came here,” he said, “Lessa asked my name.”

The innkeeper looked up from the bar but did not interrupt.

“I had been walking for weeks. I had told people different things. A traveler. A mapmaker. A scholar. Nothing that sounded like me. Then she asked, and I realized I did not want to say Alias.”



“Why?” Alias asked.

Varux looked down at the honey swirling through the tea.

“Because Alias was a name that belonged to a boy who had people waiting for him.”

The words were quiet.

“I did not think I was allowed to use it anymore.”

Alias felt the answer settle inside him.

“So you made up Varux.”

“Not exactly. I saw the word in a ruined text a few days before. It was probably the name of an old road or an old person. I did not know. I only knew it did not belong to anyone who would ask me why I had not come home.”

“And Hyborea?” Maris asked.

Varux gave a small laugh.

“An old mountain range on a map. Lessa said Varux sounded unfinished, and I panicked.”

Lessa called from the bar, “I said it sounded like you needed a surname.”

Varux looked embarrassed.

“That too.”

Rowan blinked. “So you invented a whole person because someone asked for a surname?”

“I did not invent a whole person.”

“You gave him a name, a mountain, and a room at an inn. That is at least half a person.”

Corvin looked at the journal. “Second question. What did you do for five years before we met you?”

Varux’s face changed.

That question hurt differently.

“I waited,” he said.

“That is not five years of work,” Corvin replied.

“No. It is not.” Varux looked at the maps on the wall. “I learned routes. I found places that would matter. I learned enough old language to read the signs the structures used. I tried to understand how I had come back. I collected things I thought would help.”

“Did they?” Alias asked.

“Some did.”

“And the rest?”

“The rest were ways to pretend I was preparing instead of hiding.”

No one spoke for a moment.

Varux continued before anyone could ask the next question.

“I came to Ravencross several times. I copied maps for Lessa. I paid for rooms I did not need. I watched the roads. I waited for signs that you had begun the journey.”

“You could have come to Maanhaven,” Alias said.

Varux looked at him.

“Yes.”

“Did you?”

The older version did not answer.

Alias felt the old anger stir.

“Did you?”

Varux’s fingers tightened around his cup.

“Once.”

The room became very still.

“When?” Maris asked.

“Before you began traveling. Before you met the others properly.”

Alias stared at him.

“You saw Maanhaven?”

“Yes.”

“Did you see me?”

Varux did not look away.

“Yes.”

The answer struck harder than anything else had.

Alias's throat went tight.

"Where?"

"Outside Gerhardt's tavern. You were carrying a crate. You dropped it. Someone laughed."

Rowan looked toward Alias. "Did that happen?"

Alias could not answer.

It probably had. A crate. A laugh. An ordinary afternoon he had never thought would matter.

"You saw me," Alias said again.

"Yes."

"And you did not come over."

"No."

"Why?"

Varux looked at the shared journal.

"Because you were happy."

Alias stared at him.

"That is why you did not come over?"

"I thought I would ruin it."

"You do not get to decide that."

"I know."

"Stop."

Varux closed his mouth.

The silence stretched.

Lessa returned to collect the empty bowls. She looked at Varux once, then at Alias, as though she understood enough not to ask questions in front of everyone.

"Your old room is ready," she said. "Whatever you decide."

Varux nodded.

After dinner, he went upstairs alone.

Alias waited less than a minute before following him.

The upper hallway was narrow and dark. Rain tapped against the small windows. Varux stood outside the third door on the left, hand resting against the knob.

“You are not going in,” Alias said.

Varux looked over his shoulder.

“I was deciding.”

“That is what you say when you are avoiding something.”

“Probably.”

The room beyond the door smelled of old wood and dust. It was small: a bed, a desk, a cracked washbasin, a narrow window facing the square. Lessa had placed three objects on the desk.

A patched grey coat.

A cracked blue cup.

A bundle of letters tied with blue string.

Varux stopped in the doorway.

Alias walked to the desk first.

“You left letters?”

“No.”

“They have your name on them.”

The oldest envelope read: Varux Hyborea, The Crossed Feather, Ravencross.

The handwriting was neat.

Varux reached for it, then stopped.

“I never opened them.”

Alias looked at him.

“Why?”

“I thought they were from people who wanted something from Varux.”

“And?”

Varux pointed to the first envelope.

“Read the sender.”

Alias turned it over.

The return address had faded, but the name was clear.

Eldric Vale.

Alias’s heart seemed to stop.

“Eldric wrote to you?”

Varux looked at the letters.

“I do not know how he found the name. He always found things.”

He picked up the first envelope with shaking hands.

The seal had never been broken.

Behind them, the floor creaked.

Eldric stood in the doorway.

No one had heard him climb the stairs.

The older mage looked at the envelope. His face did not change, but Alias saw something in his eyes soften and sharpen at once.

“May I?” Eldric asked.

Varux held the letter tighter.

Then he gave it to him.

Eldric opened it carefully.

The paper inside was thin and yellowed. He read it silently first.

Then he looked at Varux.

“I wrote this?”

“Yes.”

“What does it say?” Alias asked.

Eldric read aloud.

“Varux, or whoever you are: I have met enough people who carry their answers like shields to recognize one. You do not have to explain yourself in a letter. But you should know that if you are the person I think you are, there is tea waiting in Maanhaven. It will be better if you arrive before it goes cold.”

The room went silent.

Varux sat down on the edge of the bed.

“I thought it was a trick,” he said.

Eldric looked at the letter again.

“It was not a very clever one.”

“I know.”

No one corrected him.

There were two more letters.

The second was from Maris.

The third was from Gerhardt.

Varux did not open them.

Not yet.

He placed them on the desk beside the cracked blue cup.

Alias looked out the window. Below, the ravens had gathered again along the inn sign. Rain shone on their feathers.

“You can read them later,” he said.

Varux looked at him.

“Not tomorrow,” Alias added. “Later can mean later. But not never.”

The older version smiled faintly.

“That is a better definition.”

Eldric folded the letter and returned it to the envelope.

“You were using a false name,” he said.

“Yes.”

“But I found you anyway.”

“Yes.”

“Why do you think that is?”

Varux stared at the old grey coat.

“Because you are annoying?”

Eldric’s mouth lifted.

“Partly.”

For the first time since they had entered the room, Varux looked almost at peace.

Only almost.

Downstairs, Rowan shouted that someone had found a room with two beds and that he was claiming both. Corvin shouted back that that was not how beds worked. Maris told them both to stop shouting in an inn.

The sound filled the hallway.

Ordinary. Loud. Alive.

Varux looked toward it.

Then he picked up the shared journal from Maris’s bag where she had left it near the door.

He opened to the newest page.

Under the three lines he had written that morning, he added another.

I used a false name because I thought my real one belonged to a home I had lost.

He paused.

Then he wrote:

Maybe it still belongs to me.

Alias read the words over his shoulder.

He did not say anything.

He did not need to.

Outside, the ravens lifted from the inn sign together.

Their wings crossed the dark sky in a single moving shape.

Below them, the road to Maanhaven still existed.

It had never stopped.

Neither, perhaps, had the way home.

\* \* \*



## Chapter 18

### The Man Called Varux *Shared Journal Entry 432*

*"A name can be a shelter. It can also become a room you are afraid to leave."*

Morning came to Ravencross in the sound of wings.

The ravens had returned to the inn sign before sunrise. Their claws clicked along the painted wood outside Varux's old room, and every few minutes one of them gave a low, rough call that sounded far too much like a person clearing their throat before saying something difficult.

Alias had not slept much.

He had spent half the night thinking about the unopened letters on the desk. Eldric's first letter had been simple. Tea waiting in Maanhaven. Come home before it goes cold.

The other two were still tied with blue string.

One from Maris.

One from Gerhardt.

They sat beside the cracked blue cup and the patched coat, waiting quietly in the pale square of light from the window.

Varux was awake before Alias opened his eyes. He sat at the desk with the shared journal in front of him, pencil resting between his fingers. He had not written anything yet.

"You are staring at the letters," Alias said.

Varux did not look up. "You are awake."

"That is not an answer."

"No."

Outside, a raven pecked against the glass.

Alias sat up. "Are you going to open them?"

Varux looked at the blue string.

"Not today."

Alias frowned. "Why?"

"Because I want to read them when I can actually answer them."

"You did not answer the last ones."

"I know."

Alias gave him a look.

Varux exhaled. "I mean, that is why I am afraid to open these. I am trying not to make the same choice twice. That does not mean I can suddenly stop being afraid of it."

The answer made it difficult to stay angry.

Alias hated that.

A knock sounded at the door.

Before either of them answered, Lessa opened it with one hand and carried a tray in with the other. Bread, eggs, a pot of tea, and a plate of honey cakes filled it so completely that Alias moved aside just in time.

"Breakfast," she said. "Eat before the ravens decide you are weak."

"Do ravens do that?" Alias asked.

"Ravens decide everything. They are just polite enough not to explain it."

Rowan appeared in the doorway behind her, half-dressed and hopeful. "Honey cakes?"

"One," Lessa said.

"One each?"

"One total."

Rowan looked as if he had just learned something cruel about the world.

Lessa placed the tray on the desk. Her gaze found Varux, then the letters, then the shared journal.

"You wrote," she said.

Varux glanced at the open page. "A little."

"Good."

That was all she said about it.

Alias watched Varux's face. The older version of him looked as if he had expected a question. Or an accusation. Lessa only moved the cracked cup away from the edge of the desk so it would not fall.

"You kept this too," Varux said.

"It was a perfectly good cup." Lessa paused. "Mostly."

"It has a crack through the side."

"Then it has character."

Rowan picked up the cup and inspected it. "I like her."

"You have known her for eight seconds," Maris said from the hall.

"That is enough for some people."

The others arrived one by one. Corvin came last, already fully prepared to leave and carrying his map case. He stopped when he saw the letters.

"Are those relevant?" he asked.

Varux's hand moved over them without touching. "Probably."

"Then we should know what they say."

"Not today," Varux replied.

Corvin held his gaze for a moment.

Then he nodded once. "Fine. But not never."

Varux looked at Alias.

"Not never," he said.

They ate downstairs at the long table near the hearth. The Crossed Feather was quiet in the morning. Rain had washed the market square clean overnight, and pale sunlight found its way through the front windows. The ravens remained on the sign outside, black against the wet grey sky.

Lessa served tea to Eldric before he asked for it. He accepted the cup with a solemn little nod.

"You remembered," he said.

"You were here once," Lessa replied. "You said the tea was good but the chairs were bad."

Eldric considered the chair beneath him.

"I stand by that assessment."

Rowan looked around. "When were all of you here without us?"

Varux's spoon stopped in the honey.

Lessa answered instead. "Five years ago, this one came into town during a storm. He looked like a road had thrown him out and regretted it. Two days later, an older man with a staff arrived and asked whether I had seen a young wolffolk traveler who lied badly."

Eldric's brow lifted. "That sounds unlike me."

"You were more polite than that," Lessa said. "But only a little."

Alias looked at Varux.

"You met Eldric five years ago?"

"Briefly," Varux said.

"And you did not tell him who you were?"

"No."

"Why not?"

Varux stirred the honey into his tea until it disappeared.

"Because he looked at me like he knew."

Eldric set down his cup.

"I did not know," he said. "Not then."

"You knew enough."

"I knew you were lonely." Eldric's voice was gentle. "That is not the same thing."

The table went quiet.

Lessa leaned one hand against the back of an empty chair.

"He stayed here nearly four months," she said. "Copied maps. Helped with repairs. Paid too much for rooms and ate too little. Every few days, he asked whether anyone had come through from Maanhaven."

Alias stared at Varux.

"You were waiting for us."

"For you," Varux said.

"But you did not want to meet me."

Varux looked down.

"I wanted to know you were all right."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

Alias felt the words from yesterday rise again.

You saw me outside Gerhardt's tavern. You saw me happy. You did not come over.

"You kept choosing the edge of things," he said.

Varux looked at him.

"The edge?"

"The edge of home. The edge of the room. The edge of the road. You wanted to see us, but not be seen."

Lessa was quiet. So were the others.

Varux's face tightened. He looked as if he wanted to explain himself and had run out of explanations he trusted.

"Yes," he said at last.

It was not enough.

It was honest.

Lessa picked up the empty tray.

"I have something else," she said. "I found it under the floorboards in the room after you vanished. I did not open it. Seemed like it belonged to the man who would eventually be brave enough to ask for it."

She disappeared behind the bar before anyone could respond.

When she returned, she carried a flat wooden box.

It was not large. Its lid had been repaired with a strip of copper. A thin line of blue paint ran along the edge, almost worn away.

Varux stood.

"I do not remember that."

"You would not," Lessa said. "You hid it well."

She set the box on the table.

Varux did not reach for it.

Alias did not either.

After a moment, Lessa sighed and opened the lid herself.

Inside lay three things.

A small bundle of folded maps.

A grey stone with a narrow blue vein through its center.

And a piece of paper covered in Varux's handwriting.

The ink had faded, but the title was clear.

Things I Will Do Before I See Him.

No one said anything.

Varux stared at the page as if it had been written by someone else.

Lessa picked it up carefully.

"I did not read much," she said. "Enough to know you were being unfair to yourself."

She handed it to him.

His hands shook as he unfolded it.

Alias could read the first few lines where he stood.

*Find a way to stop the tower.*

*Learn the old language.*

*Know what happened to our parents.*

*Make sure he does not leave.*

*Find an answer worth bringing home.*

The last line had been written more deeply than the others.

Do not let him see who I became.

Alias looked at Varux.

"You wrote that five years ago?"

Varux nodded once.

"I thought if you saw me," he said, "you would only see what happens when you leave."

"I do see it."

Varux flinched.

Alias continued before he could stop himself.

"I see that you were scared. I see that you made bad choices. I see that you let fear decide too much. But I also see you came back. You waited five years. You walked into our camp. You let us be angry at you."

Varux looked at him.

The inn was silent except for the small hiss of rain outside.

"That does not make it good," Alias said. "But it does not make you only the bad part."

For a moment, Varux looked unable to breathe.

Rowan cleared his throat.

"I agree with Alias," he said. "Mostly because we have already decided you are useful for wood, fires, maps, and being mysteriously sad at buildings."

Maris looked at him.

"That was almost kind."

"Do not tell anyone."

Corvin reached into the box and lifted the bundle of maps. The top sheet showed Ravencross, Maanhaven, the Hall, Hollow Creek, and a thin route heading east across a range of low mountains.

"These are your preparations," he said.

Varux nodded.

"Some of them."

A red circle had been drawn around a location far east of the road.

No name appeared beside it. Only a note in small handwriting.

Find the place above the first road.

Maris leaned closer.

"The tower," she said.

Varux's eyes moved to the words.

"Yes."

Alias looked from the map to the paper list.

"You knew about the tower before we met."

"I knew where I thought it was."

"And you did not tell us."

"No."

"Why?"

Varux gave a tired smile.

"Because I was afraid you would go there."

"We are going there anyway."

"I know."

Alias folded his arms.

"Then why are you still hiding the map?"

Varux looked at the red circle.

"Because knowing the place is not the same as being ready for it."

Eldric studied the route. "That may be true. But readiness is not made by secrecy."

Varux looked at him.

The old mage spoke calmly, but each word landed with weight.

"You have spent years deciding when people are ready to know you. That is not your decision to make alone."

The man called Varux lowered his gaze.

"No," he said.

Lessa touched the cracked cup with one finger.

"You know what I remember about you?" she asked.

Varux looked up.

"Not the fake name. Not the strange questions. Not the way you stared out the window every time a wagon came through town." She paused. "I remember that you fixed the broken shelf in the pantry without being asked. I remember that you gave Kellan the last honey cake because he looked hungry. I remember you stayed up all night with a sick traveler because you thought he would die alone."



Varux stared at her.

"I did that?"

Lessa smiled, small and sad. "You did."

Alias watched the older version of himself try to hold that memory.

It looked harder than carrying a map.

"Varux was not only a lie," Lessa continued. "It was the name you used while you were lost.  
There is a difference."

The words settled over the table.

Alias looked at the map, then at the shared journal in Maris's bag.

"What do you want to be called?" he asked.

Varux went very still.

The question was simple.

That was why it hurt.

"I do not know," he said.

Rowan leaned back in his chair. "That is allowed. We can call you Varux until you decide."

"And Alias?" Maris asked.

The older version looked at the younger one.

Alias thought of the boy outside Gerhardt's tavern. Carrying a crate. Happy for one ordinary second while someone he would become watched from across the street and decided not to walk over.

"Alias is still yours," he said. "It is not mine to give away."

Varux's eyes filled.

"It was always yours too," he whispered.

"Maybe." Alias looked at the shared journal. "But you do not have to steal it back from me."

The older Alias laughed through the beginning of a sob. He covered his face with one hand.

No one looked away.

Not because they wanted to watch him cry.

Because looking away would have been another kind of leaving.

After a while, Varux lowered his hand.

"Alias," he said softly, trying the name as if it might break. "Called Varux."

Maris opened the shared journal.

"Write it," she said.

Varux took the pencil.

Under yesterday's entry, he wrote:

Alias, called Varux.

Then he stopped.

He added one more line.

I am still learning which name feels like home.

The Paper, folded in Alias's pocket, rustled once.

Blue ink appeared.

BOTH MAY BE TRUE.

Rowan leaned over to read it.

"Your Paper is being helpful. I do not trust it."

Lessa laughed. The sound broke the tension in the room without making it disappear.

By midday, the rain had stopped.

The group stood outside the Crossed Feather with packs ready. The ravens gathered on the inn sign above them, watching with the grave attention of judges who had not been invited to the trial.

Lessa handed Varux the patched grey coat.

"You left this," she said.

He took it.

For a moment he held it against his chest. Then he folded it carefully and tied it to his pack instead of putting it on.

"Not today?" Lessa asked.

"Not today," he said.

She nodded as if that answer was enough.

Corvin held the map with the red circle.

"East," he said.

Maris checked the route. "Two days to the foothills. Another day to the tower if we find the upper road."

Rowan looked at the sky. "Does the tower have food?"

"No," Varux said.

"Rude."

Eldric stepped onto the road first.

Alias followed. Varux walked beside him, not behind.

They passed beneath the ravens.

For the first time, Alias did not hear the birds as a warning.

He heard them as witnesses.

The man called Varux was still afraid.

The man called Alias was still angry.

But the road ahead was no longer one of them running from the other.

It was east.

And this time, they were going together.

\* \* \*

## PART III - THE TOWER ABOVE

### Chapter 19

#### East of Home

#### *Shared Journal Entry 433*

*"East was only a direction until I used it as an excuse not to turn around."*

The road east began at a broken signpost.

One arm pointed west.

MAANHAVEN — 3 DAYS.

The other pointed toward the hills.

NO MARKED SETTLEMENTS.

Someone had scratched a third message into the wood years ago, deep enough to survive rain and road dust.

TURN BACK WHILE YOU STILL KNOW WHY.

Rowan read it aloud.

Then he looked at Varux.

"That feels pointed."

Varux did not answer.

The group had left Ravencross at dawn. The town still clung to the edges of Alias's thoughts: Lessa's cracked blue cup, the ravens on the inn sign, the letters tied with blue string that Varux had not opened. The old map with its red circle now rested in Corvin's case, folded beside the route to the tower.

They had enough food for five days.

Enough water for two.

Enough questions for a lifetime.

Alias stood in front of the signpost and looked west.

Maanhaven was not visible. It was too far behind the hills, beyond the road they had used to reach Ravencross. But the word was there anyway, cut into the wood as plainly as a door.

Home.

Varux stood a short distance away with his grey cloak folded over one arm. He had not worn it since leaving the inn. The patched coat Lessa had given back to him was tied to his pack instead.

"You do not have to go east," Alias said.

Varux looked at him.

"Neither do you."

"That is not an answer."

"No."

Alias folded his arms. "Then answer me."

The older version looked toward the hills.

"The tower is east."

"I know."

"You want answers."

"I know."

"You are angry that I left."

"I know that too."

A faint smile touched Varux's face, then faded.

"I do not want you to take this road because I took it," he said. "I want you to take it because you still choose it after knowing what I did with it."

The words made Alias quiet.

It was not a command. Not a warning. It was a choice handed back to him, and he did not entirely like how heavy it felt.

Maris stepped up beside the signpost. "The tower may be east, but it is not your east."

Varux looked at her.

She continued, "Your road went looking for a single answer. Ours is going toward a place we have agreed to investigate together. That difference matters."

Corvin nodded. "We also have a map, supplies, and a route back. Those are practical improvements."

Rowan leaned against the signpost. "And I am here. Which is an emotional improvement."

"No one has said that," Corvin replied.

"I am saying it now."

Eldric looked at the western arm of the signpost.

"Roads are not guilty," he said. "People give them meanings. East did not take you away from home."

Varux looked down.

"No," he said quietly. "I used it to keep walking."

The wind moved through the dry grass around the post.

Alias took one final look at the word Maanhaven.

Then he turned east.

"All right," he said. "We go together."

Varux's shoulders lowered slightly.

Not relief. Not yet.

But something close enough to make Alias notice.

The road east was quieter than the roads they had taken before.

There were no villages in the first miles. No market carts. No fences or farms. The path narrowed between hills where pale grasses grew taller than Alias's knees. Black stone pushed through the earth in broken slabs, each one marked by shallow lines that might have been natural or might have been old writing worn smooth by weather.

By noon, the group had settled into a rhythm.

Corvin led with the map open in one hand. Maris walked beside him and occasionally corrected a landmark with notes from the observatory charts. Rowan ranged ahead, returned whenever he found something uninteresting, and narrated it anyway. Eldric kept the pace slow enough that no one could pretend exhaustion was bravery.

Varux walked beside Alias.

At first neither spoke.

Then Alias said, "Did you ever go west?"

Varux glanced over.

"After I left?"

"Yes."

"Sometimes."

"To Maanhaven?"

"No."

Alias looked at him.

"Then where?"

"Near it."

"That does not count."

"I know."

"Why not?"

Varux watched the road beneath his boots.

"Because I thought being close was safer than being seen."

Alias remembered Ravencross. The inn window. Varux standing at the edge of things.

"You could see home from somewhere?"

"Not exactly. I could see roads that led there."

"And you still did not take one."

"No."

"What did you do instead?"

Varux paused.

"I found work. Fixed fences. Copied maps. Stayed in towns long enough to learn their names, then left before anyone expected me to stay."

"That sounds lonely."

"It was."

"Then why?"

The older version did not answer for several steps.

"Because lonely felt like punishment," he said. "And I thought I deserved it."

Alias stopped walking.

Varux took another step before noticing. He turned back.

"You thought leaving meant you had to be alone forever?"

"No." Varux's expression tightened. "Not forever. Just until I became someone worth coming back to."

The answer made something in Alias go cold.

Rowan, farther ahead, shouted, "I found a rock shaped like Corvin!"

Corvin did not look up from the map. "That is not possible."

"It looks disappointed and expensive."

"It is a rock."

"Exactly."

The moment passed, but Alias carried Varux's words with him.

Someone worth coming back to.

The road climbed through a long cut between two hills. At the top, the land opened.

Far beyond the next ridge, a dark needle stood against the horizon.

The tower.

It was too far away to see clearly. Just a thin black line rising from a broader shape of rock. But once Alias saw it, he could not stop looking.

Rowan followed his gaze.

"That is it?"



"That is it," Varux said.

"It looks small."

"It is not."

"Everything dangerous is always larger when we arrive."

"That is because you insist on approaching it."

"I am part of a group. I follow the map."

Corvin held up the map. "Do not blame me for this."

Maris squinted at the distant tower. "It is built above the first road."

Varux looked at her.

"The note on your map," she explained. "Find the place above the first road. That is what it meant."

"Maybe," Varux said.

"Not maybe," Maris replied. "The observatory chart showed an older route running underneath the mountain. The tower was constructed directly above its northern bend."

Eldric looked toward the horizon. "A road beneath and a tower above. A poor place for someone who dislikes symbolism."

Rowan glanced at Alias. "Do you dislike symbolism?"

"I dislike buildings that use it against us."

"Good answer."

They camped that night beside a shallow pool fed by a spring hidden under the rocks. The water was clear but bitter. Corvin insisted it was drinkable after boiling. Rowan insisted this was a sentence people said immediately before poisoning someone.

"Nobody is being poisoned," Corvin said.

"That is exactly what someone who has poisoned someone would say."

Maris looked up from the shared journal. "You used that line yesterday."

"It remains useful."

Varux was writing.

Alias noticed before anyone else did.

He sat near the fire with the shared journal balanced on one knee, pencil moving slowly over the page. He had written in it each morning since the mill. Never much. A date. A place. A few careful words.

Tonight, he paused longer than usual.

Maris did not ask to read it. Neither did anyone else.

Eventually Varux placed the pencil down.

Rowan looked over.

"Was it a lot?"

"A little."

"That is a suspicious answer."

"It was four sentences."

Rowan leaned closer. "That is practically a speech."

Varux looked embarrassed.

Alias almost laughed.

"Do you want to share it?" Maris asked.

Varux's fingers rested on the edge of the page.

Then he nodded.

He read quietly.

"Day 4. East of Ravencross. We saw the tower from the ridge. I expected to be afraid. I am afraid.  
But I am also here.

"Alias chose the road. The others chose it too.

"That matters.

"I am trying to believe it matters."

Nobody spoke at first.

Then Eldric raised his tea cup.

"It does."

Corvin gave a short nod.

Maris smiled at the page.

Rowan looked around the fire as if searching for the correct response.

"That was good," he said. "Do not let it go to your head."

Varux's smile was small.

It stayed.

Later, after the others had gone to sleep, Alias woke to the sound of the Paper unfolding in his pack.

Blue light leaked through the cloth.

He sat up.

Varux was awake on the other side of the dying fire.

The Paper lay between Alias's hands.

A line appeared.

THE TOWER REMEMBERS THE FIRST ROAD.

Alias read it once.

Then again.

"What does that mean?" he whispered.

Varux looked at the words.

"I do not know."

Alias waited.

The older version did not look away.

"I know what I thought it meant," he said. "I thought the tower was the beginning. The place that had caused everything."

"And now?"

"Now I think it remembers something older than me."

The Paper wrote a second line.

DO NOT CLIMB TO ESCAPE THE ROAD BELOW.

Varux went still.

Alias looked from the page to the distant tower, barely visible through the dark.

"Did you do that?" he asked.

The answer came quietly.

"Yes."

"Did it work?"

Varux looked toward the horizon.

"No."

The Paper stayed open between them.

A third line appeared.

THE ROAD BELOW STILL LEADS HOME.

Alias felt the words settle into him.

Not a promise.

A direction.

Across the fire, Varux reached for his coin. He held it in one hand, thumb rubbing over the old scratch.

"I thought climbing higher would make the road look smaller," he said.

"Did it?"

"Only for a while."

Alias looked at the tower.

"Then we will not climb to forget it."

Varux met his eyes.

"No?"

"No." Alias tucked the Paper back into his pack. "We climb to find out what is there. Then we come down."

For a second, Varux looked younger.

Not nineteen.

But less alone.

"Come down," he repeated.

"That is the plan."

The tower remained dark against the sky.

Below it, somewhere beneath stone and earth, the first road waited.

And for the first time, east did not feel like the place where Varux had gone missing.

It felt like a direction they could survive together.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 20

### Burned Memory III - Following M

#### *Burned Memory III*

*"He said he was following M. The truth was that he was following every sign that let him postpone turning around."*

The tower had no road leading to it.

That was the first thing Alias noticed when they reached the foothills.

The old route from Ravencross had carried them east for two days through long fields of black grass and low stone ridges. The tower had grown slowly during that time, changing from a dark needle on the horizon into a shape too large to ignore. By the third morning, it rose above the hills like a piece of night that had forgotten how to leave.

But the road did not reach it.

It ended at a ring of broken stones.

Beyond that ring, the land dropped into a shallow basin filled with pale gravel. A dry channel cut through the middle. At the far edge, the tower rose from a cliff of black rock.

No bridge crossed the basin.

No path climbed the cliff.

No door showed in the tower wall.

Rowan stood at the final marker stone and looked around.

"That is unfair," he said.

Corvin lowered his map. "The map says the upper road reaches the tower."

"It does not."

"Clearly."

"Then perhaps we should stop trusting the map."

Corvin gave him a look. "The map brought us here."

"The map brought us to a very large wall."

Maris walked to the nearest broken stone. A line of old writing had been carved around its edge. She brushed grit away with her sleeve.

"Not a road marker," she said.

"What is it?" Alias asked.

"A boundary."

Varux stopped behind her.

The wind pulled at his coat. He had begun wearing the patched grey one again after Ravencross, though he kept the hood down. The black journal remained in his pack. The shared journal was with Maris. His old field journal had been tied shut with a strip of blue cloth.

He looked at the circle of stones as though he had been here yesterday.

"I remember this," he said.

Alias looked toward the cliff.

"Where is the way in?"

Varux did not answer.

"Varux?"

The older version pointed at the dry channel.

"Underneath," he said.

The basin did not look deep enough to hold anything. It was only pale gravel and cracked earth, with a thin line of thorn bushes following the old channel toward the cliff.

"Underneath what?" Rowan asked.

"The road."

"There is no road."

"There was."

Eldric stepped into the circle of stones. He placed the end of his staff against the gravel. A soft blue pulse spread from the point of contact, moving down the dry channel in a thin line.

For a moment, nothing happened.

Then the gravel shifted.

Not much. A few stones rolled aside. But beneath them, darker slabs appeared. They were fitted together with unnatural precision, running straight toward the cliff.

A buried road.

Maris breathed in.

"The first road," she said.

Varux closed his eyes.

The Paper rustled inside Alias's pack.

He pulled it out.

Blue letters wrote themselves across the page.

THE TOWER REMEMBERS THE FIRST ROAD.

Alias looked toward Varux.

"You knew this was here."

"I remembered part of it."

"How much?"

The older Alias looked at the buried stones.

"Enough to be afraid."

The answer made Rowan quiet.

Corvin stepped onto the exposed road. He crouched and ran one hand along the stone. "There are tracks."

"Recent?" Maris asked.

"No. Old. Deep enough that water did not erase them."

He pointed to a narrow pattern pressed into the stone. It was not a wheel mark. Not an animal print.

A line of small, repeated boots.

Someone had walked the road many times.

Eldric watched the marks.

"Readers," he said.

"How can you tell?" Alias asked.

The old mage pointed to a faint symbol stamped beside the tracks: the open eye, then the circle crossed by three lines.



The Reader mark.

Maris followed the road with her gaze until it vanished beneath the cliff.

"It goes inside the mountain."

"Or under the tower," Varux said.

"Did you follow it?" Alias asked.

The older version's face changed.

He did not need to answer.

Alias looked back at the Paper.

Blue ink had begun to pool at the bottom of the page.

Varux saw it too.

"No," he said.

The word was sharp.

Everyone turned.

Varux stared at the Paper.

"Not here."

Alias held it tighter.

"Is it another memory?"

"Yes."

"Then maybe we need it."

"Not like this."

"Why?"

Varux looked at the buried road.

His hands had curled into fists at his sides.

"Because this is where I stopped thinking I was searching for answers."

The wind moved over the gravel.

Alias waited.

Varux swallowed.

"This is where I began following M."

The Paper opened by itself.

Blue light spilled over Alias's hands.

The basin disappeared.

The tower became smaller.

The sky turned winter-grey.

And Alias stood on the first road with no one beside him.

The stones were new.

That was the first difference.

They were not buried under gravel or broken by weather. They ran clean and dark across the basin, lined by small blue lamps that glowed without flame. The tower rose above them, whole and black, its windows lit in narrow vertical strips.

Varux - younger, thinner, and alone - stood at the edge of the road.

His coat was too large for him. His bag was worn at the corners. The scar on his cheek was still pale and new. He held the Paper in one hand, open to a page covered in blue writing.

FOLLOW THE ROAD THAT REMEMBERS.

The younger Varux read the words again.

Then he looked west.

The road behind him had no lamps.

It was only mud, grass, and a track of uneven footprints leading back toward towns he had already passed through. Somewhere beyond those hills were Ravencross, Maanhaven, the Hall, the others.

Home.

The younger Varux closed the Paper.

"One night," he whispered.

The older Alias watching from inside the memory wanted to scream.

He knew that sentence now.

One night.

One more day.

Later.

The road did not answer.

The blue lamps flickered on one after another, leading east toward the tower.

Young Varux stepped onto the stones.

The first road hummed beneath his boots.

He followed it.

The memory moved with him.

At first, the road ran beneath open sky. It crossed the basin and passed under the cliff through an archway so broad that the tower seemed to have been built around it. Carved into the stone above the arch was a sentence in old letters.

THE ROAD DOES NOT PROMISE RETURN.

The younger Varux stopped long enough to read it.

Then he kept walking.

Inside the mountain, the road narrowed. The blue lamps continued along both walls. Old shelves were built into the stone at regular intervals, each one holding something left behind by travelers: a broken compass, a child's shoe, a faded red scarf, a sealed jar full of grey dust.

Young Varux walked past them all.

At the third shelf, the Paper unfolded in his hand.

A new line appeared.

ASK WHY THEY LEFT THESE THINGS.

He frowned.

"Because they did not need them."

The Paper remained still.

"Or because they could not carry them."

Again, nothing.

Young Varux looked at the shelf. The faded red scarf had been folded neatly. It did not look abandoned. It looked placed.

He reached for it.

The moment his fingers touched the cloth, blue writing appeared on the stone behind it.

I LEFT THIS BECAUSE I COULD NOT RETURN WITH IT.

Young Varux pulled his hand back.

The words faded.

He looked down the tunnel.

"That is not an answer," he said.

The Paper wrote:

NO.

He walked on.

The road descended for what felt like hours. The lamps became farther apart. The air grew colder. Somewhere below, water moved through the stone in slow, heavy sounds.

At last he reached a circular chamber.

A figure was waiting there.

The older Alias watching the memory felt his breath catch.

The figure stood with their back to the road. They wore a long dark coat, patched at the shoulders, and carried a lantern with a blue flame. Their hair was tied back beneath a hood. No face showed.

"M?" young Varux asked.

The figure did not turn.

Instead, they placed a small square of paper on the floor.

Then they walked through an open doorway at the far side of the chamber.

Young Varux ran after them.

The doorway led to a narrow stair winding upward inside the tower.

By the time he reached the first landing, the figure was gone.

Only the lantern light remained, floating ahead around the curve.

Young Varux followed.

He climbed until his legs ached.

The tower had rooms on every level. Some held broken instruments. Some held empty chairs facing blank walls. Some were filled with shelves of maps, all drawn with different roads leading toward the same small mark in the west.

HOME.

The young Varux did not stop to read them.

He followed the light.

At the seventh landing, he found another piece of paper waiting on the stair.

The handwriting was not blue archive ink.

It was dark, pressed hard into the page.

IF YOU WANT TO KNOW WHY THEY LEFT, DO NOT ASK WHERE THEY WENT.

ASK WHAT THEY COULD NOT STAY FOR.

Young Varux read it once.

Then again.

He pressed the page against his chest.

The older Alias watching the memory knew why.

It sounded like a clue to his parents.

It sounded like M knew them.

It sounded like the kind of answer he had been walking east to find.

Young Varux climbed faster.

The light led him to the top of the tower.

There, the stair opened into a circular room beneath a sealed dome. The walls were covered in names. Hundreds of them. Maybe thousands. Some were carved into stone. Some written in ink. Some scratched in with knives.

Most had been crossed out.

At the center of the room stood a wooden chair.

On the chair lay a grey cloak.

Not Varux's.

Older. Heavier. Its hem was frayed with travel. A single letter had been embroidered into the inside collar.

M.

Young Varux approached slowly.

The Paper in his hand began to shake.

A voice came from somewhere above him.

Not loud. Not close.

"You are late."

Young Varux spun around.

No one stood behind him.

He looked toward the dome.

The sealed panels overhead had opened just enough to reveal a slice of grey sky.

"M?" he called.

The voice did not answer.

The Paper unfolded.

Blue ink covered the page.

RETURN.

Young Varux looked at it.

Then at the cloak.

Then at the names on the walls.

"Not yet," he said.

The Paper wrote:

WHY?

"Because M knows something."

DOES M KNOW?

Young Varux's jaw tightened.

"I followed them here."

THAT DOES NOT MEAN YOU FOUND THEM.

The words made him angry.

He crumpled the Paper in his hand.

The blue ink faded.

The tower room went silent.

Then a second paper, hidden under the cloak, slid to the floor.

Young Varux picked it up.

Its writing was sharp and black.

IF YOU FOLLOW ME, YOU WILL LOSE THE ROAD HOME.

He stared at the sentence.

Then he turned it over.

The other side carried a rough map. A line led from the tower farther east, across a mountain range toward a mark labeled THE FIRST KEEPERS.

Beneath it was one final line.

OR YOU WILL LEARN WHY YOU LEFT IT.

Young Varux sat down in the chair.

The older Alias watching felt the old shame flood him.

He had understood the warning.

He had simply chosen to read it as an invitation.

A sound came from the stairs.

Young Varux stood.

For one breath, he expected M to appear.

Instead, a messenger climbed into the room.

She was young, perhaps seventeen, with rain on her coat and a leather bag strapped across her chest. She stopped when she saw him.

"Are you Varux Hyborea?" she asked.

Young Varux froze.

"Who wants to know?"

The messenger pulled out a folded letter.

"A woman in a town west of here. Maris. She said if I found you, I was to give you this."

The older Alias watching the memory could not breathe.

Young Varux took the letter.

His name was written across the front.

Not Varux Hyborea.

Alias.

The handwriting was Maris's.

He did not open it.

The messenger waited.

"Aren't you going to read it?" she asked.

"Later."

The word came easily.

Too easily.

The messenger looked at the open Paper in his hand.

Then at the cloak.

Then at the walls full of crossed-out names.

"You are following someone?" she asked.

Young Varux looked toward the eastern map.

"Yes."

"Do you know who they are?"

He did not answer.

The messenger shifted her bag on her shoulder.



"My father says you should never follow a person who only leaves notes," she said. "They might be trying to lead you somewhere. Or they might be trying to make sure no one catches them."

Young Varux looked at her.

"What did you say?"

She shrugged.

"He is a courier. He says roads teach you to read people."

The older Alias wanted that sentence to stop him.

The memory had other plans.

Young Varux put Maris's letter into his coat without opening it.

"Thank you," he said.

"Will you answer?"

He looked toward the eastern map.

"Yes."

The messenger watched him for a moment.

Then she nodded and went back down the stairs.

Young Varux did not move until her footsteps were gone.

Then he walked to the wall of names.

At the lowest edge, beneath an old Reader mark, he found a blank space.

He drew his knife.

The older Alias watching felt the memory recoil from him.

Young Varux carved one word into the stone.

VARUX.

Not Alias.

Not the name written on Maris's unopened letter.

Varux.

When he finished, he looked at the eastern map again.

Then he left the tower by the upper road.

He did not go west.

The memory began to blur.

The grey tower darkened.

The blue lamps along the first road winked out one by one.

The letter inside young Varux's coat remained unopened.

Then the scene broke apart.

Alias stumbled back into the present.

The buried road was beneath his boots again. The tower rose above the cliff, dark and silent. The Paper lay open in his hands, its blue ink fading to nothing.

Varux was on his knees in the gravel.

Eldric had one hand on his shoulder. Maris stood near him with the shared journal held against her chest. Rowan and Corvin had not moved.

Nobody knew what to say.

Then Rowan spoke quietly.

"You had a letter."

Varux did not answer.

"From Maris."

"I know."

"And you did not read it."

"I know."

"Why?"

The older Alias looked down at his hands.

"Because I knew what it would say."

Maris's face tightened.

"You did not."

Varux looked up.

"I knew it would ask me to come back."

"And?"

"I was afraid I would want to."

The words did not make the hurt smaller.

They made it make sense.

Alias thought of the messenger on the stairs. Of Maris's handwriting across his own name. Of the younger Varux carving a new one into the wall because he could not bear to carry the old one.

"You were not following M," Alias said.

Varux looked at him.

"I thought I was."

"No." Alias pointed to the buried road, then to the tower. "You were following every sign that meant you did not have to go home yet."

The older version flinched.

But he nodded.

"Yes."

Maris opened the shared journal.

She turned to a blank page.

"What did the letter say?" Alias asked.

Varux stared at the journal.

"I do not know."

"Do you still have it?"

For a second, nobody moved.

Then Varux reached into the inside pocket of his grey coat.

His hand came out holding a folded piece of paper.

It was worn soft at the edges. The ink on the front had faded almost to grey.

Alias.

The letter had been carried for years.

Varux looked at it as if he had never seen it before.

"I never opened it," he whispered.

Maris looked at the envelope.

The present version of her was younger than the one who had written it. Her hands trembled slightly as she reached out.

"May I?"

Varux looked at her.

Then handed it over.

She opened it carefully.

The letter inside was only one page.

Maris read it silently at first.

Her face changed.

"What does it say?" Rowan asked.

She swallowed.

"It says..." She looked down again. "It says, 'I am angry. I am worried. I do not understand why you left without telling us. But I still set a place for you when we stop for dinner, because Rowan says you will complain if we do not.'"

Rowan looked away.

Maris continued.

"Come back before you think you deserve to. You do not need to bring proof. You do not need to bring answers. Just bring yourself."

The wind moved through the gravel basin.

Varux covered his face with both hands.

Eldric did not speak.

No one did.

After a while, Alias stepped closer.

"The letter was not a door you missed," he said.

Varux looked up.

Alias pointed toward the tower.

"The road was still there. You can read it now."

The older Alias's eyes filled.

"It is too late for that Maris."

"No," Maris said.

Everyone looked at her.

She held the old letter in both hands.

"It is too late to answer the letter. But I am here."

Varux stared at her.

Maris's voice shook, but she kept going.

"Write a new answer."

The shared journal lay open between them.

For a long time, Varux did not move.

Then he took the pencil.

His hand trembled as he wrote.

Alias did not read over his shoulder.

He waited.

When Varux finished, he passed the journal to Maris.

She read the entry silently.

Then she closed the cover.

"What did he write?" Rowan asked.

Maris looked at Varux.

The older version nodded.

She read aloud.

"Maris,

"I am sorry I made you carry an empty place for me.

"I am here now.

"Alias, called Varux."

The road beneath them hummed.

The buried stones brightened blue.

A line of light ran from the circle of boundary stones to the base of the cliff.

There, stone shifted.

A doorway opened in the black rock below the tower.

Not at the top.

Not above the road.

At its end.

Corvin stared.

"The entrance."

Eldric looked at the open door.

"The first road," he said. "It only opened when he stopped following the wrong one."

Rowan looked at Varux.

"That was dramatic."

Varux laughed through tears.

"Apparently the tower likes lessons."

"It is a terrible building."

"Yes."

Alias looked at the doorway.

Beyond it, darkness waited. A stair climbed upward into the tower.

For the first time, Varux did not step forward first.

He looked at Alias.

"Your choice," he said.

Alias felt the weight of the road behind him. West toward home. East toward the tower. Years ago, the future version of himself had chosen east because it let him run.

Now the road was still east.

But no one was alone on it.

Alias looked at his friends.

At Maris with the journal.

At Corvin holding the map.

At Rowan pretending not to be emotional.

At Eldric with one hand on Varux's shoulder.

Then he faced the open door.

"Together," he said.

And the six of them stepped onto the first road.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 21

### The Climb

#### *Shared Journal Entry 434*

*"A staircase does not ask why you climb it. It only remembers whether you looked back for the people below."*

The doorway at the end of the first road opened into darkness.

Not ordinary darkness.

Alias had seen enough old places to know the difference. Ordinary darkness belonged to rooms without lamps. It sat quietly in corners and gave way when someone brought a flame close enough.

This darkness seemed to wait.

The stone arch swallowed the light from the basin outside. Beyond it, the air was cool and still. A narrow stair curved upward along the inner wall of the tower, disappearing after only a few steps.

Varux stood at the threshold.

He did not enter.

Alias looked at him. "You said we were going together."

"I know."

"Then come on."

The older Alias stared at the stair.

For a second, he looked as though he might speak. Then he nodded and stepped inside after Alias.

The door closed behind them.

Not with a slam.

With a soft click.

Rowan turned around immediately. "I hate that."

Corvin pressed one hand against the stone. "It is still open."

"How do you know?"

"Because there is air coming through the seams."

Rowan leaned closer to the edge of the door. "I cannot see seams."



"That is why I am checking."

"That is why you are boring."

Eldric lifted his staff. A blue light appeared at its tip, soft enough not to hurt their eyes. It showed the first turn of the staircase, the damp stone floor, and a narrow strip of old writing winding along the wall.

Maris moved closer to read it.

"Climb with what you can carry," she said. "Leave only what you are willing to lose."

Rowan looked at his pack. "That sounds threatening."

"It is advice," Eldric said.

"That is worse. Threats are honest."

Varux had gone still beside the wall.

Alias noticed the way his eyes followed the words. He had read them before. Perhaps he had read them alone, with the same lamp-light trembling over the stone.

"What happened when you came here?" Alias asked.

Varux looked toward the stair.

"I climbed."

"That is not what I meant."

"No." The older version swallowed. "It is what I did."

"Did you check the lower rooms?"

Varux's gaze shifted away.

"No."

"Why not?"

"I thought the top would have the answer."

The quiet that followed was not angry.

Not yet.

It was the quiet of everyone seeing the shape of the same mistake again.

Corvin checked the straps of his map case. "Then we check everything."

Maris nodded. "Every door. Every room. Every page."

Rowan looked up the narrow stairwell. "That could take days."

"Then it takes days."

The answer came from Alias.

Varux looked at him.

Alias met his eyes.

"You can warn us," he said. "You can tell us what you remember. But no skipping rooms because you want the highest one."

The older Alias held his gaze for a long moment.

Then he nodded.

"No skipping rooms."

The first landing came after thirty steps.

A round chamber opened off the stair. It was nearly empty. A low stone bench followed the curve of the wall, broken in two places. A metal hook had been set near the door, its rusted shape bent under the weight of years.

On the floor lay a single piece of chalk.

Rowan crouched beside it.

"Is this important?"

Maris looked around. "Maybe it was a rest room."

"A rest room in a tower?"

"People get tired."

"I know that. I have been trying to tell everyone."

Corvin noticed the wall opposite the bench. It was covered in faint marks, too high and too scattered to be decoration. He raised the blue light from his lantern.

Names.

Not carved deep enough to last forever. Most were scratched with chalk or charcoal. Some had faded until only a few letters remained.

Ari.

Lin.

Oris.

M.

At the bottom, beneath a thin layer of dust, was one name written in a sharp hand.

VARUX.

The older Alias did not move.

Alias looked at it, then at him. "You wrote that."

"Yes."

"What was this place?"

Varux stared at the name.

"A resting point."

Rowan looked around the empty chamber. "It did not do a very good job."

"It was not meant to make anyone comfortable," Varux said.

The edge in his voice made Rowan go quiet.

Maris crossed the room and touched the stone beside the list of names. A blue line appeared under the final one.

Varux.

Then another line wrote itself beneath it.

YOU CLIMBED PAST THE ROOM THAT KNEW YOUR NAME.

The blue letters remained for only a moment.

Then they faded.

Alias looked at Varux.

"What does that mean?"

The older version's hand moved toward the wall but stopped before touching it.

"I do not know."

This time, Alias believed him.

They climbed to the second landing.

The next room held a table with six chairs.

Dust covered every surface. One chair had fallen on its side. Another had been pushed back from the table as if someone had left it in a hurry.

At the center rested a wooden bowl containing six smooth stones.

Each stone was a different color.

Blue. Red. Green. White. Black. Gold.

Rowan walked straight to the bowl.

"Those look important."

"Everything looks important to you when it is on a table," Corvin said.

"Tables are where important things go."

Maris picked up the blue stone with two fingers.

Words appeared on the tabletop.

SIT BEFORE YOU DECIDE WHO LEADS.

Everyone looked at Varux.

The older Alias gave a tired smile. "I did not sit."

"No," Rowan said. "Really?"

Varux ignored him.

Alias pulled out the nearest chair. "Then we sit now."

The six of them took places around the table.

For a moment, nothing happened.

Then the colored stones began to roll across the wood. Each one stopped in front of a different person.

Blue before Maris.

Red before Rowan.

Green before Corvin.

White before Eldric.

Black before Varux.

Gold before Alias.

Maris studied the stone in front of her. "Are we supposed to do something?"

The Paper rustled inside Alias's pack.

He took it out.

Blue letters appeared.

NAME WHAT YOU CARRY.

Rowan groaned. "Of course it wants feelings."

"It does not say feelings," Maris replied.

"It is always feelings."

Corvin looked at the green stone. "I carry maps."

Nothing happened.

He frowned.

"I carry responsibility."

The green stone gave a faint glow.

Maris looked at hers.

"I carry records," she said. "And questions."

The blue stone brightened.

Rowan stared at the red one.

"I carry..." He stopped.

Nobody laughed.

He looked down at his hands. "I carry people being afraid. Sometimes I make jokes so no one has to sit in it alone."

The red stone glowed.

Eldric placed one hand over the white stone.

"I carry the names of those I could not save," he said.

The room went still.

The white stone shone softly, like moonlight under water.

Varux looked at the black stone.

For a long time, he said nothing.

Then he spoke quietly.

"I carry guilt."

The black stone did not glow.

The words on the table shifted.

GUILT IS NOT A THING YOU CAN CARRY FOR OTHERS.

Varux's face went pale.

The black stone stayed dark.

Alias looked at the gold stone in front of him.

He thought of the coin against his chest. The road. His parents. The future version of himself standing where he could not reach him.

"I carry questions," he said.

Nothing happened.

He swallowed.

"I carry the fear that I will become him."

The gold stone warmed under his hand.

The table began to hum.

The black stone rolled away from Varux. It stopped at the center of the table.

New words appeared.

WHAT YOU CARRY MUST NOT STOP YOU FROM WALKING BESIDE THEM.

Varux looked at the sentence.

Then at the others.

He did not seem to know what to do with the words.

Alias reached across the table.

Not far enough to touch him.

Far enough that Varux could see he was there.

"Maybe it means you can bring it," Alias said. "Just not make it everyone else's pack."

Varux's throat moved.

"Maybe," he said.

The stones dimmed.

The room released them.

When they stood, the door to the next landing was open.

The third level was different.

It had no room.

The stair ended on a narrow bridge spanning the tower's hollow center. Below them, darkness dropped farther than the blue light reached. Above them, the stair continued in a spiral around the inside of the tower.

The bridge was made of black metal, its rails covered in old symbols.

Rowan stopped at the first step.

"No."

Corvin looked at him. "It is stable."

"You said that about every bridge."

"And every bridge has held."

"That does not make them kind."

Maris leaned over the rail. "There are doors below."

Alias followed her gaze.

She was right.

Along the inner walls of the tower, at different levels beneath them, old doorways opened into blackness. Some were sealed. Some hung open. One had a faint blue lamp glowing beside it.

Varux stared at the blue lamp.

"I went there," he said.

"Which door?" Corvin asked.

"The one with the lamp."

"Did you check the others?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because the lamp was lit."

Rowan pointed to the dark doors. "And that did not make you think those might matter?"

Varux looked at him.

"It made me think I had been given a sign."

Rowan lowered his hand.

The answer was too familiar now. A sign. A clue. A reason to keep moving.

Eldric studied the bridge. "The tower has been teaching the same lesson in different ways."

"That we should look around?" Rowan asked.

"That we should not confuse the loudest direction with the only one."

The bridge trembled beneath their feet.

Everyone froze.

A sound rose from below.

Not wind.

Voices.

Faint at first. Then clearer.

Alias heard someone call his name.

"Alias."

His heart stopped.

It was his mother's voice.

Not exactly. It was too distant, too thin, like a voice remembered after years of not hearing it. But it carried the shape of her voice. The warmth. The way she said his name when she wanted him to stop pretending he had not heard her.

He took one step toward the rail.

Varux caught his sleeve.

"Do not."

Alias pulled back.

"You heard it too?"

Varux's face had changed.



"I heard something."

"What?"

The older Alias looked down into the dark.

"My father."

The bridge trembled again.

Below them, the blue-lit door opened.

The voices grew louder.

Rowan heard someone else. He turned toward the lower level, his joke gone. Maris's hand tightened around the journal. Corvin stood perfectly still. Even Eldric looked toward the darkness as if someone had spoken a name he had not heard in a very long time.

The Paper opened in Alias's hand.

DO NOT FOLLOW A VOICE THAT ONLY KNOWS YOUR HUNGER.

The blue words cut through the sound.

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version was breathing hard.

"What did you do?" Alias asked.

Varux did not answer.

"What did you do here?"

The blue lamp below flickered.

Varux closed his eyes.

"I followed it."

The bridge seemed to tilt beneath them.

"You went down?"

"Yes."

"Did you find your father?"

"No."

"What did you find?"

Varux looked at the open door below.

"A room that knew what I wanted to hear."

The voices faded suddenly.

The blue lamp went out.

The tower became silent again.

Rowan exhaled shakily.

"I hate this building," he said.

Nobody argued.

They did not go down to the blue-lit door.

Not yet.

Corvin marked its level on the map. Maris copied the symbols from the rail. Eldric said they would return when they could name what the room was trying to take from them.

Varux did not protest.

That mattered.

They crossed the bridge one at a time.

On the far side, the stairs continued upward.

The climb grew steeper.

The tower seemed to have no interest in being kind. Some stairs had broken edges. Some leaned toward the hollow center. Others were so narrow that Alias had to turn sideways to pass with his pack.

They climbed until their legs shook.

They climbed until Rowan stopped making jokes.

They climbed until the air thinned and the blue light on Eldric's staff seemed smaller.

At the next landing, they found another room.

This one had a door.

Not a grand door. Not magical-looking. Just wood, dark with age, set into a stone frame.

A small sign hung from one nail.

DO NOT ENTER WITHOUT A WITNESS.

Rowan read it slowly.

"That seems reasonable."

Varux stopped in front of it.

His hand rose toward the handle.

Then he lowered it.

Alias watched him.

"Did you enter this room?"

The older Alias nodded.

"Alone?"

"Yes."

"What happened?"

Varux looked at the sign.

"I do not remember."

"That is impossible."

"I know."

"Then what do you remember?"

The older version stared at the door.

"A chair."

The answer made everyone quiet.

"Just a chair?" Maris asked.

"An old coat on it." Varux's voice had gone thin. "And a page on the floor."

He stepped back.

"I thought it was a message from M."

"Was it?" Alias asked.

"I do not know."

"You said you went in."

"I did."

"Then why do you not know?"

Varux looked at him.

For the first time since they entered the tower, fear crossed his face without being hidden behind regret.

"Because I left before I read the whole page."

The sign moved slightly in the still air.

DO NOT ENTER WITHOUT A WITNESS.

Alias looked at the others.

"We are witnesses," Rowan said.

Corvin nodded. "All of us."

Maris stepped forward. "Then we enter together."

Varux did not move.

Alias placed one hand on the door handle.

"It is your memory," he said. "But it is our room now."

The older version looked at him.

Then he placed his hand over Alias's.

The door opened.

Inside was darkness.

And somewhere in it, a chair waited.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 22

### The Room of Farewells

#### *Shared Journal Entry 435*

*"A farewell is not proof that someone stopped loving you. Sometimes it is proof that they did not know how to stay."*

The room was smaller than Alias expected.

After the darkness beyond the door, after the long climb and the hollow center of the tower, he had imagined another grand chamber. A hidden observatory. A wall of names. A machine waiting to ask more questions than anyone could answer.

Instead, the room was almost plain.

One window looked out over the basin below. It was narrow and covered in dust, but enough light entered to show a chair near the far wall. A single lamp hung above it, unlit. A low shelf stood beside the chair, empty except for a small ceramic cup. The floor was clean stone. No shelves. No symbols in the walls.

Nothing magical.

Nothing obvious.

And on the chair lay a coat.

Varux stopped in the doorway.

Alias felt the older version's hand leave the door handle beneath his own.

The coat was grey-brown, not the dark patched one Varux wore now. It looked older than it should have. The sleeves had been mended twice at the elbows. A thin tear ran along the left cuff. The collar was lined with faded blue thread.

Beside it lay a pair of boots.

Not polished. Not preserved. Worn boots, placed neatly together beneath the chair as if their owner might return for them after dinner.

No one moved.

Rowan was the first to speak.

"Those are yours."

Varux did not answer.

"Varux?" Maris asked softly.

The older Alias stepped into the room.

He did not walk toward the chair. He stood several paces away, as though the space between them had become dangerous.

"I thought they belonged to M," he said.

Alias looked at him.

"What?"

"The first time I came here, I saw the chair. I saw the coat." Varux's voice had gone thin. "I thought it was a clue. Someone else's coat. Someone who had left before me."

"But they are yours," Corvin said.

Varux nodded.

"I know that now."

The words did not explain enough.

Alias looked at the coat again. It was not his coat. Not one he had ever worn. But he could see pieces of himself in it. The way the sleeves had been rolled once and never fully smoothed back. The small stitched repair at the shoulder. The faded line where a strap had rubbed against the fabric for years.

It looked like a coat a younger Alias might choose.

It looked like a coat a person would wear when he was trying to become someone who did not need anyone.

Maris moved toward the chair slowly.

"May I?" she asked.

Varux closed his eyes for a moment.

Then nodded.

She lifted the coat by its shoulders. Dust fell from the hem. Underneath it, hidden in the seat of the chair, was a folded square of paper.

The room changed.

The lamp above the chair burst into blue flame.

Letters appeared on the floor around them in a circle.

WHAT IS LEFT BEHIND MUST BE WITNESSED.

Rowan looked down at the words.

"That is less comforting than it thinks it is."

Eldric stepped inside and closed the door.

The latch clicked.

Not locked. Just heard.

Maris held the folded paper without opening it.

"It is addressed," she said.

Alias looked closer.

The writing on the front had blurred with time, but the name was still clear.

ALIAS.

Not Varux.

Alias.

The older version of himself went very still.

The Paper in Alias's pack rustled.

Blue ink appeared on its folded edge.

THE NAME WAS WAITING.

Varux saw it.

For a moment, he looked angry.

Not at the Paper. Not really.

At the years.

At every time he had called himself something else because it hurt less than being reminded of what he had left behind.

Alias stepped toward the chair.

"You did not open it," he said.

Varux's eyes stayed on the letter.

"No."

"Why?"

"I saw it. I knew it had my name. I knew it should have been mine." He gave a small, hollow laugh. "Then I decided it was not possible. I thought the room was trying to trick me."

"Did you not want it to be real?" Maris asked.

Varux looked at her.

"I did not want to find out that they had waited."

The sentence settled heavily between them.

No one spoke.

Outside the narrow window, wind dragged shadows across the basin. Far below, the first road was only a dark line beneath the tower.

Maris looked at the letter in her hands.

"Who wrote it?" Alias asked.

"I do not know," she said. "The seal is broken, but the back is blank."

"Open it," Rowan said.

Varux flinched.

Rowan looked immediately sorry.

"Not because I want to know," he added. "Well, I do want to know. But not only because of that. It has been waiting a long time."

Varux stared at the letter.

Then he reached out.

Maris gave it to him.

His hands shook as he unfolded the paper.

The first line was written in blue ink.

Not archive blue. Not Paper blue.

The blue of their shared journal.

Varux read silently.

His face changed before anyone else could see the words.

Alias watched the color leave him, then return in a sudden painful rush.

"What does it say?" he asked.



Varux tried to speak.

Nothing came out.

He handed the paper to Maris.

She read it.

Then pressed one hand to her mouth.

"Maris?" Corvin asked.

She took a breath.

"It is from us."

"Us now?" Rowan asked.

"No." Her eyes moved across the page. "Us later."

The room seemed colder.

Maris read aloud.

"Alias,

"We found your coat at the old crossroads two days after you left. Corvin said it was proof you were not thinking clearly because you had packed too little. Rowan said you probably did it because you wanted to make us worry. I said neither of them were helping.

"We did not know where you had gone. We only knew you left without the things you would have needed if you meant to stay gone.

"We brought them here because this room understands farewells. We are leaving them where you can find them if you ever come back.

"Not because we are finished with you.

"Because we are not."

Maris stopped.

The next lines had been signed by several hands.

Maris. Corvin. Rowan. Eldric.

Beneath them, in a smaller line written in darker ink:

Come home before you think you deserve to.

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version had turned away.

His shoulders shook once.

Then again.

Eldric stepped near him, but did not touch him yet.

"That was why I thought it was M," Varux said.

His voice was almost gone.

"I could not believe they had climbed here. I could not believe they had brought my things. I could not believe..." He swallowed. "I thought if I called it a clue, I did not have to admit it was love."

No one moved.

Alias looked at the coat.

The coat had been left behind by a version of him who thought he would come back tomorrow.

The future team had found it. Saved it. Carried it up a tower. Left a letter.

They had not stopped waiting.

They had not turned the farewell into an ending.

Maris folded the letter carefully, but she did not put it away.

"What else is here?" Corvin asked quietly.

The question did not break the moment. It made space around it.

Eldric walked to the low shelf beside the chair. The ceramic cup was empty, but beneath it lay a small wooden box. He opened it.

Inside were six objects.

A cracked pencil.

A brass map pin.

A red piece of string.

A white tea leaf wrapped in paper.

A thin blue thread.

And a dull silver button.

Rowan stared at them.

"Those are ours too."

Maris picked up the blue thread. "I wear that in my hair."

"Not yet," Alias said.

"No." Maris held it against the light. "But I will."

Corvin turned the brass pin between his fingers.

"It is from my map case."

Rowan lifted the red string. "This is mine."

"How do you know?" Corvin asked.

"Because I keep strings."

"You have many strings."

"Yes. This is one of mine."

Eldric unfolded the paper around the tea leaf. A single line had been written across it.

For the days he forgets someone is waiting.

The old mage looked at Varux.

He did not say anything.

He did not need to.

The dull silver button remained.

Alias picked it up.

It had a crescent stamped into its surface.

Varux watched him.

"That was from my first coat," he said.

"The one on the chair?"

"Yes."

Alias held the button in his palm.

The small objects felt too light to carry everything they seemed to mean. A pin. A string. A tea leaf. A thread. A button.

Tiny pieces of a life.

Things people had chosen to leave beside a chair because someone might come back one day and need proof that he had belonged somewhere.

The floor circle began to glow again.

A new sentence appeared.

A FAREWELL IS NOT A DOOR. IT IS A PLACE TO PUT WHAT YOU CANNOT CARRY ALONE.

The Paper unfolded in Alias's pack.

Blue ink wrote:

THE ROOM KEEPS WHAT WAS OFFERED, NOT WHAT WAS ABANDONED.

Varux looked at the words.

"What is the difference?" he asked.

The Paper remained still.

Alias looked at the chair.

"Maybe abandonment is leaving because you think no one will care," he said. "Offering is leaving something because you trust someone to hold it."

Varux's expression tightened.

"I did not trust them."

"No," Alias said. "But they trusted you."

The older version closed his eyes.

Outside, thunder rolled somewhere beyond the hills.

The lamp flickered blue.

Then the chair moved.

Only an inch.

But everyone saw it.

The stone wall behind it slid aside without a sound, revealing a shallow space hidden in the tower.

Not a room.

Not yet.

A narrow ledge held a second folded letter and a small metal plate engraved with an arrow pointing upward.

ONE FLOOR HIGHER.

The letters were old, blackened with age.

Maris stepped closer to read the smaller line beneath.

"The first thing you miss is not always the first thing you left."

Corvin looked toward the hidden space. "A clue."

"Or another warning," Rowan said.

"Both," Eldric replied.

Varux stood in front of the chair.

He had not looked at the new letter.

Alias noticed.

"Do you want to open it?" he asked.

Varux looked at the hidden shelf.

"No."

The answer was soft but steady.

"Not yet."

Alias waited for the usual guilt to follow. The apology. The fear that he was disappointing everyone.

It did not come.

Varux simply looked at the first letter in Maris's hands.

"I want to keep this one for a while," he said.

Maris nodded. "You can."

She gave it to him.

He folded it along its old creases and placed it inside the pocket of the coat from the chair.

Then he lifted the coat.

For a moment, Alias thought Varux would put it on.

The older version held it open, looking at the worn sleeves and the faded collar. His hands trembled.

But he did not wear it.

Not yet.

He folded it carefully over one arm.

"Can I carry it?" he asked.

It was such a small question.

Alias almost did not know how to answer.

"Yes," he said.

Varux nodded.

The room's blue light softened.

The door behind them clicked open.

No grand announcement. No sudden vision. Just a door that was no longer holding them in.

Rowan exhaled.

"I think the tower is done being emotional for at least an hour."

The Paper wrote:

UNLIKELY.

Rowan pointed at it. "See? No sense of timing."

Maris laughed quietly.

It surprised them all.

Even Varux.

The sound did not fix anything.

It did not return years or answer letters or make the road west any shorter.

But it filled the room.

The six of them left the chair where it stood.

The small objects remained in their box, except for the coat and the first letter Varux carried now.

The second letter stayed on the hidden ledge beside the arrow pointing upward.

One floor higher.

Another room.

Another thing the older Alias had missed because he had been too desperate to reach the top.

Alias paused at the doorway and looked back.

The chair sat beneath its blue lamp.

Empty now.

Not abandoned.

Waiting.

Then he turned toward the stair.

They still had higher to climb.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 23

### What I Left Behind

#### *Shared Journal Entry 436*

*"I kept thinking I had left objects behind. The truth was worse: I had left people holding the space where I should have been."*

They did not climb higher that night.

The tower had already asked enough of them.

After leaving the room of farewells, they found a broad landing two floors below. It had no door, only a curved wall and a narrow window through which the dark basin could be seen far below. Corvin checked the stone for cracks. Eldric placed a small ward at the foot of the stairs. Maris spread bedrolls close together because the tower made silence feel too large.

Rowan looked at the circle of blankets.

"We are sleeping in a hallway."

"It is a landing," Corvin said.

"It is a hallway with ambition."

"It is safe," Eldric added.

Rowan looked at the dark stairwell above them. "Nothing in this tower has earned the right to use that word."

No one argued.

Varux sat apart from the others with the old coat folded over his knees.

He had carried it from the room of farewells without putting it on. The coat looked wrong beside him, almost like a younger shadow that had been separated from its owner. Its repaired elbows and worn cuffs caught the blue light from Eldric's staff.

Alias watched Varux trace the blue thread inside the collar.

"You do not have to keep looking at it," he said.

The older version glanced up.



"I know."

"Then why are you?"

Varux looked down again.

"I am trying to remember why I left it."

Alias frowned. "Because you left in a hurry?"

"Maybe." Varux's thumb passed over the torn cuff. "Or because I wanted to become someone new and thought I should not take anything old with me."

Rowan, already inside his blanket, lifted his head.

"That is a terrible reason to leave a coat."

"It was not a good plan."

"You could have been cold."

"I was cold."

"Then it was definitely terrible."

A small smile tugged at Varux's face.

It faded when he looked back at the coat.

"Everything I left behind seemed small at first," he said. "One coat. One letter. One dinner. One day I did not come back."

The landing became quiet.

Maris looked at the shared journal in her hands but did not open it.

Varux continued before anyone could interrupt him.

"Then there were too many small things to count. It became easier to call them years."

Alias felt the words land heavily.

Years made the loss sound distant.

A coat did not.

A letter did not.

A place set at a table did not.

Eldric sat beside Varux, leaving a respectful distance between them.

"Do you want to count them?" the old mage asked.

Varux looked at him.

"No."

Eldric nodded.

"Then perhaps we begin by naming them."

Varux's expression tightened.

"Is there a difference?"

"Yes," Eldric said. "Counting makes a debt. Naming makes a truth."

Nobody spoke for a moment.

Then Maris opened the shared journal to a blank page.

"We can write it down," she said.

Varux looked alarmed.

"Not as a list of crimes," she added quickly. "Not for that. As a record of what mattered."

Rowan shifted in his blanket.

"That sounds dangerously close to feelings."

"It is feelings," Maris said.

"Fine. I am tired. I cannot stop you."

Corvin sat on the stone floor with his map case beside him. "Start with the things you can name."

Varux stared at the page.

The pencil waited in Maris's hand.

For a long time, he did not speak.

Then he said, "I left my coat."

Maris wrote it down.

"I left a letter unopened."

She wrote that too.

"I left the first map Corvin made for me."

Corvin looked up.

"I made you a map?"

"In the future." Varux looked toward him. "You marked the safe roads home in green. I used it for years."

Corvin's face changed slightly.

"Did you follow them?"

"Not enough."

Maris's pencil moved again.

"I left Rowan's whistle on a table in a town near the river."

Rowan frowned. "You had my whistle?"

"Not this one. Another one." Varux glanced at the red string tied around Rowan's wrist. "You gave it to me after I complained that camp was too quiet."

"I did that?"

"Yes."

"That sounds like me."

"It was."

Varux took a breath.

"I left one of Eldric's tea leaves in a book so I would remember the smell of home."

Eldric looked down at his cup.

"And I left Maris's blue thread in a drawer because I was afraid I would wear it and then have to explain where it came from."

Maris did not look up from the page.

But Alias saw her hand pause.

Varux's voice grew quieter.

"I left every answer I was given because I wanted a different one."

The blue flame at Eldric's staff flickered.

No one rushed to fill the silence.

Then Alias said, "You left yourself too."

Varux looked at him.

"What?"

"You stopped using your name. You stopped reading letters. You stopped doing things that made you feel like you belonged." Alias swallowed. "You did not just leave objects or people. You left yourself somewhere on the road too."

The older version stared at him.

For a moment, Alias thought he had said the wrong thing.

Then Varux's shoulders loosened.

"Yes," he said. "I did."

Maris wrote one more line.

When she finished, she turned the journal so Varux could see.

The page did not look like a list of crimes.

It looked like a map of small things.

The coat. The letter. The map. The whistle. The tea leaf. The blue thread. The name.

At the bottom, Maris had written:

What I left behind was proof that I had been loved before I believed I deserved it.

Varux read the sentence twice.

"I did not say that," he whispered.

"No," Maris said. "But you meant it."

He looked at her.

Then he nodded.

A sound came from the room of farewells above them.

Everyone froze.

It was soft at first. A scrape of wood against stone. Then a thin click, like a latch being opened.

Corvin stood immediately.

"Stay here," he said.

Rowan pushed himself out of his blanket. "That never works."

"It is still the instruction."

"I am not staying in a hallway while a haunted chair starts moving."

Eldric lifted his staff.

The six of them climbed back toward the room of farewells.

The door stood open.

Inside, the chair was empty.

The coat was no longer on Varux's knees.

He looked down sharply.

For one second, Alias thought he had dropped it on the landing.

Then he saw it.

The coat had been placed back on the chair.

Neatly folded.

The letter in its pocket had been removed and set on the low shelf beside the ceramic cup.

No one had touched it.

Alias knew that because he had watched Varux carry it down.

The blue lamp above the chair burned brighter than before.

The hidden ledge with the second letter and the arrow pointing upward still stood open in the wall.

But something new rested beneath it.

A small square mirror.

It had no frame. Its surface was dark and clouded, reflecting none of them properly.

Maris stepped closer.

"Did this exist before?"

"No," Varux said.

The mirror brightened.

Images moved beneath the surface.

Not one memory.

Many.

Alias saw a tavern table. Five chairs. A blue journal. Rowan laughing with his head thrown back.  
Corvin pointing at a map while Maris wrote something down. Eldric drinking tea. A place set  
beside them, empty but waiting.

Then another image.

A road in rain.

A younger Varux walking away with his back turned.

Then another.

The same young Varux sitting in a room alone, holding a coat and not wearing it.

The mirror shifted again.

This time it showed the tower room.

The chair.

The coat.

And a message appeared in blue light.

WHAT YOU LEFT BEHIND REMAINED BECAUSE IT WAS CARRIED TO YOU.

Varux stood perfectly still.

Alias read the words again.

Carried to you.

The team had not simply waited in the future. They had gone looking. They had carried his things  
up the tower. They had brought proof of him with them because they believed he might return.

Maris stepped closer to the mirror.

"It is not showing a farewell," she said.

"No," Eldric replied. "It is showing an invitation."

The mirror changed.

A final image appeared.

A closed door in Maanhaven. Warm light beneath it. No one visible on the other side.

Then a sentence.

THE DOOR WAS NEVER LOCKED.

Varux inhaled sharply.

The mirror went dark.

The room was silent except for the wind outside the narrow window.

Rowan rubbed at his face.

"I know I am supposed to make a joke now," he said. "But I do not have one."

"That is fine," Maris said.

"It is not. I always have one."

"Not always."

Rowan looked down.

Then he walked to the chair and picked up the coat.

Varux watched him.

Rowan held it out.

"Put it on."

Varux blinked.

"What?"

"You carried it this far. Put it on."

"I do not know if it fits."

"It is your coat."

"It was my coat."

Rowan stared at him.

"That is the same thing with more sadness."

Varux did not move.

Alias stepped closer.

"You do not have to become the person who wore it," he said. "But you are allowed to wear it."

Varux looked from Alias to the coat.

Then he took it.

He slipped one arm into the sleeve. Then the other.

The coat was too tight across the shoulders. The cuffs sat above his wrists. The hem ended higher than it should have.

Rowan tilted his head.

"It fits terribly."

Varux looked down at himself.

"It has been twenty years."

"Yes. That is what I said."

For the first time since the memory began, Varux laughed.

It was quiet. It was brief.

But it was real.



The coat did not make him younger.

It did not erase the grey in his fur or the scar on his cheek or the years in his eyes.

It made him look like someone who had decided not to throw away every version of himself.

Maris opened the shared journal again.

"Write that," Rowan said.

Varux looked at him.

"What?"

"That the coat fits terribly but you are wearing it anyway."

Maris smiled. "I can write that."

Varux considered it.

Then he nodded.

"Write it."

The next morning, they climbed again.

The tower did not resist them. It did not make the stairs easier either. The path above the room of farewells grew narrower, turning around the outside of the hollow center. Wind came through cracks in the stone. The basin below seemed impossibly far away.

Varux wore the old coat.

He had put his grey coat inside his pack. The old one pulled at the shoulders whenever he reached for the rail, but he did not take it off.

At the next landing, they found the arrow from the hidden ledge repeated on the wall.

ONE FLOOR HIGHER.

Underneath, a second line had appeared sometime during the night.

YOU CANNOT FIND WHAT YOU LEFT IF YOU NEVER LOOK BACK.

Alias touched the words.

The coin beneath his shirt warmed.

"Is this about your parents?" he asked Varux.

The older version stopped beside him.

"Maybe."

"That is not an answer."

"No."

Varux looked upward.

"I came here because I thought M knew where they went. I thought the tower would tell me what they could not say." He rested one hand against the old coat over his chest. "But I never asked what I had left behind to find them."

Alias studied him.

"And now?"

"Now I think the tower has been trying to show me."

"What?"

Varux looked at the stair ahead.

"That I made a home into a mystery because mysteries are easier to chase than people."

No one spoke.

It was not a complete answer.

But it was a true one.

They continued upward.

One floor higher waited above them.

And this time, Varux did not look away from the road below.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 24

### One Floor Higher

#### *Shared Journal Entry 437*

*"The sign said one floor higher. It did not say the floor would be waiting in the place we expected."*

The second letter waited on the hidden ledge.

No one touched it until morning.

They had slept badly on the tower landing. Even Rowan, who could normally sleep through rain, arguments, and at least one collapsing ceiling, woke several times. The tower shifted and settled around them. Somewhere below, a door clicked open and closed in the dark. Somewhere above, wind passed through the broken stone like a long breath.

By sunrise, they had returned to the room of farewells.

The blue lamp over the chair had gone out.

The chair was empty.

Varux stood in front of it in his old coat, his hands tucked into sleeves that ended too high above his wrists. He looked less like a mysterious stranger that morning and more like a person wearing a memory that did not fit.

Maris approached the hidden ledge.

The second letter remained there beside the metal plate marked with the upward arrow.

"Do you want to open it?" she asked Varux.

He looked at the paper.

"Not especially."

"That was not my question."

Varux exhaled.

"No. But I think I should."

Alias watched him carefully. "Because the tower says you should?"

The older version shook his head.

"Because I do not want to keep making fear look like patience."

The answer hung in the quiet room.

Then Varux reached into the alcove and lifted the letter.

It was smaller than the first one. The fold was neat. The name on the front had not faded.

ALIAS.

He stared at it.

"That is not your name anymore," Rowan said before he could stop himself.

Varux looked at him.

Rowan winced. "I mean it is your name. It just is not the one you use."

"It is the one they used."

The room became still.

Varux opened the letter.

The page inside was written in two hands.

The first was Maris's.

The second belonged to Corvin.

Maris read it over Varux's shoulder, then passed it to Corvin when she realized the lower half was his writing.

"Read it," Alias said.

Corvin did not look comfortable with that.

"Why me?"

"Because you wrote it."

"Another me wrote it."

"Still you."

Corvin gave Alias a look, then cleared his throat.

"Alias," he read, "we found the room above the room you never opened. We are leaving this letter where you will see it if you ever return to the chair."

He stopped.

His face changed slightly.

Maris continued.

"You always thought the tower was telling you to climb. It was not. It was telling you to stop before you decided the top was the only place worth reaching."

Rowan looked up at the dark ceiling.

"That is very direct."

"Future Maris has apparently learned to write better letters than I do," present Maris said.

The next paragraph was Corvin's.

"If you are reading this, you have already done something difficult: you looked back. Do not ruin it by hurrying forward again. The room above is not the answer. It is a reminder that you missed a floor because you did not believe anything below the final room could matter."

Varux's gaze dropped.

The final lines were signed by all four of them.

We did not leave this to punish you.

We left it because we knew you would try to make a warning into a reason not to come home.

Please do not.

The letter ended there.

No map.

No answer about M.

No message from Alias's parents.

Just an instruction written by people who had learned exactly how their friend would misunderstand a thing.

Rowan rubbed the back of his neck.

"They knew you well."

Varux folded the letter along its old creases.

"Too well."

"That is not always a bad thing," Eldric said.

Varux looked toward the stairs.

"No," he said. "It is just frightening."

They climbed one floor higher.

The sign on the wall led them around the outer curve of the tower, through a corridor so narrow that Corvin had to carry his map case in front of him. The window slits were covered by iron shutters. Every few steps, the tower wall bore the open-eye symbol.

At first, nothing seemed different.

Then Maris stopped.

"Look."

She pointed to the floor.

Dust lay across the stone, but not evenly. A wide circle near the center of the corridor had been kept clear. Not recently. Not by feet. The dust simply did not settle there.

Inside the circle lay a small glass sphere.

It was the size of an apple. Blue light swirled slowly inside it.

Rowan crouched beside it.

"That looks important."

"Do not touch it," Maris said.

"I was not going to."

"You were leaning toward it."

"I am interested."

"That is how touching begins."

Varux stared at the sphere.

"I saw this," he said.

Alias looked at him. "When you came here before?"

"Yes."

"What did it do?"

"I did not wait to find out."

Rowan straightened. "That is becoming a theme."

Varux nodded. "It is."

Eldric moved into the dustless circle. The blue light inside the sphere brightened. Words began to appear on the wall in a slow ring around him.

WHAT HAVE YOU ASSUMED?

Eldric read them once.

Then he said, "That the tower speaks to the person closest to its door."

The light in the sphere dimmed.

Maris stepped into the circle.

"I have assumed that records tell the truth if I can read them correctly."

The sphere pulsed.

The words shifted.

WHAT HAVE YOU MISSED?

Maris looked at the wall for a long time.

"People," she said finally. "I have missed what people wanted while I was trying to understand what they wrote."

The sphere glowed blue.

A faint crack opened in the wall beside the corridor. Not a doorway. Only a thin line of light.

Corvin frowned. "It responds to answers."

"Not answers," Eldric said. "Admissions."

Rowan looked unhappy.

"That is worse."

"Of course it is," Maris said.

The wall waited.

Corvin stepped forward next.

"I have assumed that every road can be made safe if I have the right map."

The sphere brightened.

"What have you missed?" the wall asked.

Corvin's jaw tightened.

Alias expected him to say nothing.

Then Corvin said, "That people can choose unsafe things for reasons a map cannot measure."

The crack widened.

A cold draft came through it.

Rowan stared at the sphere.

"Does everyone have to do this?"

"It appears so," Maris said.

"Can I go last?"

"No."

Rowan sighed and stepped into the circle.

"I have assumed that if I keep everyone laughing, no one will notice I am afraid."

The blue light flashed.

Alias looked at him.

Rowan did not look back.

The wall wrote:

WHAT HAVE YOU MISSED?

Rowan's voice was quieter.

"That people might still want me around when I am not funny."

The crack widened again.

The wall had become a narrow doorway.

Not enough to pass through.

Not yet.

Eldric placed one hand on Rowan's shoulder as he stepped out of the circle.

"You were never only funny," he said.

Rowan tried to answer with a joke.

Nothing came.

He settled for nodding once.

Alias knew his turn was next.

The gold coin under his shirt had begun to warm.

He stepped into the circle.



The sphere swirled faster.

WHAT HAVE YOU ASSUMED?

Alias looked at the words.

He thought of the future. Of Varux. Of the roads east. Of the letter his parents might have left somewhere, waiting for someone who knew how to find it.

"I assumed that if I found the answer about my parents, I would know what to do."

The sphere glowed.

WHAT HAVE YOU MISSED?

Alias's throat tightened.

He looked at Varux in the too-small old coat.

"I missed that I have people with me now," he said. "I keep acting like I have to solve things alone before I can let them matter."

The doorway widened enough for blue light to spill into the corridor.

Only Varux remained outside the circle.

He stood beside the wall with both hands clasped in front of him.

No one rushed him.

Eventually he stepped forward.

The sphere dimmed.

It did not brighten when he entered. It waited.

WHAT HAVE YOU ASSUMED?

Varux stared at the words for so long that Alias thought he might leave.

Then he spoke.

"I assumed that I was the danger."

The blue light inside the sphere trembled.

"I assumed that if I stayed away from people, I could not hurt them again. That if I did not return, I could not disappoint them. That if I carried everything alone, nobody else would have to."

The wall stayed silent.

Then the next question appeared.

WHAT HAVE YOU MISSED?

Varux looked at the doorway forming in the stone.

His voice broke.

"That leaving hurts people too."

The sphere blazed.

The wall opened.

A narrow chamber lay beyond it.

There was no furniture inside. No books. No chair. Only a second stair climbing straight upward into darkness.

On the wall at the far end was a single line.

ONE FLOOR HIGHER DOES NOT MEAN ONE STEP CLOSER.

Rowan read it.

"That is very rude."

Maris entered the chamber.

"The stairs go up," she said.

"Yes," Corvin replied.

"But the room is hidden behind a question."

"Also yes."

"Then this is not the floor the letter meant."

Varux looked at the stairs.

"I thought it was."

Alias turned to him.

"What happened the first time?"

The older version did not answer immediately.

Then he said, "I saw the sphere. I saw the stair. I assumed the stair was the way forward."

"And you did not answer the questions."

"No."

"What did you do?"

"I broke the sphere."

The room went quiet.

Rowan looked at the glass sphere in the corridor.

"You broke it?"

"I was angry."

"At a ball?"

"At myself."

The answer landed more softly than expected.

"I thought the tower was refusing to help me," Varux continued. "I thought it wanted me to confess something before I had earned an answer. So I broke it. The wall opened anyway, but only enough for me to see the stair."

Maris studied the doorway.

"You forced it."

"Yes."

"And you climbed."

"Yes."

"What did you miss?"

Varux looked back at the glowing sphere.

"The question."

No one spoke.

Eldric walked to the stair in the hidden chamber. He held his staff near the first step. The blue flame reflected from the stone, but the darkness above did not move.

"There is another route," he said.

"How can you tell?" Alias asked.

"The stair is too obvious."

Rowan looked pleased. "Finally. My instincts are being respected."

Corvin knelt beside the bottom step. He ran his fingers over the stone and found a thin line along the wall.

"Here."

A panel sat beside the stair, nearly invisible. It had no handle. Only six small hollows, each shaped differently.

A crescent.

A feather.

A circle.

A compass needle.

A leaf.

A red thread.

Maris looked from the panel to the group.

"Not coins," she said.

"Objects," Corvin replied.

The meanings were clear.

Alias placed his coin in the crescent hollow.

Maris laid a small blue thread from her notebook into the feather-shaped space. Corvin set one of his brass map pins into the compass hollow. Eldric placed the dried tea leaf into the leaf. Rowan untied the red string from his wrist and placed it in the final hollow.

Varux stood before the circle-shaped space.

He had nothing in his hands.

Alias looked at him.

"Your journal?"

Varux's hand moved toward his pack.

Then stopped.

"The journal is not a thing I can give the tower," he said.

"No," Maris said. "But maybe there is something in it you can."

Varux opened the black journal.

He turned through pages slowly. The paper was crowded with notes, maps, questions, and crossed-out sentences. At last he stopped near the back.

He tore out one page.

Everyone stared.

The paper did not seem important. It held only a few words written in faded ink.

I AM FINE.

I AM BUSY.

I WILL RETURN SOON.

The sentence had been copied again and again beneath it, each version less certain than the last.

Varux looked at the page.

"This was what I told people when I could not answer them."

He folded it once.

Then placed it in the circle hollow.

The panel opened.

Behind it waited another passage.

Not a stair.

A low corridor descending back toward the center of the tower.

Rowan looked at it.

"One floor higher," he said. "And the way forward goes down."

Eldric nodded. "The tower is correcting a very old assumption."

Varux stood at the entrance to the descending corridor.

For a moment, Alias expected him to look ashamed.

He did not.

He looked tired.

But also relieved.

"I thought the climb was the point," Varux said.

"What is the point?" Alias asked.

The older version looked at the passage below.

"Maybe finding what I skipped."

They followed the corridor downward.

It curved beneath the stairwell, through a space inside the tower that none of them had known existed. The air smelled of old dust and stone. Blue lights woke in small wall niches as they passed.

The passage ended at a locked door.

Unlike the others, this door had no Reader mark.

Only a sentence carved at eye level.

YOU CANNOT OPEN WHAT YOU INSIST IS EMPTY.

Maris read it aloud.

Corvin examined the frame. "No visible lock."

Rowan pressed one ear against the door.

"Can you hear anything?" Alias asked.

"No."

"Then why are you doing that?"

"I am checking whether it is empty."

Corvin sighed.

The Paper rustled.

Blue ink appeared.

NOT EMPTY.

Rowan pulled back. "I knew it."

"What is inside?" Maris asked.

The Paper stayed blank.

Varux stared at the door.

"I did not find this," he said.

"No," Alias replied. "But now we did."

The door did not open.

Not when Alias used the coin.

Not when Varux used his.

Not when Corvin tried the black key from Hollow Creek.

They tried the words from the walls. They tried the sentence from the letter. They tried pushing, pulling, and asking politely.

Nothing.

At last, Eldric rested his hand against the stone.

"Perhaps it is not for us yet," he said.

Rowan looked offended. "We passed the feelings test. We put our special objects in a wall. We have done enough."

The door remained still.

Varux looked at the carved sentence.

"You cannot open what you insist is empty."

"What does it mean?" Alias asked.

The older version did not answer.

Instead, he took the shared journal from Maris with a silent question. She handed it to him.

He opened to a blank page.

Then he wrote.

Alias could not see the words at first.

When Varux finished, he turned the journal so everyone could read.

The page said:

There is something here.

I do not know what it is.

I am willing to find it with them.

The door clicked.

A narrow line appeared at its edge.

Then it opened inward.

Beyond it lay darkness.

But this darkness was different from the darkness behind the first road.

It smelled faintly of paper.

Of dust.

Of a room that had been closed for a long time.

Maris lifted her lantern.

At the far end of the hidden chamber stood a shelf.

On it waited a single book.

And beside the book, a small silver bell.

The door began to close behind them.

Rowan caught it with one hand.

"Not again," he said.

The tower did not answer.

The book waited.

And for the first time, no one knew whether opening it would take them farther up, farther down,  
or somewhere they had not expected at all.

\* \* \*



## Chapter 25

### The Hidden Room

#### *Shared Journal Entry 438*

*"We found the hidden room by admitting it was there. That felt unfairly simple for a tower that had spent two days asking us riddles."*

The hidden chamber smelled of paper.

It was the first thing Alias noticed after Rowan held the closing door long enough for everyone to slip through.

The room beyond was not large. It had no windows and no obvious way out. The ceiling curved low above them, made from the same black stone as the tower. Blue lamps burned in shallow wall niches, but their light reached only the center of the room.

A shelf stood at the far end.

On it rested one book.

Beside the book sat a small silver bell.

Rowan let the door close behind him.

The latch clicked.

He looked around.

"Well," he said. "I expected more chairs."

"Why?" Corvin asked.

"Every strange room has chairs. It is how they make you feel judged."

"There was a chair in the last room."

"Exactly. This one is already suspicious for refusing one."

Maris approached the shelf slowly. The book was bound in dark blue cloth, faded almost to grey at the corners. No title had been printed on the cover. A thin metal clasp held it shut.

The bell was smaller than Alias had expected. It could fit in one hand. Its handle had been shaped like an open eye.

The same eye that had appeared on the key from Hollow Creek.

The same eye that had been carved into the walls of the observatory.

Varux stopped several steps behind them.

"I did not find this room," he said.

No one answered immediately.

They all knew that already. The room existed because he had not found it. The tower had been leading them through the places he had skipped, forced, or misunderstood.

Still, hearing him say it felt important.

Maris looked back. "Then we find it now."

Varux nodded once.

His old coat pulled at the shoulders as he moved closer. The sleeves had been rolled up so his hands were free. The faded blue thread in its collar caught the lamp light.

Alias noticed the letter still tucked into the pocket over Varux's chest.

The old one from Maris.

The one he had carried unopened for years.

"Can you open the book?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at the clasp.

"I do not know."

"That is better than saying no."

A faint smile crossed Varux's face.

"Low standard."

"Progress is still progress."

Maris tried the clasp first.

It did not move.

Corvin examined the metal with the end of a small knife. "No keyhole."

"That is unfair," Rowan said. "We have a key now."

"We have several keys," Maris corrected. "None of them are promised to fit everything."

Eldric placed two fingers against the cover. The blue lamps flickered. A line of writing appeared across the book in pale light.

THE LEDGER OF THINGS NOT ASKED.

The room went silent.

Alias read the words twice.

"That sounds like the archive," he said.

"Not quite," Maris replied. "The archive held questions that had been written down. This sounds like..." She paused. "Questions someone chose not to ask."

Rowan folded his arms. "That is somehow worse."

Varux stared at the title.

"I know that feeling," he said.

The book's metal clasp clicked open.

No one touched it.

The cover lifted by itself.

The first page was blank.

Then the blue lamps around the room dimmed. Ink appeared in the center of the page, writing one word at a time.

WHO WILL ASK?

The letters stayed there.

Rowan looked around.

"I vote Maris."

"Why?" Maris asked.

"Because you are the best at questions."

"That is not an answer."

"It is exactly an answer."

Maris looked at the book.

Then at Alias.

"This may be meant for you."

Alias felt the coin under his shirt warm.

Of course it was.

Everything seemed to want him to answer something lately.

He stepped forward.

"What are you?" he asked.

The ink disappeared.

New words formed.

A RECORD.

"Of what?"

WHAT WAS NOT SAID.

Alias frowned. "By who?"

BY THOSE WHO NEEDED TO SAY IT.

The answer was not helpful.

Rowan groaned. "The book is doing riddles now."

Maris leaned closer. "Maybe it cannot answer that way. Try something personal."

Alias did not want to.

He looked at Varux.

The older version stood near the wall with both hands clasped behind his back. He looked as if he wished he could disappear into the stone.

Alias thought of the room of farewells. The coat. The letter. The pages Varux had avoided.

"What did Varux miss?" he asked.

The book remained still.

Then a line appeared.

ASK HIM.

Alias turned.

Varux looked caught.

"That seems fair," he said quietly.

"Fine." Alias folded his arms. "What did you miss?"

Varux looked at the floor.

The room waited.

He could have said everything. He had said it before. He could have said home, dinners, letters, years.

Instead, after a long moment, he said, "The chance to let someone answer me before I made up the answer myself."

The ink moved.

A new page turned.

On it was a single sentence written in small black letters.

You were not forgotten. You stopped listening for the people who remembered you.

Varux went still.

Rowan did not make a joke.

Maris looked at the book as if it might hurt him if she looked away.

The sentence stayed for a few breaths.

Then the page turned again.

At the top of the next page was a name.

M.

Alias leaned closer.

Below the initial, a question appeared.

WHY DID YOU FOLLOW ME?

Varux's face lost color.

"You wrote that?" Maris asked.

"No."

"Then who did?"

"I do not know."

The words on the page changed.

YOU ASSUMED I KNEW YOUR ANSWER.

Varux took a step closer to the shelf.

The old coat shifted around his shoulders.

"I thought you knew my parents," he said.

The book did not respond.

"I thought you knew why they left."

Nothing.

"I thought every note was meant for me."

The blue lamps brightened.

At the bottom of the page, new words appeared.

I LEFT NOTES FOR THE PERSON WHO WOULD CHOOSE TO READ THEM.

Varux stared at the sentence.

"And that was me."

NO.

The answer appeared immediately.

That single word felt heavier than a page.

Varux's mouth opened.

The book continued.

IT WAS YOU.

IT WAS THE PEOPLE WITH YOU.

IT WAS ANYONE WHO ASKED BEFORE THEY RAN.

No one moved.

Eldric stepped nearer to the shelf.

"The notes were not a path for one traveler," he said.

"No," Varux whispered.

"They were invitations."

The book turned another page.

A rough sketch filled it. The tower viewed from above. The first road beneath it. The Hall in the west. The observatory to the north. The archive hidden among hills.

Thin blue lines joined them.

At the center of the map was a small circle.

M.

Under it, in dark handwriting:

A place is not a promise. A path is not a command.

Maris read the line aloud.

"That sounds like M," Rowan said.

"How do you know?" Corvin asked.

"I do not. It sounds like someone who is very pleased with themselves."

The silver bell rang.

No one touched it.

The sound was not loud. It was one clear note that seemed to enter the stone, the floor, the air in their lungs.

The book pages began to turn rapidly.

Names flashed past.

Ari. Lin. Oris. Varux. Alias.

Then two names Alias did not recognize.

One was blurred.

The other had been crossed out by a deep black line.

The book stopped.

A page lay open before them.

At the top was a small drawing of a child wrapped in a blue blanket.

Alias forgot how to breathe.

His coin burned hot against his chest.

Under the drawing were two lines.

LEFT AT THE WESTERN GATE.  
NOT LEFT BEHIND.

The room tilted.

Alias reached for the shelf to steady himself.

"That is me," he said.

Nobody contradicted him.

The child in the drawing had no face. The blanket was only a few strokes of ink. But he knew. He knew with the sharp certainty of recognizing something he had spent his whole life not remembering.

The western gate.

Maanhaven.

His hands shook.

"What does it mean?" he asked.

The book did not answer.

"What does it mean?"

Maris put one hand on his arm.

"Alias."

"No." He looked at the page again. "It says not left behind. So who left me? Why? Where did they go?"

The book stayed silent.

Alias felt anger rise fast and hot.

"You have answers," he said. "You have all these records. You know about M and Varux and the tower. You know about me."

The silver bell rang again.

The sound cut through him.

A new line appeared beneath the drawing.

THEY CHOSE A ROAD THAT DID NOT HAVE ROOM FOR YOU.

Alias stared at it.

The words did not feel like an answer.

They felt like a door opening into another question.

Varux moved beside him.

He did not touch him at first.



Then he placed one hand gently between Alias's shoulders.

"I am sorry," he said.

Alias wanted to pull away.

He did not.

The book wrote again.

THEY DID NOT LEAVE BECAUSE YOU WERE UNWANTED.

The room became so quiet that Alias could hear the faint buzz of the lamps.

He looked at the child in the blue blanket.

Not left behind.

Not unwanted.

But still left.

The difference mattered.

It did not make it hurt less.

Rowan stood near the door with his arms crossed tightly. Corvin looked down at the floor. Maris's hand remained on Alias's arm. Eldric watched the page with an expression Alias could not read.

Varux's hand was still at his back.

"That was not your fault," the older Alias said.

Alias turned sharply.

"You do not know that."

"I know what it is like to make every missing answer become evidence against yourself."

"That does not mean you know this."

"No." Varux's voice was quiet. "It means I know how alone it feels."

The book pages stirred.

A new heading appeared.

TO THE CHILD AT THE WESTERN GATE.

Alias could not look away.

The text beneath it was not written in blue or black.

It was written in a soft brown ink, uneven as if the hand that had formed it had been trembling.

If you are old enough to read this, then we failed to return before you needed an explanation.

Alias felt his heart stop.

The next line appeared slowly.

We did not leave because you were too small to carry. We left because the road we were called to  
was already carrying too much danger.

Maris inhaled sharply.

The words kept appearing.

We believed we could make it safe and return before you remembered waiting.

We were wrong about the road.

We were wrong about time.

We were never wrong about loving you.

Alias could not breathe.

His vision blurred.

The book was still there. The lamps. The shelf. Varux beside him. But all he could see was the  
sentence.

We were never wrong about loving you.

He had wanted something clear. A reason. A name. A direction he could follow until it ended at a  
door.

Instead he had been given a letter from people who had failed him and still loved him.

It was not enough.

It was everything.

He pressed one hand over his mouth.

Maris pulled him into a hug before he could stop her.

He stood stiffly at first.

Then he held on.

The blue journal was caught between them. The familiar cover pressed against his ribs.

Varux turned away.

Not to leave.

Only to give him a little space.

The letter continued.

Do not spend your life following our absence.

Make your own road.

Let people walk it with you.

The ink faded.

The page went blank.

Alias pulled back from Maris slowly.

"Where are they?" he asked.

The book waited.

Then, at last, it answered.

UNKNOWN.

The word hurt almost as much as silence.

But under it, another line formed.

THEY WALKED EAST OF THE FIRST ROAD.  
THEIR LAST RECORD WAS NOT A FAREWELL.

Corvin looked up sharply.

"Last record?"

The book turned to a map.

A red line ran from the tower eastward into a region marked only with mountain shapes and a black sea beyond them.

At its end stood a symbol Alias had never seen before: a circle split in two.

Maris copied it into her notebook immediately.

"That is not on any of our maps," she said.

Varux looked at the symbol.

"I have seen it."

Everyone turned toward him.

"Where?"

"On the first page I found after I left." He looked sick. "I thought it meant the First Keepers."

"Does it?" Alias asked.

"I do not know."

The book wrote one final sentence below the map.

THE FIRST KEEPERS DID NOT LEAVE A KINGDOM.  
THEY LEFT A WAY TO RETURN.

The bell rang a third time.

This time, the sound did not fade.

The black stone wall behind the shelf began to slide open.

Beyond it was another staircase.

Not the narrow stair they had followed before. This one was broad enough for all six of them to climb side by side. It spiraled upward toward a white light far above.

On the first step, a message had been carved.

THE LAST LESSON IS NOT ABOUT THE ROAD.

Varux stared at the words.

"Then what is it about?" Rowan asked.

The book remained open behind them.

Its final page showed the small child in the blue blanket again.

Below the drawing, in blue ink, appeared a sentence.

ASK WHAT YOU WILL DO WITH WHAT YOU KNOW.

Alias looked at the new stair.

At the map to the east.

At the words from his parents, still burning in his mind.

They had not left because he was unwanted.

They had loved him.

They had still left.

Both things could be true.

And now he had to decide what truth would make him do.

He took a breath.

"We climb," he said.

Varux looked at him.

"Are you sure?"

Alias looked back at the child on the page.

Then at Maris, Corvin, Rowan, and Eldric.

"I am not climbing to find them," he said. "Not only for that."

"What then?" Eldric asked.

Alias placed one hand against the Reader coin at his chest.

"To find out what I do next."

The older Alias nodded slowly.

No warning.

No attempt to take the choice away.

Just a nod.

Together, they stepped onto the broad stair.

Behind them, the hidden room held its book, its bell, and the answers that had not been answers at all.

Above them, the tower waited with one final lesson.

And farther east, beyond every road Alias knew, a new direction had begun to exist.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 26

### M's Final Lesson

#### *Shared Journal Entry 439*

*"The last lesson was not an answer. It was a question someone had trusted us to carry home."*

The broad stair did not feel like the rest of the tower.

The earlier stairs had been narrow, uneven, and hungry for mistakes. They turned sharply around the hollow center, forcing everyone to climb single file. The broad stair rose gently beneath a high arch, wide enough for all six of them to walk beside one another.

That should have made it easier.

Instead, Alias felt as though the tower had become quieter around them.

No symbols watched from the walls. No blue questions appeared beneath their feet. The air smelled of rain, old stone, and the faint dry scent of pages left too long in closed rooms.

Varux walked beside him in the old coat.

The coat still did not fit. Its sleeves were too short, the shoulders too tight. But he had stopped tugging at it every few steps. He kept one hand in the pocket where Maris's old letter rested, as if checking that it was still there.

Rowan looked up the stairwell.

"I do not trust the easy stairs."

"Nothing has been easy," Corvin said.

"These are easy in a suspicious way."

Maris looked over the rail. "The tower may have no more rooms below this point."

"That is optimistic," Rowan said.

"It is an observation."

"Observations can be optimistic."

Eldric held his staff low. Its blue flame was smaller now, but it did not need to show the way. Pale light appeared at intervals along the upper wall, leading them toward the top.

Varux stopped.

The others took two more steps before noticing.

"What is it?" Alias asked.

The older version looked at the light ahead.

"I remember this part," he said.

"Better than the rest?" Maris asked.

Varux nodded once.

"This is where I heard M speak."

The stair went silent.

Alias looked up.

"Not a note?"

"No." Varux rubbed the old scar on his cheek. "A voice. Or something close enough that I believed it was one."

"What did it say?" Corvin asked.

Varux was quiet for too long.

"It asked me what I was willing to leave behind for an answer."

Rowan frowned. "That sounds like a bad question."

"It was not the question that was bad," Varux said. "It was the answer I gave."

Alias felt a cold line move through his chest.

"What did you say?"

The older Alias looked at him.

"Everything."

No one spoke after that.

The stair continued upward.

At the top waited a round room with no door.

The tower had opened directly into it.

The ceiling was gone. Not broken. Gone. Above them, the morning sky stretched pale and wide between the black stone walls. Clouds moved far overhead. A cold wind crossed the circular space and lifted the edges of Maris's hair.

The room had only three things.

A stone table stood in the center.

A lantern hung from an iron hook above it, its glass empty.

And a wooden writing desk rested against the far wall.

The desk was small, scarred, and utterly ordinary. It had ink stains along one corner and a drawer beneath the writing surface. A cup stood beside it, cracked through the middle.

Varux stared at the cup.

"Lessa's cup," Rowan said softly.

Varux shook his head.

"Not hers. Mine."

The cup was blue.

Alias approached the desk.

There was no name written anywhere. No Reader symbol. No carved warning.

Only a shallow scratch in the wood, almost worn away.

M.

Maris traced it with one fingertip.

"Did you find this before?" she asked.

Varux stood at the edge of the room, not moving closer.

"I found the desk."

"And?"

"I thought it was empty."

Rowan looked at the drawer. "It has a drawer."

"I know."

"You did not open it?"

"No."

"Why?"

Varux looked at the cup.

"I thought the answer would be in the sky."

The wind moved through the open roof.



Alias thought of every stair Varux had climbed past. Every room he had left unopened. Every object he had treated as a clue only if it pointed farther east.

He placed his hand on the drawer handle.

"Then we open it now," he said.

The drawer did not resist.

Inside lay a folded page, a small brass key, and a dark blue ribbon tied around a bundle of thin papers.

The papers were not letters.

They were copies of maps.

Corvin came forward first.

His eyes widened as he lifted the top map from the bundle. It showed the region around the tower, but the ink was older than any map he carried. Lines marked roads that no longer existed. Small circles indicated structures: the Hall, the observatory, the archive, Hollow Creek.

A fourth mark lay farther east.

Not the circle split in two from the hidden book.

Something simpler.

A gate.

At the bottom of the map, written in an uneven hand, were the words:

The road east is not the road away.

Corvin read it twice.

"That is not a direction," he said.

"It is not supposed to be," Eldric replied.

The brass key was different from the one at Hollow Creek. It had no eye symbol. Its handle had been shaped like two hands meeting.

Maris untied the blue ribbon.

The papers inside were covered in writing from different hands. Some were notes about roads. Some were dates. Some were only a line or two, as if their writers had been interrupted.

The first note was signed M.

If you reach the tower, you have already followed a road I did not mean to build for you.

The wind stopped.

Not slowly.

All at once.

The lantern above the table lit with blue fire.

Varux stepped backward.

"No," he whispered.

The blue flame did not grow larger. It only burned steadily, reflected in the empty glass.

Then a voice filled the room.

It was not loud. It did not come from a person standing before them. It came from the lantern, the walls, the open sky.

It sounded young.

Not like a god. Not like an ancient ruler. Just someone tired, curious, and perhaps a little afraid.

"If you are hearing this," the voice said, "then I was not able to explain it myself."

Alias felt Varux go rigid beside him.

The voice continued.

"My name does not matter as much as I thought it did. But people called me M, so that is what I left behind."

The lantern flame bent in the windless air.

"I made notes because I was afraid I would forget. Then other people found the notes and followed them because they were afraid they had nothing else. That was never what I wanted."

Rowan looked at Varux.

The older Alias could not look back.

"A note is not a command," M's voice said. "A path is not a promise. I learned that too late."

The room dimmed.

A picture appeared in the lantern flame.

Two figures stood on the eastern side of the tower. A wolffolk woman with dark fur and a human man carrying a long case over one shoulder. They were younger than Alias had imagined. Tired, but alive. The woman wore a blue scarf. The man held a map against the wind.

Alias stopped breathing.

His parents.

Not memories. Not a drawing. Not words on a page.

People.

The woman turned slightly, and Alias saw his own eyes in her face.

The man smiled at something she said.

Then the image flickered.

M's voice became quieter.

"They came to ask whether the eastern passage could be made safe. They did not ask because they wanted to leave anyone behind. They asked because something beyond the First Road had begun to open, and they believed it would reach west if no one went to close it."

Alias gripped the edge of the stone table.

"What was opening?" he asked.

The recording did not answer him.

It could not.

It continued as if it had been waiting for the question anyway.

"They knew the danger. They knew the road might not return them. They wrote letters. They left a child at the western gate with people they trusted. They promised to return before the child learned what waiting was."

The lantern flame shook.

"They were wrong about time."

Alias could not look away from the image.

His mother touched the man's arm. His father folded the map. Then both of them turned east, toward a place beyond the light.

"They were not wrong about love," M said.

The image faded.

The room was only stone again.

Only the desk. The table. The blue lantern.

Alias felt Maris take his hand.

He did not remember reaching for hers.

He held on.

Varux stood a short distance away, his old coat moving in the wind.

For once, he did not say he was sorry.

Maybe he understood that sorry was too small.

Eldric spoke instead.

"They chose a danger," he said quietly. "Not an absence."

Alias nodded, but it did not make the ache disappear.

His parents had not stopped loving him.

They had still left.

Both truths remained heavy in his hands.

The flame brightened.

M's voice returned.

"To the child at the western gate, if you ever reach this room: do not make their road your punishment. Do not follow it because you think their absence is a debt you must pay."

Alias felt the coin under his shirt burn warm.

"You have a right to ask what happened," M continued. "You have a right to look east. But you do not have to walk alone. And you do not have to walk only because they did."

The last sentence settled over the room.

It was not an answer.

It was permission.

The flame changed color.

For a moment, the lantern showed another image.

Varux.

Young Varux, standing alone at the edge of the room. His bag was still slung over one shoulder. He had not yet grown the scar on his cheek. He looked tired and angry and very small beneath the open sky.

M's voice spoke to the memory of him.

"To the man who called himself a road because he was afraid to be called home: you will not find forgiveness by walking until you disappear."

Varux stumbled backward.

The lantern flickered hard.

"No," he said.

It did not stop.

"You are not responsible for every road that hurt you. You are responsible for the next one you choose."

The older Alias raised one hand toward the lantern.

"Stop."

The blue flame leaned toward him.

"You will think leaving makes you safer," M's voice continued. "It will only make you harder to find."

Varux's hand shook.

"Stop."

The room filled with wind.

Alias stepped between Varux and the lantern.

"It is a record," he said. "It cannot hear you."

"I know."

Varux's voice broke.

The flame showed the younger version of him again, turning toward the eastern road.

"I followed you," Varux whispered.

M's voice became almost gentle.

"No. You followed your fear and borrowed my notes to make it feel like destiny."

The flame went still.

No one moved.

Varux stood with his eyes closed.

For years, Alias thought, he had told himself that M had led him away. That a mystery had called him east. That he had been following a road someone else built.

Now the voice had taken even that excuse from him.

Not cruelly.

Truthfully.

The lantern dimmed enough that the writing desk came back into view.

On the stone table, the brass key began to glow.

A line appeared beneath it.

WHAT WILL YOU RETURN WITH?

Rowan read it.

"That is a better question than what will you leave behind."

"Not necessarily easier," Maris said.

Corvin placed the eastern map beside the key. "We return with a map."

The words did nothing.

Maris set the shared journal beside it. "A record."

Nothing.

Eldric placed his tea leaf on the stone table. "A promise to remember."

The lantern flickered but did not answer.

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version was still facing the blue flame. His eyes were wet, but he had opened them.

"What will you return with?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at the old coat around his shoulders. Then at the letter in its pocket. Then at the shared journal.

"Not an answer," he said.

The lantern brightened.

He took a breath.

"I will return with myself."

The blue fire rose.

The brass key turned once on the table.

A sound came from the far wall.

Stone shifted.

A narrow compartment opened beneath the writing desk.

Inside lay a final folded letter, sealed with blue wax.

This one was not addressed to Alias.

It was addressed to all of them.

Maris broke the seal.

The letter contained only three lines.

When you leave this tower, do not follow the eastern road yet.

Find the place where your choice began.

Then choose again with witnesses.

Below the lines was a small mark: the open eye, the Reader symbol, and the circle split in two.

Maris read the message again.

"Find the place where your choice began," she said.

Varux looked toward the stair.

"The east road near Veyr's Crossing."

Alias looked at him.

"The fork."

Varux nodded.

"The first time I chose it, I had every chance to go west. I could have gone home. I could have opened the letter. I could have turned around before the road became years."

Eldric placed a hand on his shoulder.

"And now?"

The older Alias looked at the map.

"Now I go back there."

Alias felt something shift inside him.

Not the road beneath his boots.

The shape of the story.

They had climbed the tower to learn what stood east.

But M's final lesson did not tell them to rush there.

It told them to return to the point where a choice had been made and look at it together.

Not to erase it.

To understand it.

The lantern began to fade.

M's voice returned one last time.

"If you have reached this room, you may be tempted to call this the end of a road. It is not. A road does not end when you understand where it went wrong. It changes when you decide what you will do next."

The flame lowered.

"Go home when you can. Go east when you choose. But do not mistake a lesson for a cage."

Then the lantern went dark.

The wind returned through the open roof.

The room was ordinary again.

No voice. No image. No blue fire.

Only the six of them, the desk, the maps, and a wide morning sky above.

Rowan looked at the empty lantern.

"I liked M better before M talked."

Corvin glanced at him. "You liked M before you knew anything about M."

"Exactly. It was simpler."

Maris held the letter close to the shared journal.

"It was not a final lesson," she said.

Varux looked at her.

"What?"



"It was one lesson. Not the final one." She looked at the message from M. "A person cannot leave a final lesson for someone else. Not really. We have to make the rest ourselves."

The older Alias considered that.

Then he smiled, small but honest.

"That sounds right."

Alias walked to the table and picked up the brass key.

It was warm in his palm.

"What does this open?" he asked.

Corvin studied it. "Nothing here."

Eldric looked at the eastern map.

"Maybe it opens something later."

"That is not very useful," Rowan said.

"It is more useful than a closed door," Eldric replied.

The tower did not argue.

For the first time since they entered, it seemed to have nothing else to ask of them.

They left the top room together.

The broad stair carried them downward, not back toward fear but back toward the rooms they had skipped and the road beneath the tower. Varux walked beside Alias in the old coat. He did not pull away when the younger version matched his pace.

At the lower landing, they stopped beside the blue-lit door Varux had once followed alone.

He looked at it.

The door stayed closed.

"I do not need to go in," he said.

"No," Alias replied. "Not today."

Varux nodded.

They continued down.

By afternoon, they stood again at the doorway beneath the cliff. The first road stretched across the basin behind them. Beyond the broken signpost, west waited in one direction and Veyr's Crossing in another.

The tower rose above them, dark against the sky.

It no longer felt like a place that had swallowed Varux.

It felt like a place that had finally given him back.

At the boundary stones, Alias stopped.

"Where do we go now?" Rowan asked.

Varux looked toward the western road first.

Then toward the fork near Veyr's Crossing.

"Back to where I chose," he said.

Alias looked at the group.

No one objected.

They had not found every answer.

But they had found the question that mattered next.

What do you do with what you know?

Together, they turned from the tower.

And began walking back toward the road where everything had changed.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 27

### Where My Choice Began

#### *Shared Journal Entry 440*

*"A choice does not begin at the fork. It begins when you decide that no one else is allowed to help you choose."*

The road away from the tower felt shorter than the road toward it.

Alias knew that was impossible.

The tower still stood behind them. Its black walls rose above the basin, sharp against the pale morning sky. The first road still ran beneath the cliff. The boundary stones still marked the place where old maps became unreliable and ordinary roads became stories.

Nothing had changed.

Except that they were walking west.

Varux walked near the front with Corvin. The old coat was still too small. Its sleeves pulled against his wrists whenever he lifted the map. He had stopped trying to hide it beneath the grey cloak.

Alias kept noticing that.

The future version of him had spent years changing names, hiding papers, leaving rooms before they could ask him questions. Now he wore a coat that did not fit because it had belonged to a version of himself he had abandoned.

It was not a large thing.

It felt important anyway.

Rowan kicked a loose stone down the road.

"So," he said, "we are going back."

Corvin did not look up from the map. "Yes."

"Back back."

"That is usually what back means."

"To Maanhaven?"

Varux stopped walking.

The road went quiet around them.

Maanhaven was not visible from here. It lay days west, beyond the hills and the old crossings and the places where roads began to feel familiar again. But the name changed the air.

Maris looked toward Varux.

"Is that where we are going?" she asked.

The older Alias stared at the map.

For a moment, Alias thought he might answer with a careful maybe. A later. A map mark. Something that sounded like an answer without becoming one.

Instead, Varux folded the map.

"Yes," he said.

Rowan blinked.

"Just yes?"

"Just yes."

"That is new."

"I know."

Rowan pointed at him. "Do not say that. It ruins the moment."

Varux almost smiled.

Almost.

They walked until the basin disappeared behind the hills.

By afternoon, the first road had become an old track again. The blue lamps had gone dark one by one behind them. Grass pushed through the stones. Thorn bushes leaned across the edges. The tower was no longer visible, but Alias could still feel it in the back of his mind like a question he had not finished answering.

The Paper rested in his pack.

It had been quiet since they left.

That worried him more than when it wrote.

Maris walked beside him with the shared journal open in both hands.

"What are you writing?" Alias asked.

"Nothing yet."

"You have had it open for an hour."

"I am thinking."

"That is dangerous."

She gave him a small look.

"I am trying to write the tower down without turning it into a warning."

"Was it not a warning?"

"Yes." Maris looked back toward the unseen tower. "But it was not only that."

Alias considered it.

"The tower was a lot of things."

"Exactly."

"Then write that."

Maris smiled.

"That is not very useful."

"It is honest."

She wrote something.

Ahead, Varux stopped at a broken signpost.

Alias recognized it before he reached it.

The same signpost from the memory.

One arm pointed west.

MAANHAVEN - 3 DAYS.

The other pointed east.

NO MARKED SETTLEMENTS.

The third message remained carved into the wood:

TURN BACK WHILE YOU STILL KNOW WHY.

Nobody spoke.

The road east looked ordinary in daylight.

That was what Alias hated most.

It was only a road. Narrow. Muddy. Tall grass at its edges. A few dark birds lifted from the thorn bushes when the wind changed.

No glowing signs told a person to abandon everyone they loved.

No voice made the decision for him.

The road had never done anything.

Varux walked toward the east marker.

He touched the worn wood with one hand.

"This is not where I thought my choice began," he said.

Alias watched him.

"Where did you think it began?"

"Here." Varux looked down the eastern path. "I thought I chose when I took this road."

"And now?"

The older version looked at the west sign.

"I chose earlier."

The others gathered near him.

Varux took a breath.

"The first choice was at camp. Before the road. Before the letter. Before I found a name for myself that no one else knew." He looked at Alias. "I found a page that might have said something about our parents. I decided I had to understand it before I told anyone."

Maris lowered the journal.

"I did not want them to tell me no," Varux continued. "More than that, I did not want them to tell me they would come with me. Because then I would have to admit I was afraid."

Eldric nodded slowly.

"The first road was not east," he said. "It was silence."

Varux looked at him.

"Yes."

No one made a joke.

The truth had made the place too quiet for that.

Alias looked at the signpost.

He thought of the younger Varux at camp, packing a bag too carefully. Writing a note. Gone east.  
Back tomorrow. Do not worry.

The choice had not begun at the fork.

It had begun when he decided the people around him could not be part of the question.

"Then choose again," Alias said.

Varux looked at him.

"What?"

"Here." Alias gestured to the two roads. "Not to fix the old choice. You cannot. But choose now."

The older version did not move.

"The east road is still there," Alias said. "My parents went east. M's map points east. You still  
want answers."

"Yes."

"The west road is still there too."

Varux looked at the word Maanhaven carved into the old sign.

His eyes were wet.

"You do not have to go west just because you think that is what everyone wants," Alias  
continued. "And you do not have to go east just because you are scared you will become someone  
else if you stop."

The sentence surprised Alias as he said it.

It felt true anyway.

Varux looked at the group.

At Maris holding the shared journal.

At Corvin with his map.

At Rowan with red string tied around his wrist.

At Eldric, quiet and steady.

Then at Alias.

"What would you choose?" Varux asked.

Alias looked toward east.

Somewhere beyond the hills and the first road, his parents' last record waited in a place no one could name yet. The thought pulled at him. It was sharp. It was real.

He wanted to go.

He wanted to run until the road ended in a room that could tell him where they had gone, what they had faced, whether they were alive.

But the tower had shown him the child at the western gate.

It had shown him that love and leaving could exist in the same sentence.

And M had said not to make their road into a punishment.

"I would choose west first," Alias said.

Varux stared at him.

"Why?"

"Because I want to go east." Alias swallowed. "That is why."

No one spoke.

He continued.

"If I go east now, I will spend every step wondering if I am doing it because I want answers or because I am scared to go home without them."

Maris looked at him.

"That is a good question," she said.

"I am tired of questions," Rowan said.

"Then you are in the wrong group."

Corvin looked between the roads.

"West is not giving up east," he said. "It is choosing the order."

Eldric nodded.

"Some roads must wait until you can walk them without turning them into a way to disappear."

Varux looked at the east sign again.

Then he reached into the pocket of the old coat.



He took out the letter from Maris.

He did not unfold it. He only held it.

"I thought coming back had to be the last thing I did," he said.

Alias watched him.

"Why?"

"Because I thought if I came home without answers, they would see how much time I had wasted."

Rowan crossed his arms.

"They would probably see that you came home."

Varux gave him a small, broken smile.

"Yes."

"People do notice that."

"I know."

"Do not say it."

"Sorry."

"That is allowed."

The wind moved through the tall grass.

Varux stepped away from the east sign.

He walked to the west marker.

Then he took a piece of charcoal from his pack and drew a thin line beneath the word  
Maanhaven.

Nothing magical happened.

No blue light rose from the road.

No door opened.

It was only charcoal on weathered wood.

Still, Alias felt his chest loosen.

Varux turned to the group.

"West," he said.

This time, it did not sound like retreat.

It sounded like a decision.

They made camp that night beside a creek they had crossed on the way east.

The water ran shallow over smooth stones. The trees were shorter here. Familiar, though Alias could not have said why. Maybe because they had passed them before. Maybe because every road felt different when it carried you toward something instead of away from it.

Corvin built the fire.

Rowan gathered wood and declared the branches western enough to burn better.

Maris sat with the shared journal open.

Varux stood beside her for a long time.

Then he asked, "Can I write?"

Maris looked up.

"Yes."

He took the pencil.

The others did not watch him this time.

That was new too.

Alias sat by the creek with Eldric.

For a while, they listened to the water.

Then Alias said, "Did you ever have a road like that?"

Eldric did not pretend not to understand.

"Yes," he said.

"What did you choose?"

The old mage looked at the fire.

"Once, I chose to keep walking because I thought someone needed me farther ahead." His voice was quiet. "I came back too late to learn how much I had been needed behind me."

Alias looked at him.

"What happened?"

Eldric's hand tightened around his cup.

"That is a story for another fire."

Alias nodded.

He did not ask again.

After a while, Eldric said, "You do not have to become careful enough that you never leave home."

Alias looked toward the west road.

"Then what do I do?"

"You leave when you choose to. You return when you can. And you let people know which road you are taking."

It sounded simple.

It probably was not.

But Alias wrote the words down in his mind anyway.

Across the fire, Varux finished writing.

He handed the journal back to Maris.

She read it silently.

Then she looked at him.

"Do you want to share it?"

Varux nodded.

Maris passed the journal to Alias.

The page read:

Day 5.

I stood at the road where I thought my life changed.

It did not change there.

It changed when I decided I had to be alone before anyone else could tell me I was not.

Today, I chose west.

Not because east stopped mattering.

Because I do not want home to become the place I only visit after I have earned it.

Alias read the words twice.

Then he looked at Varux.

The older version was watching the fire.

"It is good," Alias said.

Varux's smile was barely there.

"Thank you."

Rowan leaned forward. "Can I add something?"

Maris looked alarmed. "No."

"I am not going to ruin it."

"That is not a promise you make often."

Rowan held out his hand for the pencil.

After a moment, Maris gave it to him.

He added one line beneath Varux's entry.

Also, the west road is better because it has Gerhardt's food.

Corvin looked at the page.

"That is not relevant."

"It is very relevant."

Maris tried not to laugh.

She failed.

The sound traveled across the creek.

For a few moments, the road east did not pull at Alias. The tower did not loom behind them. The future did not press against every word.

There was only a fire.

Six people.

A journal.

And the road home.

The next morning, the Paper wrote again.

Alias opened it before breakfast.

Blue ink formed slowly across the page.

THE EAST ROAD WILL WAIT.

He read the words.

Then looked west.

The Paper added one more line.

WILL YOU?

Alias folded it shut.

"Yes," he said.

Varux heard him.

The older version stood beside the creek, wearing the old coat and looking toward the road.

"What did it say?" he asked.

Alias looked at him.

"It asked whether I will wait."

"And?"

"I said yes."

Varux nodded.

The answer seemed to matter to him.

They packed their bags.

The west road was still long. Maanhaven was still days away. Nobody knew what waited there. Gerhardts might be angry. He might be glad. He might throw Varux out before letting him in. The future team, if they existed in the way Varux remembered, would be older and changed and carrying their own years.

None of that could be solved from a road.

But the road was there.

And this time, everyone knew which way they were walking.

Together, they turned west.

Not away from the mystery.

Toward the people who had always been part of the answer.

\* \* \*

## PART IV - HOME

### Chapter 28

#### Returning

#### *Shared Journal Entry 441*

*"We did not arrive home all at once. First there was the road, then the rain, then the smell of bread, and only then did we understand where our feet had taken us."*

The road west was not quiet.

Alias had expected it to be.

After the tower, after the buried roads and blue lamps and messages that had waited longer than people should be asked to wait, he thought returning would feel like walking through the space after a storm.

Instead, the world became louder.

Wagons rattled past them on the lower roads. Birds called from hedges. A farmer shouted at a stubborn mule in a field so green it hurt to look at after the black stone of the tower. Smoke rose from chimneys in small villages, straight and ordinary against the sky.

Every ordinary thing made Alias feel something he could not name.

They passed a family eating bread beside a cart. The youngest child dropped a pear in the mud and cried as though the world had ended. The child's mother washed it in a stream, cut away the bruised part, and gave it back.

Rowan watched the whole thing.

"That is a very good pear," he said.

"No one asked," Corvin replied.

"I am making an observation."

"Observations can be optimistic," Maris said.

Rowan looked at her. "You have been spending too much time with Corvin."

"I have been spending exactly the right amount of time with Corvin."

Corvin did not look up from the map, but the corner of his mouth moved.

Varux walked ahead of them in the old coat.

The grey fabric was still too small. He had loosened the sleeves at the seams with a small knife so he could bend his wrists without pulling at the stitches. The repair looked rough. The coat looked worse for it.

He had refused to put the newer cloak back on.

Alias noticed that too.

Varux had spent years making himself into someone unrecognizable.

Now he wore a coat that told the truth.

By the second day, the road began to feel familiar.

Not because Alias had traveled every mile of it before. There were still turns he did not remember, small bridges he had never crossed, fields that looked different under different weather. But the land softened as they went west.

The hills lowered.

The trees grew broader.

Roadside shrines carried faded blue ribbons tied around the posts.

At one of them, Eldric stopped.

A stone bowl sat beneath a small carved roof. Someone had left a handful of dried flowers in the bowl. A painted sign above it read:

FOR THOSE WHO ARE STILL ON THEIR WAY.

Varux stood beside him.

"I saw one of these on the road east," he said.

Eldric looked at the flowers.

"What did you think it meant?"

Varux considered that.

"That it was for people who had not found what they were looking for."

"And now?"

The older Alias watched a loose blue ribbon move in the wind.

"Maybe it is for people who are still allowed to return."

Eldric nodded.



"Good."

They left a small piece of bread in the bowl before continuing.

No one said whose idea it was.

On the third evening, rain found them.

It began as a cold mist over the road, then thickened into a steady silver curtain. Corvin had wanted to reach the next village before dark, but the path became slick and the wagon ruts filled with water.

"We stop," Eldric said.

Corvin looked at the clouds. "We are less than an hour from shelter."

"We are also less than one poor step from someone twisting an ankle."

Rowan pointed at the mud. "I support the person protecting us from wet feet."

"You have been complaining about wet feet for twenty minutes," Maris said.

"They are my feet. I have a relationship with them."

They found shelter beneath an abandoned roof built along the side of the road. It had once been a trader's stop, perhaps, but only the three stone walls remained. The fourth side faced a field of tall grass bending under the rain.

Varux helped Corvin build a fire in the driest corner.

It took longer than it should have. The wood was damp. Smoke filled the shelter before the flames caught. Rowan coughed dramatically and announced that the fire was trying to kill him.

"It is trying to stay alive," Corvin said.

"Then it has something in common with me."

Maris set the shared journal on her pack to keep it from the mud.

Varux looked at it.

"Can I write?" he asked.

Maris nodded without looking up.

He took the journal and crouched near the fire.

His pencil hovered over the page for a long time.

Alias watched the rain beyond the open side of the shelter.

He could have asked what Varux was writing.

He did not.

The silence felt different now.

It was not the silence of someone hiding a road.

It was the silence of someone trying to choose his words.

After a while, Varux spoke.

"I used to hate rain."

Rowan turned his head. "That is a strange thing to confess."

"It is not a confession."

"Everything is a confession if you say it sadly enough."

Varux ignored him.

"Rain meant I had to stop walking," he said. "When I was alone, I hated anything that made me stop. It felt like losing time."

Maris lifted her eyes from the fire.

"And now?"

Varux looked out at the rain.

"Now it means we have to sit here together until it passes."

Rowan wrapped his blanket closer around his shoulders.

"That still sounds unpleasant."

"It is not nothing," Varux said.

No one made a joke.

The fire crackled.

Rain tapped against the stone roof.

Alias thought of the younger Varux in the cold room above the market, staring at a shared journal he was too afraid to read. He thought of the tavern window in the snow. The unopened letter. The road stretching east because it was easier to walk than to turn around.

He looked at the man beside the fire now.

The future had not disappeared.

The scar was still there. The grey in Varux's fur. The years behind his eyes.

But he was sitting in the rain with them.

That was something.

Late that night, when everyone else had fallen asleep, Alias woke to the sound of the Paper rustling in his pack.

Blue light bled through the fabric.

He sat up.

Varux was awake too.

The older version sat near the edge of the shelter, watching the rain fall across the road. The old coat was pulled tight around him.

Alias unfolded the Paper.

Two lines appeared.

THE WEST ROAD REMEMBERS YOU.

Below it:

SO DOES HE.

Alias glanced at Varux.

"What does that mean?" he whispered.

Varux looked over.

The blue letters reflected in his eyes.

"I do not know."

Alias waited.

Varux gave a small, tired smile.

"That was not me hiding."

"I know."

The Paper wrote again.

THE TOWN WILL NOT BE THE SAME.

Varux's hand tightened around the coat.

"No," he said quietly. "It will not."

Alias looked toward the dark road.

"Are you scared?"

Varux did not pretend otherwise.

"Yes."

"Of Gerhardt?"

"Of everyone."

"That is a lot of people."

"It has been a long time."

Alias folded the Paper shut.

"It does not have to be all at once."

Varux looked at him.

"What?"

"You do not have to explain twenty years in one sentence."

The older Alias considered that.

Then he laughed quietly.

"That would be a very long sentence."

Rowan spoke from beneath his blanket without opening his eyes.

"Do not try it. I am sleeping."

The next morning, the rain had stopped.

The road shone black beneath a pale sky. Water hung from every branch. The air smelled like wet soil and new leaves.

They walked west.

By midday, Alias saw the first familiar marker.

It stood beside the road at the top of a small hill: a carved stone with a moon above a wave.

Maanhaven.

The sight of it made him stop.

The others stopped too.

Varux did not move.

He stared at the marker as if it had appeared from a dream.

"I remember this," he said.

Alias looked at him.

"You remember a stone?"

"I remember passing it the first time I left."

The words were almost swallowed by the wind.

"What did you think?" Alias asked.

Varux looked down the road.

"That I would see it again tomorrow."

The old sentence.

Tomorrow.

Alias felt anger rise, but it did not burn the way it used to. It hurt. It probably always would.

Still, he stepped beside Varux.

"You are seeing it now."

Varux nodded.

"Yes."

They continued.

The road curved through a shallow valley. Fields spread across both sides, separated by low walls and hedges. A flock of sheep moved slowly through one field, followed by a young shepherd with a crooked staff. Smoke rose in the distance.

Then the sea appeared.

Maanhaven sat along the curve of the water, tucked beneath hills that fell toward a wide grey bay. The roofs of the town clustered together in blue, brown, and red. Old wooden docks reached out across the harbor. Boats bobbed at their ropes. Beyond them, gulls wheeled through the sky.

Alias had seen Maanhaven before.

He had walked its streets. He had sat in its tavern. He had heard Gerhardt complain about muddy boots and rude customers. He knew where the baker put the warm rolls in the morning and which alley Rowan used when he wanted to avoid the market crowd.

But seeing it from the hill felt different.

It did not look like a destination.

It looked like a living thing.

People moved along the docks. A child ran after a gull. Someone hauled nets from a boat. A woman shook a rug from an upstairs window and shouted at someone below.

Home was loud.

Home was busy.

Home had not frozen while they were gone.

Rowan breathed out slowly.

"That is a lot of roofs."

"You have seen the town before," Corvin said.

"Yes. But now it feels dramatic."

"Everything feels dramatic to you."

"That is because I notice things."

Maris stood beside Alias with the shared journal held to her chest.

"What do we write?" she asked.

Alias looked at the town.

He did not know.

How could a page hold the sight of it? The bay, the smoke, the gulls, the old roads leading down to people who had no idea the six of them were coming.

Varux still had not moved.

The old coat hung loose around his shoulders. His hands were clenched at his sides.

Eldric approached him.

"You can take time," the mage said.

Varux looked at the town.

"If I take too much, I will leave again."

Eldric did not argue.

"Then take one breath."

Varux nodded.

He breathed in.

Then out.

"Another," Eldric said.

Varux did.

Alias watched him do it.

One breath. Then another.

A small thing.

But the future seemed full of small things that had mattered more than anyone knew.

Finally, Varux stepped forward.

The road down to Maanhaven was steep. It wound past the last fields and through a line of old warehouses before reaching the harbor streets. As they descended, the smells of the town grew clearer.

Salt.

Smoke.

Fish.

Fresh bread.

Rowan stopped so suddenly that Corvin walked into him.

"What?"

Rowan closed his eyes.

"That is Gerhardt's bread."

Corvin stared at him. "You can smell one baker from this far away?"

"I can smell a good baker from anywhere."

Maris laughed.

Even Varux smiled.

The smile did not stay long.

But it was there.

At the edge of town, they passed the western gate.

It was older than Alias remembered. Two stone pillars stood on either side of the road, their tops carved with weathered moons. A wooden arch connected them overhead. Vines climbed one side.

A guard sat beneath a small awning with a ledger open on his knees.

The child at the western gate.

Alias slowed.

The words from the hidden room returned with painful clarity.

LEFT AT THE WESTERN GATE.

NOT LEFT BEHIND.

He looked through the arch.

Years ago, his parents had stood here with a child in a blue blanket.

They had trusted someone enough to leave him.

They had loved him enough to promise they would come back.

They had been wrong about time.

He stood at the edge of the gate while the others passed through.

Maris noticed.

"Alias?"

He touched the stone pillar.

It was cold beneath his hand.

"I was here," he said.

"Yes," Varux said softly.

Alias looked at him.

"Not like this."

The older version watched the gate too.

"No," he said. "Not like this."



For one moment, neither moved.

Then Rowan came back through the arch.

"Are you both planning to stand there forever?"

"Maybe," Alias said.

"Do it after dinner."

The simple sentence broke the weight of the moment.

Alias smiled despite himself.

"Fine."

They walked through the gate together.

Maanhaven did not welcome them with music or bells.

A cart nearly ran Rowan over in the first street. A dog barked at Corvin's boots. A fisherman carrying a basket of eels asked them to move out of the way. The town had work to do.

That was good.

It meant home did not perform for them.

It simply existed.

Varux slowed as they reached the market square.

Every direction seemed to hold something he remembered. A fountain with a cracked moon carved in the middle. A narrow bookshop beneath a green awning. The alley leading toward the docks. The path up the hill to the old academy road.

He looked overwhelmed.

Alias could see it in the way he kept trying to look everywhere at once.

"Where do we go first?" Maris asked.

No one answered.

Then the smell of bread came again, stronger this time.

Rowan pointed down the street.

"That way."

Corvin sighed. "Of course."

"Gerhardt's tavern is that way too," Rowan added.

Varux went still.

The tavern stood near the harbor, at the corner where the market road met the docks. Alias could not see it yet, but he knew the shape of the sign: a painted lantern above a door. He knew the windows. He knew the worn step outside. He knew Gerhardt's voice when someone opened the door without wiping their boots.

Varux knew it too.

"I can go alone," he said.

Alias turned toward him.

"No."

"I mean, I can go first."

"No."

Varux looked tired.

"Alias..."

"You said we go together."

"I know."

"Then together."

The older version looked at the group.

Rowan had stopped joking. Maris held the journal close. Corvin's hand rested near his map case, as if he needed something familiar to hold. Eldric stood quietly at the edge of the square.

No one pushed Varux toward the tavern.

No one promised it would be easy.

They simply stayed.

At last, Varux nodded.

"Together," he said.

They walked toward the harbor.

The painted lantern sign came into view through the drifting gulls.

Varux stopped at the bottom of the tavern steps.

The wooden door was closed.

Warm light shone beneath it.

Somewhere inside, a chair scraped against the floor. Someone laughed. Dishes clinked. The ordinary sounds of a place that had gone on existing while the road tried to convince a man he had lost it.

Varux looked at the door.

His hand shook.

Alias stood beside him.

"You do not have to knock yet," he said.

Varux stared at the warm line of light beneath the door.

Then he took one breath.

And another.

"I do," he said.

He raised his hand.

The knock had not landed yet.

But he was no longer walking away.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 29

### Familiar Walls

#### *Shared Journal Entry 442*

*"The walls knew our names before we said them. They did not ask why we had been gone. They only kept standing until we came back."*

Varux knocked once.

The sound was small against the tavern door.

Alias had expected something dramatic. A burst of blue light. The Reader coin heating against his chest. A door that refused to open until someone confessed another truth to an old piece of stone.

Instead, there was only wood beneath Varux's knuckles and warm light beneath the threshold.

Inside, someone moved a chair.

Then the latch lifted.

The door opened halfway.

Gerhardt stood in the gap with a towel over one shoulder and a wooden spoon in one hand. He looked exactly as Alias remembered and not exactly at all. His beard had grown more grey at the chin. His eyebrows had become thicker, if that was possible. Flour dusted the front of his dark shirt. The familiar smell of onions, bread, and smoked fish rolled past him into the street.

He looked at Alias first.

His expression softened.

"There you are," he said.

Then he looked at Varux.

The spoon slipped from his hand.

It struck the floor with a clatter.

For a long moment, no one spoke.

Gerhardt's eyes moved between the younger Alias and the older man in the too-small coat. He did not seem frightened. That made it worse somehow. He looked like someone who had opened a door to a storm he had been expecting for years.

Varux swallowed.

"Hello, Gerhardt."

Gerhardt breathed out through his nose.

"You look older," he said.

Varux gave a weak smile. "I am."

"You look tired."

"Also true."

Gerhardt nodded once, as if he had confirmed something in his own mind.

Then he stepped aside.

"Come in before the gulls decide you are part of the menu."

Rowan blinked. "That was it?"

Gerhardt looked at him. "No. That was the part where you come inside. The rest is going to take longer."

They entered.

The tavern walls were familiar in a way Alias had not expected. Dark wood ran along every side of the main room, scarred by years of chairs, boots, and careless knives. A lantern hung above the central tables. Nets decorated one wall beside an old map of the bay. Someone had written a crooked line of numbers into the wooden beam near the kitchen door, probably a score from some game Rowan had insisted on playing months ago.

Nothing had frozen while they were gone.

The same table stood beneath the front window.

The same fireplace smoked too much when the wind came from the sea.

The same long counter held a jar of pickled onions that nobody but Gerhardt seemed to enjoy.

Alias felt his chest tighten.

Home had not waited like a statue.

It had continued being itself.

Gerhardt closed the door behind them and picked up the fallen spoon.

"Sit," he said.

No one moved.

He pointed the spoon at the nearest table.

"That was not a suggestion. I have soup on the stove, bread in the oven, and no interest in hearing twenty years explained on an empty stomach."

Rowan sat first.

"I knew I liked him," he said.

"You like anyone who feeds you," Corvin replied.

"That is not true. I also like people who let me make informed comments about their cooking."

"You have never made an informed comment in your life," Maris said.

The ordinary argument moved through the room like a small fire beginning to catch.

Varux remained standing.

He had stopped beside the table but did not pull out a chair.

Gerhardt noticed.

"You can sit," he said.

Varux looked at the chair as if it might accuse him.

"I do not know if I should."

Gerhardt's face changed.

Not angry. Not gentle, exactly.

Tired.

"You are in my tavern," he said. "You are wet from the road, underfed by the look of you, and standing like a person who expects the floor to disappear. Sit down. You can earn the right to make things complicated after supper."

Varux stared at him.

Then he pulled out a chair.

It scraped against the wooden floor.

He sat.

Alias took the chair beside him.

Gerhardt disappeared into the kitchen before anyone could say more. The sounds of chopping and ladles against metal filled the silence he left behind.

Rowan leaned toward Alias.

"I think that went well."

"You think everything goes well if nobody throws a chair," Corvin said.

"That is a reasonable standard."

Maris folded her hands over the shared journal.

"Gerhardt knew," she said softly.

Varux looked at the tabletop.

"Not everything."

"He knew enough to write you," Maris said.

The older Alias's hand moved to the pocket of his old coat.

The letter from Gerhardt was still in his pack. The unopened one from Ravencross. Alias had seen the corner of it when Varux had packed that morning, tied beneath the blue ribbon that held the other letters together.

"Did you read his letter?" Alias asked.

Varux shook his head.

"No."

Gerhardt returned with a tray before anyone could ask why.

He set down six bowls of soup, a loaf of bread, butter, and a plate of fried potatoes that made Rowan sit straighter in his chair.

"No one speaks until there is food in front of them," Gerhardt said.

Rowan looked at the bowls. "That is cruelly specific."

"It is wisdom."

The soup was thick with beans, onions, and something sharply herbed. Alias took one bite and felt the road leave his shoulders by a small amount.

Varux lifted his spoon but did not eat.

Gerhardt stood at the end of the table, watching him.

"It is not poisoned," he said.

Varux looked up.

"I did not think it was."

"Good. Eat anyway."

The older Alias took a bite.

His eyes closed.

Only for a second.

But Alias saw it.

The first taste of soup. The same room. The same kitchen. A person who knew how to make a bowl of food feel like a command to stay alive.

Gerhardt turned away and busied himself with the counter.

No one called attention to it.

That was another kind of kindness.

After the first bowls had been emptied and the bread had been attacked thoroughly enough that even Corvin admitted Rowan had earned a second piece, Gerhardt came back to the table.

He put both hands on the chair across from Varux.

"Now," he said, "you may make things complicated."

Varux's shoulders tightened.

Gerhardt looked at Alias first.

"You are nineteen?"

"Almost twenty."

Gerhardt's gaze moved to Varux.

"And you?"

"Thirty-eight."

Gerhardt nodded slowly.

"That is about what I expected."

Alias stared. "You expected this?"

"Not this exactly." Gerhardt gestured between them with one hand. "I expected the road to bring trouble eventually. It has always been good at that."

Rowan raised a hand. "I would like to state that I was not brought by the road. I was already trouble."

Gerhardt pointed at him without looking. "You were not invited to speak."

Rowan lowered his hand.



Gerhardt looked back at Varux.

"Lessa sent word five years ago," he said. "A man called Varux was staying at the Crossed Feather. Eldric had been looking for someone who sounded very much like him. Maris had a theory. Corvin had three maps. Rowan had opinions."

"I had useful opinions," Rowan said.

"One of them was that we should tie the man to a chair until he explained himself."

Rowan considered that. "Still not the worst plan."

Gerhardt ignored him.

"I sent a letter."

Varux looked down.

"I know."

"You did not answer it."

"No."

"You did not read it."

Varux's fingers tightened around the edge of the table.

"No."

Gerhardt waited.

He did not demand an explanation.

That seemed harder for Varux than anger would have been.

Finally, Varux said, "I thought if I read it, I would have to come back."

Gerhardt's expression remained still.

"And now?"

"Now I am here."

The tavern became very quiet.

Outside, a gull screamed near the harbor.

Gerhardt looked at the old coat. Then at the scar on Varux's cheek. Then at the younger Alias sitting beside him.

"Yes," he said. "You are."

It was not forgiveness.

It was not a welcome big enough to fix every year between them.

But it was not a closed door either.

Gerhardt reached beneath the counter and pulled out a folded sheet of paper.

Varux froze.

"Your letter," Gerhardt said.

The paper had been opened at least once. The edges were soft from handling.

"I kept a copy," he added. "I did not know whether you would ever read the first one. I thought having another chance might be useful."

Varux looked at the page as though it might burn him.

"You made a copy?"

"I am a tavern keeper. People lose things. I prepare."

"That is not why you made a copy," Maris said.

Gerhardt glanced at her.

"No," he admitted.

He placed the letter on the table in front of Varux.

No one touched it.

Alias watched the older version of himself stare at the handwriting.

"You do not have to read it now," Gerhardt said.

Varux looked up.

"I know."

Gerhardt's mouth twitched.

"Do not say that too often. It makes a man feel unnecessary."

A laugh escaped Varux before he could stop it.

It was rough and unfamiliar.

But it was there.

Gerhardt poured tea for Eldric, then one cup for himself. He sat at the end of the table, not quite part of the group and not apart from it either.

"Your parents came here once," he said to Alias.

Alias looked up sharply.

The room seemed to narrow around the words.

"When?"

"Before you were old enough to remember. They had you with them. Your mother carried you in that blue blanket of yours. Your father tried to pay me for a room and forgot he had already paid in the morning."

Alias tried to imagine them sitting in this room.

His mother with the blue scarf.

His father carrying maps.

A smaller version of him sleeping against one of them.

"What were they like?" he asked.

Gerhardt looked toward the window.

"Tired," he said. "Kind. Not as certain as they pretended to be."

"Did they talk about leaving?"

Gerhardt's expression became careful.

"They talked about a road. They said it was dangerous. They said they might have to go east for a while."

Alias held still.

"Did they say when they would return?"

"Yes."

"Did you believe them?"

Gerhardt met his eyes.

"I believed they meant it."

The answer hurt differently from the others.

Not because it gave him nothing.

Because it gave him the truth without making it easier.

Gerhardt continued.

"Your mother left a packet with me. Letters, perhaps. I never opened it. She said it was for you if she did not come back before you were ready to ask for it."

Alias's heart stopped.

"You have it?"

Gerhardt nodded.

"Locked upstairs. I did not know if you were ready."

"Am I?"

Gerhardt looked at the six of them around the table.

At the shared journal. At the old coat. At the maps and packs still wet from the road.

"I do not know," he said. "But you are not alone while you decide. That is more than most people have when they open a letter."

Alias looked down at his empty bowl.

The packet was upstairs.

Near enough to touch.

He could ask for it now.

He could tear through every page until he found a name, a place, a direction east.

The hunger to know rose so quickly that he almost stood.

Then he remembered the tower.

The book asking what he would do with what he knew.

The road that could become a punishment if he let it.

He took a breath.

"Not tonight," he said.

Gerhardt nodded.

"Good."

Alias blinked. "Good?"

"Letters are better when opened by people who have eaten." Gerhardt looked at Rowan. "And preferably after everyone has stopped trying to steal the potatoes."

Rowan pulled his hand away from the plate.

"I was not stealing. I was preventing waste."

The room warmed again.

Later, Gerhardt showed them the rooms upstairs.

The hallway smelled of old wood and sea salt. The walls had been painted blue long ago, but time had worn the color thin near the stairs. A crooked framed picture of the harbor hung beside the second door. Alias remembered it from when he was younger. He had never noticed that the boat in the painting had been drawn twice, one shadowed behind the other.

Varux stopped beneath the picture.

"I slept in that room," he said, pointing to the last door on the right.

Gerhardt nodded.

"For six weeks."

"I did not remember the picture."

"You remembered the room?"

"Not much."

Gerhardt looked at the door.

"You did not leave it much."

Varux's face tightened.

Gerhardt continued before anyone could misunderstand the tone.

"You wrote maps. You repaired the broken shutter once. You made a list of places you would go tomorrow. I found it after you left." He looked at Varux. "There were thirty-two tomorrows on it."

Varux looked down.

"I did not know you saw that."

"You did not know many things."

It was not cruel.

That made it worse.

Gerhardt unlocked the room.

The bed was narrow. The window faced the harbor. A small desk stood beneath it, its surface marked by old ink stains. The shutter had been repaired with uneven strips of wood.

Varux walked inside slowly.

The room was empty.

Still, Alias could see the outline of what had been there. Maps across the desk. A coat over the chair. A person looking out the window but not going down to the street.

Varux touched the repaired shutter.

"I did this badly," he said.

Gerhardt stood in the doorway.

"You did it carefully. That was not the problem."

No one asked what the problem was.

They all knew.

Maris entered the room and placed the shared journal on the desk.

"Do you want to write here?" she asked.

Varux looked at the journal.

Then at the harbor outside.

"Not tonight."

Maris nodded.

This time, the answer did not sound like running.

It sounded like a boundary.

Gerhardt handed Alias a small key.

"Your room is across the hall," he said. "The packet is in the office downstairs. It will still be there in the morning."

Alias closed his fingers around the key.

"Thank you."

Gerhardt grunted.

"Do not thank me before you see the mattress."

When the tavern had gone quiet, Alias lay awake in the small room across from Varux's.

The moonlight from the harbor made pale lines across the familiar walls. He could hear water against the docks. A gull cried once in the distance. Someone downstairs moved a chair, then all was still.

The Paper unfolded on the blanket beside him.

Blue letters appeared.

HOME IS NOT A TEST.

Alias read the line.

Then another appeared.

NEITHER IS FORGIVENESS.

He thought of Varux in the next room. Of Gerhardt downstairs. Of the packet waiting behind a locked office door. Of the old coat that did not fit and the letter that had finally been read only enough to be held.

He folded the Paper shut.

Across the hall, a floorboard creaked.

Alias opened his door.

Varux stood in the hallway with one hand against the wall. He looked at the harbor picture, not moving.

"Could not sleep?" Alias asked.

Varux glanced at him.

"No."

Alias stepped out into the hall.

The familiar walls held the two of them in quiet blue shadow.

"Do you want to talk?" he asked.

Varux looked at the picture again.

"Not yet."

Alias nodded.

They stood there for a while anyway.

They did not solve the letters.

They did not explain the years.

They did not make the future disappear.

But neither of them went back to the road.

When Gerhardt's old clock downstairs struck midnight, Varux looked toward Alias.

"Happy birthday," he said.

Alias blinked.

He had forgotten.

Then Varux gave a small, uncertain smile.

"I did not forget this one."

The old clock finished its last chime.

The walls remained around them.

And for the first time, Alias stepped into a new year of his life already home.

\* \* \*



## Chapter 30

### The Birthday

#### *Shared Journal Entry 443*

*"For one morning, nobody asked what the road would take from us. They only asked whether there was enough bread for everyone."*

Alias woke to the smell of sugar and burnt butter.

For one confused second, he thought he was still dreaming.

Moonlight had filled the room when he fell asleep. He remembered the Paper writing that home was not a test. He remembered hearing Varux moving quietly in the hall. He remembered the harbor outside the window, the low knock of water against the docks.

Now sunlight lay in thin gold stripes across the floor. Voices carried up from downstairs. Rowan was laughing too loudly. Gerhardt was telling someone to get away from the oven. Maris was trying and failing to sound calm while saying the word "surprise."

Alias sat up.

A folded note rested on the chair beside his bed.

It was not blue.

It was written on the back of an old tavern order slip in Rowan's messy handwriting.

DOWNSTAIRS. WE ARE DOING A THING. DO NOT ASK QUESTIONS UNTIL YOU  
HAVE EATEN.

Alias read the note twice.

Then the door across the hall opened.

Varux stepped out wearing the old coat. He looked as though he had not slept much. The letter from Maris still rested in the pocket over his chest. His newer cloak was folded over one arm.

He saw the note in Alias's hand.

"You got one too?" Alias asked.

Varux held up a small scrap of paper.

MINE SAYS: BE DOWNSTAIRS BEFORE ROWAN EATS THE ENTIRE BIRTHDAY.

Alias looked at him.

"The entire birthday?"

"I did not write it."

"That does not explain anything."

Varux's mouth shifted toward a smile.

"I think that was intentional."

They walked downstairs together.

The main room of Gerhardt's tavern had been rearranged.

The long table beneath the front window was covered with a clean blue cloth. It was not perfectly clean. A small soup stain darkened one corner, and someone had placed the butter dish directly over it. Twenty small candles stood in a row down the center, each pressed into a shallow round of moonbread.

The bread smelled of honey, cinnamon, and the burned butter that had woken Alias.

Rowan stood behind the table wearing a paper crown.

It was crooked, too large, and covered in an uneven number of hand-drawn gulls.

"There he is," Rowan said. "The birthday person."

Alias stopped at the bottom stair.

"What are you doing?"

"Celebrating your birthday. Try to keep up."

"You made a crown."

"Gerhardt made the crown. I decorated it."

From the kitchen, Gerhardt shouted, "I cut the paper. That is not the same thing."

Maris stood beside the table with the shared journal tucked under one arm. Corvin had positioned the candles in a careful straight line, which had clearly annoyed Rowan. Eldric sat near the fireplace with tea in one hand and a look of deliberate innocence.

Varux did not move.

He stood behind Alias, too quiet.

Gerhardt came through the kitchen door carrying a second tray of bread.

He looked at the table, then at Alias.

"Twenty," he said. "You are old enough to be responsible for yourself now. Terrible news."

Alias could not stop himself from smiling.

"You knew?"

"I own a tavern, not a cave. I know when people were born."

Gerhardt set the tray down and pointed a wooden spoon at Alias.

"Sit."

Alias looked at the candles.

"This is too much."

"It is bread and wax. You have faced worse."

"There are twenty candles."

"Then do not eat them."

Rowan pulled out a chair. "I made you a place between Maris and me. That was generous."

"Why is that generous?"

"Because I could have made you sit next to Corvin."

Corvin looked up from the candle arrangement. "I am sitting right here."

"Exactly."

Alias sat.

Varux remained standing at the end of the table.

Gerhardt noticed at once.

"There is another chair," he said.

Varux looked at it.

"I know."

Gerhardt raised an eyebrow.  
The older Alias sighed, pulled out the chair, and sat beside Eldric.  
The paper crown still rested on the table.

Rowan pushed it toward Alias.

"Put it on."

"No."

"It is the rule."

"There is no rule."

"There is now."

Alias looked at Gerhardt for help.

Gerhardt shrugged. "It is a terrible crown. You should wear it so it can suffer too."

So Alias put it on.

It fell over one eye immediately.

Rowan looked delighted.

The candles were not lit until everyone had food.

Gerhardt insisted on this with the seriousness of a military order. Bowls of sweet porridge appeared first, followed by fried potatoes, soft cheese, sliced apples, and the remaining moonbread. The tavern was still closed to customers. A small sign hung on the front door.

BACK IN AN HOUR. IF IT IS IMPORTANT, KNOCK TWICE.

Rowan had added beneath it:

UNLESS YOU ARE BRINGING PIE.

Gerhardt had crossed out the last line, though the ink had not fully covered it.

By the time the bowls were empty, the room had warmed. Alias did not feel as though he deserved all the attention. That was the strangest part. He kept waiting for someone to say there was a condition hidden beneath it. A question he needed to answer. A road he needed to take to earn the next piece of bread.

Nobody did.

Maris stood and placed the shared journal in front of him.

"I have a gift," she said.

Alias looked nervous. "Is it a question?"

"Not today."

She opened the journal to a new page.

At the top, in blue ink, she had written:

YEAR TWENTY.

Below that was a single sentence.

Things I did not know I would keep.

The rest of the page was blank.

Alias looked at it for a long time.

"You left it empty," he said.

"Yes."

"Why?"

Maris smiled a little.

"Because it is your year. You should get to write some of it before everyone else tells you what it meant."

The gift was only a page.

It felt larger than the tower.

Corvin went next.

He placed a folded map on the table in front of Alias.

"This is not finished," he said.

Rowan leaned over. "That is an odd way to give a present."

"It is finished enough."

Alias unfolded it.

The map showed Maanhaven, Ravencross, the Hall, the observatory, Hollow Creek, and the tower. The familiar roads were drawn in black. The sea was shaded lightly in blue. To the east, past the First Road, Corvin had left a wide empty space along the edge of the parchment.

At the bottom, he had written in small letters:

KNOWN ROADS. RETURN ROUTES. SPACE FOR WHAT COMES NEXT.

Alias touched the empty section.

"You left it blank."

"Because I do not know it yet," Corvin said. "And because empty is not the same as missing."

The words were simple. They still made Alias's throat tighten.

"Thank you," he said.

Corvin nodded once, as if that settled the matter.

Rowan stood up so quickly his chair scraped.

"My turn."

He placed a small object in Alias's hand.

It was a wooden whistle.

Not Rowan's usual whistle. This one was smaller, carved in the shape of a gull with one wing raised too high. A red thread tied through the hole at its end.

Alias looked at it.

"You made this?"

"I tried," Rowan said. "Do not test whether it sounds good."

"That is not encouraging."

"It is a travel whistle. One note means I am fine. Two notes means come find me. Three notes means I found food or trouble. You will learn the difference."

"What if it is both?"

"Then use your judgment."

Corvin muttered, "That seems unwise."

Rowan ignored him.

"The important part is that you do not have to walk ahead alone if you want someone to know where you are."

Alias closed his fingers around the whistle.

The red thread was rough against his palm.

"I will keep it," he said.

"Good. That is what gifts are for."

Eldric placed a small tin on the table.

Inside were tea leaves and two dried orange peels.

"For a day when you think every question needs to be answered before supper," Eldric said.

"Make tea first. Ask later."

Alias smiled.

"That sounds like a rule."

"It is advice."

"That is worse," Rowan said.

Eldric gave him an amused look.

Only Varux had not moved.

The older Alias sat with his hands folded in his lap. He looked at the gifts spread across the table: the blank journal page, the half-finished map, the little gull whistle, the tea tin.

Then he reached into his coat.

Alias expected another letter.

Instead, Varux pulled out a small square of folded paper.

The edges were worn. It had been folded and unfolded so many times that the center had almost torn.

"I did not know what to bring you," Varux said.

Alias looked at the paper.

"You do not have to bring me anything."

"I know." Varux breathed out. "But I wanted to."

That was different.

He held the paper out.

"I wrote this on the day I turned twenty. I was alone then. I did not know I was writing it for you."

Alias took it carefully.

The handwriting was younger than Varux's current hand. Uneven. Pressed too hard into the page.

He opened it.

It contained only three lines.

Come home before you can explain everything.

Ask someone to walk with you before the road gets quiet.

Do not wait until you feel worthy of being celebrated.

Alias read the words once.

Then again.

His chest hurt.

"You wrote this?"

"I wrote it because the Paper would not stop asking what I wanted to tell myself." Varux gave a thin smile. "I did not listen."

"You listened enough to write it down."

Varux looked at him.

"Maybe."

Alias folded the paper carefully and placed it inside the shared journal, on the blank page for Year Twenty.

"I am listening," he said.

The older version's eyes filled.

He looked away before anyone could say anything about it.

Gerhardt did not give Alias an object.

He walked to the kitchen and returned with a large flat moonbread, still warm from the oven.

Twenty candles had been pressed into it at uneven angles.

"I made this for your first birthday after your parents left you with us," he said.

The whole room became quiet.

Alias looked at the bread.

"You made this then?"

"A version of it. You were too small to eat more than a bite. You got honey in your fur and cried when Rowan - a younger Rowan, still somehow just as loud - tried to blow out the candles before you could see them."

Rowan sat up. "I did not do that."

Gerhardt looked at him. "You did."

"I was a child."

"So was Alias. That was the problem."

A laugh escaped Alias before he could stop it.

Gerhardt set the moonbread in front of him.

"You do not need to make a wish," he said. "You have had enough things asking something from you. Just blow out the candles before the wax reaches the bread."

Alias looked around the table.

At his friends.

At Gerhardt.

At Varux.

The future version of him had spent so many birthdays walking east, telling himself that he would celebrate when he had become someone better. The present version had nearly spent this one the same way: staring at letters, turning every unknown into a road he had to chase immediately.

But the bread was warm.

The candles burned low.  
And nobody was asking him to prove he belonged at the table.  
Alias blew them out.  
The room filled with a thin curl of smoke and a loud, uneven cheer.  
Rowan clapped first. Corvin clapped because Rowan was looking at him. Maris laughed. Eldric raised his tea cup. Gerhardt nodded once, satisfied.  
Varux did not clap.  
He placed one hand over his heart.  
That was enough.  
After breakfast, the tavern opened again.  
Gerhardt removed the sign from the door and told Rowan to stop hovering near it in case someone brought pie. Customers drifted in from the harbor: fishers smelling of salt, a dockworker with a broken boot strap, two women arguing quietly over a basket of mussels.  
No one made a scene when they saw Alias's paper crown.  
That was worse.  
A few people smiled. One older woman told him it suited him. Rowan nearly fell out of his chair laughing.  
Varux stayed upstairs for a while.  
Alias knew because he had seen him pause at the stair with the old coat pulled around him, then disappear into the blue-painted hall.  
He wanted to follow.  
He did not.  
Sometimes staying meant letting someone have a room to breathe in.  
Instead, he helped Gerhardt carry clean bowls from the kitchen. He sliced bread. He learned that Gerhardt's knife was sharper than it looked and that chopped onions made his eyes water even when he was determined not to let them.  
"You cut those like you are apologizing to them," Gerhardt said.  
"They are onions."  
"That is no reason to be cruel."  
Alias tried again.  
By midday, the tavern had returned to its usual noise.  
Then the front door opened.  
Varux stood in the doorway.  
He had changed nothing. The old coat remained on his shoulders. The scar remained on his cheek. The years had not vanished.  
But he had come downstairs.  
Gerhardt was wiping the counter.  
He looked up.  
For a second, neither man spoke.

Then Varux walked to the counter and placed the unread letter from Gerhardt on the wood between them.

"I want to read it," he said.

Gerhardt's hand stopped moving.

"Now?"

"Not alone."

The tavern quieted in small pieces. Not entirely. People still breathed, cups still moved. But the group at the long table stopped talking.

Gerhardt looked at the letter.

Then at Varux.

"All right," he said.

They did not read it in front of everyone.

Gerhardt led them to the back room, where the afternoon light fell across the old harbor map.

Alias, Maris, Corvin, Rowan, Eldric, and Varux gathered around the small table.

Gerhardt opened the letter slowly.

The words inside were his own, written five years ago.

He read them aloud.

"Varux, or Alias, or whoever you are when you are too tired to answer: you are welcome here.

You do not need to bring a story that makes sense. You do not need to swear you will stay forever. You can come in, eat, sleep, and leave in the morning if that is all you can manage. But come in. That is the part that matters."

Varux closed his eyes.

Gerhardt continued.

"I will not pretend I am not angry. I will not pretend the people who care about you are not hurt.

But hurt is not the same as locked. The door is here. Knock when you are ready."

The letter ended there.

No great answer.

No forgiveness pressed into a page.

Only a door.

Varux sat very still.

Then he said, "I am sorry I did not knock sooner."

Gerhardt looked at him.

"I know," he said.

It was not the same as saying all was forgiven.

It was not meant to be.

But Gerhardt reached across the table and placed one hand over Varux's.

"You knocked today," he said.

Varux's fingers curled beneath his hand.

For a while, no one spoke.

Then Rowan cleared his throat.



"I am still hungry."

Maris gave him a look.

"What?" Rowan said. "I am emotional and hungry. Both things can be true."

Gerhardt stood up.

"That may be the wisest thing anyone has said all day."

The moment loosened.

Not disappeared.

Just loosened enough for everyone to breathe again.

That evening, Alias went down to the harbor with the small gull whistle in his pocket.

The sky was turning violet over the sea. Boats knocked softly against the docks. Lanterns began to appear in windows along the waterfront.

He did not mean to be alone.

But Varux found him anyway.

The older Alias stood at the end of the dock, looking over the water. The old coat moved in the sea wind.

"Happy birthday," Varux said again.

Alias smiled. "You already said that."

"I did." He hesitated. "I wanted to say it while you were awake."

Alias leaned against one of the posts.

"Did anyone say it to you when you turned twenty?"

Varux looked out across the harbor.

"I do not remember."

The answer felt sad in a way Alias did not want to touch too quickly.

"Then I will say it," he said.

Varux glanced over.

"What?"

"Happy twentieth birthday. Late."

The older version stared at him.

Alias shrugged. "You had one. It counts."

Varux laughed once, quietly.

"That is not how time works."

"You are the one who keeps appearing with a second coin. Do not lecture me about time."

For a moment, Varux looked lighter.

Then the Paper rustled in Alias's pack.

He opened it.

Blue words appeared.  
TOMORROW, ASK WHAT THE MOON SAW.  
Alias read the line.  
Varux saw it over his shoulder.  
"The moon?" he asked.  
"Apparently."  
The harbor water caught the first pale reflection of moonlight.  
Alias folded the Paper closed.  
Tomorrow could hold letters, questions, and roads east.  
Tonight held the dock, the sea, the tavern lights behind them, and a birthday he had not had to  
earn.  
He stood beside Varux until the lamps came on across Maanhaven.  
Neither of them went anywhere.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 31

### Moonlit Secrets

#### *Shared Journal Entry 444*

*"The moon did not tell us where to go. It only showed us the things that had been waiting in the dark."*

The next morning, the Paper would not stop glowing.

Alias found it beneath his pillow before the tavern had properly woken. Blue light seeped through the folded pages and painted thin lines across the wall of the room he shared with Rowan. Rain tapped softly against the window. Somewhere below, Gerhardt was moving pans across the kitchen stove with the determined noise of someone who had already decided everyone else was late.

Alias unfolded the Paper.

The message from the harbor the night before had vanished. In its place, new blue words appeared.

ASK WHAT THE MOON SAW.

He read them once.

Then again.

From the other bed, Rowan made an unhappy sound into his blanket.

"Is it morning already?"

"Probably."

"That is not the question I asked."

"The Paper wrote something."

Rowan rolled over immediately. "That is worse than morning. What did it say?"

Alias held up the page.

Rowan squinted at the words.

"Ask what the moon saw," he read. "That is poetic, mysterious, and not useful before breakfast."

"It might mean the harbor."

"Everything in this town smells like the harbor. That does not narrow it down."

Alias folded the Paper again, but the blue glow remained visible through the crease.

"It means something," he said.

Rowan sat up and rubbed at his eyes. "Then we ask someone who has lived here longer than one night. Ideally someone who owns bread."

That was how they went downstairs.

Gerhardt was already at the long table with a ledger open in front of him.

He looked up when Alias entered, took in the glowing Paper, and did not seem surprised.

"That looks like trouble," he said.

"It might be a clue," Alias replied.

"That is what trouble calls itself when it wants breakfast."

Rowan slid into a chair. "I have always agreed with him."

Gerhardt ignored that and set two bowls of oat porridge on the table. Maris, Corvin, Eldric, and Varux joined them one by one. Varux wore the old coat again. Its cuffs were still too short, but he had brushed the dust from it, and the faded blue thread inside the collar showed when he moved.

Alias placed the Paper beside the bread.

"It says, 'Ask what the moon saw,'" he said.

Gerhardt stopped with one hand on the tea kettle.

For a second, the only sound in the room was the harbor gulls outside.

"Where did you get that?" he asked.

"The Paper wrote it."

"Yes, I can see that." Gerhardt set the kettle down more carefully than usual. "I meant why now."

Alias looked at him. "You know what it means."

Gerhardt did not answer immediately.

Varux's attention sharpened. "You know something about the moon?"

Gerhardt glanced from the older Alias to the younger one. He looked tired in the way he had looked the night before, as if a piece of the past had walked back through his door and started asking questions before he had finished washing the dishes.

"Your parents told me a phrase," he said at last. "Years ago. The night before they left Maanhaven."

Alias stopped breathing.

Gerhardt continued.

"They said that if you ever came home asking about what happened to them, I should not hand you a map. I should ask what the moon saw."

Rowan set down his spoon.

"And you did not mention this yesterday?"

Gerhardt looked at him. "Yesterday a man arrived carrying eighteen years of silence and a second version of my regular customer. I had priorities."

Rowan considered that. "Fair."

Alias leaned forward. "What does it mean?"

Gerhardt looked toward the harbor window.

"It means there is something they left under the old moonwall.

The moonwall stood at the far edge of the harbor.

It was not much of a wall now. Most of Maanhaven's sea defenses had been rebuilt over the years, but a low stretch of pale stone still curved around the oldest docks. At night, moonlight struck the seawater there before reaching any other part of the bay. The harbor workers called it the moonwall because it made even an ordinary high tide look silver.

Gerhardt led them there after breakfast.

The morning sky was grey, but the clouds were thinning. Fishermen moved around them with nets over their shoulders. A pair of children raced along the dock with wooden toy boats. The

ordinary noise of the harbor seemed too loud for the secret Gerhardt had just given them.

At the end of the old wall, he stopped beside a stone marked with a carved crescent.

"Your parents came here after midnight," he said. "Your mother had you wrapped in that blue blanket. Your father kept looking at the tide like he expected the sea to answer him."

Alias tried to picture it.

His mother with her blue scarf. His father with a map. A smaller version of himself asleep against one of them.

"What did they leave?" he asked.

"A box." Gerhardt pointed at the crescent stone. "They put it in the tide niche beneath that mark. They told me not to touch it unless you asked the right question. I did not know what the right question would be. I only knew it had something to do with the moon."

Corvin crouched beside the stone. "There is a seam."

The crescent mark ran deeper than the others on the wall. He pressed against it, then traced the edge with his knife. A narrow section of stone shifted inward with a low scrape.

Behind it was a dark compartment.

A small wooden box rested inside.

It had been wrapped in oilcloth and tied with blue thread.

Maris inhaled sharply.

"The same thread," she said.

Alias did not touch the box.

Neither did Varux.

Gerhardt looked at him. "It is yours."

Alias shook his head.

"It is ours," he said.

He looked at the group. No one argued.

Then he reached into his shirt and took out the Reader coin.

The coin warmed in his palm.

The wooden box did not open when he touched it. It did not open when Corvin tried the brass key from the tower. It did not open when Maris held the shared journal against the lid.

Varux had not moved.

Alias looked at him.

"Your coin."

The older Alias's hand went to the chain at his neck.

For a moment, fear crossed his face.

"What if it does not want me here?"

Alias looked at the box.

"Then it is wrong."

The words came out before he had time to doubt them.

Varux stared at him.

Then he removed the older coin from beneath his coat.

The two coins looked almost alike. Alias's was brighter around the edges, though scratched from travel. Varux's was darker and worn smooth in places where years of nervous fingers had touched it.

They placed both coins on the lid.

The blue thread untied itself.

The box opened.

Inside lay a folded square of cloth, a small piece of pale glass, and a sealed letter.

The cloth was blue.

Not a blanket. Only a corner of one, cut carefully along the edge and stitched so it would not fray.

Alias touched it first.

The fabric was soft with age.

His mother had wrapped him in a blue blanket.

He knew that from the tower. He knew it from Gerhardt. He knew it from the ache in his chest.

But this was not a story anymore.

This had been against his skin.

The small glass piece lay beneath the cloth. It was round and cloudy, like a drop of moonlight trapped in stone. A crescent had been etched into it.

Maris lifted it carefully.

"Moonglass," Gerhardt said. "Old harbor glass. It shows ink that ordinary light cannot."

The sealed letter had no name on the front.

Only one line.

READ UNDER THE MOON.

Rowan looked up at the daylight sky.

"That is inconvenient."

"It is barely noon," Corvin said.

"Exactly. We have to wait an entire day."

"You can survive an afternoon."

"I have done it before, but I would not recommend it."

They returned to the tavern with the box wrapped in Gerhardt's old cloth. Alias carried the blue blanket corner inside his jacket. He did not want to put it down. He was not ready to decide what it meant.

The day moved slowly.



Gerhardt gave everyone jobs.

He told Rowan to carry empty crates from the kitchen to the back storeroom. Rowan complained that this was unfair labor for a birthday week. Gerhardt told him he could complain while lifting.

Corvin repaired a loose table leg because he had noticed it wobbling. Maris copied the crescent mark from the moonglass into the shared journal. Eldric spoke quietly with a harbor woman who had recognized him from years ago.

Alias helped in the kitchen again.

He sliced onions more carefully this time.

Gerhardt watched him for a while.

"Better," he said.

"I am not apologizing to them anymore."

"That is progress."

Alias set the knife down.

"Why did you keep the box all this time?"

Gerhardt paused beside the stove.

"Because they asked me to."

"That is not all."

The tavern keeper looked at him.

Alias had learned something at the tower. Sometimes people gave the first true answer because it was easier than giving the whole one.

Gerhardt sighed.

"Because I was afraid," he said. "Your parents trusted me with you and with that box. I thought if I opened it without them, I would be taking something that did not belong to me. And when you got old enough to ask questions, I kept waiting for the right moment."

"There was not one."

"No." Gerhardt stirred the pot. "There rarely is."

Alias understood that more than he wanted to.

"Do you regret it?" he asked.

Gerhardt looked toward the harbor window.

"I regret that you had to learn so much from old rooms and roads before I told you what I knew.  
But regret does not turn a choice into another choice."

The words sounded like something Eldric would say.

Gerhardt noticed his expression.

"Do not tell him I said that. He will become unbearable."

Alias smiled.

"I will keep it secret."

"Good. We have enough secrets for one day.

At sunset, the group went back to the moonwall.

The harbor was quieter now. Most boats had returned. Lamps glowed along the docks, their reflections breaking across the water. The tide had risen, pressing gently against the old pale stone.

The moon appeared above the hills before the sky was fully dark.

It was nearly full.

Alias stood beside the crescent mark with the letter in his hands.

The Paper rested open beside him. It had said nothing all afternoon.

When moonlight reached the water, the moonglass began to shine.

Maris held it over the sealed letter.

The ordinary ink disappeared.

New writing emerged beneath it in pale blue lines.

Alias read aloud.

"For the night our child asks what the moon saw."

He stopped.

The next words were written in two hands.

One was his mother's. One was his father's.

He continued.

"The moon saw us leaving, and it saw how hard we tried not to. It saw two people who believed one dangerous road was better than bringing danger to the person we loved most."

The harbor wind moved through his hair.

"We do not know whether this choice will look brave or foolish from the years ahead. It may be both. But know this: we did not leave you because we wanted a life without you. We left because we believed the passage east would open toward Maanhaven if no one closed it from the other side."

Varux stood very still beside him.

Alias read the next lines more quietly.

"If we fail to return, do not spend your life proving you were worth coming back for. You were worth it before you could speak. You were worth it before you were born."

The words blurred.

Maris took the letter when his hands began to shake.

She read the final paragraph.

"The road east will always be there. It may call you. It may offer answers in exchange for everything else. Go only when you can name what you are returning for. Go only with people who will remind you that a road is not the same as a home."

There was one final line at the bottom.

"And when you reach the split gate, show them the moon."

The blue writing faded slowly.

No one spoke for a long time.

The moon reflected across the water. It touched the old wall, the crescent carving, the box at their feet. It made the harbor look almost unreal.

Alias stared at the letter.

His parents had known the road might call him.

They had known answers could become a kind of hunger.

They had not told him to stay away from east forever.

They had told him to remember what he was returning for.

Varux looked at the paper.

"The split gate," he said.

Corvin unfolded his old tower map. He pointed to the eastern mark that looked like a circle divided in two.

"This symbol," he said. "The gate M marked."

Maris held the moonglass over the map.

Under the moonlight, a new line appeared beneath the symbol.

WESTERN MOON. EASTERN THRESHOLD.

Eldric read it once.

"A gate that can only be opened from both sides," he said.

"Or a road that must be understood from both directions," Maris replied.

Rowan looked at the moon, then at the map.

"I dislike both of those possibilities."

"That is because they sound like work," Corvin said.

"They sound like towers.

Varux reached into his coat pocket and removed the old letter from Maris.

He did not open it. He had read it already. He did not need to.

"I came to this wall once," he said.

Alias turned toward him.

"When?"

"Five years ago. After Ravencross. I stood here at night and saw a blue reflection in the water."  
He looked down at the crescent stone. "I thought it was the coin warning me to keep away."

"You did not ask Gerhardt," Alias said.

"No."

"Why?"

Varux looked at the moon.

"Because I was afraid the answer would tell me I had another reason to go east. And I was afraid  
it would tell me I had a reason to stay."

The honesty hurt.

It also made sense.

Alias thought about the road west. The tavern. His parents' letter. The split gate waiting  
somewhere beyond maps.

"What do you want now?" he asked.

Varux looked surprised.

Then he answered carefully.

"I want to know what happened to them. I want to see the gate. I want to go east." He looked back  
at the harbor lights. "But I want to stay long enough that leaving is not another way of running."

Alias nodded.

"Me too."

The Paper finally wrote.

GOOD.

Rowan leaned over Alias's shoulder.

"That is all?"

A second line appeared.

STILL GOOD.

Rowan looked offended. "It has become smug."

"It was always smug," Maris said.

The blue letters faded.

The moonlight stayed.

They did not make a new plan that night.

That was important.

They had a map. They had a brass key. They had a message about the split gate and a road east.  
They had enough information to turn the next morning into another departure.

But they also had the tavern behind them.

Gerhardt had left a lantern burning in the window. Its warm gold light reached across the harbor,  
smaller than the moon and closer than the stars.

Eldric looked at it.

"A fire waits," he said.

Rowan looked immediately interested. "Is there food with the fire?"

"Probably."

"Then this is clearly the correct direction."

Corvin folded the map.

"Tomorrow, we can decide how long we stay."

Maris tucked the moonglass and the letter into the shared journal.

"Tomorrow," she agreed.

Varux looked at Alias.

"Tomorrow," he said.

Alias looked once more at the moonwall.

The moon had seen his parents leave.

It had seen Varux return and turn away.

It had seen a blue box wait beneath a stone for years.

Tonight it saw six people choose not to run.

That felt like a secret worth keeping.

Together, they walked back toward the tavern lights.

The road east remained beyond the horizon.

It was not gone.

But for one moonlit night, it could wait.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 32

### Shared Fires

#### *Shared Journal Entry 445*

*"A shared fire does not make the dark disappear. It only makes sure nobody has to sit in it alone."*

Gerhardt closed the tavern early that evening.

He did not announce it as a celebration.

He simply turned the sign on the front door from OPEN to BACK TOMORROW, bolted the shutters against the harbor wind, and told the six of them to stop hovering in the kitchen.

"The fire is ready," he said. "That means sit down before someone decides a difficult conversation is better standing up."

Rowan looked at the long table beneath the front window.

"Is that directed at anyone?"

"Yes," Gerhardt said.

"Which one?"

"All of you."

The room had changed since breakfast.

The shutters made the tavern feel smaller, but the fire made it warmer. Orange light moved across the dark wooden walls and the nets hanging above the counter. The harbor could still be heard beyond the glass: tide against the docks, a gull complaining somewhere in the dark, ropes knocking softly against boat masts.

Gerhardt had set six chairs around the hearth instead of the long table.

No bowls waited there.

No maps.

No blue letters from the Paper.

Only a kettle, six plain mugs, and a wide iron pan full of chestnuts roasting over the coals.

Alias stopped in the doorway.

"What are we doing?" he asked.

Gerhardt looked at the fire.

"Sharing one."



Rowan leaned toward Corvin. "I thought shared fires were usually for people who sing badly."

"You are thinking of a different kind of tavern," Gerhardt replied.

"There are different kinds?"

"More than one. Shocking, I know."

Varux stood at the edge of the room in the old coat. He had spent most of the afternoon near the harbor window, watching Maanhaven continue without asking him to explain where he had been.

Now he looked at the empty chair nearest the fire and did not move toward it.

Alias noticed.

Gerhardt noticed too.

"The chair has not changed its mind," he said.

Varux looked at him.

"About what?"

"About being a chair. Sit before I have to make you a stool."

A laugh escaped Rowan. It was loud enough to shake the quiet loose from the room.

Varux sat.

Alias took the chair beside him. Maris sat with the shared journal in her lap. Corvin chose the seat with the clearest view of both doors, which Alias thought was probably a habit rather than a decision. Eldric settled near the kettle. Rowan took the chair closest to the chestnuts before anyone else could.

Gerhardt poured tea.

For a while, no one said anything.

The silence was not uncomfortable. That was new too.

They had spent so much of the road filling silence with warnings, questions, arguments, and things they were afraid to name. Here, the fire gave the quiet somewhere to go. It crackled. The kettle breathed steam. Chestnut shells split softly in the pan.

At last, Gerhardt said, "This tavern keeps a shared fire for travelers who need one."

Rowan looked up. "That sounds generous."

"It is practical. People who have been on the road too long make foolish choices after dark."

"That also sounds familiar."

Gerhardt ignored him.

"The rule is simple. You do not ask a person to tell the whole story. You do not demand that they make their worst day easier to understand. You offer one true thing. Then someone else offers one."

Maris looked at the shared journal.

"A record," she said.

"A fire," Gerhardt corrected. "The difference matters. A record keeps what happened. A fire keeps people while it is happening."

Eldric nodded slowly.

"Well said."

Gerhardt gave him a suspicious look. "Do not tell anyone I said something wise. I have a reputation."

Rowan held out his mug. "I will write it down in great detail."

"You will do no such thing."

The Paper rustled from inside Alias's pack.

Blue light shone through the folded cloth.

Alias took it out and opened it.

One sentence appeared.

KEEP THE FIRE.

Rowan leaned over to read it.

"That is almost helpful."

A second line formed beneath the first.

NOT FOREVER. JUST TONIGHT.

Rowan sat back.

"It is getting better at timing."

"It is getting smugger," Maris said.

"Both may be true," Alias replied.

Varux looked at him.

For a moment, the older version smiled.

Then Gerhardt placed a chestnut in the center of the small stone hearth ledge.

"One true thing," he said. "I will begin, because I own the building and this is my fire."

He folded his hands over his knees.

"When Alias's parents came here, I thought they were too young to be as tired as they were. Your mother had blue thread in her hair. Your father kept checking his map even while he ate. They told me they would return in a week."

Alias looked down at the flame.

Gerhardt continued.

"I believed them. Not because they sounded certain. Because I wanted them to be right."

The tavern keeper picked up the chestnut, turned it once between his fingers, and placed it back.

"That is my true thing. Sometimes wanting a promise to be true is not the same as knowing it will be."

No one tried to comfort him.

That seemed to be part of the rule too.

Eldric reached for a chestnut next.

"I once spent three years teaching a young mage to make light without fire," he said. "He was impatient. He wanted it quickly. Every time he failed, he made the room darker by being angry at himself."

Rowan looked thoughtful. "That sounds exhausting."

"He was."

"What happened to him?"

Eldric's eyes reflected the fire.

"Eventually, he learned that light is not a reward for being calm. It is something you make by staying with the work long enough to see the first spark."

Varux glanced at him.

"Were you the young mage?" he asked.

Eldric smiled.

"No. I was the teacher. I made the mistake of thinking I had to solve his anger before I could teach him."

He let the answer rest there.

"That is my true thing," he said. "People are not projects. You can walk beside them. You cannot walk for them."

Corvin took the next chestnut.

He looked unhappy about it.

"I do not have a story about magic," he said.

"Good," Rowan replied. "We have enough magic."

Corvin held the chestnut above the fire for a moment.

"When I was younger, I made maps because I did not like being surprised. If a road was written down, I thought it could not betray me. If I knew where every river turned and every hill ended, then nobody could get lost."

Maris watched him quietly.

"Then my brother took a road I had mapped for him," Corvin said. "It was safe. The map was correct. But he left in winter because he did not tell anyone he was sick. The map could not show that."

The fire popped.

Alias felt Rowan go still in the chair beside him.

"I spent years making better maps," Corvin continued. "I thought accuracy would protect everyone. It helps. It matters. But it cannot replace asking a person whether they are all right."

He put the chestnut down.

"That is my true thing. A map can show you the road. It cannot tell you who is walking it alone."

No one spoke for a while.

Then Rowan took a chestnut before anyone could ask him to.

"I hate this rule," he said.

"You are doing very well," Maris replied.

"That is not comforting."

He turned the chestnut in his fingers.

"When I was little, I learned that people stop looking worried when you make them laugh. That is useful. I am good at it."

"You are," Alias said.

"Thank you. I will accept compliments now, because apparently this night is trying to ruin me."

The smile left Rowan's face.

"But sometimes I keep making jokes because I do not know what else I am supposed to do when someone is hurting. I keep thinking if I can make them laugh, I have helped. And if they do not laugh, I feel like I failed."

He looked at the fire rather than anyone else.

"That is my true thing. I do not always know how to sit with people when nothing is funny."

Maris reached across the small space between their chairs and tapped the back of his hand once.

"You are sitting here now," she said.

Rowan looked at her.

Then he nodded.

"Yes," he said. "I am."

Maris took the next chestnut.

For a moment, Alias expected her to speak about records or journals. Something sensible. Something that would help everyone organize their feelings into a useful shape.

Instead, she said, "I am afraid of forgetting something important."

The firelight caught in the blue cover of the shared journal.

"Not facts," she continued. "I can write facts down. I am afraid of forgetting how something felt. The way someone sounded when they were trying not to be afraid. The way a room looked before people left it. The stupid joke that made everyone laugh when nothing else could."

Her voice remained steady, but Alias could hear the effort in it.

"I thought recording things would save them. But I know it cannot save everything."

She looked at the journal in her lap.

"That is my true thing. Sometimes I write because I am afraid that if I stop, the people I love will become only a story."

Varux looked at the journal.

His hand touched the pocket of his old coat.

"You gave me that journal," he said.

Maris nodded.

"Yes."

"I thought it was proof that life continued without me."

"It was proof that we kept a place for you in it."

The fire settled lower.

Alias looked down at his own hands.

He knew his turn was coming.

Before anyone could ask him, Varux reached for the final chestnut.

His fingers shook when he held it.

"I have had many years to think of true things," he said. "Most of them were not true. Or they were only partly true, which can be worse."

No one interrupted.

"I told myself I left because I needed answers. That was true. I told myself I stayed away because I did not want to hurt anyone again. That was also true. But I used those truths like walls."

He looked at the old coat on his shoulders.

"I thought carrying guilt meant I cared. I thought being alone meant I was protecting people. I thought returning without answers would make my absence worse."

His voice became quiet.

"The truth is that I was afraid to find out whether anyone could still want me."

Alias felt the sentence in his chest.

Varux put the chestnut down without eating it.

"That is my true thing. I spent too long treating love like a door I had to earn the right to open."

Gerhardt looked at him from across the fire.

"And now?"

Varux took a breath.

"Now I am trying to knock."

No one spoke.

The harbor wind tapped at the shutters.

Then Gerhardt stood, crossed the room, and placed one hand on Varux's shoulder.

It was not a dramatic gesture.

It was only a hand.

But Varux covered it with his own.

Alias's throat tightened.

The final chestnut sat beside the fire.

Everyone looked at him.

"I know," Alias said.

Rowan leaned back. "We did not say anything."

"You all looked at me."

"That is fair."

Alias picked up the chestnut.

The shell was warm. He held it in both hands and thought of the tower, the moonwall, the blue blanket corner folded in the shared journal, the letter his parents had left without being able to promise they would return.

"I thought the most important thing about me was that I had been left," he said.

The words sounded different when spoken aloud.

More fragile.

"I thought every answer about my parents would tell me who I was. And I still want to know what happened to them. I still want to go east."

He looked at the fire.

"But I do not want their road to be the only thing I inherit."

Maris's hand tightened around the journal.

"That is my true thing," Alias continued. "I am scared that if I stop chasing them, it means I did not love them enough. But I think I can love them and still stay here tonight."

The Paper unfolded in his lap.

Blue letters appeared.

CORRECT.

Rowan looked at it.

"It has no manners."

A second line formed.

STILL CORRECT.

This time, they all laughed.

Even Varux.

The sound rose into the dark wooden room and stayed there a little while.

Gerhardt moved the kettle from the coals. He brought out more mugs. He did not insist on more true things. The rule had done its work.

They sat by the fire long after the chestnuts were gone.

Rowan told a story about falling into a canal while trying to impress a merchant's daughter. Corvin corrected every detail until the story became less impressive and much funnier. Maris read one harmless entry from the shared journal about Rowan arguing with a goat. Eldric admitted that he had once accidentally turned his own boots blue for an entire month.

"Why did you not fix it?" Alias asked.

"I could not," Eldric said.

Rowan's eyes widened. "You were stuck with blue boots?"

"Yes."

"That is incredible."

"It was humiliating."

"It can be both."

Later, Gerhardt brought out a small bottle of berry syrup and poured a little into everyone's tea. He said it was too sweet and he had only bought it because a traveling seller had been persuasive.

Rowan declared it perfect. Corvin said it tasted like a candle. Maris drank hers anyway.

Varux did not leave the fire.

Alias noticed that more than once.



Each time the room grew quiet, the older version looked toward the door. Each time, he looked back at the chairs around him and stayed.

Near midnight, the fire had burned down to red coals.

The tavern seemed softer around the edges. The maps remained folded. The eastern road remained beyond the horizon. The brass key waited safely in Corvin's case. The moonglass rested inside the shared journal.

None of it had disappeared.

It simply was not the only thing in the room.

Maris opened the journal one last time.

"One sentence each," she said.

Rowan groaned. "Again?"

"Not a true thing. A thing we keep."

That sounded easier.

Gerhardt went first.

"A warm meal before an argument," he said.

Eldric smiled. "Tea before the question."

Corvin thought for a moment.

"A return route."

Rowan said, "A whistle that someone answers."

Maris looked at the shared journal.

"A page with room left on it."

Varux's hand rested on the old coat.

"A chair that stayed empty until I was ready to sit in it."

Everyone looked at Alias.

He watched the last red light in the coals.

"A fire shared with people who know I want to leave sometimes," he said. "And who remind me I can come back."

The Paper wrote one final line.

KEEP THIS.

Alias folded it carefully.

Not because he was afraid it would vanish.

Because some things deserved to be carried.

When they finally went upstairs, the fire was still warm behind them.

It would be cold by morning.

That was all right.

They had shared it while it lasted.

And when the road called again, they would remember that warmth was something people made together.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 33

### Things Worth Keeping *Shared Journal Entry 446*

*"Keeping something is not the same as holding it so tightly that it cannot change. Sometimes it means knowing where to put it until you are ready to carry it again."*

The morning after the shared fire, Gerhardt placed a wooden box on the long table and told everyone not to touch it yet.

The box was not large. It was the kind of thing a traveler might use for spare buttons, a deck of cards, or a small amount of money they did not trust in their pocket. Its wood was dark with age, and the lid had been repaired along one edge with a strip of brass.

Rowan arrived downstairs first and immediately reached for it.

Gerhardt struck his knuckles lightly with a wooden spoon.

"Not yet," Rowan said, rubbing his hand.

"Correct.

"You did not tell me there was a rule.

"I am telling you now.

Rowan looked at the spoon. "You enjoy this too much.

"I own a tavern. I have earned small pleasures.

Alias came down with the Paper folded in his pocket, the little gull whistle tied to the strap of his bag, and his parents' letter tucked inside the shared journal where Maris had placed it the night before. The moonglass lay safely between two blank pages. The blue blanket corner had spent the night beneath his pillow.

He was not sure whether that was sensible.

He was also not ready to put it anywhere else.

Varux entered last. He wore the old coat again. The repaired sleeves were still too short, but he had fixed the loosened seams neatly with dark thread. The coat no longer looked like a costume from another life. It looked worn in. Not comfortable, perhaps. But chosen.

Gerhardt looked around the table.

"Good. Everyone is here.

"Except the customers," Rowan said.

"They have survived one closed morning before.

"Why is the tavern closed?" Maris asked.

Gerhardt rested one hand on the wooden box.

"Because a group of people has spent three days talking about roads, gates, letters, and future journeys while pretending they are not preparing to leave again.

The room became quieter.

Corvin adjusted the folded map beside his cup.

"We are not leaving today," he said.

"I did not say you were.

"You implied it.

"I own a tavern. Implying things is part of the work.

Rowan leaned toward Alias. "I knew he had a secret profession.

Gerhardt ignored him.

"The road will call again. It always does. Before it does, you should decide what belongs in your packs, what belongs here, and what you are only carrying because you are afraid to set it down.

Alias looked at the small box.

"What is that?" he asked.

"The things people leave behind.

Gerhardt lifted the lid.

*A brass button with a missing coat.*

*Three keys that opened nothing anyone remembered.*

*A red ribbon, faded almost pink.*

*A tiny wooden horse with one wheel.*

*A folded recipe for onion soup.*

*A note that said only: Back before dark.*

The box was fuller than Alias expected. None of the things looked important. That seemed to be the point.

"People leave treasures too," Gerhardt said. "But those are easier. A treasure tells you it matters. The difficult things are the ones that look ordinary until someone comes back asking for them.

Varux looked at the note near the bottom of the box.

"Did they come back?" he asked.

Gerhardt looked at the words.

"I do not know.

The honesty did not feel cruel. It felt like the kind of thing the tavern had learned from keeping its door open for people who might never use it again.

Maris set the shared journal on the table.

"What do we do?" she asked.

"Three piles," Gerhardt said. "Things you carry. Things you leave waiting. Things you share.

Rowan looked relieved. "Finally, a task with categories.

"You are still not touching the box without asking.

"I am learning.

"Slowly.

They cleared the table.

Corvin spread one of his maps at the center. Maris brought the shared journal closer. Gerhardt placed three empty bowls in a row along the blue tablecloth.

CARRY.

WAIT.

SHARE.

The words were written on small paper slips, but Alias read them as though they had been carved into stone.

He reached for the first thing near him: the blue blanket corner.

It was soft and frayed, folded into a square small enough to fit in his palm. His mother had wrapped him in the larger blanket when she and his father left him at the western gate. He knew that now. He knew they had loved him.

He still did not know where they had gone.

"Carry," he said.

He placed it in the first bowl.

No one questioned it.

The moonglass came next.

Alias held it to the light. In daylight, it looked like a pale round of cloudy harbor glass. At night, it revealed the ink beneath ordinary words. It had given him his parents' letter. It had shown him the split gate on Corvin's map.

He wanted to carry it too.

But something in him resisted.

"Wait," he said.

Maris looked at him.

"Why?"

"Because every time I touch it, I start thinking the next answer is hiding somewhere else.

The words surprised him. They were true anyway.

Gerhardt nodded once.

"Then it waits here until you choose a reason to take it.

Maris wrapped the moonglass in a square of blue cloth and placed it in the second bowl.

Alias felt the pull in his chest loosen slightly.

Not gone. Just set down.

Rowan put his wooden gull whistle in the carry bowl before anyone could stop him.

"That is mine," Alias said.

"Exactly. Carry it.

"I was already carrying it.

"Then you are doing this part correctly.

The red thread tied to the whistle caught the morning light. Alias touched it, then left it there.

Corvin placed his newest map in the share bowl.

"Not carry?" Maris asked.

"I will make copies," Corvin said. "One stays here. One goes with us. A map is less useful when only one person knows where it is.

Gerhardt looked approvingly at that.

"A return route," he said.

Corvin nodded.

"A return route.

Eldric placed his tea tin in the share bowl as well.

"That seems impractical," Rowan said.

"It contains enough tea for six people and enough patience for none of you," Eldric said. "It can be refilled at either end of a journey.

"That is almost poetic.

"Do not tell anyone.

Maris chose the shared journal last.

She rested both hands on its blue cover.

"Share," she said.

"It is already shared," Rowan said.

"Yes. But I mean something else.

She opened it to the page marked Year Twenty. Under Alias's list of things he had not known he would keep, she wrote another heading.

*Things we will not make one person carry alone.*

Below the heading, she left six blank lines.

"One each," she said.

"This feels like another feelings exercise," Rowan said.

"It is another feelings exercise," Maris replied.

"I knew it.

Varux had not put anything in a bowl.

He stood at the end of the table with one hand in the pocket of his old coat. Alias knew what was there: the letter from Maris, the copy of Gerhardt's letter, the small page Varux had written at twenty and carried for years.

Things he had kept alone.

"What about you?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at the bowls.

"I do not know.

"That is all right," Eldric said.

"No." Varux's voice was quiet. "It is not all right. I have spent years knowing exactly what I could not put down.

He reached into his coat and pulled out a small folded card.

The paper was stiff at the edges. On the front, in dark ink, was a name.

VARUX HYBOREA.

Rowan looked at it.

"Your false name card?

"A room ledger card," Varux said. "Ravencross. I used it when I rented my room.

"You kept that?

"I kept many things I told myself did not matter.

He turned the card over. The back was blank.

"I thought I should burn it," he said.

Alias looked at the name.

It was the name Varux had used when he did not think he deserved his own. The name he had hidden behind. The name that had become real enough that he had said, Alias, called Varux.

"Do you still want to burn it?" Alias asked.

Varux considered.

"No.

"Then do not," Gerhardt said. "You do not have to destroy every road you survived.

Varux nodded slowly.

He took the pencil from Maris's journal and wrote beneath the old name.

ALIAS, CALLED VARUX.

The two names rested together on the card.

Not one replacing the other.

Not one winning.



"Share," Varux said.

He put the card in the third bowl.

For a moment, Alias did not understand.

Then Varux looked at him.

"I do not want either name to be a thing I hide alone anymore.

Alias felt something tighten behind his ribs.

Maris wrote the first line beneath her new heading.

Varux's name.

"What will you not carry alone?" she asked Corvin.

Corvin looked at the map.

"The responsibility for every route," he said.

Maris wrote it down.

Eldric said, "The names of people I could not save.

Rowan frowned at the table for a while before saying, "The idea that I have to fix every sad thing with a joke.

Maris wrote each one carefully.

Then she looked at Alias.

"Your turn.

Alias looked at the carry bowl. The blue blanket corner. The whistle. He looked at the wait bowl.

The moonglass wrapped in cloth. He looked at the share bowl. The map. The tea. The card bearing both of Varux's names. The shared journal.

"The answer about my parents," he said.

Maris's pencil paused.

"You will not carry the answer alone?

"I will not carry the need for it alone.

The words felt right when he said them.

Maris wrote them down.

Then she placed the pencil in front of herself.

"And I will not carry the memory of everyone alone," she said.

The journal page held all six lines.

It did not make them lighter.

But it made them visible.

Gerhardt closed the wooden box and set it at the far end of the table.

"This stays here," he said. "The moonglass stays with it. Corvin's duplicate map stays here. Anything else you need to leave waiting can go in it.

"Do you lock it?" Alias asked.

Gerhardt shook his head.

"No. If someone has to earn the right to open a box, they usually wait too long.

Varux looked down at the card in the share bowl.

"What if someone takes something?

"Then they needed it more than I knew.

The answer was so simple that Alias did not know what to do with it.

Gerhardt walked behind the counter and returned with a small iron key on a blue cord.

He placed it in front of Alias.

"What does this open?" Alias asked.

"The back door.

Alias blinked.

"The tavern's back door?

"Yes.

"Why would I need that?

Gerhardt folded his arms.

"Because front doors are for arriving when you feel ready to be seen. Back doors are for arriving tired, muddy, and uncertain whether you have the right words yet.

The key lay between them.

"You are giving me a key to your tavern," Alias said.

"I am giving you a way in.

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version had gone still.

Gerhardt saw it too.

"There is another key," he said.

He placed a second iron key beside the first.

Varux stared at it.

"I do not know if I should take that," he said.

Gerhardt's voice was calm.

"You do not have to use it today. But you do not need to earn the right to know it exists.

Varux picked up the key.

The blue cord was the same color as the thread in the old coat.

He closed his fingers around it.

"Carry," he said.

For the first time that morning, no one laughed.

They spent the rest of the day making copies.

Corvin drew a clean return map for the wooden box, marking Maanhaven, Ravencross, the Hall, the observatory, Hollow Creek, and the tower. He added the eastern symbol beyond the First Road in a thin outline, not a promise, only a place on the page.

Maris copied the moonwall letter into the shared journal and wrote beside it: We will go east only when we can name what we are returning for.

Eldric refilled the tea tin and put a second small packet beside it for Gerhardt. Rowan repaired the red thread on Alias's whistle when it began to fray, complaining loudly that delicate craftsmanship was not being appreciated.

Varux sat at the tavern counter with Gerhardt for a long time.

Alias did not hear all of their conversation. He only heard pieces.

"I should have written," Varux said.

"Yes," Gerhardt replied.

"I should have come back sooner.

"Also yes.

"You make that sound simple.

"It is simple. It is not easy.

Later, Varux took a blank tavern order slip and wrote a new note.

*Gone east when we are ready.*

*Going together.*

*Returning by choice, not by accident.*

*- Alias, called Varux, and the people walking with him*

He read it once, then passed it to Maris.

She looked at the names and handed the slip back without changing a word.

Gerhardt pinned it to the wall beside the kitchen door.

It hung there beneath the menu, the harbor notices, and an old drawing of a gull that Rowan had made badly years ago.

It was not a promise that nothing would go wrong.

It was not a promise that the road east would be kind.

It was only a promise that no one would have to wonder whether they had been left without a word.

As evening came, Alias stood near the back door with the new key resting in his palm.

Beyond the alley, Maanhaven moved through its ordinary evening. A boat horn sounded from the harbor. Someone laughed from the market road. The tavern kitchen smelled of onions and bread.

Varux joined him.

The older version held his own key on its blue cord.

"Are you going to use it?" Alias asked.

Varux looked at the locked back door.

"Not tonight.

"Why not?

"Because I am already inside.

Alias looked at him.

Varux smiled, a little embarrassed by the answer.

"It sounded better in my head," he said.

"No," Alias replied. "It was good.

The Paper stirred in Alias's pocket.

He unfolded it.

Blue ink appeared in one short line.

KEEP THE WAY IN.

Alias folded the Paper again.

Some things went in packs.

Some things waited in boxes.

Some things belonged to everyone at the table.

And some things were only a key, a note, or a place set by the fire.

But those were the things that made a road worth returning from.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 34

### The Last Evening

#### *Shared Journal Entry 447*

*"The last evening did not feel like an ending. It felt like putting a lamp in the window before you left for the road."*

Gerhardt announced their last evening in Maanhaven by throwing a spoon into the kitchen sink.

The noise made everyone in the tavern jump.

Rowan nearly dropped the loaf he had been trying to cut. Corvin looked up from the map he had been repairing for the third time that day. Maris paused with the shared journal open across her knees. Eldric stopped pouring tea. Alias, who had been helping carry clean mugs from the back room, turned toward the kitchen doorway.

Gerhardt stood there with his hands on his hips.

"Enough hovering," he said.

Rowan blinked. "We are sitting."

"You are hovering while sitting. It is a talent, and I do not approve of it."

"What did we do?"

Gerhardt pointed at the collection of packs, maps, folded papers, dried food, spare blankets, and walking sticks that had slowly taken over the tavern's long table.

"You are leaving in the morning."

The sentence landed more heavily than Alias expected.

No one had hidden the plan. They had talked about it all day. The road back to camp would take them away from Maanhaven, past the hills, past the old road markers, toward the place where their journey had begun before the tower, before Varux, before anyone knew a future could arrive carrying a second coin.

But talking about leaving and hearing it said aloud were not the same thing.

Gerhardt continued before anyone could answer.

"You are leaving in the morning, and that means tonight you eat something that has not been dried, folded, or packed in a cloth. You sit down. You do not discuss routes for at least one hour. And you do not turn a farewell into an argument because I am too old to win one."

Rowan looked offended. "You could win an argument."

"I know. I simply prefer not to waste my strength proving it."

Varux stood near the back door in the old coat.

The coat still did not fit. It never would. Its sleeves ended high at his wrists, and the shoulders pulled when he moved. But it had become part of him over the last few days. The grey cloak he used to wear was folded inside his pack. The old coat stayed on.

"We do not have to leave tomorrow," Varux said.

Gerhardt looked at him.

The room quieted.

The tavern owner crossed his arms.

"Are you saying that because you want to stay?"

Varux hesitated.

"Maybe."

"Or because you are afraid to leave?"

The older Alias looked down.

"Maybe that too."

Gerhardt nodded once.

"Then you should go."

Varux looked up.

"That is not unkindness," Gerhardt added. "You have spent enough years believing a room was only safe if you never stepped outside it. You are allowed to stay here. Your key works. Your chair stays where it is. But you are not going to make this tavern another place you hide."

Varux's expression tightened.

Gerhardt softened only a little.

"Leave because you choose a road with people. Return because you choose to. That is different from running."

The older Alias took a slow breath.

"Yes," he said.

Gerhardt picked up the spoon again.

"Good. Then help me peel vegetables."

Rowan's face lit up. "There are vegetables?"

"You are peeling them."

His face fell.

"This tavern is a cruel place."

"And yet you keep coming back."

By the time the sun lowered behind the harbor roofs, the long table had been cleared of maps.

Not packed away. Not forgotten. Corvin had rolled them carefully and tied them with green cord. Maris placed the moonglass and the copies of Alias's parents' letter inside the shared journal. The brass key from the tower went into Corvin's map case. The little gull whistle lay at the top of Alias's bag, red thread neatly repaired by Rowan.

They had made their preparations.

Now the table held bowls of stew, bread still warm from the oven, roasted onions, fried potatoes, and a dish of apples cooked with berry syrup.

Gerhardt had not made a grand meal.

That was what made it feel grand.

He served everyone before sitting down himself. The tavern was closed to customers. The shutters were open, letting in the last orange light from the harbor. A lamp burned beside the window. Its reflection trembled over the wood table.

Rowan lifted his spoon.

"To not discussing routes."

Corvin gave him a look.

"That is technically discussing the rule about routes."

"Then I am honoring the rule."

Maris smiled into her tea.

Eldric raised his cup.

"To the road tomorrow," he said. "And to the room waiting when we return."

Varux's hand rested on the blue cord of his key.

The small iron key Gerhardt had given him hung against the old coat. Alias had his own key too, tied with a short piece of blue thread. They had not talked much about them after receiving them.



The keys were simple things. They did not explain the past. They did not guarantee anything about the future.

They only said there would be a way in.

Alias raised his mug.

"To both."

They drank.

For the first few minutes, nobody knew what to say.

Then Rowan complained that Gerhardt had put too many onions in the stew.

Gerhardt told him he had put exactly enough onions in the stew.

Rowan said that was the problem.

The conversation became normal after that.

Corvin told a story about a mapmaker he had met years ago who had drawn a river in the wrong place because he had copied it from a map that copied it from a map that copied it from a rumor. Maris corrected him twice on the details and once on the word "years." Eldric explained that the mapmaker had probably been honest, which only made Rowan complain that honest mistakes were more annoying than dishonest ones.

Varux did not speak much at first.

But he listened.

Alias watched him from across the table. The older version had spent so much of the journey sitting slightly apart. At camp, he had stood outside the firelight. On the road, he had walked at the edge of the group. In Ravencross, he had taken the chair nearest the door. At the tower, he had seemed prepared to vanish into any room that opened.

Tonight he sat in the middle of the table.

Not at the end.

Not near the door.

In the middle.

Gerhardt noticed too.

He did not say anything about it.

That felt like kindness.

After dinner, Rowan produced a deck of cards from somewhere inside his coat.

"I brought these from the market," he said.

Corvin looked suspicious. "Did you pay for them?"

"The seller accepted a fair trade."

"What did you trade?"

"A compliment."

Maris put both hands over her face.

Gerhardt leaned back in his chair.

"Who was the seller?"

"A man with a hat."

"That narrows nothing down."

"It was a very good compliment."

They played anyway.

Alias did not understand the rules at first. Rowan explained them three times, changing at least one rule each time. Corvin accused him of inventing points. Rowan accused Corvin of being upset because strategy had failed him. Maris won the first game without visibly trying.

Varux lost badly.

"You are supposed to pay attention to the cards," Rowan told him.

"I was."

"Then you should have paid attention better."

Varux looked at the hand in front of him.

"I have been away from card games for a while."

"Twenty years?"

"Something like that."

Rowan grew quiet for half a breath.

Then he pushed the deck toward Varux.

"Good. You can lose for twenty more games and catch up."

Varux looked at him.

Then he smiled.

"That is generous."

"I am a generous winner."

"You lost the second game," Maris said.

"That was an example of generosity."

Outside, the tavern's old clock struck nine.

The sound reminded Alias of the first night Varux had returned to Maanhaven. The clock had struck midnight then. Alias had stood in the hallway with the older version of himself and listened to him say happy birthday as though he had been holding the words for years.

Now the room was full of people.

The clock did not feel lonely.

Later, Gerhardt carried the empty bowls into the kitchen and returned with a small wooden tray.

On it were six folded pieces of paper and six short pencils.

Rowan eyed them warily.

"This is either a game or a trap."

"It is neither," Gerhardt said. "Write something you are taking with you tomorrow."

"I have already packed."

"Not an object."

Rowan sighed.

"It is a trap."

Gerhardt placed a folded page in front of everyone.

"Write it down. Put it in your pack. Read it when you feel like leaving without saying anything."

Alias looked at the paper.

The request was simple.

That made it hard.

Maris began writing first. Her pencil moved steadily. Corvin wrote slowly, crossing out two lines before settling on a third. Eldric sat with the paper in front of him for a long time before he put down a few careful words.

Rowan looked at his blank page like it had personally insulted him.

Varux had not touched his pencil.

Alias did not ask why.

He looked down at his own paper.

What was he taking with him?

The answer could have been the moonglass. The gull whistle. The Reader coin. The letter from his parents. The map with the split gate marked far east.

But Gerhardt had said not an object.

He remembered the warm fire from the night before. Varux in the old coat. Maris's hand on his arm when the hidden book had shown him the letter. Rowan making jokes until nobody had to sit alone in a frightening silence. Corvin drawing a return route. Eldric saying he did not need to become careful enough that he never left.

At last, Alias wrote:

I can ask before I go.

He read it again.

Then folded the paper and placed it inside the pocket of his pack.

Across the table, Varux finally picked up his pencil.

He wrote more than anyone else.

When he finished, he did not fold the page immediately. He read it. Then he looked toward Gerhardt.

"Can I leave this here instead?" he asked.

Gerhardt looked at him.

"You can leave anything here."

Varux nodded.

He folded the paper and put it beneath the wooden tray.

No one asked what he had written.

Not because they did not want to know.

Because he had chosen where to leave it.

The last light disappeared from the harbor.

Gerhardt lit the lamps one by one. The tavern grew gold around them. Beyond the open shutters, Maanhaven moved through its evening: gulls arguing over scraps near the docks, a boat bell somewhere across the water, footsteps on the market road, voices drifting past the front door.

Normal sounds.

Alias had spent so much of the journey looking for signs. Blue writing. old marks. coins warming against his skin. Doors that opened only after someone admitted a truth.

Now he tried to listen to the ordinary things too.

A chair scraped across the floor.

A kettle began to whisper.

Gerhardt humming badly in the kitchen.

Home did not always make an announcement.

Sometimes it was only a room that stayed lit when the night came.

When the cards had been put away and the tray of folded notes cleared from the table, Varux stood.

Alias watched him.

The older version did not head for the door.

He walked to the wall beside the kitchen, where the note from the morning still hung.

Gone east when we are ready.

Going together.

Returning by choice, not by accident.

- Alias, called Varux, and the people walking with him

Varux read it for a long moment.

Then he took the charcoal from the small ledge beneath the note.

He added one line at the bottom.

Home first.

The room grew quiet.

Rowan looked at the words.

"That is good," he said.

Varux looked slightly embarrassed.

"It is not very clever."

"It does not have to be."

Maris stood beside him with the shared journal under one arm.

"It is clear," she said. "Clear is good."

Corvin nodded. "It is also a useful route note."

"Of course you would say that," Rowan said.

Eldric smiled.

"Some lessons remain useful because they are simple."

Alias looked at the note.

Home first.

The words did not mean never east.

They did not mean fear the road or stop asking questions or lock every map in a box.

They meant the road was not allowed to become an excuse again.

That was enough.

Near midnight, the group carried their packs upstairs.

The tavern rooms were small, but Gerhardt had made space for them. Corvin and Eldric took the room facing the harbor. Rowan had claimed the bed nearest the window in the room he shared with Alias. Maris had the little room at the end of the hall, with the shared journal on the bedside table and the moonglass safely wrapped in cloth beneath it.

Varux stood outside the room Gerhardt had given him five years ago.

The door was open.

Alias paused in the hallway.

The room had changed since the first night. It no longer looked abandoned. Gerhardt had repaired the shutter. A clean blanket lay on the bed. The old harbor picture was still on the wall. On the small table beneath it, Varux had placed the grey cloak he no longer wore.

The old coat remained on his shoulders.

"Are you all right?" Alias asked.

Varux looked into the room.

"I do not know."

The answer did not frighten Alias anymore.

"Do you want someone to stay?"

Varux looked at him.

For years, Alias thought, he would have said no immediately.

Tonight he considered it.

Then he shook his head.

"Not in the room."

Alias nodded.

"Okay."

Varux leaned against the doorframe.

"But will you be here in the morning?"

The question was quiet.

It was almost nothing.

It was everything.

Alias looked down the hall toward Rowan's half-open door, where a complaint about blankets was already beginning. He looked toward Maris's room, where blue light from the Paper's pages briefly shone beneath the door. He looked toward the stair that led down to Gerhardt's locked tavern and the lamp that would stay in the window until morning.

Then he looked back at Varux.

"Yes," he said. "I will be here."

Varux nodded.

"Good."

Alias went to his own room.

Rowan was already in bed, tangled in a blanket and pretending not to be awake.

"Did he ask you something sad?" Rowan asked.

"Maybe."

"Did you answer something sad?"

"Probably."

"That is exhausting."

Alias smiled in the dark.

"Go to sleep."

"I am trying."

The room grew quiet.  
Alias lay on his back and listened to the harbor outside. The road waited beyond Maanhaven. The  
camp waited beyond the hills. East waited farther still, with a split gate, old maps, and questions  
that did not have names yet.  
But no road was asking him to walk it tonight.  
The Paper stirred beneath his pillow.  
Alias unfolded it carefully.  
Blue words appeared.  
MORNING. PACK. ASK.  
He looked at the line.  
Then another appeared beneath it.  
RETURN.  
Alias smiled.  
"I know," he whispered.  
The Paper wrote one final line.  
GOOD.  
He folded it and placed it beside the gull whistle on the bedside table.  
Down the hall, a door closed softly.  
Not a door shutting someone out.  
A door closing because the room behind it was warm and someone had chosen to sleep there.  
In the morning, they would take the road home.  
Tonight, the tavern held them all.  
And the last evening did not feel like an ending at all.

\* \* \*



## Chapter 35

### The Road Home

#### *Shared Journal Entry 448*

*"The road home did not erase the road away. It only proved that we could choose a different direction next time."*

Morning arrived quietly at Gerhardt's tavern.

Alias woke before the harbor bells, before the kitchen fire, before Rowan could begin complaining about the blanket he had apparently lost a fight with during the night. Grey light rested against the window. Beyond it, Maanhaven was only shapes: rooflines, dock posts, and the thin pale strip of the bay.

For a moment, he did not know where he was.

Then he saw the gull whistle on the bedside table. The Paper lay folded beside it. His pack waited against the wall, already half-prepared for the road.

Home, he thought.

Not forever. Not in the way a story might mean it. The east road still existed. His parents' last record still waited beyond maps he could read. The split-gate symbol still sat in Corvin's copied chart, like a direction that had learned how to be patient.

But he was here.

That had to mean something.

The Paper unfolded before he touched it.

Blue writing appeared in the early light.

*MORNING. PACK. ASK. RETURN.*

Alias read the line twice.

Then he got dressed.

By the time he reached the hall, the tavern was waking around him. Gerhardt's boots moved across the floor below. A kettle had begun to hiss in the kitchen. Somewhere outside, a gull gave a long offended cry as if the entire harbor had disappointed it personally.

Varux stood at the end of the blue-painted hallway.

He wore the old coat.

It still did not fit. The loosened cuffs looked rough where he had cut the stitches. But he had brushed the dust from the shoulders. The coat was no longer a thing he had dragged around because he did not know where else to put it.

It was simply on him.

"Could not sleep?" Alias asked.

Varux looked toward the stairs.

"I slept," he said. "That is different."

Alias waited.

The older version gave a faint smile.

"I woke up and thought I had missed my chance to leave before anyone noticed. Then I remembered I did not want to."

The words were quiet. They mattered anyway.

"That sounds like progress," Alias said.

"It sounds exhausting."

"Both can be true."

From behind the half-open door to Alias's room, Rowan said, "I heard that. Stop using my wisdom without permission."

"Get dressed," Corvin called from farther down the hall.

"I am dressed in spirit."

"That is not clothing."

The house was loud now.

Alias looked at Varux.

"Do you want to go downstairs together?"

Varux's hand moved toward the pocket holding Maris's old letter.

Then he nodded.

"Yes."

Gerhardt had breakfast waiting before anyone asked for it.

There was bread still warm from the oven, a bowl of eggs, sliced apples, and a pot of tea so strong that Rowan stared at it with suspicion.

"Is that tea or punishment?" he asked.

"Both," Gerhardt said.

No one had packed yet. Their bags rested against the wall near the stairs. The copied maps lay folded on the counter beside the wooden box of things worth keeping. Two blue cords hung from hooks by the back door, each holding an iron key.

Alias's key.

Varux's key.

They did not look like much. They were small, dark, and ordinary. One could have fit in the bottom of a drawer for decades without anyone noticing.

Still, Alias could not stop looking at them.

Gerhardt poured tea into six cups and one cracked blue cup.

He placed the blue cup in front of Varux.

The older Alias did not touch it at first.

"You kept it," he said.

Gerhardt shrugged. "It held tea. It still holds tea. I am not sentimental enough to throw away a useful cup."

Rowan looked at the crack running down the side. "That cup looks like it has been through a war."

"So have you," Gerhardt said.

"I am much more handsome."

The tavern owner almost smiled.

Almost.

When breakfast had gone quiet, Gerhardt folded a cloth around two small bundles and placed them on the table.

One bundle went to Alias.

One went to Varux.

"Road food," he said. "Not gifts. Do not make it complicated."

Alias opened his bundle enough to see dark bread, dried fruit, cheese, and a small wrapped roll. The sort of food that could survive a day in a pack and still taste like someone had planned for you to eat it.

Varux looked at his own bundle.

"You do not have to do this," he said.

Gerhardt set both hands on the table.

"I know."

"I may come back."

"I know."

"I may not know when."

"I know that too."

Varux stared at him.

Gerhardt's voice softened, though not by much.

"Take food for the road, Alias. You do not have to turn every kindness into a promise you are afraid to break."

The older Alias lowered his eyes.

"All right," he said.

"Good. And write when you can. Not because I need a perfect explanation. Because it is easier to worry about a person who is still doing the courtesy of existing on paper."

Maris lifted the shared journal slightly.

"We can manage that," she said.

Gerhardt nodded. "I expect you to."

Then Rowan reached for another slice of bread.

"Does writing count if it says I am hungry?"

"No," Gerhardt replied.

"Unfair."

They packed after breakfast.

It took longer than it should have because every object seemed to require a decision.

Corvin checked the maps three times and placed the clean copies inside a waxed sleeve. The eastward mark remained on the last page, drawn in faint ink. He did not cover it. He only folded the page beneath the return route.

Maris wrapped the moonglass in cloth and placed it in the wooden box behind the counter. The journal went into her pack, not under it. Easy to reach.

Eldric added a fresh packet of tea beside his staff.

Rowan repaired the red cord on Alias's whistle, then repaired it again because he claimed the first repair had been "structurally charming but emotionally weak."

Varux stood by the hooks near the back door.

His key rested in his open palm.

Alias joined him.

"Are you going to take it?"

Varux looked at the key. "I already did."

"You know what I mean."

"I know."

The older version looked toward the back door.

"I used to think a key meant I had to prove I deserved the room behind it."

"And now?"

"Now I think it means someone thought I might need a way in."

Alias nodded.

Varux looped the blue cord over his head. The key disappeared beneath the collar of the too-small old coat.

"That is better," he said.

"What is?"

"Carrying it where I can feel it."

Alias did not answer.

He understood.

Gerhardt walked them to the back door.

The alley outside was narrow, still wet from the night's sea mist. Crates stood stacked against one wall. A black cat watched them from atop a barrel with the expression of someone who had personally approved the entire town.

The back door was locked.

Gerhardt nodded toward the two keys.

"Well?"

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version's hand had already gone to the cord beneath his coat.

For a moment, Alias thought he might hesitate.

Then Varux took the key out, slid it into the lock, and turned it.

The bolt moved.

The door opened inward.

Nothing dramatic happened.

No blue light. No tower voice. No old mark warming under someone's fingers.

Only a door opening because someone had a key.

Varux looked at it for a long moment.

Then he stepped over the threshold, out into the alley.

He turned around.

The open door framed the tavern behind him: warm kitchen light, Gerhardt's broad shape, the familiar counter, and the wall note with its last added line.

Home first.

"I will come back," Varux said.

Gerhardt did not say he believed him.

He did not need to.

"You know the way in," he replied.

Varux nodded.

Then he stepped aside so the others could leave too.

Alias was last.

He looked back at Gerhardt.

"Thank you," he said.

Gerhardt grunted.

"Come back with fewer dramatic tower stories. I have a business to run."

"No promises," Rowan called from the alley.

"I was not speaking to you."

"That is hurtful."

"Good."

The road home began behind the tavern.

Not at the western gate. Not beneath the old moon marker. Not at the first fork where a person could choose east or west and pretend that was the beginning of everything.

It began in an alley that smelled of salt and bread, with six packs on the ground and one open door behind them.

Alias looked toward the harbor.

The town was waking properly now. Shop shutters opened. Nets were hauled onto docks. A girl ran past them with two loaves tucked under one arm and a dog racing at her heels.

Maanhaven did not know they were leaving.

That made the leaving feel smaller.

Not unimportant.

Just human.

They walked through the market road, past the harbor fountain, toward the western gate. People moved around them. A fisherman nearly ran Rowan over with a cart. Rowan apologized to the cart because the fisherman had not stopped long enough to hear him.

At the gate, Alias slowed.

The stone pillars still carried their weathered moon carvings. Vines climbed one side. The guard beneath the awning looked up from the ledger and nodded at them without interest.

Years ago, a child in a blue blanket had been left here.

Not left behind.

Alias touched the cold stone once.

Varux stood beside him.

"Are you all right?" the older version asked.

Alias looked through the gate toward the west road.

"I do not know," he said.

Varux nodded.

The answer did not frighten either of them now.

"Me too," he said.

They passed through the gate together.

The first day out of Maanhaven was strangely difficult.

The road was easy enough. It followed the coast for a while, then turned inland through bright fields. The weather stayed clear. Corvin knew every marker. Eldric kept a steady pace. They had good food and enough water.

Nothing went wrong.

Alias kept looking over his shoulder anyway.

Maanhaven became smaller behind them. The harbor roofs blurred into the distance. The gulls became white marks over the sea. Eventually the town disappeared behind a line of low hills.

His chest tightened when it did.

He had left before. He would leave again. That was not the danger.

The danger was believing that leaving meant he had lost the right to return.

The Paper stirred in his pack.



He unfolded it while they walked.

*THE ROAD KNOWS BOTH DIRECTIONS.*

Alias read the line.

Then he showed it to Varux.

The older Alias looked at the blue words and gave a quiet laugh.

"That is almost helpful."

"Almost?"

"It will probably become worse if we ask it to explain."

Rowan leaned over from the other side. "Ask it to explain."

"No," Alias and Varux said together.

Rowan looked pleased. "You are getting good at that."

By noon, the coastal road rose over a ridge. From the top, they could see Maanhaven one last time.

It was small. A cluster of roofs. A thin line of docks. A patch of bright water.

Varux stopped.

Nobody told him to keep walking.

He stood there with one hand over the key beneath his coat.

Then he turned away from the view.

"All right," he said.

"All right what?" Corvin asked.

"All right, I can leave without disappearing."

The words were so simple that Alias nearly missed how much courage they carried.

Eldric nodded.

"That is a road worth learning," he said.

They reached the old camp site on the second evening.

It sat in a shallow hollow beneath a line of cedar trees, close enough to the main road that a wagon could find it, far enough away that the firelight would not bother travelers. A small creek

ran behind the trees. The ground was uneven in familiar ways. A stone near the fire ring had a crack down its center that Rowan had once claimed looked like Corvin frowning.

"It still does," Rowan said as soon as he saw it.

Corvin looked at the stone. "It is a rock."

"A judgmental rock."

Alias stood at the edge of the hollow.

This was where the story had begun.

The future version of him had appeared near a fire like this one, grey cloak wet at the shoulders, coin at his throat, carrying answers he did not know how to explain.

The camp looked smaller than Alias remembered.

That was what places did when you returned with more memory than before.

Varux saw it too.

He did not step into the hollow right away.

"This is where I left," he said.

Eldric set down his pack beside the old fire ring.

"Yes."

"I wrote the note near that tree."

He pointed to a cedar with low branches.

"Gone east. Back tomorrow," Alias said.

Varux looked at him.

"You remember."

"You made me remember."

The older version lowered his eyes.

"I am sorry."

Alias took a breath.

"I know."

The words did not erase anything.

But they did not need to carry everything tonight.

They made camp together.

Corvin checked the creek before anyone unpacked. Maris gathered dry grass for the fire. Eldric chose the flattest patch of ground for the tents. Rowan complained that his bedroll had become smaller since Maanhaven, then admitted he had packed it wrong.

Varux stood near the cedar tree for a long time.

Finally, he reached into his bag and took out the black journal.

Alias watched him open it.

The pages inside were crowded with old notes. Routes. Questions. Names crossed out and written again. The record of a person trying to turn every feeling into a map because maps did not ask him why he had been gone so long.

Varux turned to a blank page.

He wrote for several minutes.

When he finished, he did not close the journal.

He carried it to the fire ring and placed it beside the shared journal.

Maris looked up.

"What is that?"

"My journal," Varux said.

"I know."

"I mean..." He stopped. Tried again. "I do not want it to be only mine anymore. Not every page. But some of it."

Maris looked at the black cover.

"Are you sure?"

"No."

Rowan nodded solemnly from the other side of the fire. "That appears to be our strongest kind of sure."

Varux smiled despite himself.

Maris touched the black journal gently.

"Then we can read it when you choose. And stop when you ask."

"Yes."

She placed the shared journal beside it.

Blue and black.

Two books.

Neither one a door closing.

After dinner, the fire burned low.

The creek made soft sounds in the dark. The cedar branches shifted overhead. Somewhere farther down the road, another campfire glowed through the trees, but it was too far away for voices to carry.

Alias sat between Varux and Rowan.

That had not been planned.

It simply happened.

Rowan leaned back on his elbows and looked at the stars.

"Are we officially home now?" he asked.

Corvin considered the question. "This is a camp site."

"That is not what I asked."

"Then ask a less unclear question."

Maris looked at the two journals by the fire.

"Maybe home is not one place," she said. "Maybe it is the place where you can tell someone where you are going without being afraid they will use it against you."

Eldric added another stick to the fire.

"And the place where someone leaves a light on, even if you arrive late."

Rowan looked at Alias. "What do you think?"

Alias had expected the question. It still took him a moment.

He thought of Maanhaven's back door. The key on a blue cord. Gerhardt's cracked cup. The western gate. The tower. The first road. The camp hollow beneath the cedars.

Then he looked at the people around the fire.

"I think home is the people who notice when you are gone," he said. "And who let you come back before you have a good explanation."

The fire cracked.

No one laughed.

Varux looked at him.

His eyes shone in the firelight.

"That is good," he said.

Alias nodded. "Thank you."

For a while, they listened to the fire.

It was not a dramatic ending.

No one announced forgiveness. No old structure opened. No answer came from the east.

The road remained there.

So did the people beside it.

Later, after Rowan had gone to sleep and Corvin had checked the packs one final time, Alias woke to a quiet sound near the cedar tree.

Varux was sitting where he had once written the note.

The old coat was wrapped around him. The black journal lay open on his knees.

Alias crossed the grass and sat beside him.

Neither spoke for a while.

Then Varux said, "I wrote a new note."

"Can I hear it?"

The older version nodded.

He read from the journal.

"Gone west with the people I should have told before I left."

Alias waited.

Varux continued.

"I do not know when I will be back. But I know where I am going."

The words made Alias's throat tighten.

"That is better," he said.

"It is not perfect."

"It does not have to be."

Varux looked toward the fire ring.

"Do you think I can keep choosing like this?"

Alias thought of the tower's last lesson. A road did not end when you understood where it went wrong. It changed when you decided what to do next.

"I think you can choose again tomorrow," he said. "And if you forget, we can remind you."

Varux smiled.

"That sounds tiring for all of you."

"Probably."

"You are not making it sound convincing."

"I am making it sound real."

The older Alias considered that.

Then he closed the black journal.

"Real is better," he said.

The Paper unfolded in Alias's lap.

Blue words appeared, one line at a time.

*ROAD HOME: COMPLETE.*

*HOME: CONTINUING.*

Alias smiled.

Varux looked at the words.

"Is it allowed to do that?" he asked.

"What?"

"Call home continuing."

Alias folded the Paper closed.

"I think it is the point."

They sat beneath the cedar tree until the fire burned low enough that only red coals remained.

In the morning, they would not take the east road.

They would not take the tower road.

They would not even need to decide the future all at once.

They would wake up at camp. Make tea. Write in the journals. Plan the next small thing. Perhaps return to Maanhaven after a few days. Perhaps visit the Hall. Perhaps let the world remain ordinary long enough for them to understand it.

The east road would wait.

It was not a threat.

It was only a direction.

And home, Alias understood at last, was not the opposite of adventure.

It was the reason an adventure could end without becoming a disappearance.

\* \* \*

## PART V - WHAT REMAINED

### Chapter 36

#### The Journal I Never Read

#### *Shared Journal Entry 442*

*"I thought not reading it meant I could not be hurt by it. I did not understand that it also meant I could not be held by it."*

The morning after the road home ended, nobody knew what to do with a day that had no urgent direction.

The camp hollow looked the same as it had the night before. Cedar branches moved above them. Ashes slept beneath the stones of the fire ring. The creek ran through the grass with the patient sound of water not interested in anyone's history.

Alias woke before sunrise because he expected the Paper to tell him to pack.

It did not.

For several minutes he lay still inside his blanket, waiting for blue light to appear beneath the flap of his pack. He expected a message about the east road, the split gate, the key from M's desk, or some other piece of the future that had become impossible to ignore.

Nothing happened.

Then Rowan snored loudly in the next bedroll, rolled over, and pulled half the blanket away from himself.

Alias almost laughed.

Maybe this was what a morning was supposed to be. Not a warning. Not a test. Just a morning with cold grass, a sleepy friend, and a fire that needed to be rebuilt.

He sat up.

Across the clearing, Varux was already awake.

The older Alias sat beneath the cedar tree where he had written his new note the night before. The old coat was buttoned badly around his shoulders. His black journal rested beside him, closed. The blue shared journal lay open on his knees.

Alias stopped.

Varux was not writing in it.

He was reading.



Not quickly. Not like someone checking a route or hunting for a clue. He sat with one hand over his mouth and turned each page as though the paper might disappear if he moved too fast.

Alias did not mean to interrupt, but the Paper chose that moment to unfold inside his pack.

Blue letters appeared.

*Paper:*

*LET HIM READ.*

Alias looked toward Varux again.

The older version did not see him at first.

The shared journal was thicker than it had looked at the fire. Some of its pages carried the familiar blue handwriting of the present Maris. Others were written in darker ink, in hands Alias recognized only from memories, letters, and the future pages they had found along the road.

Pages written while Varux had been gone.

Pages he had never read.

Alias crossed the grass quietly.

Varux looked up when he was only a few steps away. His eyes were red, but he did not close the journal.

'Morning,' Alias said.

'Morning.'

'Did you sleep?'

Varux glanced at the pale sky. 'A little.'

Alias looked at the open pages. 'You are reading it.'

The older Alias's fingers tightened against the edge of the journal. 'I am trying to.'

'You do not have to do all of it today.'

'I know.' Varux gave a weak smile. 'That is why I think I might be able to.'

Alias sat down beside him. Not too close. Close enough that their shoulders almost touched.

For a while, they listened to the creek.

Then Varux turned the book toward him.

'I found the first page I skipped,' he said.

The entry had been written in Maris's hand. The date at the top belonged to a day Alias could not place. It was years ahead of him, but only days after the younger Varux had left camp.

*Shared Journal - Maris:*

*Day 4.*

*Alias left east before sunrise. He wrote that he would return tomorrow.*

*I am writing this because I do not want tomorrow to become a story we tell ourselves without proof.*

*He is alive. I do not know how I know. But I do.*

*When he comes back, I will be angry. I will also make tea.*

Varux stared at the entry.

'I saw the first line once,' he said. 'Years ago. I closed the book after that.'

'Why?' Alias asked.

'Because I could picture her writing it.'

Alias looked at the page.

The words were simple. Not an accusation. Not forgiveness. Maris had written the way a person wrote when she wanted to make sure the truth stayed somewhere safe.

Varux's thumb rested near the line about tea.

'She still made tea,' he said.

'Of course she did,' Alias replied.

Varux laughed once, but the sound did not carry far.

By the time the others woke, the shared journal was still open between them.

Rowan emerged from his blanket with his hair in every direction and paused when he saw it.

'Is that the book?' he asked.

'Yes,' Varux said.

'The one you did not read?'

Varux nodded.

Rowan looked as though he wanted to say something careless. Then he looked at Varux's face and chose not to.

'Do you want company?' he asked instead.

Varux looked around the camp.

Maris had woken too. She stood near her bedroll, silent, watching the blue cover in Varux's hands. Corvin was kneeling beside the fire ring, arranging kindling. Eldric held two cups, steam rising from them.

'Yes,' Varux said. 'I think I do.'

So they made breakfast slowly.

No one treated the journal like an artifact from a dangerous place. No one held their breath waiting for it to open a hidden door. Corvin burned the first flatbread on one side. Rowan declared it was intentionally crisp. Maris cut fruit with a knife that was too dull. Eldric poured tea into mismatched cups.

Then they gathered beneath the cedar tree.

Varux held the journal. Maris sat beside him, but she did not take it away. Alias sat opposite. Rowan leaned against a root. Corvin stayed near enough to hear without pretending he was not listening. Eldric rested his cup in both hands.

'I do not want to read every page,' Varux said.

'You decide,' Maris told him.

'I want to read the pages that made me afraid to open it.'

The Paper rustled in Alias's pocket.

Blue ink appeared along the edge of a blank scrap.

*Paper:*

*START WHERE HE STOPPED.*

Varux turned pages until he found a strip of blue thread marking a place near the middle of the journal.

The thread had been tied around one page as a bookmark. He stared at it for a long time before speaking.

'This is Maris's,' he said.

Maris nodded. 'I know.'

'Did you put it here?'

'I do not remember.'

Varux looked at her. 'Future you did.'

Maris's expression softened. 'Then future me had good taste in bookmarks.'

That earned a quiet laugh from Rowan.

Varux read the page.

*Shared Journal - Corvin:*

*Year 3, first thaw.*

*I redrew the eastern routes. There are three ways he might return without crossing the flooded pass.*

*Maris says I am making maps for a person who is not reading them.*

*She is correct.*

*I am making them anyway.*

Corvin looked down at his hands.

'You did that?' Alias asked.

The present Corvin cleared his throat. 'Apparently.'

'Why?' Varux asked.

Corvin looked irritated by the question, which meant it had reached somewhere important.

'Because a route home should exist,' he said. 'Whether someone uses it or not.'

Varux lowered his eyes.

'I did not deserve that.'

Corvin shook his head once. 'Maps are not rewards.'

The sentence made Varux look up.

Corvin continued, quieter now. 'You do not earn the right to know where the road is. You just have to decide whether you are walking it.'

No one spoke for a moment.

Then Varux turned the page.

*Shared Journal - Rowan:*

*I moved his chair because it was in my way.*

*Maris moved it back because she said he might come home and complain.*

*I said he would complain either way.*

*We kept the chair.*

Rowan made a sound halfway between a laugh and a cough.

'That is exactly what I would write,' he said.

'You did write it,' Maris said.

'Future me has excellent instincts.'

Varux stared at the entry.

'What chair?' he asked.

Maris looked toward the fire. 'The one at the table in the old camp kitchen. You used to sit in it when you were mapping.'

'I do not remember.'

'You did not have to,' she said. 'We remembered for you.'

The next entry was Eldric's.

*Shared Journal - Eldric:*

*There is no correct amount of time to wait for someone you love.  
There is only the work of continuing to live while keeping the door visible.  
Today I made tea. Tomorrow I will make it again.*

Eldric read the words without changing expression.

Then he placed his cup down carefully.

'I remember writing that,' he said.

Varux looked at him sharply. 'You do?'

'Not every word. But the day.' Eldric looked at the cedar branches. 'We had received a rumor that an unnamed traveler had helped repair a bridge near the east pass. Maris thought it might be you. Corvin drew three routes. Rowan pretended not to worry. I made tea.'

'And it was not me,' Varux said.

'No.'

'Did you stop looking after that?'

Eldric met his eyes. 'No.'

The answer was not heroic. It was not dramatic. It did not make Varux's years away disappear.

It was only true.

Varux turned another page, but stopped when he found a sheet that had been folded inward. It was thicker than the others. The edges had been sealed with blue wax, now cracked from age.

'What is this?' Alias asked.

Maris leaned closer. 'I do not know.'

The writing on the outside was not in Maris's hand. It was written in a rough, hurried script Alias had learned to recognize.

Varux.

The older Alias looked stunned.

'That is mine,' he said.

'From the future?' Rowan asked.

Varux nodded slowly. 'I must have put it in here.'

'Did you read it?' Alias asked.

Varux looked at the cracked wax.

'No.'

The camp seemed to grow quieter around them.

'You wrote a letter and did not read it?' Rowan asked.

'I wrote many things I did not read.'

Maris touched the edge of the sealed page. 'Do you want to open it?'

Varux looked at Alias.

'Will you?' he asked.

Alias's stomach tightened.

'Me?'

'It is addressed to all of us,' Varux said.

Alias looked more closely. Under the name, in smaller writing, were the words:

*Written on the sealed page:*

*For the people I left behind, if I ever become brave enough to return.*

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version's hands were shaking.

'You wrote this before you returned?'

'Maybe. I do not know when.'

'Then why put it in the journal?'

Varux swallowed. 'Because I wanted it to be somewhere they might find it. I think I was hoping someone else would read it before I had to.'

Maris did not judge him for that.

She only said, 'You are here now.'

Alias placed both hands on the edge of the blue journal.

'Then we read it now.'

The wax broke easily.

Inside was a single page, written in uneven black ink.

Alias began aloud.

*Varux - unsent letter:*

*I am sorry I made you carry the part of me that should have come back with you.  
I have spent too long believing I needed to understand everything before I could stand in front  
of you again.*

*The truth is that I was afraid you would let me come home before I knew how to forgive myself.*

*If I return, I do not want you to say it is all right. It was not all right.*

*I only want to be allowed to sit at the table and learn what happened while I was gone.*

Alias stopped reading.

Varux stared at the ground.

No one tried to make the letter prettier than it was.

It did not fix the years. It did not ask anyone to forget them. It did not even know whether the person who wrote it would ever be brave enough to deliver it.

But it was honest.

Maris took the page from Alias and held it beside the entries she had written years later.

'You wanted to sit at the table,' she said.

Varux looked up.

'Yes.'

'Then that is where we start.'

Rowan shifted against the cedar root. 'We have been doing a lot of table things lately.'

'Because tables are important,' Corvin said.

Rowan stared at him. 'You are agreeing with me from three days ago.'

'Do not make it unpleasant.'

The small moment loosened something in the camp.

The journal did not close.

Instead, a blank page near the back began to glow faintly blue.

The Paper unfolded in Alias's lap.

*Paper:*

*WHAT REMAINED WAS NOT ONLY WRITTEN.*

New writing appeared in the shared journal.

Not a full entry. Not a message from the tower.

Only an address.

*Shared Journal:*

*Gerhardt's attic.*

*The box above the old harbor map.*

*Do not open it alone.*

Varux stared at the page.

'The attic?' Alias asked.

Gerhardt's tavern came back to him immediately: the warm kitchen, the harbor map in the back room, the blue-painted hall upstairs. He had walked past the old office twice since returning. He had not thought about the attic above it.

'Did you know about a box?' Maris asked Varux.

The older Alias shook his head.

'No.'

'Then it is not yours to carry alone,' Eldric said.

Varux looked down at the black unsent letter, then at the journal pages he had finally read.

'No,' he said. 'It is not.'

He closed the shared journal carefully.

Not quickly. Not as if he were fleeing from it.

Carefully, as though it contained a road that would still be there when he opened it again.

Alias watched him place the blue book beside the black one.

Two journals.

One full of pages he had written alone.

One full of pages he had been too afraid to read.



Neither one was empty now.

By noon, the camp had been packed.

Corvin tied down the map case. Maris wrapped both journals in oilcloth. Rowan complained about leaving before he had eaten a second breakfast. Eldric poured the last of the tea onto the roots of the cedar tree and thanked it for shelter.

Varux stood at the edge of the road with the old coat buttoned over his chest.

'Maanhaven?' Alias asked.

Varux looked west.

Then he looked at the people beside him.

'Maanhaven,' he said.

The Paper wrote one final line before Alias folded it away.

*Paper:*

*READ. RETURN. RECEIVE.*

Alias smiled at the words.

The road did not need to become a mystery for them to follow it.

It led toward a tavern, an old harbor map, a locked attic, and a box someone had left waiting for a person who had not known he was ready to be found.

This time, no one went alone.

They took the west road together.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 37

### The Gifts Left Waiting *Shared Journal Entry 443*

*"Some gifts are not meant to solve the past. They are meant to prove that someone expected you to have a future."*

Maanhaven appeared at the end of the second day just before rain did.

The clouds arrived first, low and silver over the sea. Then came the gulls. Then the harbor roofs, crowded beneath the hills. By the time the six of them reached the western gate, the town had become a blur of wet stone, smoke, and familiar color.

Alias stopped beneath the moon-carved archway.

He had crossed this gate enough times now that he no longer expected it to explain anything. It was still only stone. It still held the chill of the sea. The guard still looked up from a ledger, nodded once, and returned to the business of deciding whether anyone had properly paid the market toll.

But the gate had changed in Alias's mind.

It was no longer only the place where his parents had left him in a blue blanket. It was also the place they had trusted. The place they had believed would hold him until they came back.

Not left behind.

Not forgotten.

The words did not make the loss easier.

They made it possible to carry without turning it into a wound he had to keep opening.

Varux stopped beside him.

The old coat was damp at the shoulders. The blue cord of Gerhardt's key showed at his collar. He looked at the gate for a long moment, then at the road behind them.

"Are you all right?" Alias asked.

Varux gave the answer he had learned to give honestly.

"I do not know."

Alias nodded.

They walked through together.

The tavern was open when they arrived. Warm light spilled over the street from the front windows. The painted lantern sign creaked above the door. Even before Rowan opened it, the smell of onions, bread, and tea reached them.

Gerhardt was behind the counter, arguing with a sailor about the price of stew.

"It is not the price," the sailor said. "It is the amount of onion."

"The amount of onion is the price," Gerhardt replied.

Then he saw them.

His expression did not become surprised. That would have been too much like a question.

Instead, he looked from Alias to Varux, to the wet packs and tired faces, and said, "You came back before the bread went stale. That is progress."

Rowan looked offended. "We walked for two days."

"Then you should be hungry enough to appreciate food. Sit down."

No one argued.

They ate in the back room near the old harbor map. Rain began properly while they were halfway through the stew. It tapped against the shutters and filled the pauses in conversation, but no one seemed in a hurry to talk over it.

Varux had the shared journal beside his bowl.

He had carried it all the way from the cedar camp, wrapped in oilcloth with his black journal. The two books sat together like two versions of a road that had finally agreed to meet.

Gerhardt noticed the blue journal when he brought more bread.

"You found something," he said.

Maris looked at Varux.

The older Alias nodded once.

"The journal gave us an address," Maris said. "Your attic. A box above the old harbor map."

For the first time that evening, Gerhardt stopped moving.

The bread basket remained in his hands.

"It did?" he asked.

Varux looked up sharply. "You know about it?"

Gerhardt looked at him for a long moment.

"You brought a box here five years ago," he said. "You asked me to store it where you would not find it by accident."

Varux went still.

"I did?"

"You did." Gerhardt set the bread down. "You had a list of rules. Most of them were written twice, which told me you did not trust yourself to follow the first version."

Rowan leaned forward. "What rules?"

Gerhardt folded his arms. "The important one was this: if you came asking for the box alone, I was to tell you I did not have it. If you came with the blue journal and people willing to stay in the room, I was to give it to you."

The room became quiet.

Varux looked down at his hands.

"I wrote that?"

"You did."

"Why did you agree?"

Gerhardt's expression softened only slightly.

"Because you sounded like a man trying to leave a rope for himself before he forgot he might want to climb back."

Varux swallowed.

Alias looked at the shared journal. The blue cover had led them here. Not because it was another mystery to chase. Because five years ago, the older Alias had known he might someday need help opening something he had packed away.

He had made a plan for the day he stopped pretending he could do everything alone.

That was not nothing.

Gerhardt went upstairs without another word.

The attic door was at the end of the blue-painted hallway, hidden above a narrow stair that Alias had never noticed. Gerhardt carried an oil lamp. The flame made the walls glow gold as they climbed.

The attic was smaller than Alias expected. Low beams crossed the ceiling. Old crates crowded the walls. Nets, broken chairs, empty bottles, and the remains of a once-important fishing sign had been stacked in patient layers of dust.

At the far end hung the old harbor map.

It was larger than the copy in the back room downstairs. Its paper had yellowed at the edges. The bay was painted in faded blue. Tiny boats had been marked near the docks. A red line traced the western road out of town.

Above the map, tucked onto a narrow shelf between two beams, rested a dark wooden box.

It was not large.

That made it worse.

The difficult things were often small enough to carry under one arm.

A brass strip reinforced the lid. A leather cord wrapped around the middle. Six names had been written on the top in faded ink.

Alias.

Maris.

Corvin.

Rowan.

Eldric.

Varux.

The last name had been written darker than the rest, as if someone had gone over it twice.

Varux stared at it.

"I remember the box," he said.

Gerhardt looked at him. "You do?"

"Not where I put it. But I remember making it. I remember..." He pressed one hand to his forehead. "I remember carrying things into the tavern. I thought I was cleaning out a room."

"You were," Gerhardt said. "You cleaned out everything except the part that mattered."

Varux gave a small, unhappy laugh.

"That sounds like me."

Gerhardt set the lamp on an overturned crate. "It was you. That does not mean it has to remain you."

He loosened the leather cord.

Then he stepped back.

"Open it together.

No key was needed.

The lid lifted with a soft scrape of wood.

Inside, six bundles lay side by side beneath a square of blue cloth. Each had been wrapped carefully in plain paper. Each had a name written in a different hand.

Varux reached for his own bundle and stopped.

Maris saw it.

"You do not have to open yours first," she said.

He looked at the other names.

"No," he said. "I think I should not."

Alias picked up the packet with his name.

The paper had been folded around a small notebook. Its cover was blue, but darker than the shared journal. A strip of silver thread held it closed. On the first page, someone had written in neat future Maris handwriting:

*For the days you believe a thought is too small to share.  
Write it anyway.*

Below that was another line.

A small thing told in time is not a burden. It is how people stay near each other.

Alias ran his thumb over the page.

There were no maps inside. No instructions for the eastern road. No explanation of the split gate or his parents' last record.

Only blank pages.

"She made you a journal," present Maris said.

Alias looked at her.

"Future you did."

Maris smiled a little. "Then she was probably tired of everyone speaking only when the world was ending."

Rowan made a thoughtful sound. "That is a good journal rule."

"You can borrow it," Alias said.

"I would ruin it in a day."

"Probably."

Rowan looked pleased by the answer.

Corvin opened his packet next.

Inside was a folded map no larger than his palm. When he spread it out, it unfolded again, then again, until it covered most of the attic floor.

Routes crossed the page in green ink.

Maanhaven. Ravencross. The Hall. Hollow Creek. The observatory. The tower. Smaller towns and bridges they had never visited. Roads that ended at the sea. Roads that turned east and then came back west.

At the bottom was a note written in future Corvin's hand.

*Every place I could confirm had a way back.*

*Not every return route is safe.*

*That is not the same as saying none exists.*

Present Corvin knelt beside the map.

He did not speak for a while.

Finally, he said, "I made this?"

Varux looked at the green lines.

"You kept making maps for me," he said. "Even when I did not use them."

Corvin's face tightened the way it did when he was trying not to show feeling.

"Maps are not rewards," he said.

The words were familiar now.

Varux nodded.

"No," he said. "They are not."

Corvin folded the map back along its old lines. He did not return it to the box.

He placed it inside his map case.

"Carry," he said.

No one asked what he meant.

They all knew.

Rowan's bundle contained a card case.

It was made from dark leather, scuffed at the corners, with a red thread tied around the clasp.  
Inside was a deck of wooden cards, each painted with a simple symbol: moon, road, cup, lantern,  
gull, map, fire.

On top lay a note.

*One game when you come back.  
You are not allowed to leave until you lose at least once.  
- Rowan*

Rowan read it twice.

Then he sat down hard on an old crate.

"Future me wrote that?"

"Apparently," Maris said.

"He is very wise."

"He is demanding."

"Same thing, sometimes."

Varux looked at the cards.

"We played cards at Gerhardt's," he said.

"You were terrible," Rowan replied.

"I remember that now."

"Good. Then you remember losing."

The older Alias smiled.

Rowan held the card case out to him.

"You carry it," he said. "But I am still expecting one game."

Varux took it carefully.

"I will lose honestly."

"Do not promise too much."

For a moment, the attic felt warm despite the rain.

Eldric's bundle was the smallest.



It contained a tea tin, dented on one side and painted with a crooked blue star. The lid had been labeled in future Eldric's quiet handwriting.

For the day you do not know what to say.  
Make tea first.

Inside were dried leaves, still fragrant after all those years. Beneath them, wrapped in cloth, lay a folded piece of paper.

Eldric read it silently.

Then he handed it to Varux.

The paper said:

You never have to earn the chair beside the fire.  
Sit down before you understand why you are tired.

Varux closed his eyes.

Eldric's present hand rested on his shoulder.

"I would say that," he said.

"You did say it," Varux replied.

"Then perhaps we should both listen."

The older Alias held the tea tin against the old coat over his chest.

"Carry," he said softly.

Eldric nodded.

Only two bundles remained.

One bore Maris's name.

The other bore Varux's.

Maris opened hers with careful hands. Inside lay a strip of blue thread, longer than the one she had used as a bookmark in the shared journal. A small silver needle rested beside it. Underneath was a folded note.

Future Maris had written:

*For the days you need to mend something before it becomes a reason to throw it away.*

Present Maris held the thread against the light.

"That is very much like me," she said.

"It is," Varux said.

Maris looked toward the old coat. "I could fix the cuff properly."

Varux laughed quietly.

"I think I would like that."

Maris nodded. "Then leave it with me tonight."

Not take it away forever.

Not repair it because he could not.

Leave it with her tonight.

Varux seemed to understand the difference.

He nodded.

"All right."

The last bundle waited.

No one reached for it.

The paper around it was old and darkened. The name on top had been written by Varux himself.

VARUX.

Below it, in smaller letters:

For the day you open this with them.

The attic became quiet again.

Varux looked at Alias.

"Will you?" he asked.

Alias's throat tightened.

"You want me to open it?"

"I packed it for myself. I think I knew I would try to make it a test." He looked at the others. "I do not want to do that anymore."

Alias nodded.

He unfolded the paper.

Inside was a small brass ring holding six tiny keys.

Each key had a different colored thread tied through its bow: blue, green, red, white, grey, silver.

Beneath them lay a note.

Alias read aloud.

*I do not know what I can leave you that will make the years smaller.  
So I am leaving a way in.*

One key for every person I hope will still be willing to open a door with me.

If you are reading this alone, put the box away.  
If you are reading this with them, give them the keys.

Do not ask whether you deserve one first.

Ask whether you will use it.

Alias stopped.

Varux covered his mouth with one hand.

No one hurried him.

The keys lay on the blue cloth between them.

Gerhardt looked at the brass ring, then at Varux.

"You gave those to me too," he said. "You told me they did not open a room yet. You said you hoped they would someday."

"What do they open?" Rowan asked.

Gerhardt shook his head. "You did not say."

Corvin lifted the green-threaded key. It was small enough to fit in his palm. A tiny open-eye symbol had been stamped along the shaft.

Maris picked up the blue key. Eldric took the white one. Rowan claimed the red before anyone else could. Alias held the silver key, and Varux kept the grey.

The moment they touched them, the keys warmed.

Not hot.

Not dangerous.

Warm like they had been kept near a fire.

The Paper unfolded in Alias's pocket.

A single line appeared.

SIX KEYS. ONE ROAD. MANY RETURNS.

Corvin looked at the blue ink.

"That does not explain the lock."

"It explains enough," Eldric said.

Varux looked at the grey key in his hand.

"I did not know I had planned this," he said.

"Maybe you did not plan it," Alias replied. "Maybe you hoped for it."

The older version looked at the others holding their keys.

His eyes were wet.

"I hoped you would still be here."

Maris closed her fingers around the blue key.

"We are."

No one said always.

No one said nothing would change.

They only stood in the dusty attic with a box open between them and small keys warming in their hands.

That was more honest.

At the bottom of the box, beneath the blue cloth, Alias found one final envelope.

It had no name on the front.

Only a sentence.

For the Reader who refuses to become a warning.

Alias looked at Varux.

The older version shook his head. "That is not mine."

Maris recognized the handwriting first.

"It is future me," she said.

Alias opened the envelope.

Inside was a folded page and a small brass compass with no needle.

The page read:

*To the younger Alias,*

You are not here to prevent him from becoming us.

You are here to become yourself with more information than we had.

Do not make your future a prison. Do not make our mistakes a map you must follow or avoid perfectly.

Keep asking. Keep returning. Let people know which road you are taking.

The compass does not point north. It will point only when you have named where you are going and how you intend to come back.

The empty space beyond the first road is not a promise. It is an invitation.

- Maris

Alias held the compass in his palm.

It was light. The face showed no markings except the Reader eye at the center and two small words along the rim.

GO.

RETURN.

The needle did not move.

Rowan leaned over his shoulder.

"Does it work?"

Alias thought of the road east. The split gate. His parents' last record. The people beside him. The key in his hand. The warm tavern below.

He closed his fingers around the compass.

"I do not know where I am going yet," he said.

The compass stayed still.

"And I know how I am coming back," he added.

The needle moved.

Not east.

Not west.

It turned slowly until it pointed toward the attic stair.

Toward the tavern below.

Toward home.

Nobody spoke for a moment.

Then Rowan said, "That is annoyingly meaningful."

Alias smiled.

"It is honest."

The needle held steady.

They carried the box downstairs together.

Not every gift went into a pack.

The blue notebook stayed with Alias. Corvin kept the map. Rowan tucked the card case into Varux's pack only after making him promise one future game. Eldric carried the tea tin. Maris took the blue thread and the old coat upstairs to mend its cuff properly.

The six small keys remained on their cords.

Gerhardt placed the wooden box behind the counter, not hidden this time.

"It can stay here," he said. "Not because you are finished with it. Because a tavern is allowed to hold things for people who are still deciding what to carry."

Varux looked at the box.

"Thank you."

Gerhardt grunted.

"Write when you leave."

Varux touched the grey key at his chest.

"I will."

This time, no one doubted that he meant it.

Outside, the rain had stopped. The harbor was silver beneath a clearing sky. The east road still existed beyond the town, past the first road and the tower and the map edge where the split gate waited.

It had not become less dangerous.

It had not become less unknown.

But now Alias had a compass that would not point until he could name both the road ahead and the return behind him.

Varux had a card case, a tea tin, an old coat, a letter, and a key.

The others carried their own small proofs.

Gifts left waiting.

Not instructions.

Not debts.

Proof that someone had expected them to keep living long enough to receive them.

The Paper wrote one final line before Alias folded it away.

RECEIVED.

He looked toward the harbor, then toward the tavern door behind him.

For the first time, the next road did not feel like something waiting to take him away.

It felt like an adventure that could begin only because he knew the way home.

\* \* \*

## Chapter 38

### Adventure Awaits

#### *Shared Journal Entry 444*

*"A road becomes an adventure when you stop using it to escape and begin choosing who will walk it with you."*

The morning after the attic box was opened, Maanhaven woke beneath a sky so clear that the harbor looked painted.

The rain had washed the streets during the night. Water clung to the gutters and shone along the market stones. Gulls called from the roofs. Someone was already arguing with a fish seller near the docks, and somewhere farther down the road a cart wheel squealed in the same uneven rhythm it always had.

Alias stood outside the Crossed Lantern with the brass compass in his hand.

The small needle rested at the word RETURN.

It had not moved since the attic.

Behind him, Gerhardt was opening the tavern shutters one at a time. He lifted each one with the same practical lack of ceremony he used for everything important.

"You are standing in the road," he said.

Alias glanced back. "I am not in the road."

"You are directly in front of my door. That is worse."

Alias stepped aside.

Gerhardt grunted and opened the final shutter. Warm light spilled across the doorway. The old painted lantern sign creaked overhead.

Home, Alias thought.

Not because it was perfect.

Because someone had just told him to move out of the way.

The others came out slowly.

Rowan appeared first, wearing a coat he had not properly fastened and carrying a piece of bread stolen from the kitchen. Corvin followed with his map case under one arm. Maris had the blue shared journal tucked close beneath her cloak. Eldric carried his tea tin. Varux came last.

He wore the old coat.



Maris had mended the cuff during the night. The thread did not match perfectly, but it held. A short blue line now crossed the tear at his wrist. The six small keys rested on cords beneath everyone's collars; Alias could see the grey thread of Varux's key above the old coat.

Varux stopped on the tavern step.

Gerhardt looked at him. "You leaving?"

"Not today," Varux said.

"Good. You still owe me for three bowls of stew and one very disappointing card game."

Rowan looked offended. "I was not disappointing."

"I was speaking to Varux."

"Then he was disappointing."

Varux smiled.

It was not the small, careful smile he had given when he was trying to prove he could still do it. This one came before he could stop it.

Gerhardt saw it.

He did not comment.

Instead he placed a wooden sign beside the tavern door.

*BACK AFTER BREAKFAST.*

Rowan stared at it. "You are closing?"

"For ten minutes."

"That is not breakfast."

"Then eat faster."

They went inside.

Breakfast was bread, eggs, fried potatoes, tea, and enough onions that Rowan accused Gerhardt of trying to make them all cry before the day had begun.

"You are already emotional," Gerhardt replied. "The onions are not responsible."

Nobody mentioned the box at first.

The gifts had been put away. The blue notebook lay in Alias's pack. Corvin's folded return map was tucked into his map case. The card set waited in Varux's bag. Eldric's tea tin stood beside his

cup. Maris had returned the repaired coat to Varux before dawn, and the brass compass lay on the table between Alias and the shared journal.

They were all still there.

Small things. Carryable things.

Proofs.

After a while, Gerhardt set down the kettle and looked at Alias.

"You have the east face again," he said.

Alias blinked. "The east face?"

"The face someone has when he is looking at breakfast and seeing a road instead." Gerhardt poured more tea. "It is not a bad face. It is only an annoying one."

Alias looked at the compass.

The needle had shifted a fraction.

Not east.

Not west.

It trembled between the two words around its rim.

GO.

*RETURN.*

"I keep thinking about the split gate," Alias said.

The table went quiet.

Nobody looked surprised. They had all been thinking about it.

The final map from the hidden room. The eastern passage. The last record of Alias's parents. The place beyond the first road that had not been a kingdom, but a way to return.

Varux's hand rested over the grey key at his chest.

"So do I," he said.

Rowan put down his spoon.

"Are we deciding something?"

"Not this morning," Corvin said immediately.

"That sounds like deciding not to decide."

"It sounds like breakfast."

Maris opened the shared journal to a blank page.

"We can decide what we know," she said. "That is different."

Alias looked at her.

"What do we know?"

Maris tapped the page with the pencil.

"We know the eastern passage is real. We know it may connect to the last place your parents were recorded. We know M left a warning about treating roads as commands. We know the compass will not guide us until we name both where we are going and how we intend to return." She looked around the table. "And we know none of us should go alone."

Corvin nodded. "We also know that going east without better maps, supplies, or a clearer route would be stupid."

"Thank you," Rowan said. "I was worried nobody would say the important part."

"You were going to say it?"

"Eventually. After more potatoes."

Eldric lifted his cup.

"Then we prepare," he said. "Preparation is not fear. It is how a person honors the road and the people who may need to walk it with them."

Varux looked down at the old coat.

"And what happens to me?"

The question was so quiet that for a moment no one answered.

Alias looked at him.

"What do you mean?"

"I came here to stop you from becoming me." Varux's fingers curled around the blue cord of his key. "Now we have a gate east of the first road. Your parents may be beyond it. The road I ran from is still there. I do not know whether I am supposed to follow you, stay here, or..."

He stopped.

Or disappear, Alias thought.

He did not say it.

"You are supposed to decide," Alias said.

Varux looked at him.

"Not alone," Alias added. "But it has to be your choice."

The older Alias held his gaze.

"What would you want?"

Alias thought about it.

"I want you to come with us when we go east," he said. "Not as my warning. Not as someone who already knows what will happen. Just as you."

Varux's eyes shone.

"Alias?"

"Both names," Alias said. "The name that belongs at home and the name that survived the road. You do not have to throw either one away."

A long silence followed.

Then Varux nodded.

"All right," he said. "I want that too."

The Paper unfolded beside Alias's plate.

Blue letters appeared between the crumbs.

*NAME THE ROAD.*

Rowan leaned over.

"It has terrible timing."

"It has perfect timing," Maris said.

The Paper wrote a second line.

*NAME THE RETURN.*

Alias picked up the brass compass.

The blank needle waited.

He felt every eye at the table turn toward him. Not demanding. Not pushing. Waiting the way Gerhard's tavern key had waited. The way the room of farewells had waited. The way the old letters had waited for a person who had been too afraid to read them.

He took a breath.

"I want to go east," he said.

The compass did not move.

"I want to find the split gate beyond the first road. I want to learn what happened to my parents. I want to know what the First Keepers left there, and why M believed it was a way to return."

The needle trembled.

Then stopped.

Alias looked at the people around the table.

"And I am going with all of you, if you choose to come." He paused. "We will return to Maanhaven. We will write when we leave. We will tell people which road we are taking. We will not turn an answer into a reason to disappear."

The compass needle moved.

Slowly at first.

Then it turned past GO, past the small eye carved at the center, and pointed east.

At the same moment, every key around the table warmed.

The silver key at Alias's chest. Blue at Maris's. Green at Corvin's. Red at Rowan's. White at Eldric's. Grey at Varux's.

Blue light ran over the brass compass face.

A map appeared above the table.

Not a paper map. A thin projection of lines and symbols drawn in light.

Maanhaven glowed beneath them. The route east crossed the old road, the first road, and the black outline of the tower. Beyond it stood the split gate.

Farther still, where the known map ended, another symbol appeared.

A circle opening into a road.

The Paper wrote one last line beneath the shining map.

*THE FIRST ROAD WAS ONLY THE FIRST.*

No one spoke for several breaths.

Then Corvin reached beneath the projection and marked the route in the air with one finger.

"This is not enough for a full map," he said.

"It is enough to start," Maris replied.

"It is enough to know what we need to learn before we leave."

Rowan looked at the glowing road.

"Does the gate open with six keys?"

The Paper went blank.

"Useful as always," he said.

Eldric watched the far symbol fade and return.

"Some answers are meant to wait until we have become the people who can carry them," he said.

Varux looked at the map.

"That sounds suspiciously like another lesson."

"It probably is."

"I am tired of lessons."

"Then call it preparation."

Varux gave a quiet laugh.

The light faded from above the table. The compass needle settled, steady and eastward.

But beneath it, close to the rim, RETURN still remained.

Alias closed his hand around the compass.

The needle did not stop moving because he had found the final answer.

It moved because he had named a road and the people who would help him come back from it.

They spent the rest of the day doing ordinary things.

That was not what Alias expected after the compass revealed a new road.

He expected a rush of packing. A dramatic departure. A door opening in the tavern wall.

Someone from the tower appearing in the harbor with a warning and a terrible cloak.

Instead, Corvin bought more paper for maps. Maris visited the bookshop and returned with three books about old eastern roads and one book about sea birds that Rowan insisted was essential research. Eldric went to speak with the healer about supplies for a longer journey. Rowan repaired a strap on Varux's pack while complaining that the pack had chosen a difficult life.

Varux wrote a letter.

Not a long one.

He sat at the tavern's back table with the black journal open beside him and the shared journal nearby. He wrote on plain paper, addressed the envelope to Gerhardt even though Gerhardt was standing behind the counter only a few steps away, and sealed it with blue wax.

Then he placed it in Gerhardt's hand.

The tavern owner looked at the envelope.

"You could have said it."

"I know," Varux replied. "But I wanted to write it too."

Gerhardt turned the envelope over.

"Will I be allowed to read it?"

"Yes."

"Good. I dislike mystery letters."

Varux smiled.

Alias did not ask what it said.

He did not need to.

The act of writing it was the answer.

Before sunset, they walked to the western gate together.

The road outside Maanhaven was quiet. The moon carvings on the pillars had turned gold in the evening light. A few travelers passed through, none of them knowing that a new adventure had been named over breakfast in the tavern behind them.

Alias touched the cold stone where he had imagined his parents leaving him years ago.

The pain was still there.

So was the love.

He could carry both now.

Varux stood beside him in the old coat.

"Do you think they knew they would not come back?" Alias asked.

The older Alias did not pretend the answer was simple.

"I do not know," he said. "But I think they hoped they would."

"Is hoping enough?"

"Not always." Varux looked down the road. "But it is not nothing either."

Alias nodded.

For a while, the six of them stood beneath the gate without moving.

Then Rowan lifted his red-threaded key.

"So what do we call this?"

Corvin looked at him. "Call what?"

"The next journey. Every journey needs a name."

"It does not."

"That is why your maps are not fun."

Maris thought for a moment.

"The Road Beyond the First Road," she said.

Rowan considered it. "Too many roads."

"The Gate of Returning," Eldric offered.

Varux looked at the compass in Alias's hand.

"The road we choose," he said.

Alias looked east, though the eastern road was far beyond the town and the hills. It did not matter.  
He could feel it now. Not pulling him. Waiting.

"Adventure," he said.

Rowan grinned.

"That is not a very mysterious name."

"Good," Alias replied. "We have had enough mystery for a while."

The Paper unfolded in his hand.

This time, the words were large enough that everyone could read them.

*ADVENTURE AWAITS.*

Rowan pointed at the page.



"See? It agrees with me."

"It agrees with Alias," Maris said.

"That is close enough."

The blue letters remained until the light faded from the sky.

Then the Paper folded itself closed.

No one left that evening.

They returned to the tavern. Gerhardt put stew on the table before anyone could complain. The maps stayed rolled. The compass stayed in Alias's pocket. The six keys rested against six different chests.

Outside, the east road waited beyond the harbor, the hills, the first road, and the gate split between what had been lost and what might still be found.

Inside, they ate.

They laughed.

They planned slowly.

And when the night became quiet, Alias looked around the table and understood something the tower, the letters, and the road had all been trying to teach him.

An adventure did not begin when he disappeared from home.

It began when he could leave the door open behind him.

The next road was waiting.

So was the way back.

And this time, he knew better than to confuse one for the other.

\* \* \*